

On
Obstacles to and Conditions for
Spiritual Life in the Present Age.

Sixteen Lectures,
delivered at the University of Christiania
September—October 1867

by
R. Nielsen.

Copenhagen.
Published by the Gyldendal Bookshop (F. Hegel).
Printed by J. H. Schultz.
1868.

Translated from the Danish

Preface.

Although these lectures in their present form cannot be said to be in each and every respect a direct reproduction of the spoken word, I have nevertheless, by making use partly of my own notes and partly of more detailed reports in Norwegian papers, sought to come as close as possible to the lectures as originally and freely delivered. Here and there, however, the analyses of concepts have been carried somewhat further, and certain parts, notably in the last two lectures but one, have been inserted; I have likewise found myself called upon to meet several misgivings and epilogical misconstructions in a separate Postscript.

Copenhagen, 17 January 1868.

R. Nielsen.

To my Norwegian
Listeners, Men and Women,
these Lectures
are dedicated
with deep gratitude
by
the Author.

Contents

Preface	iii
Lecture I	1
Lecture II	15
Lecture III	31
Lecture IV	47
Lecture V	63
Lecture VI	77
Lecture VII	89
Lecture VIII	101
Lecture IX	115
Lecture X	131
Lecture XI	149
Lecture XII	165
Lecture XIII	177

Lecture XIV	191
Lecture XV	215
Lecture XVI	233
Postscript	247
Errata	273

I.

A thought, a great and fruitful thought, has gathered here a numerous circle of [1] honor. It is teachers and students at this university, old Norway's young university, who in fair union have set the thought in motion, the surely momentous thought for the future, that a closer scientific intercourse among the Nordic universities must contribute in particular to the mutual elevation of our spiritual life, the awakening of spiritual powers. So the invitation went out, to me as well; and since I, gripped by this fair thought, could not but prize the rare honor that on so significant an occasion it was granted me to come forward with my contributions and to take the word in an assembly such as this: I knew of no other or more fitting task to choose than an attempt at a general presentation of *Hindrances and Conditions for the Spiritual Life in the Present Age*.

Yes, in the present age the spiritual life certainly has peculiar, favorable conditions, but for that very reason it also meets great and peculiar hindrances. If we look away from the hindrances in order to fix our gaze exclusively on the condi- [2] tions, then bright prospects open up; of the bright prospects is born a glittering, fleeting hope, but a fleeting hope can beguile. If we forget the conditions and lose ourselves in contemplating the manifold hindrances, then the prospects grow dark; of the dark prospects comes despondency; but despondency is like a mist before the eye. We will not, then, give ourselves up to a one-sided consideration either of the conditions alone, so that we thereby forget the hindrances, or of the hindrances alone, so that we overlook the conditions; no, we shall in all sobriety seek to weigh hindrances against conditions, conditions against hindrances; so

there comes equilibrium.

It is an old saying that he who wills the end must will the means; but the saying has a double meaning. It can be understood thus: that nothing can come forth in the end which does not lie in the means, that the realized end is the result of the means, so that everything first and last depends on the means: that is the understanding's view, that is the counsel of prudence, and wisdom itself cannot give up prudence. "For"—says the Holy Word—"which of you, intending to build a tower, sitteth not down first, and counteth the cost, whether he have sufficient to finish it; lest haply, after he hath laid the foundation, and is not able to finish it, all that behold it begin to mock him, saying, This man began to build, and was not able to finish." But it can also be understood thus: that the means are the subordinate, the end the superordinate; the true, self-valid goal has, in an eternal sense, the means in its power: first the end, the first decisive thing, the One Thing Needful, and the conditions, the means, the finite necessities, come as of themselves! This is the demand of spirit. The kingdom of spirit is in the highest sense the kingdom [3] of righteousness, the kingdom of God. In the kingdom of God, of righteousness, prudence must serve wisdom, care for the temporal must vanish in striving toward the eternal; for—says the Holy Word—"seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these (temporal) things shall be added unto you."

The reciprocal determination of means and end just stated can now serve to clarify for us the relation between hindrances and conditions for the spiritual life. In active union with the overarching, all-determining end, the finite means are nothing but favorable conditions; the sensuous serves the spiritual by being permeated, inspirited and moved by spirit. But if the conditions are taken in a finite sense as a sum of means which of themselves, added together, are to make up the end, then they stand against spirit and become for the life of spirit nothing but snares, nothing but barriers, nothing but hindrances. From this standpoint it cannot then be difficult to characterize the present age.

The present age is in a peculiar sense to be called the age of prudence, an age that looks to the means and works with the conditions. Hence this age has at once

its bright and its shadow side. Our age rightly calls itself an age of the sciences, of enlightenment and of culture; the eye of culture is an eye for conditions; the practical consciousness of culture understands thoroughly how to conquer reality, increase the means and bring them into use. What has the modern age not already achieved in this direction? The progress of the natural sciences, these ingenious inventions, these magnificent, truly astonishing discoveries—what fertility in means, what wealth of conditions! That ships go against wind and current; that the steam horse, like a snorting Leviathan, rushes through the lands from place to place and makes the enormous distances vanish; that the express messenger of thoughts is sent out and reaches in the instant of thought to another world: [4] this and more bears sufficient witness to the power of ingenuity, to the fruit of research; yes, the searching eye is an eye for conditions.

The lively sense for conditions and the conditioned contains naturally a temptation to overlook the absolute, the unconditioned, and thus a temptation to misjudge spirit. To misjudge spirit is to draw it down under nature-bound terms in such a way that the laws of freedom simply coincide with the laws of natural necessity. What holds of the outward natural, the consciousness of culture will only too gladly transfer to the inward and spiritual. By a sharpened eye for conditions we discover the laws of nature; by the laws of nature we cognize the forces of nature; by insight into the forces of nature we become more and more able to master matter and show ourselves lords in the realm of nature. It then lies near at hand to ask whether something similar could not happen with the spiritual too? “Should it not at last be possible for our searching eye to discover the laws of spirit too, by the laws of spirit to determine and measure the powers of spirit, by the powers of spirit to master spirit itself and raise ourselves to autocrats in the realm of spirit—on conditions, of course?” Here is the presumption. It is impossible for man to set himself up as lord of spirit; it is, on the contrary, his highest destiny to be its servant.

That the present age misjudges the right of spirit is expressed, in all indefiniteness, by saying that the age is too materialistic. In what does its materialism

- consist? It surely cannot consist in its regarding matter as something real, for in that it is of course right; nor can it be placed in its laying weight on material goods, working to increase the material conditions; for in that it certainly does
- [5] right. No, the materialism of the age consists precisely in this, that it measures the eternal with the measure of temporality, makes the absolute relative and draws the unconditioned down under finite conditions. For sheer means it is unable to see the goal. What one-sided weight the present age lays on the means is seen, among other things, from the immense zeal with which, in small things and great, by all roads and in all ways, it strives to acquire the means of means, not the self-valid but the silver-valid end (*nervus rerum gerendarum*). The power of the present age is in a particular sense the power of capital. And yet the character of the present age is not properly avarice. The mark of avarice is that it makes gold the goal, everything else a means; but the present age makes gold the highest goal only insofar as it makes it the highest means. The age of means is the age of interests; everything has its interest insofar as it has its relative value; everything has its relative value insofar as it can pay. Now, can freedom pay? What does war cost? How many percent does justice yield when it is put out at interest? If really everything is to be able to pay, then—it lies in the nature of the case—everything must also be able to be paid for. How much, then, does one pay for a man's honor, a woman's virtue? By considering how consistently these questions follow from the whole fundamental view, and where they lead, one will at least find it explicable that poets and deeper natures regard the golden age of interests as the iron age of spirit, despair of getting the unconditioned along in a world of sheer conditions, and complain despondently of the spiritual slackness of the age. It is like a sigh of the soul in the poet's lament that the race is growing old, that youth is already old, characters pale, that the busy individuals, interested in freedom and independence, would much rather go with the wind, leaving it to the ships to go against the wind.
- [6] There is a sigh of the soul in the poet's lament that the spirit of the present age is faint and cold, that the coldness of spirit in the autumn of life is the harbinger of winter. There is a sigh of the soul in the poet's lament that the days of creation

are shortening, that the light gives way and the shadows grow, that “the sun sinks lower and lower, that the nights grow longer and longer, and the cold dark powers step more and more into life.”

Yet what good is it to complain; selfish dejection, overwhelming despondency, betray an offense against spirit too. If the hindrances are great, well then, the conditions are all the richer. For hindrances and conditions relate to one another in quite another way in the spiritual than in the sensuous world. The more sensuously the opposition is conceived, the more strongly will the opposed terms stand against one another and exclude one another; the more spiritual, on the other hand, the conception is, the more clearly will it be seen that the opposed terms relate either as consequence to ground or as power to impotence. In the sensuous meaning it holds, indeed, that hindrance is not condition, condition not hindrance: the stronger the hindrances, the weaker the conditions, and conversely; but spiritually understood it holds that the hindrance is in possibility condition, the condition hindrance: the greater the hindrances, the more essential the conditions, and conversely.

We can illustrate this by some examples. Only set adversity against prosperity, suffering against acting, fear against hope, and the difference between sensuous and spiritual understanding will be conspicuous. Sensuously seen, adversity stands against prosperity as poverty against wealth, sickness against health, sorrow against joy. How sharply exclusive the opposition is, shines out immediately from the fact that an increase of the one term necessarily presupposes a decrease of the other: the more adversity, the less prosperity, the greater the sorrow, the less the joy. In the world of spirit it is otherwise. Here prosperity is not simply a decrease of adversity, wealth of poverty, sickness of health, sorrow of joy; no, the relation is in all originality quite the contrary: that intensified adversity becomes the ground and presupposition of a correspondingly heightened prosperity; the power of spirit reveals itself precisely in this, that it transforms adversity into prosperity, founds a spiritual prosperity on sensuous adversity, a spiritual wealth on sensuous poverty, a spiritual health on sensuous sickness, a spiritual joy on sensuous sorrow. Thus [7]

speaks the Holy Word: “Blessed are ye that mourn; ye shall be comforted. Blessed are ye that hunger; ye shall be filled. Blessed are ye that weep; for ye shall laugh.” Sorrow as sorrow is certainly not itself joy, for the joy is in the comforting; but the joy of comforting is conditioned by the sorrow. Here, then, there is talk not merely of a present adversity and a coming prosperity, a present sorrow and a coming joy; but, when we look more closely, also of a present prosperity conditioned by adversity, a present joy conditioned by the sorrow itself. So far is it from being the case that the prosperity thus present should have been diminished because it coincides with adversity, that the corresponding joy is on the contrary raised to its highest, to blessedness. Spirit cannot, then, prove its power more clearly by transforming hindrances into conditions than when it so wondrously refashions adversity into prosperity that it even becomes blessed to mourn, blessed to hunger, blessed to weep, blessed to suffer.

For spirit—we mean the absolutely divine spirit, because a spiritual life without it is as little possible in the present age as it has ever been in the past—for spirit [8] itself nothing in the natural world is simply either hindrance or condition; but everything depends on a transformation. Therefore the divine can in a certain sense use everything and everyone. In the kingdom of spirit no one is too weak when spirit transforms his weakness into strength for him, and no one too strong when spirit transforms his strength into weakness. From this standpoint there can be no talk here of any essential difference between good and evil, convenient and inconvenient times; every time is at bottom equally good for the end that produces its own means, always convenient for the unconditioned that itself creates its conditions. Spirit in its working is by no means indifferent to conditions, not condition-less, nor does it create the conditions simply out of nothing; no, it forms them out of natural presuppositions, it forms them by a transformation. Whatever in the natural states with their natural terms lets itself be transformed becomes, however much it may look outwardly like a hindrance, nevertheless a condition; whatever remains in its naturalness and does not let itself be transformed becomes, though to a sensuous view it looks like the most favorable condition of

all, nevertheless essentially a hindrance.

But, it will perhaps be objected, if there really is something in the natural world that the divine spirit cannot transform, something that can offer it resistance, set it a barrier and place itself as a hindrance, then spirit is surely not almighty, and so not truly divine either. If spirit is truly divine, and so almighty, able everywhere to lift every resistance, break through every barrier and create conditions out of sheer natural hindrances: why then does it not come with equal strength to every generation in the history of mankind, why is it not equally mighty in every age? If it needed servants who could go before and prepare its way; if it now [9] and then had to lie still and wait for favorable conditions, just as a skipper lies still and waits for a favorable wind, then we could understand it. But when it must itself inspire its servants and itself bring the conditions along, is it not then incomprehensible that it will not always and everywhere work with equally powerful presence? Here, then, there must surely in reality exist something that can set spirit barriers, something that can prepare serious hindrances for it and bring it about that it, though almighty, seems to be impotent. We answer: there really is such a something! But this something does not exist outside spirit; no, it is for spirit itself, in its own kingdom: it lies in freedom, and the essence of spirit is freedom.

If we grasp freedom in brief concept as the will's unity of wisdom and power, then we grasp at once that the eternally free spirit must be raised above dark natural necessity and blind arbitrariness. Free in itself, spirit will work on the terms of freedom in free organs; such free organs are the human wills. If it depended solely on using power and ruling as a despot, then there would certainly be nothing either in heaven or on earth able to set the almighty spirit barriers; but by ruling despotically over free wills, the spirit of freedom would contradict itself. Here, then, appears the singular sight that what in the realm of creation must seem the weakest of all, the human will, really can do what the hard rocks, the mighty mountains, the high stars cannot: prepare hindrances for the divine will, set a barrier to omnipotence itself. To a fleeting, superficial consideration

this must seem to us quite absurd. For what, after all, is the human will when we look away from drive and inclination? The pure willing, the so-called pure self-determining, is in itself an empty shadow-being, an ideal phantom: what can well be more shadowy than the willing that wills itself, more empty of content than the determining that determines itself? And yet it is literally true that pure self-determining is the only thing in the whole world able to set a hindrance for spirit. Or if anyone thinks that the hindrance does not originally proceed from the will in man, let him tell us, then, whence it proceeds. We know well that our will in reality can determine itself to something only insofar as it is determined by something; but we also know that the will could not possibly become free if it could not originally determine itself to let itself be determined. The matter is not so involved as it might seem at first glance; it clears up at once when we consider what difference it makes whether the will is determined by drive or by spirit. The natural will is in the beginning one with the natural drive; sensuously moved by sensuous drive, the will reaches for the sensuous. If the drive is now further determined as inclination, and inclination rises to passion, then the sensuous will becomes strong by the strong passion; but the will ruled by passion is, with all its sensuous strength, unfree. Why unfree? Because in its naturalness it has not itself decided for the passion, but is simply possessed, inflamed by the passion. It is an easy matter for inclinations and passions to get the natural will into their power, because they can, if we may say so, come upon it from behind, swoop down on it, seize it and move it despotically. The strong passions are the despots of the sensuous will. Already from this one sees why spirit cannot, like drive, master the will. The spirit of freedom will set the will free; but the will can be set free only by its itself inwardly willing freedom. Over against drive and inclination the will can do nothing when it is left to itself; what it can do, it can do solely and only by the aid of spirit. If the aid of spirit were immediate like the promptings that proceed from drive, then it could simply come to a struggle, independent of the will, between the free spirit and the nature-bound drive; if drive then got the upper hand and swept the will along, it was not the will's but spirit's fault: the divine

spirit would then have been too weak. If a man has leave to see the matter from this standpoint, he can easily excuse himself: "How can I help that I am born with sensuous drives and impure desires? I cannot possibly change my own nature. If spirit wants the desires purged, it must purge them itself; if it would set my will free, it must itself seize and move it. I am quite willing to let myself be set free; my will offers absolutely no resistance; spirit, for that matter, may take it, turn it, twist it and do with it what it will, if only it will do something. But when the divine spirit itself either cannot or will not immediately do something, what then am I supposed to be able to do?" Here is an enormous misunderstanding. If spirit really were to move the will quite immediately, in the manner of drive, then it would have to begin the will's liberation by making it unfree—what a contradiction! The will's first act of freedom, the fruit of its very first inspiriting, is precisely the heightened self-determination with which it inwardly longs for and, in struggle against drive, gives itself up to the influences of spirit. As these influences are then received and appropriated by the will that, in appropriating, frees itself, the relation is by no means this, that the will, in self-separation from spirit, should have any power for any independent working whatever; on the contrary! it can move only after spirit, as it is moved with freedom by spirit. The moving power [12] of freedom is solely and only the power of spirit; but it rests with the will itself whether it will, in inwardness, in true originality, appropriate this power. If it will not, then it "grieves the spirit"; then its impotence is a negative power which, sadly enough, sets a barrier to omnipotence itself.

And what, then, is the practical result of the considerations here set forth? What does spirit demand of the man who works with the conditions of reality; what sort of fundamental demand is it that it makes in particular of this present age? Is our age worldly beyond all previous ages? Is it renunciation of the world in great outward demonstrations, medieval states of affairs with monkery, praying, fasting, church processions and monastic good works, that spirit demands in order to transform the natural hindrances into favorable conditions? By no means! The demand of spirit is not, and by its principle cannot be, any finite demand for

anything finite and outward whatever. As to its outward side, the present age may well be said to be, if not better, then at least as good as any preceding one. No, the fundamental demand that spirit makes of this as of all other times is first and last a demand of inwardness; it demands faith, faith in its eternally free, liberating power; it demands will, will to make oneself free by letting oneself be set free; in short and definitely: it demands earnestness.

Every finitely determinate demand the present age, with its restless reflections and its almost feverishly overstrained criticism, can easily rewrite, halve and, especially when the demand is put forward singly, easily protest. But there is one demand it cannot rewrite, cannot halve, cannot protest, and that is the demand: earnestness!

[13]

This demand is strict enough, but it is not too strict. There may perhaps be a race that boasts of having given up eternal life in order to live the temporal all the more vigorously; but there is surely no race that would in earnest boast of having given up all earnestness. There may perhaps be born a generation that makes it an honor to lack a sense for God and his holy Word; but could there well be born a generation that would make it its honor to lack earnestness? When, then, spirit in this present demands only essential and true earnestness, it demands at bottom nothing else of the age than what the age must necessarily demand of itself: here, then, an understanding must be possible. To be in earnest about something is, as one says, to take something to heart, to lay it on one's mind; by earnestness there is posited a unity of matter and mind. But from this it follows in turn that the mind, which takes the matter into itself and makes itself one with it, must itself in turn become of the same essence as the matter. If the matter is unessential, in itself insignificant, then the mind is paltry; only a paltry mind can make much of the insignificant. If the matter is not simply unessential but still of finite nature, then the mind gives itself up as a prey to the finite, makes its essence finite by taking the matter to heart and giving itself wholly up to it. The finite is by its nature changeable; but earnestness demands, after all, that the mind in relation to the matter be like itself, know itself raised above the changes in the midst of

the changeable. The world of interests and means is inconstant. The earnest man must be prepared for vicissitudes; his fear and hope are determined by his always being able to expect the opposite: after adversity prosperity, after gain loss, and so forth. Here the wise words fit: *Sperat infestis, metuit secundis alteram sortem bene praeparatum pectus*. See, that is the earnestness of prudence. [14]

But the earnestness of prudence cannot possibly be true earnestness; it suffers from an inborn frailty, it drags along a heavy contradiction, the contradiction that the mind is at once both to give itself up and yet not to give itself up to the finite essence. Certainly the finite has its interest as condition, as means. But if one becomes so earnest about the means that the goal is excluded, then the self-deception is manifest. The condition is seized; but it has significance only for something that was to be conditioned by it. Now what sort of something is this? Within finitude itself, a new condition! And the new condition? Has significance only for a something that was to be conditioned by it! The real value of the condition falls infinitely outside the condition itself, just as the value of the means falls outside the means. He who on these terms will live on his means and sate his soul with sheer conditions can indeed be said to be an earnest man—earnest, yes, like Tantalus when he would pluck the fruits and drink from the stream. The earnestness that makes a Tantalus old and gray may well make a whole race old before its time. If it is really true that mankind is growing old, then it cannot be nature's fault, for of nature holds what the poet says: "every age and every year has its own, its blossoming spring." Still less can it be spirit's fault, for spirit as spirit has springs of eternity, and the eternal cannot grow old. The fault must then fall on the false earnestness, the finite earnestness of interests, of means, of conditions.

If false earnestness has made a race old, then it is to be hoped that true earnestness can make it young again. True earnestness is a gift of spirit, but on the terms of freedom. The condition is that the inspirited will will receive, preserve and use the gift. True earnestness lays decisive weight on the end, but in such a way that it at the same time lays weight on the means. To rave for empty ideals that [15]

fly over reality is not earnestness. The earnestness of ideals is that they will be realized. Realization requires exertion, endurance, constancy. But endurance and constancy under great exertions correspond precisely to essential earnestness. Earnestness is a power of the soul that holds out in trials, a fundamental mood of the mind that is secured by firm resolution; earnestness is the renewal of the self, the consecration of character, the baptism of the will, that it is baptized with spirit. Therefore true earnestness is not merely something with which the spiritual life is to be completed and concluded, but also something with which it is to be begun. Earnestness is not for the old alone, but also for the young. A gifted youth has essential earnestness because it has essential spirit. There is indeed something cool, hidden and severe in the depths of earnestness, just as there is something cool in the depths of the sea; but just as well as the deep sea can be irradiated by the sun, so can earnestness itself be surrounded by the radiance of joy. If a sense for the earnestness of life did not originally belong to the rich endowment of youth, how would things then look for the future? What good, then, would all our striving with upbringing, instruction and education do, if that which in due time was to be applied and used in earnest were not grasped and understood in earnest? What good would—to keep to what now lies so near at hand—an endeavor to bring richer variety into the academic lectures and to initiate closer intercourse among the different universities do, if the student youth were not itself livingly interested in all that furthers and heightens the spiritual life.

[16] It is, then, with lively joy and a good hope that we dare try to carry out our undertaking, because we recognize that the younger have as much—let us just say it, fully as much—share in its carrying out as the elder. It is the young who have willed that now it should be earnest, and what is thus willed in earnest will, with the aid of Providence, also be carried out in earnest. A youth that listens when ideal strings are touched, and itself works along so that spiritual aims are furthered, an academic youth with clear eyes, wakeful sense and spring-fresh thoughts, will soon understand what is at stake when it is a matter of the choice of means and goal, of the transformation of hindrances by the power of spirit, of the victory of

freedom in the strife of life: it will understand it in earnest.

II.

It is told of Alexander, son of Philip of Macedon, that as a youth he wept when his father had performed a great deed. They were tears of admiration the youth wept, for he looked up to his father with filial reverence; he saw in him the renowned hero. But they were also tears of envy; “for,” said he, “my father performs all the great things; what is left over for me?” ^[17]

This so characteristic relation between the youth Alexander and his father can in a certain sense—from one side at least—serve to illuminate the successive ages of history. *Le présent est gros de l’avenir*, says the philosopher Leibnitz, and rightly; the time immediately following is, if I may so express myself, always a son of the preceding one. But if the present age has the preceding one for father, and so, to stay in the image, the one before that for grandfather, then, when we look back over the long series of generations, over great-grandfather, great-great-grandfather, great-great-great... and so on, there results a mighty family tree. The generation now living is a noble race with many ancestors and great fathers; when, then, the present age turns and contemplates the past, its deeds and heroes, it must involuntarily exclaim: “My fathers have performed the great things!” and could ^[18] then easily be tempted to ask with Alexander: “What is left over for me?”

It is not, earnestly seen, youthful ambition, not envy, still less empty vanity, that breathes in such a question; it is on the contrary a quiet, deep concern; it is spiritual anxiety for one’s livelihood. It does not help that someone will say to us: “Where are you going with your asking about the great? If, like Alexander, you have the great powers, well then, like Alexander you will yourselves know how

to perform great deeds; if not, then you do best to keep to the ground, learn to crawl until you can walk, and make do with the lesser.” This rebuff is unwarranted. For our own part we will gladly content ourselves with the lesser; but in order to have the lesser with spirit and truth, we must necessarily be helped by the great. If the great so vanishes from a given contemporary age that it no longer has the power of presence, then it becomes a spiritual torment to live in the lesser. The past must indeed furnish presuppositions for the present; but the present wastes away when it must feed exclusively on a pastness; every age must have sources of nourishment in itself: the present lives on a present and the lesser on the greater. It goes with the movements in world history as in the world ocean. If wind and storm and ebb and flow and strong currents did not ceaselessly move the waters in the great sea, how would things then look with bays and fjords?

It is a true saying that no one can live unless he has something to live on and something to live for. Sensuously the two demands can be separated, but not spiritually. In material respects the first necessity is undeniably this, that he who [19] is to live must have something to live on. Yes, the urgency of this demand is even so conspicuous that many take it for the only valid one and think to themselves: if only we had enough to live on, we should easily find something to live for. But in the spiritual sense the two demands are inseparable: what a man spiritually lives for, he also lives on. An artist, for example, who lives exclusively for his art also lives—certainly not always materially, but still ideally—on his artistic production, has in this production his spiritual food, his life, his joy. He who unconditionally lives for faith lives spiritually on faith; he who lives for knowledge, on knowledge, and so on. In the ideal as well as in the material it is a matter of working capital.

In the commercial world, and generally in the practical world of workers and of civic interests, watch is kept that the great capitals are not scattered and divided into mere small change. It is as much in the interest of those without means as of those with means that the capitals be preserved. So also in history. Capitals of spirit are needed for every age to have something to live for and to live on; at critical turning points great stakes must be laid down. The great stakes mark the

epochs of history; the employment and distribution of the capital in greater and lesser, until it has given its yield and is used up, is what characterizes a period. The greater the epoch, the greater is the life-capital staked, and the longer will the corresponding period be too. The absolute epoch of spirit is, in the language of religion, the turning point called the fullness of time, the turning point when not merely one of the great thoughts of eternity but the Eternal himself, he who says: "before Abraham was, I am," revealed in flesh and blood, stepped into time. Seen from this summit, the Word of Life is the spiritual fundamental capital on which the generations are to live; for this epoch all following times are to be regarded as [20] a single, continuous period.

It is otherwise, on the other hand, with the relative epochs; to these belong naturally only relative periods, longer or shorter in proportion to the greater or lesser capital staked. Such relative epochs we have in the ideal breakthroughs on which the division between antiquity, the Middle Ages and the modern age originally rests; as regards the life of spirit they may on the whole be said to represent: the folk-spirit, the church-spirit, the world-spirit. It is necessary in this connection to bethink oneself of the distinction between the relative forms under which spirit works in human life, and the divine spirit itself. In the history of culture spirit does not work immediately on man's thoughts and powers; here there is an inner intermediary between spirit absolute and human self-consciousness, an intermediate being in which spirit each time deposits a peculiar content, determined by a peculiar form; this intermediate being we call the idea. Only as man's consciousness, in mind and thoughts, in willing and working, appropriates the idea can the human spirit receive its peculiar stamp.

By bringing out the difference between idea and spirit we can at once characterize the opposition between revelation and mythology. In revelation the idea is so perfectly transparent that in many cases it looks as though it had quite vanished. God speaks to man, teaches man, places himself over against man as will against will, spirit against spirit. At the stage of mythology the matter stands the other way round; here the idea as idea has become opaque to the human spirit; the proof

of this is that the ideas themselves are set up in figurative form as gods: the mythic
 [21] gods are personified ideas. The opposition between Jews and Greeks is in this respect characteristic; the Jewish people is the people of spirit, the Greeks the people of ideas. Among the Jews everything aims at satisfying spirit; therefore the humane ideas of art and science could not come to development; not even the state as state got leave to develop out of its own idea: the theocratic state is immediately subject to the power of spirit. Otherwise among the Greeks. Here it is so far from being the case that spirit overwhelms the idea, that the content of life in all directions on the contrary develops out of the idea, is formed and individualized into a peculiar idea-content. Herein lie the strong impulses to the development of art and science, politics and rational ethics; but from this, then, is explained also the fundamental defect, that the supernatural everywhere melts together with the natural, the will with drive, freedom with necessity, in such a way that not a single demand of spirit comes to hold in absolute unconditionedness.

As the most gifted cultured people of antiquity, the Greeks furnish a striking example of what a folk-spirit signifies in its originality, what inner limits it has, how it struggles with hindrances and conditions. In every gifted people there stirs from the beginning a circle of peculiar ideas with the force of nature. How characteristic such ideas are of the national peculiarity leaps to the eye when we compare Greek mythology with Nordic. Zeus and Odin, Frigga and Here, Helheim and Hades, Olympus and Valhalla—what a difference! The difference is twofold: partly outward, insofar as the gods' form, individuality, deeds and fate are depicted otherwise by Greek fantasy than by Nordic; partly inward, insofar as each of the
 [22] different worlds of gods presupposes its own degree of self-consciousness, its own view of the world and of life in the people concerned. The Greek gods are gods of beauty, the Nordic gods of battle. This must of course not be understood as though the Greek gods could not fight and the Nordic could not be beautiful; but the point is that the Greek have their most perfect manifestations in beauty, the Nordic in battle. How far-reaching this opposition is in determining the peculiar spiritual direction of the two peoples and their role in world history can be illustrated by a

couple of traits.

That a deity's manifestation is completed in beauty means, in other words, that its peculiarity, its ideal independence, lies essentially in aesthetic individuality. But when individuality in its immediate phenomenon is the highest expression of the independence of the gods, then it must also be so for that of men; for the divine is the pattern for the human. Homer will, he says (*Iliad*. I, 1–5), have the goddess sing the wrath of Achilles, which sent the souls of many heroes to Hades, but made them themselves a prey for the dogs (αὐτοὺς δὲ ἐλώρια τεῦχε κύνεσσιν). Certainly we must at this “them themselves” involuntarily think of the corpses; but what is characteristic in the expression is still this, that what designates the heroes themselves is not their souls but their bodies. The bodily form is, namely, the aesthetic individuality of the hero; to have individuality is common to gods and heroes. But now comes the difference: the gods are immortal, men mortal; by the division between immortal and mortal races fate has set a tragic barrier between gods and heroes. Forsaken by bodily individuality, the bloodless shades in Hades drag out a pitiful existence. It is said of Hector's death (*Iliad*. XXII, 362): “Out of his limbs flew his soul and hastened to Hades, wailing over the lot of [23] parting from valor and youth.” Otherwise with the heroes in the old North; there another lot awaited them as Einheriar in Valhalla, and why? Because Odin was so different from Zeus, the gods of Valhalla different in mind and thoughts from those of Olympus. Odin and Thor did not place the personal essence in beautiful individuality but in the strength of will that lives on battle and grows in battle; it is such a strength of will, which the heroes have in common with the gods, that ennobles the deed and overcomes death. That death triumphs, that the light is quenched, and the souls tremble in the realm of shades, is not the fault of fate; the fault is in cowardice and the weak will. Therefore Thor is “so wroth with the fearful men of Helheim,” and addresses them harshly: “You wretched fools, who feared wound and death! Now Hel shall wound you forever with torment and bitter need.”

From the difference between the aesthetic individuality and the battling char-

acter in the mythic patterns there flows yet another consequence, which is truly characteristic of the role each of the peoples named was to play in history. The “blessed gods” of Olympus could certainly not—it lies in the nature of individuality—break through with the clear, completed form and get the better of the old, half-formless elemental gods sprung from chaos, except after great upheavals and hard battles; but while the Æsir, the strong-willed battle-gods of Valhalla, must wage a constant war with the giants, a war that begins with the slaying of Ymer and ends with Ragnarok, the Olympian individualities are finished in a comparatively short time with the whole war of the gods and so get occasion, in plastic beauty and classical repose, to enjoy all the pleasure of life with the blessed joy of ideality: “Here the heart lacked not an ample meal, nor the lovely lyre struck by [24] Phoebus Apollo, nor the alternating songs of the Muses’ beautiful voice.” While the Northmen with their divine leaders are so caught up in the whirl of endless battle that they could only begin to come to rest in the advanced Middle Ages and develop any civilization on the foundation of Christianity, the Greeks reach, through comparatively brief crises and grandiose catastrophes, the turning point of the time of rest, when the ideas are clarified and the material formed, so that not only the laws of the state but also those of thought and beauty are fulfilled. It is now easy to see that the folk-spirit determines the actual life of the people, that its historical rise, culmination and decline are inwardly conditioned by the ideas at work in the spirit itself. Greek history is in a peculiar sense to be called catastrophic. The catastrophic is suited precisely to an all-round development of aesthetic individuality, and gives us conspicuous examples of how a folk-spirit first proves its power by transforming hindrances into conditions, and then again betrays its weakness when the conditions turn about and are transformed into hindrances. Greek individuality in its heroic immediacy is combative; already in the struggle for Troy the strife between Achilles and Agamemnon is of great catastrophic effect. Had the combative individualities now got leave to tumble about freely among one another, then the state, this universal being, could not possibly be formed and come to be at one’s disposal; but just as Plato’s God at a

glance upon chaos originally saw that order is better than disorder, so the Greek eye saw that disorder was in equal degree contrary as much to the beautiful as to the good. But as the individuals bowed under the state as under a deity, they still did not bow so slavishly that the stamp of individuality was effaced; on the contrary! the individualities were taken up into the state precisely in such a way that the essence of the state thereby itself became individualized. Instead of one single general Greek state there forms itself from the beginning a plurality of [25] individual states, mutually at strife in accordance with their immediate, and so likewise aesthetic, individuality.

From the ground of the rich individualities the springs of ideas well up; here, then, everywhere in the outward as in the inward, in the colonies as in the mother states, impulses, powers, elements are in motion enough. If, however, something whole and great was to come out of this motley manifoldness, something on which the spirit of beauty could set its stamp, and so something that was in truth of one casting: then above all an enormous pressure had to be brought about; a condition was needed that carried weight. And the condition came; but at the moment it came, it certainly by no means looked like a condition; no, it looked on the contrary like a crushing hindrance. It is Xerxes who with his hundreds of thousands got the task, the fair historical task, of procuring the condition for the rich, wondrously strong development of the Greek folk-spirit. And Xerxes must indeed arm himself and hasten; for the condition is pressing. In the bay at Salamis strife and discord have already prepared so many hindrances for Themistocles that he knows how to do only one thing: transform these hindrances themselves into one single great, decisive condition. It is natural, after all, that individuality and freedom must correspond to one another. The aesthetically strong individuality is inflamed by enthusiasm for freedom when the danger outwardly impends; in the moment of enthusiasm it has an enormous elasticity; but it is also a matter of using the moment; and the Greek heroes used the moment: Marathon, Thermopylae, Salamis and Plataea speak of it to all generations. The Greek struggle for freedom was an enormous catastrophe; the blow that was to have crushed individuality

[26] brought about an uprising whereby it came to unfold powers that have astonished the world and surprised itself. It is in this struggle that the capital is staked, the life-capital that was to yield great spiritual, incalculable interest.

Greek political life, Greek poetry and above all Greek art would surely never have reached the summit at which a pure, strict and completed form is in so originally simple a manner enlivened and filled by the content of the idea that the latest time will look upon it with wonder, if the catastrophic struggle for freedom with its terrors and upheavals had not brought hindrances with it that spirit could transform into conditions. It was, it is said, a Greek saying that he could not be blessed who had not seen Zeus at Olympia. What, then, was there to see at Olympia? The transfigured individuality in manly youthful strength, in might and majesty, in repose and loftiness, the “father of gods and men,” whose lightning had struck the Persians as it once struck the Titans. We read in Homer of the holy sign with which Zeus confirms his promise to Thetis (Il. I, 528): “He spoke, and Zeus nodded with his dark-blue brows therewith, and from the immortal head the lord’s ambrosial locks fell waving down, and he made high Olympus tremble.” In reading this we get an inkling of the vision of the god that must have hovered before Phidias in the moment of enthusiasm; but for us—who do indeed hope to be blessed without such a vision—it is only as an inkling; for the Greek artist, on the other hand, it was real and living presence. It was the Greek folk-spirit that revealed itself in the vision, and that with a clarity and immediacy which bore witness that it had now really come to full consciousness of its divine power. If [27] we might not presuppose this, where should we then seek the condition for what history calls “the great art”?

Upon the catastrophic development with its rapid flowering there followed, under a likewise catastrophic discord (the Peloponnesian War), a correspondingly rapid decline, withering and wasting away. When Demosthenes thundered against Philip, the lightning in the hand of Zeus was already faint; the powers of spirit were exhausted, for while states and tribes weakened one another in mutual strife, the idea bound to the classical forms exhausted its original productivity. It was

a tragic conflict between the ethical and the political in which Greek freedom perished: ethically Demosthenes was indeed right against Philip; but that Philip, politically seen, was right against Demosthenes, his son Alexander proved.

In the Middle Ages the folk-spirit is not so much permeated and essentially reborn as rather immediately overwhelmed and systematically ruled by the church-spirit. What, now, is the church-spirit? By no means one with the original spirit of the congregation, but a derived and yet mighty being, an ascetic ruling spirit disciplined by dogmas and traditions, a Greco-Roman spirit, proceeding not from the Father and the Son but from bishops and councils, hermits and monks, cardinals and popes. In the church-spirit the immediate folk-spirit is reduced to a moment, the natural cowed and transformed into a foundation. The opposition in principle between the flesh and the spirit, the profane and the holy, the earthly and the heavenly, the present and the coming, grips feeling, kindles fantasy, and breaks out in all directions, at all points and under all forms, into mighty, visible dualism. Between the strictest, most unconditional demands of spirit on the one side and worldliness with its sensuous drives, its raw lusts and strong passions on the other, [28] the ideas surface anew, and an enormous fermentation sets in. By the fermentation of the ideas the divine becomes worldly, the worldly divine, and yet the opposed poles, despite mutual attraction, go on repelling one another. The church becomes a state, and the state becomes churchly, and yet they go on, the church as the kingdom of God and the state as the kingdom of the world, counteracting one another amid ceaseless strife and reconciliation. The clash between emperor and pope, so characteristic of the dualism of the Middle Ages, begins from the moment when Leo the Third anointed and crowned Charles the Great. It is not long before the clash becomes so strong that the pillars of society are shaken. While the Carolingian political system was splitting apart, and the many-sided alternation of private lordship and personal dependence that characterizes hierarchy and feudalism confused the concepts of right and gave individuals up as a prey to violence and arbitrariness, the Northmen stormed from the north, the Magyars from the east, the Saracens from the south, and completed the distress and misery

of the time. The peoples, whose eyes the new faith had opened to the blessings of peace and righteousness, and who had just taken their first look into civilization, regarded the situation in the light of religion, were seized with terror at the vanity of the world and awaited the Day of Judgment.

With what, now, is all this to end? Not with the end of the world but with a victory of civilization, an advance of culture: the strong fermentations are the birth pangs that bring a new time with a new form to the light. The fermentation is a ceaseless conversion of hindrances into conditions and conditions into hindrances. The fermentation itself cannot produce anything actual; but it can, if I may say so, knead and duly prepare the possibilities. What is waited for is a great breakthrough, [29] a mother-idea which, by the spirit of the church, conceives and bears the many daughters. With this idea the stake is then laid down; its dowry is the life-capital that the Middle Ages have long been gathering, and on which they are long to live. The turning point is that there appears a goal of spirit which can take up into itself and embrace all other aims, that a work is found out which can enclose and include all other works, that an enthusiasm is awakened so rich and strong that its effects can extend to everything that draws nourishment from the ideal; in short: it is the Holy Sepulchre that is to be conquered.

The idea of the Crusades may with good reason be called the fundamental idea of the Middle Ages; the goal set hereby was at once so earthly that it could be grasped with hands, and yet so supra-earthly that it stood immediately as a gate to heaven. However many good works might be enumerated, there was nevertheless now no one among the Christians of the West who went wrong when the question was of the first and greatest. By the Crusades the cause of the church first became in earnest a cause of the people: by the cross of Christ against the moon of Mohammed the free men of the West would measure themselves in battle with the slaves of the East; by the Crusades the emperor and the princes first came into the right position, in the church's view, toward the pope; by the Crusades the monk and the knight got a common task to such a degree that the monk became a knight and the knight a monk; by the Crusades the social life, otherwise so particularized, divided

into provinces, estates, towns and corporations, was flooded through by one feeling, moved by one thought. Adventure and devotion, calculating self-interest and mystical piety, ambitious striving and romantic longing, outward-striving sensuousness and ascetic inwardness, in short: promptings of the most varied origin, endeavors sprung from the most heterogeneous sources, flowed together [30] here into one single enormous stream. There can surely be named no direction of spirit, no manifestation, either ideal or material, of the life of the Middle Ages, be it in trade or in science, in industry or in poetry, in religious ceremony or in knightly gallantry, which did not, mediately or immediately, stand in connection with the Crusades.

The idea of the Crusades is an idea of dualism, an idea that unfolds the essence of the Middle Ages. When the time of the Crusades was over, the pope took a fever; it was over with his sound constitution, his power was essentially broken. It is not without significance that Dante begins his descent into hell, and with it his Last Judgment upon the Middle Ages, in the very same year in which Boniface the Eighth gathered the devout in crowds about the graves of the apostles and, by instituting the jubilee year, founded the traffic in indulgences on a grand scale. Just as crusade and crusade and again crusade was a sign of the church-spirit upon the vigorously battling Middle Ages, so now, after St. Peter's star has for a time stood at the zenith, indulgence and indulgence and again indulgence becomes a clear sign of the sinking of the Middle Ages.

To acquire the forgiveness of sins by fighting as a crusader is still always to stake life in order to win life; but to barter oneself the forgiveness of sins for finite values, yes, for sausages and hams and ready money—that is more than mysticism, that is materialism itself, the most brazen that has been seen in history.

How hindrances by the power of spirit transform themselves into conditions is now seen clearly enough in the Reformation. It was not because the good and uncorrupted in the papal church still had the preponderance over the bad and corruptible that the thought of the Reformation at last broke through; no, it was on the contrary because the eruption of corruption was so strong, so conspicuous, [31]

that it could not be hidden by any hierarchical artifice. What it means that a central idea takes up, fertilizes and moves a system of relative ideas, that the spiritual life is awakened, reborn and furthered as spirit, through the end, shapes the means—this we learn from the course of the Reformation. For it is true, indeed, that the reformatory movements on the whole signify an uprising of the nationalities, a reaction against the foreign yoke, a revolt of the states against clerical despotism and against the extortions from Rome; but it nevertheless stands firm that this national and political-economic uprising would not have led to any decisive result, still less have gained any lasting significance for the life of spirit, had it not been taken up as a relative moment into the absolutely religious fundamental thought. It is true, indeed, that the intellectual weapons with which the Reformers fought were for a great part fetched from the well-stocked arsenals of humanism and of the reawakened scientific spirit; but it nevertheless stands firm that neither the classical studies nor the humanist-critical reflections would by themselves have been sufficient to steer the way of thinking of the age, least of all to fill up the hollowness and water the roots of the tree of life with streams from a rich spring. It is true, indeed, that the Reformation neither would nor could give anything originally new in the religious sense; it could and would only purge out the harmful by exposing misinterpretations and removing arbitrary additions; but it nevertheless stands firm that the thought of the Reformation was a thought fertilized by spirit itself and for that very reason fruitful, so fruitful and strong that it lifted a generation by the power of enthusiasm and refreshed the blood in all its veins. With new awakenings of heroic self-sacrifice, with new thoughts in new ideas, the capital was then staked, the life-capital whose rich means would [32] have given the life of the people a lasting upswing, had these means not in sorry measure been sacrificed to dogmatic formulas, scholastic doctrinal edifices and absolutist state churches, until the capital at last dwindled away and was consumed in the Thirty Years' War.

With the Reformation the thought of faith came into its right insofar as it got its Gospel cleansed and its account settled with the Middle Ages; but a clear

development of the principle of faith as a peculiar principle of cognition in its own right was not yet carried through. In the midst of the endless disputes over the testimony of Scripture and of the spirit, the scholastic *Credo ut intelligam* still preserved its whole ambiguity, an ambiguity that has had not only its dogmatic but has even to this day its ethical, far-ramifying consequences.

As the original idea of the Reformation grew dim, as the opposition in principle between the kingdom of God and the kingdom of the world—an opposition about whose muddling Luther himself exclaims: “der lebendige Teufel hört ja nie auf, mir diese zwei Reichen in einander zu kochen und zu brauen”—was more and more blurred in existence itself, it became evident too that the great Reformers, under the spiritual terms of their age, had had to leave the rational question of faith and knowledge, the greatest of all intellectual tasks, standing unsolved. The consequence of this was that while in orthodox Protestant dogmatics reason was constantly taken captive under the obedience of faith, in Protestant politics faith began more and more to be taken captive under the obedience of reason. For the sake of a human order, and so for the sake of reason, churchly orthodoxy was made a civic concern. That princes and governments, confusing their humane respect for the holy cause of the Gospel with living faith in the Gospel itself, took it upon themselves to make the government of the state churchly and to provide for [33] their subjects’ salvation by churchly laws of compulsion, looks indeed, at a fleeting glance, as though it were a practical carrying out of the principle of taking reason captive and letting faith rule; but it is an illusion of the senses. The world of politics is a world of finite interests; in the world of finite interests, it follows of itself, the finite considerations must rule; by being drawn down into a ruling finitude, faith as faith becomes not goal but means. To use faith as a means is to take it captive. When, then, in the orthodox state churches it looks as though faith sat on the high seat and wielded the scepter of government: it is not the free faith that rules over a worldly reason; no, it is the captive faith, whose apparent exaltation is all the more degrading as it does not even get leave to show its captivity, but must, as a cloak for the reason that in reality rules, figure as mistress.

The hidden contradiction was already exposed in the further course of the Thirty Years' War, particularly by the Peace of Westphalia; but as yet only for the clear-sighted, the properly initiated, the diplomats. But diplomats must be able to keep silent; the diplomatic secret was betrayed only gradually, as the more enlightened came to the cognition that it can only be worldly goals that are immediately furthered by worldly means. So the way of thinking changed, and, without one's being able to point to any finite why, the period of the wars of religion was at an end. As religious concerns were pushed more and more into the background, the demands of reason, the theoretical as well as the practical, naturally pushed themselves forward into the foreground. If faith, in the form of objective, blind authority, had formerly wanted to tyrannize over reason, the [34] emancipated reason, through philosophy, criticism and politics, amid ever stronger clashes with the established, reached at last the turning point when the thought of freedom broke through: the epoch-making breakthrough was the Revolution.

The spirit of the Revolution stands in decisive strife with the church-spirit; they are each other's sworn enemies. The revolutionary spirit of freedom, however great the passions it roused in its day among the peoples, is by no means a national spirit. What it has in common with the natural folk-spirits is indeed this, that it identifies the idea with the deity; but while the folk-spirit in its first naturalness is grounded in mythic presuppositions and wastes away when its chosen gods grow pale, the spirit of the Revolution is on the other hand so reflective that it makes world-reason itself the deity; it is a cosmopolitan spirit, which knows with itself that it neither can nor will strive for other aims than such as belong to the finite-infinite world of conditions. The spirit of the Revolution is the world-spirit awakened to self-consciousness, a practical spirit whose bright and shadow sides are chiefly to be sought in politics.

Seen from its bright side, this political spirit is a spirit of the rights of man, and so a spirit of humanity; its watchword is liberty and equality; its earnestness is that it will, if only after many struggles, through many hindrances, by many detours, put the rights of man in force and make civil liberty an actual truth. It

is a characteristic trait that when the Constituent Assembly in Paris (1789) was discussing the rights, and Mirabeau, impatient that the discussions were taking too philosophical a turn and dragging on, exclaimed: *N'employez pas le mot de droits, mais dites: Dans l'intérêt de tous, il a été déclaré ...*, the assembly held fast with the sureness of instinct to this, that it was precisely rights, and so expressly [35] demands of principle, that were to be carried through.

But precisely in the demands of principle one sees an enormous strife and yet a remarkable agreement between the spirit of the Revolution and that of the Reformation. Can the goal be reached, and the rights of man be put in force, if the religious principle of 1530 is rejected? We answer unconditionally: No! Can the goal be reached, and the rights of man be put in force, if the political principle of 1789 is rejected? We answer with full conviction: No! When, now, the two principles are nevertheless so mutually heterogeneous that an immediate and simple agreement between them has hitherto proved to be an impossibility, then there is certainly set before the nearest future so significant a problem, a task so decisive for the temporal as for the spiritual life, that an anxious present age, which sees with admiration that the fathers have accomplished the great things, shall not waver irresolutely and ask: What is left over for me?

III.

When rumors of war are heard, the Exchange grows restless; when the northern ^[36] lights are kindled, the magnet grows restless; when the elements of spirit are stirred, and thoughts are roused to strife, the mind grows restless. Just as one can speak of a storm of war, of a magnetic storm, so one can speak, and with good reason, of a storm of the spirit. If we look at the sky when thunder is gathering, we see the clouds moving, some with the wind, others, as it seems, against the wind: whence come these opposite movements? They come from the attractions of opposite poles, from opposite currents in lower and higher layers of the air. The outbreak itself surprises us all the more, the more hidden and quiet the preparation has been. So too with the spiritual storm! The preparation takes place in this way, that opposite ideas, heterogeneous thoughts, in mutual repulsion and attraction, move with rising tension in opposite currents through lower and higher regions. In the beginning the movements may be so hidden, the whole stir smoldering so obscurely, that conscience dozes, and immediate attention notices nothing. But under the increasing tension a restlessness is felt; what formerly expressed itself as fleeting assertions, flashing fancies, abstract representations indifferent to the practical world, gradually becomes importunate, spreads ever further and ^[37] gains more weight; and still the whole, seen from without, is like a riddle. At last the critical turning point is reached; the contending ideas meet in strife: there is a collision, a spark is kindled, a lightning flash gleams, and a trembling passes through souls.

With the religious breakthrough of the Reformation and the political break-

through of the Revolution as its presupposition, the present era is continually moved in two diametrically opposite directions, subject to two spiritual powers, of which the one unceasingly works against and combats the other. The clashes are not, to be sure, equally palpable at all times; on the contrary! there are intervals in which the spiritual strife almost wholly dies away, and a tacit agreement seems to herald a peace, if not exactly eternal, yet long-lasting. But how little one can rely on that sort of peace, the history of past ages, with its epochs and periods, must surely have taught us sufficiently. It goes with the resting conditions in history as it goes in volcanic regions. The volcano is at rest; not, indeed, without all activity, for vapors and columns of smoke do remind us that there is something stirring in there. But the gorge is closed, and the crater itself, with its heaps of lava and ash, a hollow one can walk upon. Then the whole surroundings look peaceful, inviting and reassuring: the lava hardens, the vine grows from the warm ground, and men build at the foot of the mountain and tell of old days, when the earth split open and the crater spewed fire. But that is long ago, the times of eruption are past; now there is no danger: thus a peaceful present, even if it is pregnant with the terrible, always has for the immediate sense something bewitching, indeed [38] something stupefying. For it smolders in there; it burns in the depths: suddenly, before anyone suspects it, a rumbling is heard, and the earth quakes, and the flame breaks out, and the catastrophe is there again with all its terrors.

It goes with the calm conditions in the world of spirit as in the world of nature; what the calm and the equilibrium signify, and how long it will last, depends on how, under what presuppositions and on what conditions it has been brought about. The equilibrium that at the present time apparently obtains between the principles of 1789 and the articles of faith of 1530, and in general between the religious and the humane endeavors in the civilized world, may rightly be called an unstable equilibrium. It has by no means proceeded from any true mutual understanding between the contending powers. Far from it! When decisive questions are raised, the principles still stand, in this century, just as sharply and irreconcilably against each other as at the end of the last. How, then, has

the apparent equilibrium been brought about? By a changed mood, by a finite agreement guided by practical considerations: the age of conditions, of means, of interests, understands admirably well how to deal in practical considerations and finite agreements. The Revolution went too far; its bloody consequences soon showed themselves to be revolting inconsistencies. It overthrew thrones because it tore down altars; that was abominable: then the sense for the despised religion was awakened again; the need for the faith of the fathers coincided with the need for civil order: then the prince of armies himself had to concede that a people cannot possibly live without positive religion. With this the power of the Revolution had for its part acknowledged religion, though, of course, not as an unconditional and self-valid end, but as a higher political means. On the other side, the champions of religion, in persistent, though by no means victorious, strife against “sound reason” [39] and negative knowledge, had at length learned that there must be a civil right and standing in the state independent of ecclesiastical confession of faith, and now found themselves referred chiefly to working on people’s hearts by means of feeling, fantasy and romanticism. After some violent scenes, during which a fanatical reaction, in order to quench the last revolutionary flames, had given ecclesiastical fury free rein, prudence at last gained so much of the upper hand that the contending parties found it advisable to tolerate one another.

What in the meantime has already been done to kindle the light of faith again and awaken the congregation that had fallen asleep, we shall appreciate with full acknowledgment; but we must expressly add that what has been achieved in this respect has been achieved, not by the scientific way, but solely by religious means. The theologians have, to be sure, in their own fashion endeavored partly to ward off the attacks of science on religion, partly to mediate between faith and knowledge; but that these endeavors, far from benefiting the cause of religion, have done it irreparable harm, of this the literature of the last century has furnished a proof that cannot be contradicted.

It is not the relation between church and state or between religion and politics, no, it is the relation between religion and culture, more precisely, between religion

and science, between the believing and the knowing consciousness, in which the knot was originally tied. As a contribution toward illuminating the cardinal point around which the spiritual life of the present age, with its hindrances and conditions, seen from the intellectual point of view, must be said to move, we shall in a few strokes indicate the principled opposition between the believing and the knowing consciousness, between the consciousness that will appropriate the spirit [40] of the Gospel and the consciousness that is filled and moved by the spirit of the world.

If we ask ourselves wherein man's advantage over the animal must originally be sought, the answer lies close at hand: it must be sought in consciousness. The animal's self-feeling loses itself in the sensuous, the momentary; its arbitrariness is led by instinct and drive; its understanding and memory are so taken up with sense-images and shifting representations that it cannot possibly get hold of itself, make its own being the object of a special intuition, or, in other words, come to engage in any self-contemplation whatever. If a horse, for example, or the dog with the clever eyes, could only a single time think to itself or say to itself in its own language: *I am an animal*, then such an animal would have an I, and the boundary between animal and man would be effaced. Man's consciousness is, in contrast to the animal's, expressly self-consciousness; herein lies this, that man has what the animal does not have, a free, personal self, that man is what the animal is not, a spiritual being, an I. It is now easy to understand that no human being can live with an entirely empty consciousness: consciousness must be filled and moved by a content; as the content is, so is the consciousness. The human being whose consciousness is filled up with sensuous representations, sensuous desires and temporal interests is a crude, sensuous and spiritless human being. Only when consciousness takes up and appropriates a content of an essential, universally valid nature, a distinctive content of ideas, so that the self can be said to live in it, to live from it and to live for it, does man become spirit. The idea by itself is not yet spirit, any more than the self by itself, without an idea, is spirit: spirit as spirit is the unity of the idea with the self. From this it follows that spirit

and consciousness must determine each other mutually: as the spirit is, so is the [41]
consciousness; as the consciousness is, so is the spirit.

Relying on these presuppositions, we shall now see whether we can get the opposition between the ideal powers of the age, the spirit of the world and the spirit of the Gospel, sufficiently cleared up. Let us begin with the spirit of the world.

When consciousness is filled by the idea, be it the idea of the state, of science, of art, or any contentful idea whatever, the self is freed from its natural limitation, its private egoism, is saturated with substance, is enlarged and uplifted. That is why all noble natures have an unmistakable need to give themselves up to the promptings of ideas and to live for something ideal. But when the universal satisfaction of the idea is, without further ado, to count as the absolute satisfaction of the self, then comes the contradiction. The self is temporal, the idea eternal; the unity of the temporal self and the eternal idea is an ambiguous unity, and the spirit of the world, as a consequence, an ambiguous spirit. At first it looks as if the personal self, by breathing in the idea, were to become eternal; but since the organic-physical conditions to which its individual existence is essentially bound are by no means secured by the movement of the idea, but on the contrary are exposed to danger: so it ends with this, that the individuality which has ventured the utmost in the service of the idea is, as it were, abandoned and betrayed by the idea, even though the sacrifice, which brings about the individual's downfall in the tragic moment, has something uplifting and infinitely satisfying for the individual itself. The contradiction is that the highest satisfaction of the self ends in the selfless; and the ambiguity is that this self-dissolution satisfies the self. Homer already saw what is typical here. That Hector, who fights so valiantly to save his fatherland by saving the city, is fighting for an idea, is clear enough; just as it is [42]
also clear that in the midst of the terrible battle he feels a higher satisfaction: in the temporal strife he enjoys the eternity of the idea. Then comes the last great moment; but in the great moment, when in battle with Achilles he must venture the utmost, then he stands, seen from without, forsaken by the gods and beguiled

by Athena, in other words: abandoned and betrayed by the idea. "Woe is me! now truly the gods of heaven call me to death! Fully I believed that brave Deiphobus stood at my side; but he is yonder in the city, and Athena has beguiled me" (Iliad XXII). It can almost make one indignant to witness the indifference and partiality of the gods toward the noble Hector; Athena's conduct in particular must seem to us unworthy. But such, now, are the ideal powers, the mightily ruling world-ideas; already before Homer's time they ended the game by giving up the self, and they do the same still to this very day. And yet, let us not wrong the high powers; there is in the gods of the world something divine that does not deceive. Hector understands it; he understands it heroically, just as it is to be understood in the great tragic moment. The gods withdraw their aid from him in outward things, for his goal is set, and his hour has come. Hector understands it: "Now is my rescue impossible; in former days Zeus and Phoebus Apollo, his son, saved me, who both of old graciously shielded me in danger, but now fate overtakes me." Yes, fate is the last, all-powerful world-power; the hero feels it; but does he then despair over fate? No, for he bows with resignation under fate. Does he perhaps mock the gods? No, for he prays to the gods: "Let me not then without deed, without glory perish here! Let me perform a feat that generations to come will remember!" And the gods hear [43] his prayer. The divine is infinitely near to him; for it is in himself, it strengthens him in the strife! "Speaking thus he drew from its sheath his sharpened sword, which was girt over his hip, a strong and mighty blade, then stormed forward like an eagle that, flying high through the air, swoops down from darkening clouds upon the plain and seizes either a new-born lamb or else a timid hare; so Hector stormed forward and swung his sharpened sword." Already in Homer's time, then, the high point had been reached, the heroic high point to which the spirit of the world is able to lift the self that sacrifices itself for the idea, that dissolves itself in the selfless essence: it was mythical in Homer's time, and it is mythical still to this very day.

If the self is to be saved by consciousness being moved, filled and streamed through by the idea of life, then the idea of life must not lose itself in the selfless

universal, but must in the spirit be one with the eternal, almighty self, the self that is the Word of life, the Word that from the beginning is one with God. "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. The same was in the beginning with God. All things were made by him, and without him was not any thing made that was made. In him was life, and the life was the light of man" (John 1:1). So speaks the spirit of the Gospel, not in order to promote a speculative knowledge, but in order to determine the principle of faith and to make clear its opposition to the spirit of the world.

The spirit of the Gospel does not deny the actual world with its actual laws; on the contrary! It is precisely it that makes the actual world with its strict laws into an educational institution for the human spirit, a school of self-development for the self. He, the Word of life, of whom it is said that he came unto his own, and his own received him not, did not come with pious fantasies and foggy representations of a world without laws; no, he came to the world of laws, so that he, who is [44] eternally one with the author of the laws, might at last, in the natural as in the spiritual, get the laws of selfhood fulfilled. "Whosoever will save his life shall lose it; and whosoever loseth his life for my sake shall save it." By these words the fundamental law of the Gospel is set in sharp opposition to the law of the world. According to the law of the world it holds, to be sure, that he who in cowardly fashion would save his life shall lose it; for only by venturing life for an idea can man win a life that is worth living. So the brave man stakes his life, and the soldier sings in *Wallensteins Lager*: "Und setzet Ihr nicht das Leben ein, nie wird Euch das Leben gewonnen sein". But the promise attached to the law, "whosoever loseth his life for my sake shall save it", the spirit of the world cannot utter; the moment it tries to, it becomes ambiguous and mythical. And what, indeed, has it to offer the hero who ventures the decisive thing? Only the old dilemma: "either Caesar or nothing"! These alternatives are well worth noting. The idea can, on given terms, afford the self the highest selfish satisfaction; at the heroic high point of self-satisfaction the hero is then a Caesar: from this side it looks as if the law of the world really were an original law of selfhood. But it is a semblance; the

glorification of the heroic self bears the stamp of contingency, is dependent on fortune, on Caesar's fortune. Against fortune stands misfortune; and the law of the world, indifferent toward the single self, is as much bound up with misfortune as with fortune. The law of the world is the law of changes, of outwardness, of circumstances, of chance encounters, of shifting conditions, in a word: the law of otherness; and when it turns this side forward, then fate presses, then the hero [45] turns pale, then even a Caesar becomes a nothing. In its fulfillment, continually hovering between selfhood and otherness, between the self and the selfless, the law of the world is as ambiguous as the spirit of the world.

But in the law of the Gospel there is no ambiguity; it is from first to last an absolutely decisive law of selfhood, and as such a law of freedom. The law of the Gospel exempts no one from the burdens of actuality, but it transforms the outward hindrances into conditions for the development of the self, and makes the burdens light; it exempts no one from pain and death, but it gives patience in pain and victory over death: that lies in its essence as an unconditional law of selfhood. Through its own negation, its inner resistance, its hostile other, the self gets itself fully into its own power; through corruptibility it enters into incorruptibility; therefore it behooved him who fulfills the law, the perfect law of freedom, to enter into glory through suffering and death. Where the self conquers under the law of the world, there it conquers egoistically, for if it is sacrificed, then it vanishes in the selfless and thus does not conquer: it cannot possibly both be sacrificed and yet conquer. When, on the other hand, the self conquers under the law of the Gospel, then it conquers precisely by self-sacrifice. Self-sacrifice is so far from annihilating the free self that on the contrary it strengthens, purifies and glorifies it: so divine is the law of selfhood, now that the exemplar, the eternal self, who alone has been able to fulfill it, has put it into force.

"The tragic hero," says a great author, "needs tears, and he demands tears." Right! for he needs compassion and demands compassion: his suffering expresses the universal, that the dissolution of the self is its transfiguration. He demands tears. Right! for he awakens melancholy. The dissolution of the self is its vanishing:

it vanishes for those who live on after it, and it vanishes for itself; the final transfiguration is the melancholy result, the contradiction softened in mood, that [46] the one transfigured is no longer himself, but another, a spiritual afterglow of himself, a memory. It is otherwise with the exemplar of faith; he rejects all tragic tears, for he rejects compassion. His suffering does not threaten him with self-dissolution, it only confirms the superiority of the self; just because the way of sufferings is his way to glory, he can say to the weeping women: "Daughters of Jerusalem, weep not for me, but weep for yourselves, and for your children."

That two principles as opposed as the Gospel and the spirit of the world must at all times move the race in opposite directions is a matter of course. It is not only the Middle Ages that have been dualistic; the modern age too is, and every following age will continue to be, dualistic. How indeed should the dualism be able to vanish? It certainly cannot happen through the spirit of the world, with its ideas, its tasks of actuality and its interests, vanishing; for that vanishes only with the destruction of the world. Then it would have to happen through the spirit of the Gospel, with its divine exemplar, its gifts of grace and its promises, vanishing from the earth; but then every human self would first have had to learn to defy the law of freedom and to prefer death to life. No, the point is not that the dualism is to vanish; but the point is that each age must conceive and determine the character of the dualism in its own distinctive way. In the present age the opposition is veiled, the dualistic subdued. This comes from the fact that the consciousness of the world, with its interests in the present, has stepped into the foreground. The truth which the Gospel tacitly presupposes, but which the Middle Ages could not rightly bring out, that a living for what is to come is inseparable from a vigorous living in the present, that the development of humane ideas belongs essentially to [47] the actual kingdom of the spirit, our age has given such preponderance that the heavenly is close to being absorbed into the earthly, as a prime number divides into its product. If the heavenly and the earthly, the spirit of the Gospel and the spirit of the world, are to keep to their mutual heterogeneity, to go on forming extremes without yet being separated by a gaping chasm, then the extremes must

have a middle; such a middle is precisely the spirit of the people.

How the spirit of the people and the life of the people are determined by each other has already been discussed in general terms; here we shall further attempt, if only provisionally, to determine the popular a little more closely. What is the popular? It is the fundamentally human in its naturally vigorous distinctiveness. It is heard often enough in recent times that man is a rational being; more rarely is due emphasis laid on this, that man according to his nature is originally a religious being; and yet not only must both fundamental determinations be derived from this, that man is a self-conscious being, a personal self, but the first must even be capable of being regarded as derived from the last. As a religious being, man stands through the world in relation to God; for the personal self the relation to God is the original one. As a rational being, man stands in relation to the natural order of things, so that thorough insight into the relations of the world becomes an essential task for him. The cognition of the relation to God is a religious cognition and rests on faith; cognition of the idea of the world and of the nature of things is a cognition of reason and rests on knowledge. Man, then, by nature as man, and thus as a popular individual, has an inward, essential need both for faith and for knowledge, as surely as he has by nature an inward, essential need [48] both for cognition of God and for cognition of the world. Self-consciousness is, and according to its nature must necessarily be, a consciousness doubled in itself: consciousness of another, and consciousness of itself. As its other, self-consciousness has in the absolute sense God, in the relative sense the world; in accordance with its fundamental doubling, human consciousness will then, with regard to this, divide itself into consciousness of God and consciousness of the world. What thus holds of every popular individual, when we look at the natural endowments and the corresponding need, must incontestably hold of the people as a people. Every people, then, begins its spiritual life with a doubled fundamental consciousness, a doubled endowment, a doubled need, a need for religious and for rational self-development, a need for the salvation of souls and a need for culture.

Now if a popular development of spirit either were, or in actual history could

be, normal, then it would surely show how the religious life and the life of culture, separated according to the fundamental doubling into two absolutely heterogeneous spheres of consciousness, would, by virtue of the unity of the personal self-consciousness with itself, develop through all doublings in harmonious interaction; but since no history of a people is normal, we must conduct the proof the other way around. The life of the people is, in its first spiritually vigorous beginning, predominantly religious; only gradually, as the development of reason and with it culture advances, does the consciousness of the world gain preponderance over the consciousness of God. How long religion will be able to counterbalance rising culture will prove to depend precisely on the depth in which the relation of opposition was conceived from the beginning, and thus on the dualistic fundamental doubling. The difference between the Greeks and the Jews is characteristic in this respect.

It has been aptly said of the Greek gods that in all their supernaturalness and superhuman bliss they were all too natural, all too human. Herein lies this, [49] that among the Greeks the consciousness of God coincided too immediately with the consciousness of the world. The Greek faith was without depth, without inwardness and ethical seriousness. The more the divine figures pressed forward, so to speak, to have their revelations aesthetically perfected, the more the religious faith was transformed into aesthetic faith, into an aesthetic mood determined by the intuition of fantasy. We see it in Homer. The domestic Olympian scene (Iliad I), in which Hera's taunts put Zeus into such a paternal rage that both men and gods must burst out laughing, is surely by no means designed to give the gods over—as a Lucian did much later—to mockery and contempt; no, it is a proof that the poet, without troubling himself about religious reverence, has made use of his poetic motif and transformed religion into poetry. While religion was thus gradually transformed into poetry among the cultured, the immediate, popular religious faith sank down into crude, fantastic superstition, and philosophy obtained, in the name of reason, the right to apply criticism and let knowledge dissolve faith. Although the condemnation of Socrates must surely have made Plato cautious,

he still cannot keep silent that the Homeric gods ought to be excluded from the Republic.

While the religious development among the Greeks was, even fairly early, hindered and pushed back by culture, conversely the development of culture among the Jews was in several respects hindered and pushed back by religion. If the Greek consciousness of God was absorbed immediately into the consciousness of the world, the Jewish consciousness of the world was in return absorbed immediately into the consciousness of God. Among the Jews, too, we miss the thoroughgoing opposition between the kingdom of God and the kingdom of the world to which [50] the original doubling of consciousness must consistently lead; but admittedly in the way we had to expect it among the chosen people, at the first stage of revelation, where the divine emphasis falls on religion. In the Jewish theocracy the difference between religious and civil legislation is abolished; the kingdom of David is a kingdom of God, the morality of the prophets a religious politics. The faith in Jehovah's requital by temporal punishments and temporal rewards corresponds to this. The consequence of this was that the life of the spirit, with its free inwardness, lost itself more and more in a crystallized outwardness. After the Exile, when the prophetic voices at last fell silent, the religious content was petrified in traditions; the people, without inwardness of faith and without culture, was led by Pharisees and scribes.

If we cast a glance at the Roman people, we get a truly uncanny representation of what a finite mixture of religiosity and worldliness signifies. The Roman gods are gods of the world in the lowest, most prosaic meaning of the word; these gods of the understanding, spiritless in themselves, pettily attentive to pettily calculated ceremonies and endless formulas, have no other aim than a boundless expansion of the power of the Roman Empire; nothing else to think about than how they might be of use and benefit to the Roman citizens in agriculture, cattle raising, sheep breeding, etc. That so official a religiosity must at last become comic to itself, once it became conscious of its contradiction, was natural. In the end, after all, two augurs, despite all their Roman dignity, could not meet each other without

laughing. What were the augurs laughing at? It was a doubling of consciousness; it was only formal, and had never been real.

And what is the result of all this? That the life of the people perishes when religion is undermined! At the vigorous beginning, when all the elements of the spirit of the people are in full activity, religion is a spiritual power; the holy is [51] guarded with reverence: there is earnestness in the worship of the gods. But with growing culture a separation takes place in society; the separation is at once civil and religious. From the civil side the separation shows itself in this, that the great crowd is more and more excluded from participation in the government of the state and in public affairs. The exclusion is not arbitrary; it follows from the nature of the circumstances. It is difference in station in life, in wealth, in endowment, and above all, difference in culture, on which it turns. The development of culture is never founded, and can never be founded, directly on religion; it is a development, not of the consciousness of God, but of the consciousness of the world; it is reflection and criticism, knowledge and science in manifold, partly theoretical, partly practical ramifications and consequences, that originally furnish the ideal foundation of the life of culture. With this foundation the multitude never becomes familiar: the light shines in its eyes, but it is dazzled by the glare and cannot see. Were the multitude to keep pace, its eye would have to be cleared by another light; then a religious enlightenment with a corresponding cultivation of spirit would have to step in and keep pace with culture. Now when this does not happen, the great crowd sinks down into crudeness, ignorance and superstition; then the mass lives in the country in the condition of a peasantry, in the larger cities in the condition of a rabble, and the development of the people is brought to a halt. The state may be organized and enlarged, manners refined, science, art and literature make admirable progress: it does not help; the people's fate is decided, the pulse of life cut.

It is a tragic spectacle that each of the great states of antiquity presents as they approach the goal of the development of culture: in the middle a small circle of the truly cultured, such as have by upbringing and self-development truly [52]

appropriated culture; around them a multitude of the half-cultured, who take part in civilization at second and third hand, and around these again the thoughtless multitude, whose crudeness always forms the extreme that has over-refinement as its opposite. Think of Rome in the time of Augustus, the Roman knights, the Roman manners, the Roman luxury, and then a Roman rabble, hungry for bread and spectacles (*panes et circenses*), and one gets an impression of what it means that a spirit of a people can be extinguished, and a people perish.

The principle of popular culture is essentially religious. Only in the light of religion can the people as a people advance on the way of culture and be made a partaker in civilization; if this light is extinguished, the people sits in darkness. The nature religions vanish, one after the other; the lights of antiquity are put out, one after the other: only one light is not extinguished, and that is the light of the Gospel.

It is characteristic of Christianity that from its very beginning it announces itself as a common cause of the people. Christ's birth is proclaimed by the angels as a great joy that shall be to all the people; the aged Simeon, with the Christ child in his arms, praises God that his eyes have seen the salvation which is prepared for all peoples, the light that shall lighten the Gentiles. Christ's appearance is popular in the most proper sense of all. He speaks in the synagogue, he teaches from the ship, he preaches on the mount, and everywhere crowds stream to him, and the people gather round him and hear him gladly, for "he taught them as one having authority, and not as the scribes". The whole public life of Jesus is sacrificed to awakening and preparing the people. But so strong, again, is the dualism of the holy and the sinful that the sacrifice ends with an atoning sacrifice. Only when the atoning sacrifice has been made, and he who sacrificed himself has entered into
 [53] his glory, is the Spirit sent out and the congregation founded. The unity of the religious and the popular has precisely the fundamental doubling, the most decisive separation between the kingdom of God and the kingdom of the world, between the consciousness of God and the consciousness of the world, as its presupposition. Just because Christianity is absolutely heterogeneous with everything worldly,

it can in a spiritual manner take up and use everything worldly; it does not ask what the world-ideas are worth as relative ends in themselves; for to the absolute purpose they are all means. Why can being a fisherman and being a farmer be united, in popular fashion, with being a Christian? Because fishing and farming are not merely relatively, but absolutely heterogeneous with Christianity itself. For the same reason, then, being an artist and being a cultivator of science can also be united, in popular fashion, with being a Christian. Should the man of knowledge have reason to complain that his consciousness is halved because the theoretical cognitions of science do not coincide with the religious cognitions of faith, then the farmer could, after all, also complain that agronomic cognitions cannot be developed out of the Gospel.

On the terms of the fundamental doubling, then, religious enlightenment will be able to advance together with the enlightenment of culture, and both unite in a true enlightenment of the people. That the doubling must make stricter demands on the life of the spirit than the formal unity does is natural; that the stricter demands may provoke the consciousness of culture to resistance, and this resistance bring about a tension that at last discharges itself in a storm of the spirit, is possible: we shall see in what immediately follows on what the tension rests, and how it rises.

IV.

It is the spirit of the world, with its suggestions of thought and its movements of ideas in the cultural life of the present age, that we shall attempt to characterize in a few, but large and vivid, strokes. We shall consider this spirit, not from its bright side, but from its shadow side; for the bright side is already sufficiently acknowledged. That culture and enlightenment, education and science, are essential goods, every rational human being sees, and what is fully acknowledged by everyone needs no praise or commendation of ours. But the dark side! The spirit of the world, not as the spirit of culture and progress, but as the spirit of delusion, of strong errors, of fateful necessity, has this being now also been sufficiently seen through, is it perfectly transparent to the consciousness of culture, or should there not be obscurities here in the depths, for the clearing up of which a stronger light might be needed? Here, of course, there is to be no talk, individual by individual, of any particular ungodliness in the single individuals of this time—to inveigh against the excesses of freethinkers and the blasphemies of deniers of God we must leave to the preachers of repentance—here, on the whole, there is to be no talk of the unbelief of individuals, but of the spirit of unbelief in the individuals, a spirit that poisons the air of life, deposits nodes of poison, and from the poisonous nodal points spreads out and attacks what is noblest and best in society. It is chiefly science that this spirit misuses; through natural philosophy, history and psychology it seeks, by misleading criticism, to distort the truth of faith; through knowledge and science it breathes poison into souls. But then is it perhaps the fault of science? By no means! Science is pure and noble and good when it is

allowed to count for what it originally is, in its objective scientific character. To cast a shadow on science little becomes an academic teacher, and would be in conflict with the truth: no branch of science is either dangerous or corrupting in and for itself. Only an outlived papism can, in desperate struggle against the strong light-bringing ideas, hit upon pronouncing a curse on the scientific progress of our time. No, it is neither the sciences nor the knowing individualities that we are speaking of; we are speaking of something moving that perverts the idea and gives it a false direction. We are speaking of a negative, impersonal-half-personal monstrosity which brings it about that the semblance of science beguiles the man of knowledge; we are speaking of a thinking without a thinker, a willing without a will; it looks somewhat mystical—what, one wonders, can it be? We need not exactly sink down into the innermost darkness of the God-denying will, or lose ourselves in broodings over what Scripture calls the depths of Satan, in order to get hold of our mystical monstrosity; we keep to what is nearer, less inhuman and more comprehensible, and then designate the spirit of the world, seen from its shadow side, as the juggling spirit of the age. In order to get sight of the spirit of the age we must direct our gaze particularly to the consciousness of culture and to the fundamental idea ruling in the era. The age of means, of conditions, of interests, is not forsaken by ideas. It is, to be sure, tempted in practical matters [56] to forget the absolute, the unconditioned, but theoretically it does not forget it; the age of culture can never forget that its clearest, purest light proceeds from knowledge and science; in science it has its absolute: the idea of knowledge is the ruling fundamental idea. Now that the idea of knowledge can be said to be both half-personal and impersonal is easy to see. If there were no knowers, there could not, after all, be any knowledge either: the idea of knowledge must be borne and moved by knowing individualities. But the knowing individualities must then also at the same time find themselves so filled, penetrated and moved by the idea that it is not their own thoughts that subjectively determine the essence of the idea, but conversely the essence of the idea, with its necessary laws, the eternal truths, that objectively determines the thoughts. But “the eternal truths” and universally

valid laws are, after all, impersonal: the fundamental movement is thus this, that the impersonal determines the personal, that the selfless gets power over the self. In this hovering between the self and the selfless, self-reflection at last becomes uncertain of itself. The man of knowledge thinks “the eternal truths” and is by this thinking sunk in the universal, and by the universal moved to intellectual resignation. But the man of knowledge at the same time exists in a world of finite, actual interests. Interest is selfish; for the sake of interests the existing thinker is most emphatically called upon to assert his personal right and to lay selfish weight on his own self. At once infinitely resigned and yet finitely interested, the knowing individuality is thus moved both impersonally and yet personally: where, now, does the absolute truth lie?

The absolutely personal truth lies outside the boundary of knowledge and can be grasped in faith alone. On these terms the man of knowledge would then have absolutely to acknowledge a principle of truth that is higher than knowledge; but precisely that which in the deepest sense alone is able to satisfy the self's [57] demand, the man of knowledge now regards as a contradiction in the self's essence, a desperate self-contradiction: here is the deception. From this deception the immediately existential temptations, and all the confusion of thought with which the spirit of the age corresponding to the fundamental idea dazzles and beguiles the man of culture, must essentially be derived.

It is by no means the idea as idea that beguiles the knowing individuality; it is on the contrary the individuality that, by deifying its knowledge and taking the idea in vain, dazzles and beguiles itself. The absolutely personal claim of the man of culture science cannot and shall not satisfy; from the objective standpoint of the deification of knowledge such a claim must quite rightly be rejected. But an absolutely personal claim the personality cannot, after all, reject; each time it is pushed back, it presents itself anew. The absolutely personal is the ideal of freedom; but the “eternal truths” of knowledge rest in necessity. Captive of necessity, the man of culture must then ceaselessly yearn for freedom. The spirit of the time that dazzles him is to be called an unstable, fickle spirit precisely for this reason, that

it continually hovers between two poles, between the bright region of freedom and the dark region of necessity; in order to hide the deception and complete its juggling play, it first falls in love with the light of freedom and turns away from dark necessity, but then freedom is in turn to be semblance, and necessity itself the source of enlightenment.

We are reminded of Asa-Loke from the old myths. Loke is of giant nature, but richly gifted, full of wit and cleverness, lovely to look at when he turns toward the light, so that Odin himself in the morning of time entered into sworn brotherhood with him. Though a giant, he feels himself drawn to the Aesir, he lets himself [58] be used in the service of light; but he never becomes truly at home in the region of light; his inner being is too dark for that. Seen from the shadow side he is hideous, and this hideousness testifies precisely to his giant nature. Thus with Angerbode he has begotten the Fenris wolf, the Midgard serpent and Hel, and stands constantly in league with the realm of darkness. He lacks neither liveliness nor criticism; but his liveliness is dissolute, and his malicious reflections consume his will. By these and similar traits Loke may well show himself as an image of the spirit of the age, but yet only of the spirit of the age in general, as the false, ambiguous spirit of the world. Our task is expressly this, to determine the spirit of the age in the present by showing how, from a mystified knowledge as from a shadowy background, it carries on its juggling play.

To begin with sheer lies cannot be done; a pure lie is moreover a contradiction, for in every lie there are always a few grains of truth: a lie is truth bungled, a fraction of truth that passes itself off as a whole number. Every intellectual mystification must begin with something unambiguous in order to introduce the ambiguous. It is, for example, an unambiguous proposition that he who has said A must also say B; on this proposition the emphasis now falls when the spirit of the world, with the help of knowledge, sets about confusing culture. If one has granted a presupposition, then one is compelled, whether one will or not—if, that is, one does not want to stand as a thoughtless person in self-contradiction—to grant its consequences. It is perfectly true and unambiguous that he who says A

must say B; but if, over this unambiguous thing, one forgets to examine whether the presuppositions are homogeneous or heterogeneous with the consequences drawn from them, then the ambiguity comes. The proposition is valid only on the condition that presuppositions and consequences belong to the same sphere: [59] from presuppositions in one sphere one cannot possibly derive consequences that are to hold in another. Thus there is something called harmony, both in the sphere of tones and in that of colors; now if someone places the presupposition in the harmony of tones, and derives from it consequences for the colors, then he becomes a sophist, and yet one can say: harmony is always harmony. One can speak of the hardness of stones and of the hardness of hearts, and one can say in general: hardness is always hardness; but one cannot, from determinations about the hardness of stones, derive consequences for the hardness of hearts, or conversely. One can speak of light in the spirit and of light in nature, and one can say that the concept light is always light; but one cannot derive from the natural light consequences for the spiritual. Here, then, is the subtlety: before one is well aware of it, everything is turned around; consequences in one sphere are slipped in under presuppositions in another. If one goes along with such a logic, one lets oneself be fooled, and once the sophistry has got going, there will be no lack of reflection and dialectic to complete the deception. So it is when religion and science are in question.

With religious presuppositions one must bow to religious consequences, and likewise in science to scientific ones; in this there is no ambiguity. But if one now turns it around so that one would derive scientific consequences from religious presuppositions, and conversely, then we have the sophistry. It is in this sophistry of the spirit of the age that the corruption lies; it is this that attacks personal life from the root; it is this that makes the powers of the spirit decline, characters grow weaker, and individualities weakened by doubt flutter up toward the light of faith without yet being able to believe. We are, as has been said, poisoned; the poison [60] is a sophistical mixture of heterogeneous elements that mutually consume one another. One can, in order to demonstrate this, proceed from natural science, from

history, from psychology. In the present connection we shall dwell on natural science.

When the spirit of the age dazzles the consciousness of culture through natural science, the sophistry begins roughly thus: "It is certain that we all, without regard to subjective wishes, ought to seek the truth, for truth is, after all, the highest, the eternal." In this there is no ambiguity. "Further, we ought to acknowledge that where there is truth, there must also be actuality. We know, to be sure, from the higher logic that the concept of actuality does not fully exhaust the concept of truth, but where there is complete truth there must necessarily be a corresponding actuality. If the truth conflicts with the facts of actuality, then something is lacking; the truth is then only half, and in this halfness to that extent untrue." Here, then, the consciousness of culture, insofar as it turns negatively against the highest, lays a special stress on the word actuality, and points out—in a certain sense with full right—that what we call actuality is something for which we must in practical life have unconditional respect. If we had no respect for the actual facts, we could not, after all, even walk on our own or move freely in the world of things; we would then, for example, not respect the separation between rock and abyss or between fire and water. Everyone knows that when he puts his hand into the fire he must burn himself; he need not repeat the experiment many times, no, a single experiment is enough, even for a Mucius Scaevola. It is only skeptical perversity [61] and speculative affectation to want to make experience uncertain by letting it rest on a sum of many single cases, or depend on rules that always admit exceptions. Certainly there are facts whose distinctive natural constitution can be secured to our experience only after many-sided observations and careful tests; but doubt about particular empirical propositions not yet sufficiently tested is essentially different from doubt about the whole reason-determined foundation of experience.

Those deep-seeing men who, in the name of a more ideal knowledge, think they can raise themselves above "the patchwork of the empirical sciences" by a remark such as this, that the "so-called laws" of natural philosophy are determined only by induction, and that induction, as an imperfect inference, stands far below

the categorical syllogism, would do well to think a little before they go further. If it is an uncertain inference that the attraction of masses varies inversely as the squares of their distances, then it is also an uncertain inference that he who jumps into the water must get wet. If it is an uncertain inference that oxygen and hydrogen under determinate conditions must combine into water, then it is also an uncertain inference that he who is beheaded loses his life. Now should anyone, for the sake of induction, doubt the universal validity of either the mechanical or the chemical inference, let such a deeper-seeing man, for the sake of induction, once try whether, in spite of the merely empirical laws, he might not succeed in living without a head.

To refute an induction of natural science it is of little use to raise doubts, in empty generality, about the abstract logical validity of induction; no, the demand, the true scientific demand, is that one demonstrate in concreto cases, if only a single one, that manifestly conflict with the result determined by the determinate [62] induction. And when such a case occurs, what then? Why, even then it is not the general scientific validity of induction as induction that is shaken, but it is a particular induction, applied to particular cases, that is corrected. The scientific doctrine of experience has a foundation as secure in its kind as any a priori science of reason whatever. It is not what is uncertain and wavering in the results of the natural sciences that is to comfort us in our anxieties for the religious truths; no, it is something else; it is, in the first place, an unmasking of a peculiar deception that lies in the spirit of the age.

We shall now see the deception as, in order to characterize the spirit of the age, we set about deriving religious consequences from scientific presuppositions and, conversely, scientific consequences from religious presuppositions; we shall see in some examples how the sophistry gets into motion.

An example from the Old Testament! Jehovah, it is said (Gen. IX), expressly sets the rainbow in the clouds as by a solemn act he makes a covenant with Noah. The religious presupposition is now this, that Jehovah really by a determinate act of will set this sign, thus worked a miracle, and, what is after all also a miracle,

spoke to Noah and interpreted the sign to him. "I will set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be for a token of a covenant between me and the earth. And it shall come to pass, when I gather the cloud over the earth, that the bow shall be seen in the heaven, and I will remember my covenant, which is between me and you and every living soul of all flesh, and the waters shall no more become a flood to destroy all flesh; but the bow shall be in the heaven, and I will look upon it, and remember the everlasting covenant between God and all flesh that is upon the earth."

[63]

Now if we are to be allowed to draw a scientific consequence from this religious presupposition, then we had surely best, the sooner the better, throw optics into the fire. For optics cannot and will not in any way see in the rainbow either a miracle or an express token of remembrance of God's covenant with all flesh. Optics explains the rainbow simply and solely by the angle of refraction of the rays of light, thus as a naturally necessary consequence of natural conditions.

Let us then try going the opposite way; let us make quite clear to ourselves how the rainbow is formed under certain conditions, and how we can see rainbows not only in the clouds but also in fountains: then we have here a secure scientific presupposition. Now if from this scientific presupposition one is to draw religious consequences, one comes into conflict with religion. For, say the knowing ones, we know that what is said in the Old Testament about the rainbow is nothing actual, but a fantasy; the Old Testament does not know the formation, conditions and laws of the rainbow. It is a childlike spirit, unacquainted with the actual facts, that speaks in the words put into Jehovah's mouth. But if this is so, then it cannot be true either that Jehovah himself spoke to Noah of any covenant; the covenant itself is here just as imagined as the explanation given of its phenomenon. When the unknown author of the first book of Moses has Jehovah say: "And it shall come to pass, when I gather the cloud over the earth", or: "when I bring the cloud forth", then he conceives Jehovah the cloud-gatherer just as figuratively, childishly and mythically as Homer conceives Zeus the cloud-gatherer (Νεφέληγερέτα Σεύς). Now if it is on the whole characteristic of the spiritual life of the era that movements of thought

in such opposite currents pass back and forth through the consciousness of culture, what wonder, then, if the doubts grow with a quiet growth; what wonder that [64] those who are touched by them content themselves with palliatives of aesthetically staged worship, with a little of faith and a little of knowledge, and feel but slight need to engage with deeper religious problems.

Another example! In the first chapter of the first book of Moses we meet the highest, the first of all religious presuppositions, in the account of the creation. "In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth." Attention fastens at once upon the earth: "And the earth was without form, and void," and so on. Around the earth as center the heaven must vault itself as an outstretched firmament in the midst of the waters. "And God made the firmament, and divided the waters which were under the firmament from the waters which were above the firmament: and it was so." It is said here expressly that the heavenly bodies came into being for the earth's sake. "And God made two great lights; the greater light to rule the day, and the lesser light to rule the night: he made the stars also. And God set them in the firmament of the heaven to give light upon the earth."

The earth, seen from the standpoint of religion, is thus not merely the physical center of cosmic space but, if we may say so, the apple of God's eye, because there is something on the earth that God prizes unconditionally, namely man, who bears his own image. Just as the starry heaven with sun and moon exists for the earth's sake, so the earth in turn exists for man's sake: man is not merely the lord of the earth, but the crown of creation. Precisely for this reason it is regarded as a cosmic catastrophe that man succumbed in temptation and lost his image of God; and precisely for this reason it is regarded as a new creation that God himself, in his only-begotten Son, by taking upon himself flesh and blood, raises up the fallen race and gives it back the lost image. Precisely for this reason it is said that when [65] Christ's kingdom has been proclaimed to all the heathen, then follows the last catastrophe, the destruction of the world and the judgment. When Christ foretells the destruction of the world, he says that there shall be signs in the sun and moon, that the sun shall be darkened and the stars fall. This is the fundamental view of

revealed religion, and this fundamental view is not accidental. Everything from first to last is so coherent that, if we shake one thing, we end by dissolving the whole: the world that is to be a stage for God's own becoming man must be a central world, the highest center point in the universe.

If one is now, without further ado, to draw scientific consequences from this religious presupposition, then one must break the staff over the physics and astronomy of the present age. For astronomy does not admit, cannot and will not admit, that this earth is the center of the world. On the contrary! if one will hear the voice of science, one gets another view of the world, a real view of the real.

What astronomy teaches us about the structure of the world is not loose opinions and empty conjectures; it is real facts and real laws, something so incontrovertible that one cannot toss it to the winds. It holds here that the more cultivated a man is, the greater respect he has for actual nature and its laws. The lower he stands, the more easily he settles down in the fancy that the learned do not after all really know the matter, and that one gets the true physics and the right astronomy only by taking the words of the Bible literally. Yes, on the lazy cushion of faith in the letter one slumbers sweetly off; but one does not sleep one's way to the cognition of truth. If the eye is sound and the understanding awakened [66] to see with what certainty and consistency science proceeds in determining the relation between earth and heaven, one will recognize that the earth, far from being the center of the world, is not even the center of the small part of the world that is called our solar system. The propositions belonging here are not merely set up; they are also grounded. Whoever, face to face with science at its present standpoint, would be able to doubt the incontrovertibility of a proposition such as this, that it is not the sun that moves around the earth but the earth that moves around the sun, that it is therefore the sun and not the earth that is the center of the planetary system,—let him doubt the incontrovertibility of the proposition that a headless man cannot live. That the earth in our little world is a comparatively slight magnitude beside globes such as Jupiter, Saturn, and Uranus is clear to anyone who has gained an insight into science. Now let one consider those holy

words: “There shall be”—for the earth’s sake—“signs in the sun, and in the moon, and in the stars: the sun shall be darkened, and the moon shall not give her light, and the stars shall fall from heaven, and the powers of heaven shall be shaken.” And why? Because the goal on earth has been reached; because the course of mankind’s life is at an end, because the highest has been proclaimed to all peoples and either appropriated in faith or rejected in unbelief.

How it will go now when one is to draw religious consequences from scientific presuppositions, anyone can easily tell himself. It stands written in the Book of Revelation (VI, 12–13): And I beheld when he (the Lamb) had opened the sixth seal, and, lo, there was a great earthquake; and the sun became black as sackcloth of hair, and the moon became as blood; and the stars of heaven fell unto the earth, even as a fig tree casteth her untimely figs, when she is shaken of a mighty wind.” At the root of the assumption that the stars could fall to the earth there lies evidently a [67] twofold representation: partly that the stars are very small in comparison with the earth, partly that the distance between heaven and earth cannot, after all, be so extraordinarily great.

Among the ancients something is told that testifies to how little the human imagination is able to grasp the enormous distances in the universe. Homer (*Iliad*, I, 586) has Hephaistos, who would so gladly stand by Hera against the angry Zeus, address his mother: “The Olympian lord is hard to fight against. Once before, when I would come to help thee, he seized me by the foot and hurled me from the threshold of the gods. The whole day long I floated about, but when the sun went down I fell upon Lemnos, and there was little life left in me.” One shudders to imagine the falling Hephaistos floating a whole day between heaven and earth; in Hesiod this floating is even extended to nine days and nine nights, but what does that amount to? How far, then, might it be from the earth to a star outside the solar system, to a fixed star?

If we consider the height of one of the nearest fixed stars, then we must use the speed of light, 40,000 miles a second, as our measure, and not the fall of Hephaistos. The distance from the sun to the earth, which is 20 million miles, is traversed by

light in 8 minutes and 13 seconds; but from the nearest fixed star, Alpha Centauri, light is $3\frac{1}{2}$ years on its way, from Sirius 14 years, from the Pole Star 42 years, before it reaches the earth. The Pole Star could thus be extinguished and yet still shine for us for 42 years after it had gone out. These are enormous distances, and yet they dwindle to insignificant magnitudes when we raise our gaze to the stars of the Milky Way, to stars of which it can be said without exaggeration that they [68] shine for us with pre-Adamite light.

If, to humor the spirit of the age, we permit ourselves the folly of drawing religious consequences from scientific presuppositions, then in truth it will be religion that pays the price. If the religious view of the starry heaven cannot have true religious validity unless it agrees scientifically with the astronomical, then let us be honest and say to Christ in all candor: Lord, thou hast been mistaken, thou hast not studied thy astronomy; and since thou art not especially sure in thy astronomy, neither dare we believe unconditionally that thou art always entirely sure in thy theology. Thou speakest of the stars falling from heaven on the day of judgment. How should they fall from heaven, unless thy meaning were that they should fall upon the earth? But Sirius and the Pole Star and the still more distant suns cannot possibly fall upon the earth, since the earth is a vanishing point in comparison with them.

Let us leave the heavens and dwell on the earth, and see whether it is not permitted here to draw religious consequences from scientific presuppositions, or conversely; it sounds so fine that science should be a little religious, and religion a little scientific. The holy word of revelation speaks of the creation of the earth; the speech is pithy and brief. The earth was without form and void, and darkness was upon the deep, and the Spirit of God moved upon the waters; then the word of the Almighty is heard, and day by day the work advances to completion. After the completion of creation, after man, formed of earth, has been created in God's image, there is then told of Paradise and of the state in which the spirit of peace and blessing rested over what had been created. "And God saw every thing that he had made, and, behold, it was very good." This is a true and essential religious

presupposition, and whoever undermines this presupposition, seen as principle, undermines religion. But if scientific consequences are to be drawn from it, then [69] one must necessarily break the staff over geology. Geology is a new science, which as such still has many obscurities; but it advances boldly: it already has its secure method, its measure, and its correctives. By breaking the staff over so thoroughly investigating a science, we would come into decisive conflict with the whole of culture. Conversely, if one is to draw religious consequences from scientific presuppositions, that is, to start from the doctrine of the terrestrial body and of the development of organic life on the earth, then one arrives at the result that creation cannot have come about as is told in the first book of Moses. Long, long intervals must then have passed before the one kind of creatures followed upon the other; the earth itself must have undergone many transformations before man could appear upon it. And what becomes of the Garden of Eden: modern science surely has no room at all for a Paradise? No, the literature of the Middle Ages knows all about Paradise; we see it in Dante's *divina comedia*. In Dante's time Jerusalem with Mount Zion was still the center of the earth on this side; for its antipode it then had, on the other side, the mountain of Purgatory, on whose summit Paradise lay, the blessed earthly one, where Dante met his Beatrice. But if in our time one is to draw religious consequences from scientific presuppositions, then there has never been any earthly Paradise. One thing more! According to Scripture sin came into the world through man, and death through sin; hence death is the wages of sin, and whoever violates this proposition violates the religious. But if one is to draw scientific consequences, one must violate this presupposition; for geology shows that many lower and higher races of animals fought with one another and [70] devoured one another long before man came into being, that there has thus been death and pain before man, that corruptibility did not come because man sinned, but that man sinned because he came into being in corruptibility. If it is now really true that the world-spirit, under present conditions more precisely determined as the spirit of the age, conjures up its illusions precisely in this, that scientific and religious rays of light, in wildly crossing interferences, form juggling phantoms

of mist; if this, we say, is what is bewitching in the nature of the age, then such a nature must surely also become manifest in corresponding phenomena, and these phenomena contribute especially to a characterization of the spiritual life of the present age. We do not set ourselves up as judges over the present in its immediate actuality; we consider only the phenomena insofar as they must be assumed, with inner necessity, to accompany the spirit of the age.

Here, then, two extremes must first present themselves, two spiritually opposed conditions. For the farther the individuals stand from scientific enlightenment, the less will the results of science affect them, the more easily will they be able to hold fast the religious truths handed down in the Church and determined in the tradition; this is the condition in which the preponderant majority of a country's population naturally finds itself. Among the common people and the half-educated who have still preserved some essential earnestness, the word of revelation will then on the whole coincide with the word of the Church and of the Bible and hold with divine authority. The nearer the individuals stand, on the other hand, to the scientific light of culture, the more many-sided their culture is, and the more criticism is awakened, the more strongly will they be repelled by the wonders of Holy Scripture, by its simple words about the omnipotence of spirit. Fully assured [71] of the unconditional right of the scientific view of the world against the biblical, these knowing ones will then leave positive religion to be the affair of the common people, while they themselves, partly openly, partly in silence, labor with all their might to undermine the foundation of faith among the cultivated, to whom they then, when it is finally demanded, offer as recompense and full compensation a water-clear-unclear religion of thought, a religion of white on white and gray on gray, "the Absolute itself" in logical shadow-outline and metaphysical twilight.

Between these extremes surges the great mass, chiefly in the great cities, the mobile multitude of the more and less cultivated, who make up the age's knowing public, reflecting upon everything. If such a public is considered from its shadow side—and it is expressly the shadow side that we have before us here—then its mobility is to be explained most immediately by the fact that everything sits loose

in consciousness: knowledge sits loose, and faith sits loose. Certainly some faith still remains here, a dim impression of the mystical, a practical respect for what is ecclesiastically established. But, it goes without saying, the religion of the cultivated must of course be a “perfectible religion,” the priest of the cultivated a perfectible man, cultivated faith revised by knowledge; then the thing is to hit on the best arrangement and get an ecclesiastical order fixed firmly. But to fix something firmly where the ground is loose has its difficulties; so the public is worried, and its leaders worried, the unlearned worried for knowledge, the learned for faith: yes, here are worries of every kind; worries in the public and for the public, worries for the edifying in worries for the scientific, worries enough for “silken priests” and speculative theologians!

But in these worries there is no earnestness. And why not? Because it lies in the nature of the case that there can be none. When the hindrances to the spiritual life of the present age are traced originally to an intellectual confusion, an unclear mixture of religious and scientific considerations, then earnestness must correspond to this; if it is really to correspond to it, its fundamental task must be of an intellectual nature. The age must be willing to fix its gaze on the first hindrances in order to discover in them the first conditions; it must be willing to take the opposition between the religious and the scientific sharply into view. However great the gulf between faith and knowledge, religion and science, may be, so great that it looks like a yawning abyss: still there is no danger, if only thinking can be awakened to earnestness. The consciousness of culture can, when it will, understand that here, despite the opposition, there is something which the believer and the knower must have in common, and that is a true conviction. The consciousness of culture can, when it will, understand that true conviction cannot possibly form itself, whether on the side of faith or on the side of knowledge, without clear and thorough thinking, that faith, therefore, as surely as it is an independent principle of cognition, must have thinking with it, just as well as knowledge. The cultivated man must, when he will, be able to see that thinking, even if in relation to the absolutely heterogeneous principles it moves differently [72]

in the different spheres, will nevertheless everywhere be able to be understood by thinking, and the thinking consciousness understand itself. Here, in the many hindrances, is the possibility of just as many conditions; here is reflection enough, and the task of spirit requires reflection; here is culture enough, and the task of spirit requires culture; here is freedom enough, and the task of spirit requires freedom; but one thing is still needful: on this one thing everything will depend, and it is—earnestness.

V.

“Ye shall know,” says Christ, “the truth, and the truth shall make you free.” Modern knowledge takes up and appropriates these words in a rather peculiar way, and in this appropriation the world-spirit plants its ambiguities. We cognize the truth by testing the difference between true and untrue; the difference between true and untrue is tested by thinking: against this there is nothing to object; but now comes the distortion. Thinking, it is said, is thorough, clear, and pure only insofar as it is scientific. To cognize the truth, then, means to cognize in science what is valid and invalid in religion. The religious that withstands the test in science can be acknowledged; what does not pass the test must be rejected. According to this conception, then, the light of knowledge is the highest light. Science sits on Pilate’s judgment seat; religion is summoned, and the judge asks: what is truth? Yes, now the consciousness of culture understands what it means: “Ye shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free”; it means, of course: “Ye shall know science, and science shall make you free.” That science, scientifically seen, works, has worked, and will continue to work in a purifying and liberating way upon mind and thought is not only to be admitted, but, in order after all to avert foolish misunderstandings [73] so far as possible, to be impressed again and again. But liberation and liberation are two things. One thing is the liberation of consciousness from false opinions and ingrown prejudices; another is the liberation of the soul from the bonds of corruptibility to an eternal life; one thing is scientific, another personal truth. The truth of which Christ speaks is not the universally valid, impersonal, rationally necessary truth of science, but the personal, free, liberating truth. In speaking

of the truth, he speaks of himself about himself, and says expressly: "I am the way, the truth, and the life." Here is the knot that no science is able to untie, the knot that an existing personality is the truth, yes, that the eternal truth itself is this personality existing in flesh and blood. Let the science that with a telling expression calls itself the science of sciences, philosophy, exert itself with all its might; at the very most it will bring matters so far as to develop the concept of personality and of truth, and the unity of the concepts in the idea. Confusing the universal idea of personality with personality itself, one may then perhaps imagine that one has grasped the Absolute in the pure concept and furthered the truth by saying in Christ's name: "Ye shall know philosophy, and philosophy shall make you free." But is that the untying of the knot? It is surely a great misunderstanding. If philosophy, in the name of knowledge, wishes to subject the Gospel to a critique, to dissolve the historical Christ and transform the existence of the God-man into an idea, it shall be allowed to do so; although, as regards fruitfulness, one might well be tempted to the remark that long straw that has been threshed so often will hardly yield any grain. But what philosophy is in no way allowed to do is to

[75] pass off its critical dissolution of Christ's personal existence as a solution of the riddle of Christianity. That Christ, according to the evangelical conception—and this must surely count as the originally religious one—did not come into the world to help philosophy to a general concept of the idea of personality, but to give his life, his actual, personal life, for the salvation of the world, he has plainly proved in word as well as in deed. We hear him say in the Gospel of John (6th chap.): "I am the living bread which came down from heaven: if any man eat of this bread, he shall live for ever: and the bread that I will give is my flesh, which I will give for the life of the world." This is certainly a hard saying, for the knowing as well as for the unknowing. And yet the speaker himself lays decisive weight on his word. For when the Jews strove among themselves as to how he could give them his flesh to eat, he said to them: "Verily, verily, I say unto you, Except ye eat the flesh of the Son of man, and drink his blood, ye have no life in you." It is not the concept of bread but the actual bread that satisfies the hungry, and it is not the

idea of personality but the actual personality that saves the believers. In Christ's speech no distinction is made between knowing and not-knowing, for to both kinds of listeners the speech can be equally offensive; but a distinction is expressly made between believing and not-believing: only for those who do not believe is it offensive. "Doth this offend you? What and if ye shall see the Son of man ascend up where he was before? It is the spirit that quickeneth; the words that I speak unto you, they are spirit, and they are life. But there are some of you that believe not."

But, it is said, granted that Christ gives himself, not as the idea of personality but as actual personality, for the salvation of believers, still he will surely, as we [76] hear from his speech, not be appropriated in a sensuous manner by flesh-eating disciples and blood-drinking followers. No, his words, which are life only insofar as they are spirit, must be appropriated in spirit and in truth. But if in the end it comes down to the spirit and a spiritual appropriation of Christ, then the content of the spirit must surely be clarified by thinking, and by thinking the door of science opens, and behold, then we are deep inside knowledge! Yes, we are deep inside the misunderstanding, in full course of confounding the spirit of revelation with the spirit of science. For the rest, the knowing ones of the spirit of the age may judge of the spirit of revelation as they will; but one thing they must be able to see without critical overexertion, and that is that this spirit, in being and working, in coming and vanishing, has not the least likeness to the spirit of science. How did the spirit come upon the apostles at the feast of Pentecost? "And when the day of Pentecost was fully come (Acts ch. 2), they were all with one accord in one place. And suddenly there came a sound from heaven as of a rushing mighty wind, and it filled all the house where they were sitting." If a scoffer here permitted himself the remark that a spirit which comes with such a blast cannot be scientific: upon whom, then, would the scoff fall back? Not upon those who separate faith and knowledge! "And there appeared unto them cloven tongues like as of fire, and it sat upon each of them. And they were all filled with the Holy Ghost, and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance." It is necessary that

a spirit's peculiarity be characterized by its peculiar mode of working. But that the mode of working of the language-giving spirit is here not merely somewhat different but infinitely different from the scientific, no one will venture to deny.

[77] For further confirmation we will hear from the apostle Peter's own mouth how the spirit comes and how it works. How, then, does it come, and how does it work? "And it shall come to pass in the last days, saith God, I will pour out of my Spirit upon all flesh: and your sons and your daughters shall prophesy, and your young men shall see visions, and your old men shall dream dreams." Is there in such utterances the least hint that the apostolic spirit will ever be able to identify itself with the spirit of science? Certainly Christ will be appropriated in spirit and in truth, but the appropriation is not scientific: on the contrary, he says in Matthew, chap. 2, the well-known words: "I thank thee, O Father, Lord of heaven and earth, because thou hast hid these things from the wise and prudent, and hast revealed them unto babes." A stronger protest against the conception of science he could not lodge than when he expressly says that only babes understand him, and that the wise and prudent cannot understand him at all. The opposition between the babes and the wise is not an opposition between the thoughtless and the thinking; Christ has never said that he could not be understood by the thinking, but only by the thoughtless; how should he well be able to say to the thoughtless: "Ye shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free"? No, by the babes he means the simple, who begin with faith, whose cognition must therefore from first to last become a cognition of faith; by the wise and prudent he has in mind the knowing; and then his word holds literally, that the heavenly Father has hidden the truth of the Gospel from the knowing and revealed it to the believing.

That Christ will be appropriated not by the knowing but by the believing is seen also in his apostles. We must surely admit that the apostles appropriated

[78] Christ's personal life in a true, but not in a scientific way. They did not, by thinking about his personality, clarify for themselves the objective, universally valid concept of personality. Certainly Paul is a thinker, one of the greatest in the world, but his thoughts are not scientific. It is a downright mistreatment of the great thinker

to offer his doctrinal conception in the form of a scientific system, to take, if I may say so, the doctrinal conception up into the lecture chair while the apostle himself does not come into the lecture chair. Of a scientific thinker, a philosopher for example, it holds that when one tests his knowledge, his person is a matter of indifference. But when one tests an apostle's teaching, one tests at the same time his life. The apostle's thoughts are thoughts of personality, his so-called doctrinal conception a personal explanation of his faith, his life in Christ, his self-sacrifice for the congregation. How the spirit, where it works in power, ceaselessly transforms hindrances into conditions, while the world conversely presents these conditions as sheer hindrances, can, as we have already seen, be developed from the thought of faith, and the thought of faith be developed from the principle of faith, without its thereby being settled that he who thus develops the thought of faith is himself a believer. It is otherwise with an apostle; he develops the thought of faith in explaining his life. We choose an example from Paul: "Now ye are," he says to the "puffed up" Corinthians (1 Cor. 4), "full, now ye are rich, ye have reigned as kings without us: and I would to God ye did reign, that we also might reign with you. For I think that God hath set forth us the apostles last, as it were appointed to death: for we are made a spectacle unto the world, and to angels, and to men. We are fools for Christ's sake, but ye are wise in Christ; we are weak, but ye are [79] strong; ye are honorable, but we are despised. ... Being reviled, we bless; being persecuted, we suffer it; being defamed, we entreat: we are made as the filth of the world, and are the offscouring of all things unto this day." See, that is a part, a very essential part, of "the Pauline doctrinal conception"; but such a doctrinal conception cannot be filtered into scientific systematics unless one filters away the Pauline existence. But when one has got that unity of thinking and acting which characterizes the apostolic existence scientifically purified out, what then? Why, then the doctrinal conception is perhaps theological, but it is no longer apostolic.

Another distinguishing mark by which we can easily make the separation between scientific and religious thinking is the miracle. It is a characteristic mark of revelation: without miracle no revelation, and without revelation no faith. If the

miracle is taken away or pushed aside, then the character of revelation is blurred, then faith is weakened. Let science say of the miracle what it will; it cannot deny that the miracle is the characteristic mark of religion. To want to explain and ground religion scientifically without wanting to explain and ground the miracle scientifically is nonsense: if there is a science of religion, then there must also be a science of miracles. But the miracle is the barrier of knowledge; it is the skandalon of science. Science can, when it is made judge, deny the miracles, and with them religion; there is sense in that; but it cannot cognize religion and blur out the miracle. Christ's personality is a miracle. It is not enough to seek his peculiarity in this, that he has done many miracles: no, Christ is the miracle itself, the great miracle of revelation. With this it agrees consistently that the spirit which is to [80] explain Christ comes by a miracle, that faith, in which the gifts of the spirit are appropriated, is given by a miracle; from every side knowledge here strikes against its original barrier, its skandalon, namely the miracle.

It is true that people have wanted to take the matter from another side, saying that the miracle of religion is indeed not taken up into worldly knowledge, but that precisely for that reason a distinction has been made between worldly and sacred science. As sacred science, theology does not presume to want to comprehend the miracles, for the miracles are incomprehensible; no, not by comprehending, but by presupposing the incomprehensible and bringing out the facts of revelation and of faith in sharp strokes, theology would furnish a doctrine of faith in scientific form and reconcile faith with knowledge.

This standpoint has certainly been chosen with the best intentions, in the guileless presupposition that it would one day succeed, on the foundation of faith, in raising a new scientific edifice. But it will never succeed. Already this, that a foundation is laid here consisting of supernatural facts, hence of unscientific presuppositions, and that upon this foundation one would erect a doctrinal edifice of something scientific,—already this must, as has been shown in what preceded, arouse misgiving.

It has been said that the believing dogmatician relates himself to the sacred facts

in the same way as the natural scientist to the facts of nature; what an enormous misunderstanding! The natural facts show themselves, when the question is one of knowledge and science, as entirely heterogeneous with the sacred. The facts of nature are subject to the laws of nature; here one has the universally valid, the rationally necessary, that which makes testing and critique possible. What such a rationally necessary, universally valid foundation means can be seen even [81] in material forms. If it is asked, for example, what granite and flint are, these concepts, with the corresponding facts, can be fixed so definitely that everyone who has sound understanding, preliminary training, and a sense for scientific investigations—be he, for the rest, Jew, Greek, Mohammedan—without regard to national differences and faith, is compelled to admit the validity of the concepts: “This must be granite, this must be flint.” So also when the question is of sulfuric acid, carbonic acid, and so on. If, on the other hand, one looks to such supernatural facts as turning water into wine, walking on the sea, raising the dead, then it is impossible to present such facts in such a way that they take on the stamp of something universally valid or incontrovertible. Greeks, Jews, Roman Catholics, Protestants surely see the sacred phenomena with different eyes. Those who believe science cannot make unbelieving; those who do not believe it cannot make believing; here between faith and unbelief is a personal opposition which science cannot master. The essential difference between the natural and the sacred facts is seen, in this connection, from a new side. The natural facts are present. The objects of nature lie ready for ever-renewed testing, for the realm of nature is an ever-present realm. It is otherwise with the sacred facts; they can no longer become the object of renewed seeing for oneself. He who did the miracles is, after all, no longer sensuously present; the time of miracles is past: “There happen,” people say, “no miracles in our days.” The supernatural facts of revelation belong to the past. They are not to be compared with the facts of nature, but rather with those of history. The proposition is therefore altered to this, that the believing dogmatician relates himself to the sacred facts in the same way as the historian to the historical [82] facts. Will this work? The cognition of the facts of history does indeed presuppose

a historical faith; but the facts of the Gospel expressly demand a religious faith, and between religious faith (*fides religiosa*) and general historical faith (*fides historica*) there is a great gulf fixed. The historical facts science subjects to a critique; may we now also, asks the consciousness of culture, apply critique to the sacred facts? Yes or no? If the answer is no, it is of course instantly clear that the facts of sacred history acquire an entirely different position for consciousness from the facts of profane history. If biblical criticism is to be kept out by a dogmatic decree, then we must necessarily return to the old doctrine that every word, every tittle in Holy Scripture is inspired by God, that the Testaments, the Old as well as the New, are in each and every respect infallible documents of revelation. Scientific reflection must suddenly halt—by what? By authority—blind authority! And yet it is to be scientific! Instead of reasons, fully valid, scientific reasons, our dogmatician begins his “sacred science” by invoking blind authority. Let us consider blind authority a little more closely! The Mohammedans, for example, also have their document of revelation, their sacred facts, their authority. Besides the Koran the Sunnites acknowledge a living tradition, and in this tradition a multitude of divine fairy tales about the Prophet. He was, it is told, once mocked by the unbelievers because he could not at once prove his divine mission by a miracle. Long the mocked one [83] kept meekly silent; but at last his hour struck. The half-moon stood just then shining bright on the vault of heaven; he called to it, and it fell with a silver ring to the earth. Then he took it up and carried it under his arm, as one carries a chapeau-bas. When this was done, he threw it up into the air; it then flew back to heaven and shone, as before, on the vault. That is a sacred fact; woe to the Sunnite who cannot believe in such a miracle. By blind authority critique can certainly be halted; but, we ask, can such a halting be regarded as the introduction to a scientific doctrinal conception? Can blind authority be united with Christ’s words: “Ye shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free”? One would then have to interpret them thus: “Ye shall know blind authority, and blind authority shall make you free.”

Without scientific critique there can be no talk of science. Critique, then, is

conceded—with moderation, caution, reverence, of course. But here the proposition holds: if one has said A, one must also say B. If critique is to be applied, it must be applied consistently, not merely to natural events, but also to miracles and prophecies. Once the scientific point of view has been fixed firmly; once one has credulously entered upon the radically false presupposition that the sacred facts are to be seen in the same light, have their actuality in the same sphere, and establish their reality in the same way as the profane: then personal truth says good night, for now what is revealed is to be inspected inside out. It is an easy matter for “modern science,” after it has, with the assistance of theology, won a secure foothold in the sphere of religious cognitions, to show how the miracles make up a web of contradictions, how the prophecies aim at something entirely other than their alleged fulfillment, and how the biblical accounts conflict not [84] merely with other historical accounts, but even with one another.

We choose as an example the miracle by which Christ raises Lazarus, a miracle that is to prove the truth of his words: “I am the resurrection, and the life.” The impression the miracle makes on the many witnesses is extremely various, some honoring Christ in faith, while others go as secret informers to the Pharisees. And what then do the Pharisees do? “Then,” it says (John 11), “gathered the chief priests and the Pharisees a council, and said, What do we? for this man doeth many miracles. If we let him thus alone, all men will believe on him: and the Romans shall come and take away both our place and nation . . . Then from that day forth they took counsel together for to put him to death.” But what kind of psychology is this? The chief priests and the whole council begin, of course, as believers, with the presupposition that Jesus really “doeth many miracles,” indeed works so wonderful that if he were allowed to go on thus, then “all men would believe on him.” The raising of Lazarus thus stands before the consciousness of these scribes not as a deception, a sham miracle performed by a crafty juggler, but as a fact known to many, a wonder which it cannot occur to them to deny. But how in all the world can it then occur to such clever men to want to kill a man who can raise the dead? If a man is really assumed to have power to raise the dead,

then no religious faith is needed, but only a little sound common sense, to see how useless, indeed how senseless, it is to seek such a man's life.

[85] The Pharisees and the scribes, one will perhaps say, believed only historically, but could not believe religiously, for God had hardened their heart. To get even only a glimmer of science out of all this, one would then have to be able to explain how much of the hardening belongs to these scribes and how much comes from God. But if one makes earnest of such a task, surely everyone must be able to see that the hardening of hearts will not resolve into any scientific concept. What a swarm of contradictions can scientific critique not point out here! It says in the Epistle of James (1, 13–14): "Let no man say when he is tempted, I am tempted of God: for God cannot be tempted with evil, neither tempteth he any man." But to harden a man's heart is surely to tempt it to evil. "Therefore," says Christ, "speak I to them" (the Jewish people) "in parables: because they seeing see not; and hearing they hear not, neither do they understand. And in them is fulfilled the prophecy of Esaias, which saith, By hearing ye shall hear, and shall not understand; and seeing ye shall see, and shall not perceive." Theology would level out the contradictions in such a way that the explanation should at one and the same time satisfy faith and content knowledge; in all obligingness it would serve two masters, but gets ingratitude from both. Ceaselessly confusing the psychology of faith with a scientific doctrine of consciousness, it succeeds only in preparing an easy victory for modern science and in driving its negative critique to the extreme.

By wanting to defend the sacred facts scientifically, theology contributes to keeping up the deception that these facts can in earnest be threatened by scientific attacks. But if the sacred facts can be threatened by scientific attacks, then there lies in this an admission that they might possibly one day fall before
[86] such attacks. Modern science has turned the admission to its account and answered with triumphant scorn: "They have fallen!"

There runs through religious psychology a peculiar series of doublings of reflection; of these doublings of reflection, with their immediate outcome in apparent contradictions, science has no concept, and can—so long as faith's own

thinking has not yet been allowed a clear and many-sided development of its own cognitions, but every time it would begin on a systematic self-development is instantly twisted round into the scientific—cannot possibly have any concept. To indicate what is aimed at here, we compare a couple of passages of the Old Testament. In the second book of Samuel (XXIV) the following is related: “And again the anger of the Lord was kindled against Israel, and he moved David against them to say, Go, number Israel and Judah!” And the king does expressly as Jehovah has commanded him, and bids Joab, who was captain of the host, to go through all the tribes of Israel from Dan to Beersheba and number the people. Nevertheless David, just as the census is ended, gets a notion that he has done something evil. “But,” it says, “David’s heart smote him after that he had numbered the people. And David said unto the Lord, I have sinned greatly in that I have done: and now, I beseech thee, O Lord, take away the iniquity of thy servant; for I have done very foolishly!” Thus David, by simply acting according to Jehovah’s express command, has committed a sin; thus God has expressly tempted David to evil. If that is not what is said here in plain words, what then is said here? Theological interpretation so gladly proves its scientific character by collecting parallel passages and letting “the Bible interpret itself” by letting the one passage explain the other. The parallel passage to second Samuel (XXIV) is, as is well known, first Chronicles (XXI), which [87] begins thus: “And Satan stood up against Israel, and provoked David to number Israel. And David said to Joab,” and so on. Let one turn about hermeneutically and twist oneself exegetically however one will, it stands expressly in the one passage that Satan does what in the other passage is said to be done by God himself. And that God (2 Sam.) does not let Satan tempt David, but does it himself immediately, shines out plainly enough from the unambiguous words: Go, number Israel and Judah!

If we cast a glance at the scientifically critical conception of the prophecies, theology fares not a hair better. The freethinker criticizes, and the theologian criticizes, and the more lights critique kindles, the paler religion becomes. The prophecies in the Old Testament that are fulfilled in the New have been carefully

enumerated and classified, but seen through the spectacles of critique they fall away altogether; for what the prophets say is something other than what the evangelists make them say. A single example! In the Gospel of Matthew (II), where the flight into Egypt is told, it is said that this happened that it might be fulfilled which was spoken of the Lord by the prophet, saying: "Out of Egypt have I called my son." It is Hosea (XI, 1) that is aimed at here. But in Hosea it stands: "When Israel was a child, then I loved him, and called my son out of Egypt." For critique there is no prophecy here; for by the son of whom the prophet speaks he means not Jesus, born of Mary, but the people of Israel. Now, to be sure, one gets the ingenious explanation that the people of Israel is a type of Christ, but ingenious circumlocutions we have enough of. What critique sees at the first glance is that the prophet's thought goes in one direction, the evangelist's in another. The [88] prophet speaks of something past, but the evangelist takes him as if he had spoken of something to come. There is no prophecy in the prophet's speech, and yet the evangelist would see in it the fulfillment of a prophecy.

What, now, is the consequence of these scientific attempts? One knows names such as Strausz, Rénan, and others. It is common knowledge that Strausz, with scientific thoroughness and critique, has dissolved the whole evangelical history and made Christ's life on earth into a myth. It is the world-spirit that through him completes its destructive consequences; the old theology has long said A, and now Strausz comes at last and says B. With the help of the Straussian critique one then becomes free not only of the many scientific contradictions with which religion has hitherto been encumbered, but one becomes scientifically free of religion itself; then critique is true, and truth critical; then we interpret Christ's words in the spirit of the age: "Ye shall know critique, and critique shall make you free."

If it were now the task, the goal we had set ourselves here, to clear up the psychology of faith and to develop the religious concepts from religion's own principle, then we should surely be obliged in the present connection to indicate how the misapprehensions pointed out could be removed point by point. But since we have not proposed to impart either a psychology of faith or a philosophy of

religion in detailed lectures, but rather to speak in general about hindrances to and conditions for the spiritual life: a pointing to the mistreatments that religion must suffer from the scientific character introduced by theology will already be able to make a contribution. It is, from what we have already seen, by no means an immediate enthusiasm for the ideal, but at the most an intellectual striving after the cognition of truth, that can be said to mark the spiritual merit of the age. [89]

But an age whose main strength is intellectual must first and foremost labor to clear itself out of intellectual confusions. We say it freely and with full conviction that the first and greatest hindrance to the life of spirit in the present time is a theological bungling of the sacred facts, a dogmatic mixing together of religious and scientific cognitions, a critically hollowed out but officially propped up system of authority, which leans on faith when knowledge runs short, and defends itself with knowledge where faith fails it. We say it freely and with full conviction that the first and greatest of the many intellectual tasks of our intellectual time is, as surely as it would preserve and further its spiritual life, this task: to get religion, I mean revealed religion—not by a decree of orthodoxy, not by ecstatic revivals and mystical visions, but by thinking, a thorough, clear, illuminating thinking corresponding to faith—once for all delivered and rescued from the claws of science. Until this task is thoroughly solved, hindrances and conditions must go on clashing in dull fermentation; but with the solution of the task truth will conquer by the power of spirit, not the impersonal but the personal; not the cold truth that is grounded in necessity, but the living one that shines in freedom, the very one that is heard in Christ's words: "Ye shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free."

VI.

The struggle of the consciousness of culture against the spirit of the Gospel has already been characterized from two standpoints, namely insofar as the movement of thought passes through natural science and through history. It now remains to grasp and characterize this struggle from the standpoint of the doctrine of spirit itself. Here the battlefield is inward; the struggle reaches its decisive turning point, in that it ends as a struggle within consciousness itself. If we ask the man of culture whether, in consequence of the negative world-spirit, he will deny the Highest, the ideal, the eternal, he answers No; if we ask him whether he will deny the Godhead itself, he answers No; but if we add yet the question whether he will then believe in God and his revealed Word, he also answers No. For the consciousness of culture grasps its Godhead not as almighty willing personality, but as the absolute idea of knowledge. In faith God is taken to be a personal being; but, says the knower, if God is really to be thought of as a personal being, then he must surely also be thought of as a limited being. "You ascribe to God," says Fichte to the believers, "personality and consciousness. What then do you understand by personality and consciousness? Surely that which you have found in yourselves and designated by this name? But that you in no way think, or can think, this without limitation and finitude, the slightest attention to your construction of this concept can teach you. By ascribing that predicate to this being, you therefore make it a finite one, a being like yourselves, and you have not, as you wished, thought God, but only multiplied yourselves in thought." The self-consciousness of the absolute spirit is indeed, according to Hegel, religion; but if anyone concludes from this that speculative [90]

philosophy really ascribes to God an eternal, self-subsistent self-consciousness, he will think otherwise when, by penetrating deeper into the system, he learns to see the meaning of the remarkable words that “man’s knowledge of God is God’s own knowledge of himself.” From this philosophical summit the consciousness of culture will then continue its intellectual struggle to root out faith.

And why will the consciousness of culture root out faith? If its standpoint is valid, then the endeavor is not merely consistent, but noble and good. Here there are, outwardly as well as inwardly, spiritual phenomena enough that could give offense to the enlightened man. A thinker who was zealous for faith has somewhere raised the question: “If what we understand by being a Christian really is being a Christian, what then is God in the heavens?” And the answer is given: “He is the most ridiculous being that has ever lived, his Word the most ridiculous book that has ever come to light: to set (as he indeed does in his Word) heaven and earth in motion, to threaten with hell, with eternal punishments, in order to attain what we understand by being Christians (and we are, of course, true Christians)—no, anything so ridiculous has never occurred.” The glaring contradiction between the ideals of faith and actual life, which characterizes the [92] age of means, of conditions, of interests, stands as clear to the knowing critic as to the believing thinker. When the believing thinker, wounded by the sting of the contradiction, bursts out: “The most dreadful kind of blasphemy is that of which Christendom is guilty: to turn the God of spirit into ridiculous twaddle; and the most spiritless kind of worship, more spiritless than all that is and was found in paganism, more spiritless than this: to worship as God a stone, an ox, an insect, more spiritless than all is: to worship under the name of God—a twaddler!”—when, we say, such outcries sound from the camp of the believers, then negative criticism answers Yea and Amen.

The fact of the age, that faith has lost its inspiring power, the man of culture does not grasp as a sign of a spiritual retrogression, but on the contrary as proof of an essential progress. The reason why the power of faith is waning is, according to his conviction, that the light of knowledge is waxing. It is not merely, he says, the

objects of faith, the holy facts, that dissolve into the fabulous and lose themselves in the mythical; no, faith itself is of a fabulous nature, the believing consciousness is essentially mythical. We shall now hear the closer explanation.

How the mythical consciousness comes to grasp the various deities can be seen in Homer. Already in the first book of the *Iliad*, where Achilles and Agamemnon are in their well-known quarrel with one another, there occurs a turning point characteristic of a revelation of a god. Achilles' passion is inflamed; he is so furious that he calls Agamemnon a coward and uses the strongest words of scorn; there is every sign that he will forget himself. "Under his shaggy breast his heart beat doubtfully, whether he should straightway draw his whetted blade from his thigh, scatter the thronging crowd, and cut him down, the son of Atreus, or master his hot [93] temper and curb his wrath"; then the revelation takes place. "Just as he drew the sword from the sheath, Pallas Athene came down from heaven. . . Behind Achilles she stepped, and pulled at his light-yellow locks, visible to him alone; of the others none saw her." The conversation which now passes between Achilles and the goddess is highly characteristic. "Daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus, why hast thou come?" To which Athene answers: "I have come to curb thy wrath, if thou wilt obey."

How characteristic is every feature of this revelation! What Achilles in the critical moment so sorely needs is self-possession, and behold, there stands self-possession itself visibly before him in Pallas Athene. And he knows her, yes, he knows her at once; her "dreadful glance flashes towards him." Self-possession is a personal matter: so the goddess is visible only to him; she has an errand to him alone. And yet she surprises him and makes him start! Yes, self-possession comes with divine power, with a calm exalted above the passions, with authority, with ideal superiority. Athene is no allegory; she is a daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus: she is a goddess. Here, then, we have the mythical doubling; in other words: here we have "faith." Achilles believes in the goddess, and just for that reason she reveals herself to him. Without himself knowing it, he refers the self-possession awakening in his own mind to a divine being existing outside him, and then this

being comes “down from high Olympus” and brings him what is originally his own. Here is the doubling of consciousness, the doubling which characterizes faith. The believing consciousness sets the gods up outside itself, and does so from [94] inner necessity, because in its obscure profundity it does not yet know that it has the divine in itself. It is precisely the obscurity of the mind, with the heaviness and tension corresponding to the obscurity, that causes the believer to receive the revelation. The believing consciousness lives in feeling and in the intuition of fantasy; therefore it has so irresistible an urge to present its divine content to itself in corresponding images; and when one of these images, in striking immediacy and as with a magical power, forces itself upon consciousness, then man imagines that the divine which he sees in his own vision is a real god’s revelation: on this imagining faith rests. All religions originally give themselves out as revealed; this is from the beginning no simple priestcraft; far from it! it is a self-deception of the soul, necessary by the idea; he who has seen the primitive vision of the gods really believes, fully and firmly, that he has received a revelation. Then he reflects upon his vision; he recalls it, and in his recollection it becomes ever clearer, richer, more wonderful; then he describes his vision and tells of the revelation, and those who hear the account with devotion are seized with wonder, perceive within themselves a testimony that what is told them must be divine truth. These devout ones now become the believers proper, in that, without themselves having received any revelation—be it that the originality in their nature is too weak, or that they live at a later time, after the primitive breakthroughs have already taken place—they believe in the revelation that has been granted to another, a worthier one. In the believers proper, recollection then works further; the legend of the gods (Μῦθος) is expanded, altered, completed; the idea, working in the form of fantasy, soon makes the myth a subject for poetry; now we stand again at Homer.

[95] To prove that there is a consciousness of revelation that is not mythical, one appeals to the morally pure, the truly ethical, to the necessity of grounding the ethical upon the religious. But how insufficient such a line of proof is can be seen expressly from the example we have cited. Or can one well conceive of any

purser fusion of the religious and the ethical than precisely in the lines exchanged here between Achilles and Athene? "Why hast thou come?" ... "I have come to curb thy wrath, if thou wilt obey, come from heaven; the lily-armed Hera sent me, she loves you both alike, and tenderly she cares for both." So exalted is the religious-ethical thought here that Achilles in his seething anger must be lifted above himself and take note that there is in heaven a divine love which embraces him and his enemy alike. And this divine love, how human it is, how humane! The goddess with "the dreadfully flashing glance" does not threaten him, does not compel him; but gives him counsel, if he will obey. The demand for obedience is, then, not excessively strict either. He is merely to refrain from using force, but may otherwise give vent to his wrath and rebuke Agamemnon with words as much as he pleases. By obeying the goddess's counsel Achilles here shows himself a model of Greek piety and true religiousness. "It is fitting, goddess, to take your word to heart, however wroth one be in mind, for this is most profitable; whoso is obedient to the command of the gods, him they gladly hear."

This, then, was the man of culture's conception of faith and mythology at the Greek stage of consciousness; how does he now make out the doctrine of Jehovah, the revelation in the Old Testament? At bottom in the very same way.

It is an apt saying of a modern author that man plunders himself in order [96] to adorn his God. This holds fully as much in Judaism as in paganism. The best in the Greek was his beautiful individuality. In this individuality there was something corruptible; that he could keep for himself; but the incorruptible essence of individuality, the divine, that he dared not keep for himself; it belonged to the blessed gods alone. The best in the Jew is his personally thinking I, his ethically willing self. In this I there is something limited, unclear and transitory; that man may keep for himself; but in the I as I, in spirit as spirit, there is a claim to holy wisdom and eternal power which man cannot satisfy; infinite wisdom, holy will, eternal power belong to the God alone. Out of the burning bush Jehovah speaks (Exodus III) to Moses, and gives himself the significant name: *I am that I am*. In this almighty Jehovah-I the people of Israel now intuit the eternal ideal of its

spiritual essence, in a manner corresponding to that in which the Greek intuites the ideal of individuality in the Olympian gods.

There is indeed a difference here, yes, when we look more closely, even a very essential difference; but the difference lies, scientifically viewed, by no means in this, that Jehovah is real while the Greek gods are unreal: the difference between “the idols” and “the only true God” is only a difference of faith, a difference posited by the Jewish imagination. No, the real difference is that which follows from the diversity of the ideals. The Greek gods are many; for individuality has many shapes; the God of the Jews is only one; for the I as I is, despite all the changes of the world, the same. The Greek gods are, though invisible to a mortal eye, yet [97] visible according to their essence; they are image-gods, true gods of art; for in the form of art the individual is transfigured. Jehovah, on the other hand, even if he now and then assumes a visible shape, is invisible according to his essence; for thought as thought, will as will, spirit as spirit is in all eternity invisible. But just as little as the believing Jew knows that in the imageless Jehovah he intuites the ideal of his own spiritual self, just so little does the believing Greek know that in his image-gods he intuites the ideal of his own human individuality. If the Jewish cognition of God is to be called faith, then the Greek is faith too; if the Greek faith is to be called mythical, then the Jewish faith is mythical too. Seen in faith, it is indeed Jehovah who created man in his image; but seen in knowledge, it is the Jew himself who created Jehovah in his image. The holy God of omnipotence, of wisdom, of goodness, of justice is a true man-god, the Creator of the world a creature of man’s spirit.”

According to this way of viewing things, it is so far from being the case that the Jewish faith should be less mythical than the Greek, that the mythical in the doctrine of Jehovah, even in many striking features, comes out more strongly; this is because the phenomena of revelation in Jewish mythology stand in a far more glaring conflict with the concept of God itself than in the Greek.

God is almighty; the almighty God is the Creator of heaven and earth; now comes the mythical. For the Almighty does not create as an Almighty; no, he goes

to work piece by piece; he conducts himself like a human master-builder, rather like Plato's God in the *Timaeus*. First he talks with himself and considers what he will do; then he does it, and then afterwards he looks at what he has done, and sees that it is well done. That such a creation must be an object of faith goes [98] without saying; for as soon as it is made an object of knowledge and seen in the concept, it betrays its contradiction and vanishes. If Jehovah is almighty, then his power is absolute; but absolute power can just as little engage in finite actions as in finite resolutions. It is said that Jehovah walked in the garden of Paradise in the cool of the day. How cozy! The almighty Creator of heaven and earth takes a stroll in the evening cool under the shade of the trees which he himself has lately created. That a Zeus now and then takes a stroll in the grove is after a fashion in keeping with his erotic individuality; but that an Omnipresent One takes a stroll is a monstrous contradiction. How long can such a thing continue to be an object of faith? Answer: as long as consciousness can continue to be mythical. That the Jewish people, this so peculiar, spiritually vigorous people of antiquity, has had a religious childhood, a stage of consciousness in which such narratives, attractive by their guilelessness and childlike grace, came forth with psychological necessity and just for that reason worked with psychological truth, is understandable. There is in these religious nursery tales of "the chosen people" something so bold and so grandly simple that it must impress the imagination even to this day. "And the Lord God made unto Adam and to his wife coats of skins"; just imagine: he sewed their clothes himself!

What for the childlike intuition of antiquity had its psychological truth becomes in our time psychological untruth, affectation and self-deception, when, in defiance of science and sound reason, under the name of "childlike faith," it is still to be taken straightforwardly as revelation. We will not dwell on the many surprises and violent emotions by which Jehovah, forgetting his omniscience and omnipotence, lets himself be carried away—when he, for example (Genesis VI), is so surprised by [99] the wickedness of men that "it repented him that he had made man on the earth, and it grieved him at his heart"—we will not, as we said, dwell on what is known

to all; only as an example of how far psychological untruth can go in our days, we will cite one more single feature. It is told (Genesis VII) that when Noah with all the animals had safely come into the ark, then "Jehovah himself shut him in." To this one of the present age's childlike believers has now added the following interpretation, as learned in the Scriptures as it is edifying: "Jehovah *shut*, for from outside Noah could not, of course, close it (the ark) any more, so that the water could not get in; also he must, of course, be secured against the attempts of the ungodly to be able to break the ark open in order to get in." Yes, the faith of the present age—is childlike faith!

If we look back on what has been cited here, how then can we doubt that the Jewish faith is just as mythical as the Greek? Or what should entitle us to declare Athene a false goddess, when we acknowledge Jehovah as a true God? That her existence is in conflict with the laws of nature? But so is Jehovah's existence! That in Homer she sometimes lets herself be carried away by passion? But so does Jehovah in Moses! That Jehovah's fundamental character, when we disregard his particular weaknesses, is ethical? But Athene's fundamental character, when we disregard her particular weaknesses, is ethical too! Her revelation to Achilles is then at least as ethical as Jehovah's repentance at having created men. No, if Jehovah is to be a true God, then let Athene too be a true goddess. Nor need we then, for faith's sake, fear any logical contradiction. There is, if only we will believe [100] in revelations and apparitions, absolutely nothing to prevent Athene and Jehovah from being two different revelations of one and the same "almighty Creator of heaven and earth." We know, after all—we know it in faith—that Jehovah himself together with two angels ate curds and milk and veal with Abraham under the tree in the grove of Mamre (Genesis XXIII); if the Almighty can condescend to eat milk and veal when he will reveal himself to an Abraham, why should not the same Almighty also be able to condescend to appear as a daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus when he will reveal himself to an Achilles?—So far the man of culture.

That in the often acute attacks of modern knowledge upon the faith in revelation there lies an essential hindrance to the development of the religious life

shall not be denied; but if we look more closely, it might yet turn out that precisely this hindrance, if only the solution of the fundamental intellectual task of the present age could be taken in earnest, lets itself be transformed into an essential condition. The sharper and more penetrating the thinking that attacks faith, the sharper and more penetrating must also be the thinking by which faith defends itself against the attack. Sharp against sharp, and then it will surely come to a decision! Here, then, there is in the attack of triumphant science, in the first place, an arbitrariness which must be repelled most emphatically. Here it is presupposed without further ado that faith in itself is thoughtless, that all clear, consistent and thorough thinking belongs exclusively to science: to apply the measure of thinking is to apply the measure of science. This presupposition is utterly false. Relying on an utterly false presupposition, scientific criticism begins, quite unembarrassed, by treating the concepts of faith as immature, botched concepts of knowledge, [101] and can then easily prove that these concepts contain scientific contradictions. With the false presupposition that faith is thoughtless, criticism naturally finds it beneath its dignity to acquaint itself properly with the peculiar essence and self-development of the believing consciousness; it imposes upon it, without ceremony, the obligation to be a knowing consciousness, and can then, since faith as faith is absolutely heterogeneous with knowledge, easily prove that the believing consciousness, grasped as knowing, is in contradiction with itself. With the utterly false presupposition that the believing consciousness is in original contradiction with itself, it is naturally an easy matter for the criticism of knowledge to caricature the holy facts and get revelation lumped together with mythology.

We will now see whether it is not after all possible to disentangle this confusion. It is, as we said, an utterly false presupposition that faith as faith is thoughtless; we prove this by presenting the principle of faith as a principle of thought peculiar in itself. That the principle of faith is itself a principle of thought does not mean that faith begins with the pure thinking of pure being; but it means that the believing consciousness is able to think its own original fundamental act, by this thinking to distinguish itself from the knowing consciousness, and by this distinction to

become transparent to itself. The point of departure is in the idea of the Good. The idea of the Good is the idea of the will: to the absolute Good corresponds the absolute will, the absolute Self. The absolute Self is the holy God. Over against the absolute Self there then stands, with the world between them, the relative self, the self that is not good, but obligated to the Good, the relative will that is not holy, but sinful. With these presuppositions the believing consciousness can not
 [102] only become clear to itself, insofar as it can see their absolute indispensability for the self, but it can even think its essence through so completely that each of the presuppositions transforms itself into a moment in the concept of faith.

Once the principle of faith is grasped and determined in the concept of faith as a principle of thought, there is no danger from the mythical interpretation and the mythical. To dissolve the divine images of the natural religions into personified ideas and to demonstrate the psychological origin of the unconscious illusions is a worthy task for knowledge and scientific criticism; through the progress of knowledge self-cognition in this respect then also makes a real advance: the Aristotelian concept of God is in truth far preferable to Homeric images of the gods. But spurred on by this advance, “modern science,” especially tempted and seduced by theology, has in lamentable fashion come to overstep its absolute limit. If Zeus—so one concludes—is a personification of the individuality of the Greek spirit, then Jehovah must necessarily also be a personification of the strong, self-willed I of the Jewish spirit. This conclusion is utterly false. He who says that Jehovah is only a personification of the human essence of selfhood, what does he do? He makes the human self into a personification of subjective thinking, and subjective thinking into an empty reflex of organic natural forces. By such a procedure things by no means go upward, but on the contrary downward with the self and its self-cognition. “It goes backward, Hakon”; yes, it goes backward! For surely a reflective age must be able to muster so much reflection that anyone who earnestly wills it can also very easily—without speculative overexertion—see
 [103] that the human self must stand and fall with the divine, the powerless with the almighty, the relative with the absolute.

It shall willingly be conceded that the miracles of revelation in the Old and the New Testament bear an unmistakable likeness to the myth miracles of the natural religions, when they are seen and judged from the standpoint of knowledge. By making the Bible into a stock-dogmatic document of revelation, theology has provoked scientific criticism to a demonstration of this so conspicuous likeness, a demonstration often wounding, no doubt, but in its main lines victorious and irrefutable. The cognition of knowledge is, and according to its peculiar character must necessarily be, a rationally coherent cognition of the world: from the standpoint of cognition of the world a Mosaic miracle is just as offensive, improbable, absurd and self-contradictory as a Homeric one. But the concept of the miracle is a concept of faith, an unconditioned concept of selfhood, and can never become a concept of knowledge; the contradictions which "modern criticism" so easily discovers in the miracles can all be traced back to an uncritical confusion of concepts of faith and concepts of knowledge.

The question of the difference between false and true miracles coincides originally with the question of the difference between false and true revelation, between false and true faith. With this the principle of myth is excluded once and for all, not only from the New, but also from the Old Testament. There may indeed, especially in the holy legends of the Old Testament, be talk of analogies to the mythical, but, according to the principle of faith, by no means of myths proper. To develop the difference between myths and mythical analogies in detail is a special task for a philosophical-religious treatment of the sacred history; in the present context it shall only be emphasized in general that the difference must be determined in principle by a clear and sharp development of the relation between the human word and the divine primal Word. The word of the Bible, as it lies before us, has its human as well as its divine side; it is not a word of God alongside a word of man, but from first to last a divine-human word, grasped in faith, presented in faith, handed down in faith. Religious faith is from the beginning a faith of the people, the religious word a word of the people. Instead of making the Bible into a document of revelation dictated word for word, we must on the contrary [104]

remember that the Bible is a people's book just as much as Homer. But if the Bible is a people's book, what wonder then that it expresses itself in popular fashion in popular images, images which came forth when the holy light of revelation refracted its rays in the natural media of the spirit of the people!

With a changed principle everything is changed. If it may be regarded as the most essential hindrance to the spiritual life of the present age that science has taken the concept from faith and made revelation thoughtless: then everyone can now tell himself what the requirement is if spirit is to transform such a hindrance into a condition.

VII.

If anyone comes forward with the gospel of enlightenment that no one can believe ^[105] in the holy, since the holy is precisely that which is not, and no one can believe in that which is not, he will surprise moral society in the highest degree. But if only he is allowed to speak his mind, his view of life will show itself from more than one side to be a product of a way of thinking that prevails in the present age. “The holy,” he says, “is a concept which dissolves itself before a clarified reflection. Why? Because the holy is an obscure power that always gives way before the light of day, a mystical representation, a riddle of the fantasy, that awakens dread. Just consider the holy places, the altars of the gods, the sacred groves! If you see them by the light of day, in human company, you feel nothing of fear or shuddering, that is to say: you do not come into contact with the holy. But visit these places in the darkness of night, alone, by the light of the moon, and you will shudder; this shuddering, awakened by an obscure representation of an obscure power, is a sensing of the holy. The holy needs a curtain; its essence is, like the veiled goddess at Sais, a riddle of the fantasy. But the cold understanding draws the curtain aside; a bold thought lifts the veil, and the youth overcomes his terror, and the holy ^[106] vanishes. We, the true children of the Enlightenment, the freeborn sons of the Revolution, have learned to respect the civil laws, the political institutions, the conduct of men and their pursuits; but—forgive us a bold word—we do not believe in visions and revelations, we do not bow the knee to the holy. The holy will, by its mystical nature, always pass for something unconditioned; but in the world of conditions, of means, of interests, everything is conditioned. That something is

holy to me means only that something is, under certain conditions, precious to me, perhaps even so precious that I could sacrifice my life for it. But in the sense of a hidden divine, a mystical unconditioned, I acknowledge nothing holy, no feeling, no promise, no oath, no altar, no God;—I say what I mean: the holy is that which is not, and no one can believe in that which is not.”

Upon such a man the whole of society would now pass the severest judgment; it would cast him out and see in him a dissolute and brazen person. But, we must ask, why? Is it because he says such a thing, or because he thinks it, or for both? Chiefly only for the first. Cultured society breaks the staff over the man who expresses himself so openly and inconsiderately, for this inconsiderateness is precisely an injury to society. If, on the other hand, one looks at the inward and asks whether one can then regard a man with such a way of thinking as respectable, then society will doubtless divide into two parties. The one party will keep to “the bad heart,” the other to “the good head”; yes, it would perhaps not be impossible that between those who went to extremes a middle party might arise, which would undertake to prove how difficult it is to unite a good heart with a good head, that [107] the most interesting people are most often suspected of having a little flaw in the heart, while the amiable ones are sometimes accused of having it in the head. But with all this the whole of society will easily agree that the offensive lies in the utterance; while the disputants will hardly agree that the essential brazenness lies in the thought. And yet the difference between him who thinks in silence and him who utters the thought is only this, that the one who speaks is sincere while he is brazen, whereas the silent one is brazen without being sincere, and so a hypocrite, and as a hypocrite perhaps far more dangerous to society. Religious hypocrisy in the ordinary sense of the word is by no means the fault of the present age; on the contrary, it is an advantage which growing enlightenment and greater freedom in all spiritual affairs as well have brought with them, that feigned piety is despised as the sign of an ignoble, weak and wretched character. But there is, with regard to religious and ecclesiastical questions, a political accommodation which in its consequences can hardly clear itself of favoring a certain conventional

hypocrisy. In Catholic countries, where cultural development has taken on not merely an anti-ecclesiastical but even an anti-religious stamp, there shows itself an endeavor—not expressly to settle the conflict of principle between the ecclesiastical and the political by leading it back to the first fundamental questions, beginning the religious instruction of the people over again, and guarding with all its might the freedom of spirit that this requires—but much more to extend, promote and consolidate the purely political interests, as if civil freedom and true culture could really go arm in arm with religious unfreedom and medieval mysticism. Such an accommodation, which brings the enlightened to feign a certain reverence for what in their quiet thoughts they must reckon as superstition and obscurantism, causes not merely endless troubles in the outward, but, what is worse, it hollows out the ground of life in the inward. [108]

That states which have gone through a political revolution without having previously been prepared by any real reformation of the medieval church system must feel the smoldering tension as an oppressive fate is understandable; perhaps the great pressure, when the hour of spirit strikes, may yet come to furnish conditions for a spiritual rising of which we can as yet form no representation. But in Protestant countries, where the religious principle of freedom has long been acknowledged—at least pro forma—to want to whitewash over the devices on the ecclesiastical and political coats of arms, and to muddle through by accommodation, is a procedure little in keeping with the spirit of the Reformation. The holy requires for its acknowledgment, fully as much as the profane, a thorough, firm conviction; but a reflective age cannot possibly arrive at a thorough, firm conviction without thorough, clear and consistently carried-through thinking.

But this is, if we are not mistaken, precisely one of the essential hindrances to the spiritual life in the present age, that religious thinking among the great majority of the cultured has visibly come to a standstill. People think, and that with a certain perseverance, about manifold affairs. They think about politics and industry, about art and poetry, they think about burning questions, foreign as well as domestic: they think and think about great and small, only not about the

religious. In the time of the Reformation, on the other hand, yes, then religious problems were thought about; it was not only the learned who thought, no, the people itself thought along, for then it was in earnest. When the people's thinking for itself then gradually ceased, because religious thinking became a learned matter, [109] the theologians became, if not exactly thinkers for themselves, yet in the official church as good as officially the sole thinkers; for now orthodoxy was a science. Thereupon the freethinkers began; but the freethinkers gave offense to the people; the way of thinking of freethinking was so unpopular that it contributed, even more than the theological, its share to awakening the people's suspicion of all thorough religious thinking for oneself. The consequences of this are noticeable enough in the present time.

We may by no means say that it is either dullness or indifference that keeps the cultured from taking hold of the tasks of spirit; no, it is rather despondency, helplessness and lack of overview. People have a secret fear that nothing will come of all the religious thinking; that the whole thing will end at last in dissolution, ferment and boundless confusion. It is in any case so learned, so critical, speculative and philosophical, that the layman cannot possibly keep up; no, then it is better to hold to the established order, follow the stream, keep one's own thoughts to oneself and believe in accommodation.

But is it then in reality so difficult to acquaint oneself with a religious task? We believe we can convince every cultured person of the opposite, and we choose an example which shall not be said to lie too low, in that we choose a determination of the relation between idea and God, in order thereby to determine the concept of the holy.

The difference between faith and knowledge can be stated briefly thus: the holy Self is the object of faith; the idea of the holy is the content of knowledge. The holy Self is God; in the language of faith it runs: God is holy, righteous, all-good, merciful, etc. Otherwise in "modern science"; here the view runs thus: God, the Absolute itself, cannot be holy; the holy Self cannot be God, for the holy Self is a contradiction. We find in Strauss's *Dogmatics* the following presentation, highly

characteristic of negative knowledge: “The definition ... of the divine holiness [110] (Lev. XIX, 2. Ps. VI, 5 ff. Mt. V, 48. XIX, 17. Eph. IV, 24. 1 Pet. I, 15 f., 1 John I, 5 ff.), that it is the attribute on account of which God wills what he ought, and ought what he wills, will hardly be readily accepted on the ecclesiastical side: and yet it only expresses what is the presupposition in the usual determinations of the concept. For whether one defines God’s holiness as the highest, flawless purity in God, which also demands the due purity of creatures; or as the rectitude of the divine will, on account of which it wills, in accordance with its eternal law, everything that is right and good; or finally as the attribute by which God desires and approves only the good: a moral law is always assumed, according to which the divine will determines itself, but this relation between a law and a will is otherwise always expressed by an ought ... Very rightly, therefore, Weisse says: God himself could not be called good if evil were not for him too a metaphysical possibility. But for every being for which evil is possible, the good stands as an ought, and thus our definition of the divine holiness given above here comes into its rights. But, just so conceived, this attribute—unless that possibility of evil and this ought are empty words—abolishes the concept of the Absolute ... he who holds fast to the Absolute dissolves holiness, which is something only in a being placed in relations; and he who takes holiness seriously encroaches upon the idea of absoluteness, since it is obscured by the faintest shadow of a possibility of being otherwise than it is.” (D. F. Strauss: *Fremstilling af den christelige Troeslære*. Trans. [111] by H. Brøchner. Vol. 1. Copenhagen 1842. Pp. 513–515).

From the example cited it can be seen how different scientific thinking is from religious thinking, and what practical significance it has that this difference be brought to consciousness. For if it were to be decided by scientific investigations whether a holy, righteous, almighty God can exist or not, then it is clear that the majority of the cultured will not be able to follow such investigations, still less the whole people. The question of the reality of the holy thus becomes an intricate question, whose answer laymen must leave to the highly learned, while they, until the final answer to the question arrives, try to get by with a faith that

at most requires a little talkativeness, but only very insignificant activity of the brain, namely “childlike faith.” So then, by going to an opposite extreme, one has “childlike faith” in “the childlike heart,” a faith which is thoughtless insofar as it is not able to develop concepts, but must keep to emotions, turns of phrase and images, a faith which gets its edifying quality from a confession without self-cognition, an inspiration without development of spirit, a heartfelt assurance without real conviction. The simpler—that is to say here, the more stupid—the individual is, the easier it will be for him on these terms to believe; childlike faith is the coziest affair in the world: of children and childlike faith our Lord, after all, demands no thoughts at all.

But in a reflective age it is granted only to “a little flock” to preserve faith in complete thoughtlessness. In the greater majority thoughts must sooner or later be set in motion; and the stronger the movement becomes, the more insistent also become questions such as these: how do matters stand with faith and knowledge?

[112] Is it really in science, perhaps in theology, that the thoughts of faith are to seek their last and highest clarification? Might there not after all be a true religious thinking, independent of knowledge and science? The significance of such questions every cultured person can understand, yes, every tolerably awakened person can understand it. But everyone who is able to see the significance of the questions is also able to grasp their answer.

When God in science cannot be holy, because he absolutely must be the gray Absolute: what does science then do with the concept of holiness? It elevates it to an idea with the predicate divine. Religion, says Feuerbach, represents God as holy. In the proposition: God is holy, *God* is subject and *holy* predicate; such a proposition expresses only a representation, but no concept. In order to dissolve the representation into its concept, we must turn the proposition around, make the predicate the subject, and the subject the predicate. Instead of the proposition: God is holy, we then get the proposition: holiness is divine; likewise instead of the proposition: God is righteous, the proposition: righteousness is divine; instead of the proposition: God is merciful, the proposition: mercy is divine, and so forth.

How science will otherwise go about holding fast such freely fluttering divine ideas as holiness, righteousness, etc., each by itself, or uniting them in one idea, an idea which then cannot possibly be absolute, since the Absolute itself can be neither holy nor righteous, we leave to the knowers; here it shall only be emphasized that the concept of holiness is originally a concept of faith, just as independent of science as the concept of God. That there is a holy and righteous God can be decided solely and alone by self-understanding, by inner experience, by the testimony of the Spirit in conscience, that is, by faith. Certainly it is an [113] essential and scientific task to make it more and more clear how the relative ideas relate to the Absolute itself, and above all, how the ethical relates in principle to the metaphysical; but these investigations do not concern religion as religion, nor faith as faith. For the believing consciousness it stands unshakably firm that God is just as surely holy and righteous as he is almighty. This presupposition is not a thoughtless assertion, but a conviction deeply grounded in self-cognition, a determination of concept inherent in the principle of faith itself.

To hold fast the thought of faith there is required not a new revision of the history of philosophy, but an ethical concentration in religious inwardness: the free self worships the Holy One; the faint self is beatified in metaphysics.

If the holy Self is not, that is to say: if God is not holy, then the idea of holiness is a possibility that can never become actual; but a possibility that can never become actuality is an impossibility. Instead of saying: holiness is divine, we must draw the scientific consequence, speak out plainly and say: holiness is a self-contradictory concept, holiness is impossible. As it goes with holiness, so also with righteousness: if God cannot be righteous, then righteousness cannot be divine either; it must nicely resign itself to being human. But what then does this mean? It means that righteousness can only be actualized as men, by themselves, singly and in society, at last become righteous. When does that happen? Never! For it belongs, of course, among the great discoveries of "modern science" too, that no man and no human society can in any actual state whatsoever actualize righteousness. The idea of [114] righteousness, in infinite ought without can, is in endless discord with its own

actualization. To cover over the glaring contradiction, people have appealed to this, that the righteousness of individual men was indeed imperfect, but that each could at least present his side of the righteous being, in other words, contribute his piece of righteousness. When the many contributions were then gathered in social life, we should get, by adding the pieces together, an almost righteous whole. It is, to be sure, only an approximation! Yes, it is in ethics an approximation to the ideal of the same kind as it would be an approximation to the ideal in poetry if, for want of a single true, great poet, one were to let a crowd of moderately gifted people, each of whom had his bit of poetry, work together in an aesthetic committee in order to produce a great poem by many small contributions.

He who cannot see that the assurance, the unshakable, unconditionally decisive assurance of God's holiness and righteousness, is given in and with the self-concentration corresponding to faith, has, however much he may otherwise have thought, not yet thought through the principle of faith, and does well, then, to think it through before he rejects it. But if anyone, after he has really thought the principle through and seen that the concept of a holy and righteous God is quite rightly contained in the thought of faith as an absolute thought of selfhood, breaks off with the declaration that the absolute thought of selfhood is for him without reality, since it demands an exertion of the self, an energy of self-determination, which he cannot endure: then he must seek the fault in himself and not misuse knowledge as a cover for his own weakness.

What a difference there is between the holy God of faith and the idea of God of science can also be seen from this, that while no knower will think of either [115] praying to or worshiping the idea of his knowledge, the God of faith, on the other hand, is an object of worship, a God to whom believers pray. Johannes Climacus (*Uvidenskab. Efterskr.* p. 148) has made the following reflection: "If one who lives in the midst of Christianity goes up into God's house, the house of the true God, with the true representation of God in knowledge, and now prays, but prays in untruth; and when one lives in an idolatrous land, but prays with the whole passion of infinity, although his eye rests upon the image of an idol: where then is there

most truth? The one prays in truth to God, although he worships an idol; the other prays in untruth to the true God, and therefore in truth worships an idol.” Where the task is, as with the author cited, to get subjectivity and inwardness really emphatically stressed, such reflections are no doubt of great value; but where, as in the present discussion, it is a matter of bringing out the relation in principle between worship and the object of worship, the question has only a fleeting and passing significance. To pray in truth to God and yet worship an idol is impossible; for if the worship is true, it can only be true by the idolatrous representation vanishing in the representation of a true God; but a true representation of God necessarily excludes the representation of an idol. Likewise it is impossible to worship the true God in untruth; for when the worship is in untruth, the true God hides his face from the worshiper and leaves in his place a phantom, an untrue god.

That worship and its object naturally correspond to one another, and that even enlightened men of culture often feel a need for something they can worship, is confirmed by many experiences: if one has nothing true to worship, well then, one worships something untrue, and the worship becomes accordingly; if one cannot [116] acknowledge the true God, because the true God has come into contradiction with metaphysics, then one can, of course, acknowledge one’s own Absolute and set this up as a metaphysical idol. Idolatry has not ceased because people have ceased to worship sun, moon and stars. If an individual has not self-importance enough to worship himself, he can, of course, have his pleasure in worshipping others. It is in a reflective age by no means unusual that one man practices idolatry with another. A mother, for example, practices idolatry with her son when she sees in the son a true wonder of genius and virtue, a model man, whom the world in its blindness will never know how to appreciate. That a lover, at least during a certain period, practices idolatry with his beloved is not anything unheard of either. That is why she is called, of course, the object, the adored one, and happiness is in the adoration: happy the adored one, ten times happier the adorer! But here too it shows itself how impossible it is that worship can be true when it is only an idol

that is worshiped. There is in all idolatry something mythical; therefore there is also in all idolatrous worship something mythical. The mythical is ambiguous, and lasts only for a time. Then one meets the worshiper half a year later, but where is the worshiped one? It is over; the whole thing was only a myth. "That was strange, though," says the guileless one, "for he really worshiped her; what inconstancy, what faithlessness!" The best thing now would be if the accused hit upon shifting the blame onto science and unburdened himself thus: "The concept of worship begins with faith, but must naturally, like other concepts of faith, clarify itself in knowledge. I really worshiped her, that is true, for I believed, yes, I believed; I was, after all, at that time only a beginner in science, and therefore I believed; but [117] after I have become familiar with science, and especially with metaphysics, I have learned to see that worship is a concept which cannot subsist with the Absolute, a concept which halves my consciousness, a contradictory concept, and therefore I have ceased to worship."

What here sounds like mockery, because it is said of a worship whose ambiguity everyone sees through so easily, can in full earnest be applied to the worship of the mythical gods. They could at a given time be the object of an obscure, provisional, sensuous worship; but no one has ever worshiped Zeus in spirit and in truth; for a Zeus cannot be worshiped in spirit and in truth; it goes against his mythical nature. What I am to worship must be the pure, holy origin of my being, personality itself in truth, perfection and blessedness: only the God of spirit, who is spirit himself, can be worshiped in spirit and in truth.

If one raises the question which age, which generation must be called the unhappiest, then one knows, of course, from history that one generation has been chastised in one way, another in another; one has suffered under the scourge of war, another from plague, famine, etc. There can be great misfortunes in the world; but as long as the holy is preserved, and the suffering generation has a God to pray to and to worship, the measure of misfortune is not full. The unhappiest generation must surely be the one which by a misdirection comes onto a path of culture that leads it away from faith, away from the holy, so that there is nothing

in which it can believe, nothing to which it can look up with expectation and hope, nothing, nothing before which it can bow with inward reverence. Let such an age otherwise make progress in all directions and enjoy all the temporal goods of civilization; it is and remains nonetheless the unhappiest. We have a prototype in Rome under the emperors. If anyone in the great empire could be called a happy [118] man, it would surely have to be, in the Roman sense, the emperor himself. What is it, then, that causes him torments? It is not cares for the welfare of his subjects, for about the welfare of his subjects he did not trouble himself at all; nor can it be lack of power, for he was in the human sense almighty; and yet he suffers, he suffers unbelievable torments, cruel as a Nero, raving as a Caligula, bestial as a Vitellius, lustful to the point of madness as a Heliogabalus! It is evident that he suffers. But whence does it come? It comes from this, that such an almighty one has nothing he can look up to and regard with reverence; it comes from this, that the emperor is a god, and has, like a god, learned to despise everything, even himself.

This is the measure of a misfortune of a higher kind: that the holy vanishes, that all faith vanishes, that there is nothing more to which the generation can look up with reverence, nothing on which it can build its hope, nothing that it can worship in spirit and in truth.

VIII.

When the talk is of civilization and enlightenment, the present age ought not to forget that there is a difference between light and light, between the enlightenment of culture and the enlightenment of the people; the two kinds of enlightenment are not two sides of the same matter, but things heterogeneous to one another. In their origin they are related as knowledge and faith, as science and religion; for the highest of civilization is in knowledge, and the deepest of popular enlightenment is in faith. Since the confusion of the concepts of faith and knowledge, as we have seen, is one of the most essential hindrances to the spiritual life in the present age, it will be expedient, in order to bring about their separation, to bring out the difference between the enlightenment of culture and that of the people somewhat more closely. How different true popular enlightenment is from what we call the enlightenment of culture, we shall best be able to see by sharply separating two concepts which the present age all too easily confuses, namely the folkish and the popular. ^[119]

To clear up the difference between the folkish and the popular it will be necessary to account for what it is that determines the difference between folkish and popular writings, between folkish and popular men.

There are writings which are suited to general reading by the people and may with reason be called popular, without their therefore ever being able to become folkish; conversely, there are writings which, although the majority of the population is not yet rightly able to read them or find a taste for them, must nevertheless, by their fundamental character, be called folkish. Literature has ^[120]

a popular astronomy, a popular geology, agricultural chemistry, and so on, but such books can never become folkish. And why not? Because they can never be communicated to readers who are not of the profession in the form original and proper to the content; for the original form is and must be scientific. It is not the scientific investigations, but only their results, that are communicated. But scientific results lose their original value when they are torn loose from the investigations from which they proceeded and are communicated in a form in which they cannot be grounded. The popular lies in the form; but the popular form is a lower, inadequate form, deviating from real knowledge, and therefore a more or less shabby one. Instead of leading the reader to independent insight, such a communication on the contrary accustoms him to rely on the authority of those better informed and to take what is communicated on trust. To be educated by reading nothing but popular writings is by no means to be educated to think for oneself. Were a people to be raised to independent thinking by the way of the enlightenment of culture, then it would necessarily have to be raised to scientific insight. But that is a senseless and unnatural demand. Or would it not be a senseless and unnatural demand, if one expected that enlightenment should rise so high that all in the whole people became men of science? Suppose that culture brought matters so far that all men became astronomers, geognosts, botanists, zoologists, and so on—what then would become of the women? They too, presumably, would [121] have to become scientific. Suppose that we one day got nothing but scientific, zoological, botanical, indeed mathematical women—how then would it go with womanliness? Science, in the character of science, can never become folkish; for the scientific is not for all, but the folkish is and must be for all.

What is the folkish? It is the fundamentally human in its native strength and particularity. What follows from this for the determination of popular enlightenment and of folkish writings is then easy to see. Only that thinking, that enlightenment and development of concepts, whose first presuppositions and conditions stir with life in the personal, fundamentally human consciousness, can be called folkish. A proposition such as this, that the straight line is the shortest

way between two points, is indeed in a certain sense both folkish and popular, and yet there is here an essential difference between the folkish and the popular apprehension. The apprehension is folkish insofar as the proposition is evident to sound sense without artificial abstraction, as when it is said: the straight way is the shortest. The proposition becomes popular, on the other hand, when a mathematical abstraction, even if only a provisional one, is expressly demanded in order to hold fast line as line, point as point. That here, with the popular, we come away from the folkish, is noticed at once when we ask about the meaning of the abstraction employed. For the abstraction points out beyond the immediate and reminds us that the popular understanding is only provisional and subordinate; for it is science that has laid down the abstraction, and it is in science alone that its meaning can be developed. Only one step more is needed on the way of abstraction, and the popular proposition has ceased to be popular. It is otherwise with a folkish proposition! Its development, too, must indeed be conditioned by abstraction; but the abstraction takes place naturally and as of itself: the development is living. [122] That great heroes have great passions is a proposition which can not only be made vivid in legend, history and poetry, and is to that extent called folkish; but it can at the same time be apprehended by thought, developed and presented in the very finest psychological shadings, and still be folkish; when the eye falls on the mirror of the saga, the fundamentally human consciousness itself brings along the conditions needed for understanding the proposition: Saxo Grammaticus and Snorre Sturlesen are writers of the people of the first rank, but they cannot be called popular.

The development of the folkish is constantly exposed to two misdirections, inasmuch as one either overlooks what is individual in the nature of a people and holds fast to the merely universally human, or, with contempt for the universally human, looks exclusively to the particularity of native strength. The first error is sufficiently designated by the rationalist enlightenment of the eighteenth century, its manifold cosmopolitan and philanthropic abstractions; the “rights of man” of the Revolution rest on a cosmopolitan foundation. The cosmopolitan-philanthropic

man of understanding, with his otherwise respectable zeal for education, schooling, the enlightenment of the common man, and so on, never gets beyond the merely popular. Warned by the excesses of an empty rationalist enlightenment, one is in our days, under the influence of the questions of nationality pressing in on every side, tempted to an opposite extreme, to clinging to immediate particularity to such a degree that one without further ado lumps the accidental together with the essential and forgets the universally human. Instead of awakening and preparing the people for a freer, more vigorous self-development, one flatters its natural selfishness and nourishes its boorish inclination toward self-satisfied reserve, [123] toward indifference and foolish contempt for the light that culture spreads.

If the two sides of the folkish nature, the fundamentally human and the particularity of native strength, are to work united in spirit and in truth, then this must happen through a thorough transformation, a rebirth. The regenerating power is conditioned by the revealed word's being appropriated in faith: the concept of faith on which the emphasis must here fall is the concept of the image of God.

That man is created in the image of God is the decisive principle from which all doctrine of people and folkishness must proceed. Herein lies, in the first place, a reference to the fundamentally human; only as man so deepens himself in his own being that he therein cognizes the universally human can he cognize what bears the image of God. But the essence of the image of God cannot be held fast in empty generality; it is an image of life, the archetype of man's existence, to which his true individuality must correspond. When the image of God is realized, it comes forth womanly in the woman, manly in the man; the unfolding of its content yields not empty uniformity but rich diversity; in the image of God every man's particularity is not merely preserved, but furthered and heightened. What holds of the single human being in the people, namely that by developing according to the image of God it develops its original individuality, the same holds of a whole people; but when all the individualities in a people are developed, then surely the individuality of the people is developed.

Yet here a historical misgiving arises: "If it is really true that the evangelical

archetype by its principle furnishes presuppositions and conditions for the development of the native-strong particularity of the peoples, then such a principle of development would surely have to be expressly demonstrable in facts of the history of peoples; but is that now the case?" We answer: the testimony of history is insufficient, but that is not the fault of the principle; the fault lies with those who have misused and botched the principle. [124]

The Gospel has, from more than one side, been apprehended and applied in so unevangelical a way that the people and the life of the people have had to suffer under it. What, then, has been done? Religion and faith have been used to keep the common man in spiritual tutelage through centuries. When Gregory the Great wished to defend the holy images, he appealed to the ignorance of the people: *Legant in parietibus, quod non legunt in codicibus*. The Catholic Church, as is well known, has not understood this to mean that the ignorant people should seek edification only by looking at the images until they could gradually be taught to read in the Scriptures; no, it has understood it to mean that the Catholic common folk still in our days have "the same need" to look at the images as they had in Gregory's days.

There is in faith a characteristic mark which the hierarchy has known excellently how to use to its own advantage, but to the harm of the people; this characteristic mark is obedience! Just as faith is inseparable from worship, so faith and worship are inseparable from obedience. To believe in God is to worship him, to worship him is to serve him, to serve him is to obey him. The word of revelation is an authoritative word; the authoritative word demands obedience. The temptation to lump God's commandment together with the commandments of men is in this case great. The authoritative word of revelation lent itself excellently to procuring obedience for the rulers of the Church, the blind obedience that makes it so convenient to keep order in society. The more unconditional the obedience, the less the obedient themselves need to think. The first demand on a believing Catholic is blind, unconditional submission to the authority of the Church; blind faith is one with blind obedience. Why, pray, is heresy a mortal sin? It is not the [125]

single deviations in the single articles on which weight is laid here; no, the heretic's crime is that he dares to call in question the infallibility of the Church, that he does not submit to its commandment in unconditional obedience. Blindness heeds no light: hierarchy and popular enlightenment are incompatible.

But now Protestantism? Yes, Protestantism! That the Reformation is folkish from the ground up and began in a folkish way is certain; but how far has it come? At the Diet of Worms, when the official of Trier interrupted Luther and demanded a plain and simple answer whether he would recant or not, there sounded an answer that has now sounded over a whole world, and the answer runs: "Since then Your Imperial Majesty and Your Electoral and Princely Graces desire a simple, plain and straightforward answer, I will give one that has neither horns nor teeth, namely thus: Unless I am convinced by the testimony of Holy Scripture or by open, clear and evident reasons (for I believe neither the popes nor the councils alone, since it is plain as day that they have often erred and contradicted one another), so that I am persuaded by the very passages which I have cited and used, and my conscience is made captive in the word of God, I neither can nor will recant anything; for it is neither safe nor advisable to do anything against one's conscience. Here I stand, I can do no other, God help me. Amen!" By this answer the staff is broken over blind obedience; in this answer the at once religious and folkish principle of the Reformation is fully expressed—in a great moment, by a [126] great personality! It is in earnest with the religious, for it concerns the word of God and a good conscience. It is in earnest with the folkish; for it is precisely the individuality freed by faith which, by its manly bearing, here presents to us the human, the fundamentally human in its native strength and particularity. The personal right that Luther hereby asserts for himself he asserts at the same time for every believer in the people, and the obligation that he hereby lays upon himself he lays by the same token upon everyone in the people who shares his faith. If faith is to lead to personal independence, then it must, through the spirit and the word, lead to personal self-development, to the cognition of the truth that makes free, and can then not possibly be thoughtless. The truth that makes free is indeed

a truth of conscience, not a truth of science; but as truth it must nevertheless be cognized, and in order to be cognized it must be capable of being thought. But if it is a matter of open, clear and evident reasons, then it is in earnest a matter of popular enlightenment and popular culture; then the people cannot settle down in a common folk's pious simplicity; then it is not sufficient to believe in the Pope's images of saints, but neither is it sufficient to break with the Pope and his Latinists only to remain sitting in the nursery with the figurative talk of childlike faith and talking baby talk.

When orthodox Lutheranism distorted Luther's work, it was again obedience, blind obedience, obedience not in conscience toward God's word but obedience toward the commandments of men, religious obedience toward "the high Christian magistracy," through which the distortion took place. How Luther on the whole judged of the peoples' obligations to obey their lawful princes is well known, especially from his pronouncements on the Peasants' War. The brutality with which the oppressed rose against their tyrants brought it about that the Reformers had to lay a quite extraordinary weight on civil obedience. This was, so far, quite [127] in order. But before anyone knew it, the duty of obedience in civil matters was lumped together with the duty of obedience in religious matters, and now the distortion and the abuses went beyond all bounds.

It is, however, not so much government and prince as rather the Church and its theologians who must bear the blame for the Protestant subjugation of the people's development. In orthodox theology the dogmas were determined with an objective formal precision which made them fit indeed for juridical application. Governed by theology, the prince in his own person governed theologians and Church. We have a characteristic example in Christian the Fourth. His religious ordinances and civil laws resound with Bible passages and the fear of God, and while he not seldom, in a harsh and arbitrary manner, chastises the individual teachers, he is himself dependent on dogmatic rulings, even to such a degree that in his domestic quarrels with Christine Munk he must use the theological faculty as an oracle.

Theology brought with it yet another hindrance, very essential, to popular enlightenment. As the development of the theological doctrine was, so naturally were not only the sermons but also the religious textbooks prescribed by the government. For these textbooks, arranged for the instruction of the common people, were extracts from dogmatic systems, and hence unscientific renderings of something that was to count as science; in this way religious instruction was necessarily reduced to being popular, without being able to become folkish. Luther's Small Catechism is a folkish book; but, to name an example that lies close to us, Balle's [128] textbook is not a folkish book, it is only popular. Its popular character strikes the eye when we see how the author, in the doctrine of God's being and attributes, undertakes by way of a beginning to prove the existence of God. The proof is frail, it bears the mark of the superficial philosophy of that time; but even if philosophy went forward and apprehended the matter more thoroughly, the popular proof would not on that account become better. If the assurance of God's existence, in a deeper sense, rests on the theological proof's being fully tested, then the people are not of age; for they can no more test a theological than a philosophical proof.

So much for the difference between popular and folkish writings.

We shall now cast a glance at the difference between popular and folkish men, a difference which naturally must be determined according to the same principle as the one mentioned above. One so easily mixes the two concepts popular and folkish, and yet they are so unlike that a man can be popular without ever becoming folkish, and conversely be folkish without becoming popular. Just as, so far as the single human being is concerned, there can be a great difference between his fundamental will, that which by his deeper nature he wills and must will, and his momentary will, that for which under given circumstances he has desire and inclination, so too, so far as a whole people is concerned, a distinction can be made between its finite inclinations, guided by interests and considerations of prudence, and its fundamental will. The man who leads a people to carry out what it would most like, without asking what it must will, becomes popular, but not folkish; he, on the other hand, who moves the people to carry out not what it would most like

but what it must will, becomes folkish, but not popular: the popular man makes [129] the people into a crowd, the folkish man makes the crowd into a people.

The folkish word is an authoritative word, the folkish man an authoritative man; but the folkish word has in its authority at the same time something awakening and liberating: the folkish man will awaken the people and lead it to freedom. In the folkish, weight must be laid both on the authoritative and on the liberating. Thus Bishop Absalon was for his time a folkish man, but not popular; only in recent times has he begun to win some popularity. King Gustav Erikson Vasa in Sweden was a folkish, but far from a popular, man. How he understood his life, his reign and his position toward the people, he has set forth in a gripping and eloquent manner in the last speech he held to the Estates, where, with death before his eyes, he takes leave of government and the world and without reserve renders account of his life and of the use of his royal authority. He says among other things: "I know that in the eyes of many I have been a hard king, but the times shall come when Sweden's children would tear me up out of the mould, if it stood in their power." Those were folkish words, but they were also authoritative words. The conditions of the time were hard, and hard had the king to be who with Gustav's means was to reach his goal. But the goal was,—a goal of liberation, and in the liberation lay the folkish.

Let us go back and cast a glance at antiquity. Already in Homer the difference between the folkish man and the demagogue is to be found, not indeed developed in a concept, yet made visible through the contrast between Odysseus and Thersites: Odysseus is folkish and cares but little about being popular; but what Thersites aims at is plainly the popular. When Agamemnon (*Iliad*. II.), in order to test the mood of the people, has opened to the army the prospect of coming home, the [130] hosts stream down to the shore: what a scene, what a sight! "As when a gale blowing from the west, rushing forth violently, sets the fertile field in waves, so that the corn bows with its ears, so the people were stirred, with ringing cries they rushed all together toward the ships." The powerful movement makes vivid the army's enormous longing to return to the fatherland; no wonder, when one

considers what a temptation lay in Agamemnon's words: "Nine of the high son of Kronos' circling years have passed, the timbers in the ships are already rotten, and the ropes are decaying; meanwhile yonder in our home sit our wives and little children, waiting long for us, who here wholly for nothing waste our strength on the labor for which we came hither." Agamemnon plays a high game; he is silent about the folkish and tempts with the popular. Odysseus sees with indignation the clamoring people turn into a crowd; his task is to stop the movement and turn the crowd back into a people; this can happen only by divine assistance. Just as Pallas Athene came with a revelation to Achilles where it was a matter of bringing him personally to his senses, so she comes here too, where it is a matter of bringing the whole people to its senses, with a revelation to Odysseus. Now follows a masterly portrayal of how Odysseus knows how to bend his voice, as with mildness he admonishes the princes and with severity stops the common men. So he succeeds, by his authoritative bearing, in bringing the masses to rest and getting the people to listen. "All now remained seated and kept themselves back in their places; only the babbler Thersites let his chattering voice be heard." Thersites is the demagogue in a first crude sketch. He begins immediately as the single individual in the crowd [131] who makes a row; but as he gets the floor, he involuntarily speaks in the name of all, and at once presents himself as a leader of the crowd. The hollowness of his nature makes itself known in quite a characteristic way in that the speech he makes is an echo of Achilles' reproaches against Agamemnon: "While the others fight, toil and suffer, Agamemnon has plenty of gold and fair maidens." The speech rises to agitating pathos: "Cowardly, pampered folk, Achaeans women! Achaeans no longer!" recalls the insult done to Achilles, and ends in parody: "Achilles is meek, no gall dwells in his body, else, son of Atreus! this insult of yours would surely have been the last."

The demagogue's spiritual ugliness is symbolically designated by his bodily ugliness. "Thersites was," says Homer, "the ugliest man in the army that marched against Troy; crooked were both his legs, and he limped badly on the one, his back was humped, and his shoulders bent forward toward his chest, pointed was his

head at the top, and thin sat the hair about his crown.” That the people, with the mythical gods, at the mythical stage of consciousness, was still uncorrupted is made known by the fact that the crowd, when its eyes were opened, could see Thersites’ ugliness just as well as the princes. Before the eyes of the crowd and with the crowd’s applause, Odysseus could not only rebuke the babbler with hard words, but even inflict on him a corporal chastisement: “With his staff he struck him over back and shoulder; Thersites writhed and cringed, and the tears burst from his eyes; under the golden staff a weal rose on his back, bloody and blue; then he took his place with trembling and moaning, and with a foolish look he wiped the tears from his eye. Heartily one had to laugh” ... It was a great victory that the folkish won by this chastisement over the merely popular.

But let us not forget that it was precisely by the assistance of the gods that the victory was won. As, little by little, political development displaced the originally [132] religious, the relations changed. When the popular party in Athens regained its former influence through the expulsion of the Pisistratids, ostracism was introduced. By ostracism the crowd was entitled, without proof, even without an accusation of any crime, to condemn the fatherland’s most deserving men to exile; through ostracism it became impossible for the most patriotic hero to work in a folkish way without being popular, whereas it became possible, as an Aristophanes can testify, for a political “sausage-seller” to work popularly without being folkish.

The deeper the thought of life for which one works, the more it penetrates the fundamentally human, the more strongly, too, the contrast between the folkish and the popular will be able to come forth. We see it at the stage of revelation; we see from the story of the golden calf (1 Moseb. XXXII) what a difference there is in this respect between Aaron and Moses. Moses delays in coming down from the mountain; the people gather about Aaron and say to him: “Up, make us gods, which shall go before us; for as for this Moses, the man that brought us up out of the land of Egypt, we know not what is become of him.” So speak the people, tempted by flesh and blood; they will fall away from Jehovah, the God of the spirit; they will fall away from themselves; they are no longer a people, but a sensual,

raw rabble, a crowd. What, now, was Aaron's duty? As a folkish man to stand against the crowd and see to getting the people to listen! But instead the priest Aaron bows beneath the will of the crowd and casts the golden calf. When Moses then comes down from the mountain and is to hold judgment, there unfolds a highly characteristic exchange of words between him and Aaron. "What did this people unto thee, that thou hast brought so great a sin upon them?" Aaron: "Let [133] not the anger of my lord wax hot: thou knowest the people, that they are set on mischief"; in other words: what was I to do? I could not, after all, contradict the crowd and make myself unpopular. Aaron's sin against the people is that he has treated them not as a people but as a crowd. That he himself feels it we hear from his excusing explanation: "And they said unto me, Make us a god, which shall go before us ... And I said unto them, Whosoever hath any gold, let them break it off; so they gave it me: then I cast it into the fire, and there came out this calf." The whole thing happens without Aaron rightly knowing how; the calf comes out of the fire as if by chance: one would almost think it had come about by witchcraft. But Moses understands it otherwise. Alone and at peril of his life he takes his stand at the gate of the camp and holds judgment: "Who is on Jehovah's side, let him come unto me!" so sounded his authoritative voice; yes, the folkish man is an authoritative man.

The folkish man is in his way a holder of power just as much as the prince on his throne and the popular man who rules by popular favor; but the difference in power must be determined by the difference in authority. Christ says in the Gospel (Matth. XX) to his disciples: "Ye know that the princes of the nations rule over them, and they that are great exercise authority upon them. But it shall not be so among you: but whosoever will be great among you, let him be your servant; and whosoever will be chief among you, let him be subject to you. Even as the Son of man came not to be ministered unto, but to minister, and to give his life a ransom for many." In these words all power and authority on earth is essentially characterized. The popular man can at a given time attain power, but his power is without authority; outwardly seen, he rules indeed over the crowd,

but at bottom it is the crowd that rules over him. As head of the state the prince [134] has indeed both power and authority; but the power is physical; the authority grounded on physical power is political, but not in the stricter sense personal. Personal authority stands in direct proportion to personal superiority, and personal superiority in turn in direct proportion to self-sacrifice. But from this it surely follows that the highest folkish authority must in its innermost ground necessarily be religious. The Savior of the peoples is the Lord of the peoples, a thorn-crowned, but nonetheless divine majesty, who alone can teach them obedience. For as the power and the authority are, so must the obedience be also: toward physical power obedience is compelled submission, and the highest mitigation is this, that the submission becomes popular; toward the liberating spiritual power obedience is free submission; a free and yet unconditional submission is in the deepest sense folkish, but it is not popular.

That the difference in principle between the popular and the folkish be thoroughly cognized is an important condition for the spiritual life of the present age.

IX.

The contrast between Judaism and Christianity, between revelation at the stand-^[135] point of the Old and of the New Testament, has been, and rightly, determined thus: that Judaism, although a revealed religion, is nevertheless still only the religion of a single people, and hence burdened with the limitations which the natural bounds of a people's life necessarily bring with them, whereas Christianity, by raising itself above these limitations, has become not one religion among several others, but religion itself in spirit and in truth, not religion for a single people but for all peoples, the religion of mankind. With this, then, agrees also what Paul says, that in Christ there is no difference between Jew and Greek, that what was hostile is reconciled, that Christ "hath made both one, and hath broken down the middle wall of partition, having abolished in his flesh the enmity, even the law of commandments contained in ordinances; for to make in himself of twain one new man, so making peace" (Ephes. II). Faith in Christ thus abolishes the natural difference both between the nations among themselves and between individuals: "There is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither bond nor free, there is neither male nor female: for ye are all one in Christ Jesus" (Gal. III). That Paul here points to that unity of faith and of life in which all human feelings and thoughts must^[136] meet is clear; but how is the unity to be apprehended? An empty unity it cannot possibly be, as surely as it really is a unity of life; for the unity of life is infinitely rich in quickening power, power that unfolds multiplicity and diversity.

What kind of unity is it, then, of which Paul speaks? It is the unity which comes forth when the love of the spirit gains mastery over the selfish. Where

egoism reigns, it will in all relations misuse the differences in gifts and powers, station and circumstances, which the natural order of things brings with it. Thus the stronger people, favored by fortune, will not only subjugate the weaker, but, when the deed of violence succeeds, even flatter itself that it is Providence's chosen people, a people that knows its mission. If the egoism of a people now, into the bargain, gets a point of support in the religious, then there is no limit to hatred and enmity; it is well known how the Jews in Christ's time, in the conceit that with "the law of commandments" they were, after all, "the chosen people," hated Greeks and Romans, and were hated by them in turn. This mutual hatred and enmity of the peoples disappears when the pure self, made mighty by self-sacrifice, displaces egoism. Where an unbridled egoism reigns in society, the natural difference between man and woman and the civil difference between master and servant will naturally bring it about that the man makes the woman a female slave, and the master makes his servant a thrall. And the woman and the thrall will both, without nobler self-respect, apprehend their degradation egoistically, bow in hatred before the right of the stronger, and, hidden behind the middle wall of partition, lie in wait for revenge. As a barrier against the enmity and the lurking revenge "the law of commandments" is then set up; but the law can be broken: liberation is only in [137] faith in him who, by breaking the power of egoism, broke down "the middle wall of partition."

It is the egoistic apprehension and selfish misuse of human differences whose abolition Paul speaks of in the strong words that in Christ's kingdom there is neither Jew nor Greek, neither bond nor free, neither male nor female, but that they are all one. But that Christianity should relate itself indifferently to the differences grounded in natural endowments and natural relations, whether between individuals among themselves or between nations, cannot possibly be Paul's meaning. If one understands his words to mean that the Gospel either wholly overlooks or even aims at obliterating national differences, then one must surely also assume that the Gospel either wholly overlooks or even aims at obliterating the essential difference, not only bodily but also of soul, between man and woman. Those who

understand Christianity to mean that, as the religion of mankind, it looks only to the abstractly human and hovers cosmopolitanly above all folkish particularities, misunderstand it just as surely as those who make its effects dependent on the natures of peoples to such a degree that that middle wall of partition which Christ broke down is walled up anew.

The spirit of the Gospel will cleanse, rejuvenate and strengthen, in a word: *regenerate* the fundamentally human. What is the fundamentally human? It is the personal! In the acknowledgment of personality the religious in a way coincides with the political. Only as a person does a human being gain the rights of a citizen in an earthly society; only as a person does it gain the rights of a citizen in heaven. The question how the principle of the Reformation in the articles of faith of 1530 and the principle of the Revolution in the principles of 1789 are to be reconciled [138] coincides with the question of the development of the principle of personality.

The difference between the civic and the evangelical apprehension of the essence of personality is now this, that the former acknowledges personality in its immediate, natural existence and demands merely a limitation and ennobling of its egoism; whereas the Gospel, on the other hand, will grasp personality in its innermost spiritual root, and heighten its independence by purging away its egoism. If there can now be no doubt which of the two apprehensions is the superordinate and which the subordinate, then neither can there be any doubt that the civic must be subordinated to the evangelical, and the original emphasis fall on the evangelical apprehension.

The evangelical apprehension can be reduced to the following fundamental determinations: human personality has the divine 1) as its author, 2) as its exemplar, 3) as its essential bearer and mover. To develop these fundamental determinations is to develop the apostolic articles of faith.

The development of thought in the pure, general form must, however, not be confused with thinking in the actual life of faith: it is one thing to think faith, another to live in faith. It is not our task in the present connection to make a confession of faith; but it is expressly our task to think faith, in order to think

personality.

What a difference there is between the way of thinking of faith and that of knowledge becomes quite vivid to us when it is a matter of the development of the principle of personality. Already the standpoint, with the purely human side of the first presupposition, is determined in quite another way in faith than in science. The demand is that man, in order to know himself as a person and to assert his [139] personality, must lay weight on himself. How much weight, then, may a human being in the name of personality lay on his own self? This cannot possibly be settled by subjective arbitrariness; for in that case the most puffed-up, presumptuous and conceited individuals would surely have to be the worthiest representatives of personality. No, the demand of true personality must be determined by the very principle of selfhood. But when the question runs: what independence can originally be ascribed to the human self? then it turns out that knowledge and faith must go each its own way.

If the matter is to be settled in knowledge, the independence in principle of the self will prove to be dependent on the organism, on organic-physiological natural conditions. But if we consult physiology thoroughly, the self sinks so deep into the circle of conditions that it can hardly entertain hope of surviving death. Perhaps with the help of philosophy it can raise itself again in psychology? Yes, indeed it can raise itself, but only to unity of essence with the idea, an ambiguous unity of the moment, which now gets the name of a present eternity, now, more long-drawn-out and abstract, that of a metaphysical immortality.

It is otherwise in faith. The first distinguishing mark characteristic of the cognition of faith is just this, that the independence in principle of the self is not made dependent on organic conditions, but solely and alone on the self's own essence, an essence which comes to light in the self's concentration into absolute self-determination. How this self-determination, humanly seen, must look can easily be shown. The believing self is recognizable by its peculiar demand of life; what does it demand? An eternal life in spirit and in truth! With this its unswerving demand, at this highest peak of self-affirmation, the believing self is easy to tell

from a knowing subject. The unswerving demand is no presumption; it is on the contrary an expression of the soul's innermost longing, its very deepest need. The determinations that do not concern the demand itself do not concern faith; those determinations, on the other hand, which are necessary for the satisfaction of the demand belong originally to the concept of faith and are decisive for the thinking of faith. Since, then, there can be talk here of concepts of faith just as well as of concepts of knowledge, the principle of contradiction will play a role in the development of thought in faith just as well as in knowledge; only that the contradictions, in accordance with the heterogeneous principles, must be heterogeneous. All the contradictions of science are, in their fundamental character, objective contradictions of concepts; it is either one concept that contradicts another, or a concept that contradicts itself. Thus, for example, a round square is an objective, essential contradiction of concepts. It is otherwise with the contradictions of faith; they are all recognized, according to their fundamental character, by this, that through them the self, mediately or immediately, contradicts itself: the contradictions of faith are in the deepest sense personal self-contradictions. As a contradiction is, so must its resolution be also: knowledge can no more resolve the contradictions of faith than faith can resolve those of knowledge. Herewith the presupposition necessary for the development of the principle of personality is determined; we shall now indicate in general outline the course of the development. [140]

1) Human personality has the divine as its author.

How much faith and knowledge must disagree on this point is already clear from what we have brought out in an earlier connection. When science cannot acknowledge the personality of God because the concept of an absolute personality is a self-contradictory concept: how then could it grant that the personal God can be the author of human personality? Now it is quite certain, to be sure, that science changes its concept of God every moment: every original philosophy, the atheistic not excepted, has its own original concept of God. In Spinoza God is the one infinite substance, in Leibnitz the monad of monads, in Fichte the moral world order, in Schelling—at least for a time—the Absolute-Absolute, in Hegel “the [141]

concept,” in Feuerbach zero; he who would rightly cognize the philosophical God of the times must know the metaphysical rate of exchange, just as he who would appraise the year’s harvest must know the official grain-price schedule.

To leave philosophy and flee to theology is only to make bad worse; it is to stir the contradictions of faith and of knowledge together into one and muddy the whole. The only elements that rise with any distinctness out of such a stirring together are a multitude of big words that all end in *ism*: atheism, acosmism, pantheism, polytheism, monotheism, deism, theism, and the like. But the concept of personality, however many *isms* one may drive it to, does not become clearer.

We keep, then, to faith. Every determination in a concept of faith is, in accordance with the standpoint, to be stated briefly and sharply, without any long-winded circumlocutions: the corrective lies in the self-contradiction and its resolution. Whence does the believer know that God is personal? He does not *know* it, you see, but he *believes* it! Then his assurance in faith is presumably weaker than that which he could have obtained in knowledge? By no means! it is on the contrary far stronger. To deny the personality of God, or even merely to call it in question, would be for the believer just as revolting a self-contradiction as it is for the knower a revolting contradiction of concepts that the round should [142] be square. If the personal demand of the self has validity, then it cannot, despite its relative dependence on organism and organic conditions, possibly derive its existence from a selfless nature. With the life of nature as its foundation it must, in order to live an eternal life, necessarily have a germ of selfhood from the eternal, absolute self, i.e. from the personal God.

The more living the feeling of self is, the more painfully is felt the cutting contrast between man’s personality and the impersonal being of nature: a powerless freedom stands here over against an overpowering necessity. If freedom is in truth to be cognized as the principle of all existence, then the kingdom of nature, the whole natural world, must be absolutely dependent on God, a work of his free, almighty will: to believe in the eternal author of the self is to believe in “the almighty Creator of heaven and earth.”

In the question of nature and creation the difference between the essence of faith and that of knowledge becomes quite conspicuous. For the principle of knowledge nature as nature is the first, and the concept of creation must in consequence conform itself to the concept of nature. Now, if science, by laying its concept of nature at the foundation, could develop, clarify and make distinct the religious concept of creation: then it would by the same token be able to develop all the other fundamental religious concepts; theology would then be transformed into philosophy, and the scientific reconciliation of faith and knowledge would be consummated by faith's being dissolved into knowledge. For the principle of faith, on the other hand, creation as creation is the first, and the concept of nature must in consequence conform itself to the concept of creation. Now, if the doctrine of faith, by laying its concept of creation at the foundation, could develop, clarify and make distinct the scientific concept of nature: then it would by the same token be able to develop all the other fundamental concepts of nature; the scientific reconciliation of faith and knowledge would then be to be sought and found in "Christian dogmatics"; and what then? Why, then we should have—the [143] theological universal monarchy! But the latter is, according to the conditions of human cognition, just as impossible as the former (cf. "Den gode Villie som Magt i Videnskaben," p. 30 ff.).

Since, now, neither is possible, the reconciliation can be brought about only on the condition that human knowledge cognize its absolute limit, and that faith, as a principle independent in itself, gain the right to develop its own concepts.

"But"—it is objected—"for a moment it may well look as if such a doubling were something; but if we look more closely, it is nevertheless not anything. Science never grants that outside its own preserves there can be a coherent, consistent thinking; in particular the clear heads, the true, sharp-thinking metaphysicians, the holders of pure philosophy, will soon prove to us that human knowledge cannot possibly have any absolute limit, and hence cannot grant any riddle of existence either, and hence cannot acknowledge faith as any principle of thought independent in itself." We answer that if there really arises a metaphysician who,

to the world's great astonishment, proves and makes it manifest to all who can think that human knowledge has no absolute limit: then we too shall not fail, as in duty bound, to be astonished. But until this happens, we use the interval of expectation to impress upon ourselves the following fundamental demands, which the knowledge that declares the absolute limit abolished must be able to satisfy without circumlocution.

Such a knower must show how he goes about: a) thinking, not merely *successively*, first the one thought and then the other, but simultaneously, i.e. countless [144] distinct thoughts at once, for thus thinks a godhead; b) seeing through matter and the material so thoroughly that, by his intellectual power—for to comprehend is, after all, to master—he becomes able to transform concept into existence, and existence again into concept, the concept of the horse into the existence of the horse, the concept of gold into actual gold; for to overlook the horse and ride on the concept, to keep the gold itself and pay with the concept, are mere evasions, and such evasions are unworthy of a metaphysical godhead; c) seeing through the unity of brain activity and the corresponding thinking, of the moving will and the nerve moved by the will, so clearly, and making the interaction between soul and body so evident, so distinct and comprehensible, that even the physiologists give up their intricate and laborious empiricism in order to throw themselves upon metaphysics; and so on.

What we demand here the pure metaphysician will perhaps regard as trifles and petty quibbles; for once one has, with the help of abstractions, precipitated existence as a sediment of the concept, then the determinations of power belonging to existence naturally fall away of themselves, and when the determinations of power fall away, a powerless knowledge can, of course, easily play godhead. Or might perhaps—for as regards pure metaphysics one must be prepared for the incredible—powerless knowledge one day, by “fine observations,” be able to carry things so far that it even deduced, I say and write: deduced, not the universal concept of power—for the concept of power in abstracto has been deduced often enough—but power itself, actual power, I say and write: actual power with the

actual determinations of power? Yes, if that ever happens, then a metaphysical miracle happens. Let one judge of such a miracle as one will; but every reasonable human being must surely grant us that the demands set up have their significance, and that it would nevertheless be rather interesting if, with the help of pure [145] knowledge, one could some day find out how things go with metaphysical miracles in a speculative brain.

Yet even if the astonishing thing should happen, namely that pure, powerless knowledge gets power over actuality itself and deduces, not the ideal necessity of power—such a necessity has been deduced often enough—but power’s *immediate manifestation* in actual existence: what then? Then there is still one thing that can be said in this connection with decisive certainty, and it is this: that such a metaphysical deduction the people—and it is precisely of the enlightenment of the people that we are speaking here—will never get into its head; and that for the good natural reason that a popular head is not metaphysical. In other words: if the religious concept of creation is to be dissolved, filtered off, deduced, paralyzed and turned topsy-turvy into a concept of knowledge by a powerful word of impotence, so that it is no longer permitted to count as what it originally is and wants to be—a concept of faith—then the popular light goes out; then the unscientific must learn to believe, not in the revealed Word, but in the deductions of metaphysics. They do not, of course, get knowledge itself, but only a semblance of knowledge in the popular.

To exchange faith in revelation for faith in metaphysics is a mistake that will hinder the spiritual life not only in the present age but surely also in the future. If the powers of the spirit are to be awakened, and the fundamentally human is to stir in all its originality, then the condition, the indispensable condition, is that the principle of faith asserts its right, that the fundamental concepts of revelation, the concept of freedom, the concept of creation and first and last the *concept of personality*, develop in a form that corresponds at once to religious and to popular [146] thinking. “Ye shall all,” says Christ, “be theodidacts,” that is, taught of God. These words may well be said, in the present connection, to contain a serious admonition.

For just as impossible as it is to get the life of the spirit in a people developed and clarified by popular after-glimmers of the torches of the sciences, just so necessary is it to get popular instruction grounded on personal insight into the essence of personality. The thought of personality is at once a popular and a religious fundamental thought. The richer and deeper this fundamental thought develops in a people's consciousness, the richer and deeper also will be the influences of the divine Spirit upon the spirit of the people; the richer and deeper each national spirit, according to its measure, appropriates the divine instruction, the more will hatred vanish, the middle wall of partition be broken through, and the fundamentally human thought of unity triumph through Him who came "to make peace."

2) Human personality has the divine for its pattern.

The enlightened of culture will perhaps, out of particular regard for the great majority of the population, grant us that a religious development of the principle of personality might well have its significance when it is a matter of awakening the consciousness of the fundamentally human; but, they add, with the express restriction that one keeps to the first article, which expresses the universally religious, and takes care not to touch the second. "Instead of presenting the universal, the second article presents precisely the altogether particular, indeed something so particular that not even the Christians among themselves have been able to agree on its understanding." That this article, instead of being a general article of agreement, has on the contrary become an article of strife, of discord and [147] of separation, has, in the opinion of these cultured people, its natural ground in this, that a single human being existing in flesh and blood has been set up as the normal man, indeed as the God-man has been made an object of faith and worship.

The objection rests on a great misunderstanding. Through the second article there runs the same, the very same personal thought of unity as through the first. On closer consideration it will appear that the first article first acquires its full significance by being seen in the light of the second.

If in the first article we saw the opposition between man's limited personality and the power of nature, we must now in the second article reflect upon a new

opposition, the spiritual opposition between egoism and the holy personality. This opposition points expressly to a contradiction in man himself. It is the first religious testimony of conscience that man enters as a debtor into the kingdom of the spirit: the first consciousness of spirit as spirit goes together with the consciousness of guilt. The self-contradiction is that the actual personality stands in conflict with its ideal, that the fundamentally human is distorted, that the image of God is lost. How is this self-contradiction to be removed? Philosophy must, insofar as it does not want to deny every glimmer of spirit, agree with religion that the actual, existing man is at variance with his own ideal. And yet it is a demand of the spirit that man shall be judged by his ideal. The demand is just, but it is severe: there is something horrifying in seeing an Adam Homo on the defendant's bench and hearing his counsel say that he "appeals to the ideal."

The agreement between religion and philosophy ceases, however, the moment the question is asked about the realization of the ideal. The dispute on this point is well suited to illuminate the different way in which the principle of contradiction [148] is applied by faith and by knowledge. Insofar as the opposition between ideal and actuality is apprehended from the standpoint of science, the emphasis is laid on the concept of actuality, and the question then becomes whether the ideal can be realized. If it now turns out that the existing man cannot realize his ideal, what then? Why, then its realization, strictly speaking, cannot be demanded of man either. Man in flesh and blood need not, then, take the demand too much to heart; if he really cannot fulfill it, he is of course lawfully excused. By coming into contradiction with the concept of actuality, the concept of the ideal comes into express contradiction with itself; for an ideal that demands realization without being able to be realized is a contradiction. It is otherwise in the religious. When the opposition between man's personal ideal and the man existing in flesh and blood is apprehended from the standpoint of religion, the whole decisive emphasis is laid on the ideal demand: Thou *shalt* realize thy ideal; here no excuse holds, *Thou shalt!* Instead of placing the contradiction in the ideal, religion, in order to vindicate the right of personality, places the contradiction in the human self

and appeals to conscience. If man now wants to withdraw from the obligation, he feels a painful self-contradiction; for the ideal shall—it is divine earnest—the ideal shall be realized. If man acknowledges the obligation, he feels the deepest pain of self-contradiction; for in this actuality, with “these members,” in this body condemned to death, he cannot possibly fulfill the obligation. It is a pain as though the personality must burst: what, then, can man do? In his pain he can understand [149] the Apostle’s lament: “O wretched man that I am! who shall deliver me from the body of this death?”

When the realized ideal, the pattern existing in flesh and blood, is regarded in the light of knowledge, criticism says consistently: such an ideal man is impossible, consequently he is unactual. When the evangelical pattern is regarded in the light of faith, criticism says consistently: such an ideal man is necessary, consequently he is actual.

That knowledge bows beneath the power of finite actuality as beneath a natural power independent of the ideal demand of personality is, after all, quite in order, since, according to its principle, it has had to set the concept of nature above the concept of creation: science cannot acknowledge the second article because it has not been able to acknowledge the first. With faith the case is the reverse. Since the thought of faith bows before the holy power of the ideal, it need not give way before sensuous conditions of nature. By setting the concept of creation above the concept of nature it has made the sensuous conditions of nature dependent on the personal will of the Almighty: by acknowledging the first article it has opened for itself the way to acknowledge the second.

If we go through the second article member by member, we convince ourselves that every member corresponds precisely to the ideal demand of the principle of personality. If the person of the Redeemer is to be an object of knowledge, then the whole article is a fantastic composition of mutually contradictory elements: “Conceived by the Spirit and born of the Virgin,” and yet “suffered under Pontius Pilate”; “crucified, dead and buried,” and yet “risen from the dead and ascended into heaven” ... what absurdities! If, on the other hand, the person of the Redeemer is

apprehended as an object of faith, then the one member follows from the other [150] with inner consistency.

As the one who in an actual human life is to fulfill the holy law of personality, the pattern must have a will perfectly pure and strong, moved by the Spirit of holiness; but in order that an actual human being may have a pure and strong and holy will, he must be conceived by the Spirit and born in purity. "That is absurd, impossible, in contradiction with all actuality!" cries the knower. But faith does not fear the contradictions of knowledge; it does not heed, and according to its principle cannot heed, the contradictions that spring from regard for material actuality; in its concept of creation it has a sure defense against all such contradictions. On the other hand, faith does fear one contradiction: that is personal self-contradiction, for in it is death. But now it would surely be a contradiction in the essence of personality if its ideal demands could not be realized, and an equally glaring contradiction that a human being could realize these demands without a pure and holy will, and then finally also a contradiction that a human being should be able to have a pure and holy will although he was, as David says in the pain of his contrition, "shapen in iniquity and conceived in sin."

But now the actual life of the ideal in a sensuous, actual world? Well, is it not remarkable that the richest course of life can be grasped and presented in so few and simple words? "Suffered under Pontius Pilate, crucified, dead and buried"; in these words the actual life of the ideal is summed up; for the words make his suffering visible, and the life of the ideal on earth was suffering and passion from first to last. The conflict between ideal and actuality is thus removed in suffering; the self-contradiction vanished when suffering was put in its place.

As regards the descent into Hades (*descendit ad inferos*), this member is well [151] suited to show what comes of making Christ an object of knowledge in the doctrine of religion. The disputes of the theologians about his supernatural birth, his two natures, his two wills, his union of impotence with omnipotence on the cross, are no doubt on the whole offensive and meaningless; but when the dispute turns on the "descent into hell," the hollowness of the scientific fantasizing becomes

repulsive. If, on the other hand, the pattern is apprehended as the object of faith, then his presence in the realm of the dead is a visible representation of his actual death, his victory over death, and salvation for the captives of death.

How completely the ideal of personality has triumphed over death and corruptibility is presented, in the visible manner of revelation, by the personal resurrection and the personal ascension. He who rose is personally the same as he who was buried; he who was exalted is the same, personally the same, as he who was in humiliation. The ideal's course of life is a complete circuit; so we understand his words when he says of himself: "I came forth from the Father, and am come into the world: again, I leave the world, and go to the Father."

It is the law of the spirit that actual personalities shall be judged by their true ideal; the realized ideal of personality is therefore the judge of mankind: "He shall come again to judge the quick and the dead."

3) Human personality has the divine for its essential bearer and mover.

From the different way in which the relation between actuality and the ideal is apprehended in knowledge and in faith, it follows of necessity that the spirit in science must be a different one from that in religion. The concept of spirit is [152] determined by the concept of the ideal: in order to understand the second article, we must learn to understand the third. Since science, according to its principle, is unable to cognize the realized ideal of personality, for the same reason it cannot cognize the divine personality in the spirit itself either. For the knower, spirit is only a unity of the idea and consciousness; for the believer the idea, on the contrary, is a mediating being between his own human self and the divine self working in him; the knower relates himself through the idea to himself; the believer relates himself through the idea (the idea of truth, of holiness, of righteousness, and so on) to God.

That the divine self has realized the ideal of personality on earth could not possibly benefit finite personalities if the self from God did not at the same time will to work toward the ideal's being relatively realized in every human being. By merely apprehending the pattern as a historical person we are still so far from

getting the self-contradiction resolved that we rather get it intensified. When the ideal of personality is realized in this one human being, then this one human being stands before intuition as the one who upholds the unrejectable validity of the ideal demands; he fulfills the law of selfhood, and the law of selfhood shall be fulfilled. "Think not that I am come to destroy the law, or the prophets: I am not come to destroy, but to fulfil. For verily I say unto you, Till heaven and earth pass, one jot or one tittle shall in no wise pass from the law, till all be fulfilled." But by getting the ideal realized in this way in the perfect personality, the imperfect personalities have got the actual ideal outside themselves, and then actually stand outside the ideal. Were they to be judged by the ideal in such a position, the judgment would become a condemnation. The contradiction can only be resolved by this, that the divine self does not confine itself to an outward presentation of the realized [153] ideal, but expressly posits the outward realization as the presupposition for the activity by which, as sanctifying Spirit, it repeats and forms the original pattern in each single human being. As the finite, imperfect personalities are influenced and moved by the one and the same Spirit of personality, the congregation is gathered and the pattern glorified. Without the actual pattern the Spirit cannot develop the fundamentally human in single individuals; for the development of the fundamentally human coincides with the appropriation of the pattern. Therefore Christ says to the disciples (John XVI): "I have yet many things to say unto you, but ye cannot bear them now. Howbeit when he, the Spirit of truth, is come, he will guide you into all truth: for he shall not speak of himself. He shall glorify me: for he shall receive of mine, and shall shew it unto you."

It will be seen from these fundamental features that the humane carrying-through of the right of personality must essentially rest on a religious development of the principle of personality. To the enlightenment of culture in the state corresponds popular enlightenment in the congregation: a popular state that by its laws of compulsion protects the civil personality presupposes a people's church that by the laws of freedom and the means of the spirit educates and forms the religious personality. A scientific botching of the religious principles of the people's life is

an essential hindrance to the spiritual life; but the hindrance can be transformed into a condition when the spirit of personality gets power over the impersonal, half-personal nature of the enlightenment of culture.

X.

When popular enlightenment has once advanced so far that it can really measure ^[154] itself against a many-sided, richly developed civilization, when light stands against light, the light of faith against the light of culture, then the rays from both sides will be thrown back by differing resistance and refracted in the heterogeneous media of actuality; in the refraction a many-colored light will be seen, and in the many-colored light manifold images of life. But will this refraction always be harmonious? No, not always. Will these images of light and life bear witness to a single coherent, internally consistent course of life? By no means! Among the many refracting media there is one in particular that by its nature must present a difficult matter to settle, and this refracting medium is sacred history.

Sacred history has this in common with all history, that its content is to render the actual; but it differs from all other history in this, that the actual which it renders unites the supernatural with the natural in an impenetrable way. The actual has thus here taken up something that seems to stand in conflict with the concept of actuality, and yet its validity is to be thought. The concept of actuality is placed in the foreground; in this concept the standard is given; we shall now see how differently it is applied according as thought enters the service of civilization ^[155] or of popular enlightenment.

From the standpoint of civilization, of negative criticism, actuality will naturally have to be judged according to the universally valid, unchangeable laws of nature. Civilization moves according to knowledge; in knowledge the concept of creation is so subordinated to the concept of nature that the natural cannot take up the

supernatural. From the standpoint of popular enlightenment, on the other hand, actuality is to be judged according to the law of personality and of freedom; popular enlightenment moves according to faith: in faith the concept of nature is so subordinated to the concept of creation that the natural must have its ground in the supernatural. So once again faith stands against knowledge as principle against principle. As the principle is, so must the criticism be; if knowledge has its criticism, then faith too must have its own. So criticism stands against criticism, criticism of knowledge against criticism of faith: in the alternating light of criticism sacred history must change color. The light that proceeds from the criticism of faith will everywhere clarify the difference between mythology and revelation, between myth and sacred history. The light that proceeds from the criticism of knowledge will everywhere clarify the likeness between mythology and revelation, between myth and sacred history. We shall begin with the criticism of knowledge.

The principle is that whatever in a history, be it profane or sacred, resembles the mythical in all essential features must be mythical. Now, for example, the likeness between a talking horse and a talking she-ass is so unmistakable that if the horse is mythical, then the she-ass must be so too. That the one story is found in Homer, the other in the Bible, cannot entitle us to regard the latter as a revelation [156] and the former as a myth; such a procedure would surely be just as uncritical and arbitrary as if a historian took it into his head to assume something in a document to be untrue merely because it was written in Greek letters, and something to be true merely because it was written in Hebrew ones. The task is to determine the fundamental character both of the biblical and of the Homeric narrative. In Homer's *Iliad* (XIX) it is described how Achilles, after Patroclus has fallen and the reconciliation with Agamemnon has taken place, arms himself for battle and mounts the war-chariot. He addresses his horses in these words: "Xanthus and Balius! ye famous foals of Podarge, forget not now, as last time, to bring your master home safe from the field to the camp of the Achaeans when the battle is fought out!" This conversation is in earnest, for the speaker receives an earnest answer. Xanthus, "the flying horse beneath the yoke," bows low and answers with

a sigh: "Home in safety we shall bring thee yet, thou mighty son of Peleus! Yet it hastens hard toward thy death; the fault is not ours; guilty is only the mighty god and powerful fate." Thus speaks Xanthus, and how has it come to speak? "Voice it got from the lily-armed Hera." And how does the speech affect Achilles? It does not surprise him in the least that his horse starts to talk, indeed even to talk as one initiated into the secrets of fate; on the contrary, it is as though it went without saying. Xanthus is deeply moved, Achilles too is deeply moved and answers sadly: "Xanthus, why dost thou foretell my death? The announcement thou mayest spare thyself." Now we all say: It is beautiful, it is touching, but it is only a myth. That a bright child can take such a story for actuality is very natural; but that a grown person with sound understanding can become so childish, be so deeply stuck in "childhood faith," that he too takes the story as actual, is in the very highest degree [157] unnatural. No one doubts that the horse to which Hera can give speech, and which the Erinyes can rob of voice, does not belong under the category *Equus Caballus*, which has its place in zoology, but simply and solely under mythology.

We have considered Achilles' horse; let us now consider Balaam's she-ass! The story is found in the fourth book of Moses (XXII). The children of Israel, it is said, encamped in the plains of Moab, on the other side of Jordan by Jericho. Balak, the son of Zippor, king of the Moabites, sees this power, sees in it an invading enemy and is terrified; in his terror he knows no better counsel than to send his elders to the prophet Balaam and, by the rewards of divination, prevail on him to curse the strangers. But in the night Jehovah reveals himself to Balaam and says expressly: "Thou shalt not curse the people: for they are blessed." And Balaam shows no disobedience; on the contrary, he declares that even if Balak would give him his house full of silver and gold, he could not act disobediently toward the Lord and curse Israel. They pressed him; another night passed, and Jehovah revealed himself again to the prophet, but instead of holding him back he now says: "If the men come to call thee, rise up, and go with them; but yet the word which I shall say unto thee, that shalt thou do." Balaam wakes and does as Jehovah has said, and goes along with "the princes of Moab." But on the way Jehovah's anger is kindled

because the prophet goes along; what has Jehovah become angry about? That is not known. Here not the least thing is adduced that might point to an explanation. If one wants an explanation, one must invent it oneself. The text tells us only that Jehovah has become angry, and in his anger sends the angel who is to stop Balaam. The anger is very great; the prophet has fallen into disfavor to such a degree that [158] he is not even found worthy to see the angel, whereas the she-ass is found worthy. The angel stands in the hollow way by the vineyard, where there was a stone wall on both sides, and when the she-ass sees the angel and presses herself against the wall, the prophet is angered and strikes her three times; now the Lord gives the she-ass voice, and the speaking she-ass asks quite meekly: "What have I done unto thee, that thou hast smitten me?" Instead of being astonished at this address, Balaam listens to it with the same naturalness with which Achilles listened to Xanthus, and says: "I would there were a sword in mine hand, for now would I kill thee."

So striking is the likeness between the story of the talking she-ass and the story of the talking horse that if both were found in Homer, then both, of course, would have to be mythical, and if both were found in the Bible, then both—regarded from the standpoint of faith, naturally—would have to be revelations. Here one sees, then, what comes of letting the concept of creation supplant the concept of nature and of acknowledging an actuality in which the so-called supernatural is permitted to mix itself into the natural. The believers will no doubt appeal to the fact that it is only Hera who works the miracle with the horse, whereas it is Jehovah who works the miracle with the she-ass; that Hera's miracle belongs only to the imagination, like herself, whereas Jehovah's miracle is a sign of the power he actually has as the almighty creator of heaven and earth; in short: one will defend the actuality of the miracle by appealing to actual omnipotence. But what comes of letting the concept of omnipotence devour the concept of nature in unbounded arbitrariness? We learn it from the she-ass's words to the embittered prophet. "And the ass said unto Balaam, Am not I thine ass, upon which thou hast ridden ever since I was [159] thine unto this day? was I ever wont to do so unto thee?" Who, now, is really

the speaking subject here? It surely cannot be either the angel or Jehovah who speaks in such a way that to Balaam it sounds as though the speech came from the she-ass: such a miraculous ventriloquism would surely be unworthy of the Godhead. It must, then, be the she-ass that speaks. But what kind of miracle is this, after all? It is a miracle whereby a dumb animal soul is in an instant re-created into a rational, self-conscious soul; and that in such a way that this self-conscious soul in a single moment is developed to such a degree that it knows the language, the language Balaam as a child took a longer time to learn; a miracle whereby the animal soul is not merely re-created from dumb to speaking, and so into a quite different soul, a quite different being, but on top of that is re-created in such a way that, in spite of the re-creation, it nevertheless remains the same being, the same soul. The man on whose head the hair does not stand on end when he is to acknowledge such an actuality—his head must have lost either its hair or—its wits; for the sight is horrible. The speaking she-ass is actual; the dumb one is also actual: the one crowds the other out, and yet these two actual animals are in actuality one and the same animal; that is what one may call actuality!

However, lest it should look as though the criticism of knowledge, if we may say so, had fastened its teeth in a single, obscure narrative, less essential to the history of revelation as a whole, we shall, to illuminate the miraculous actuality, choose a couple of examples that stand in so intimate an organic connection with the economy of revelation in its entirety that they cannot be taken away without the whole collapsing; we mean the legend of Paradise and the Gospel of Christ's resurrection.

The legend of Paradise must, from the standpoint of faith, be apprehended as a true history and, as a true history, refer to the actual. There must, then, in the actual Paradise have been an actual tree of life, an actual tree of knowledge, an actual serpent, and so on, and so on. Adam and Eve must have lived as full-grown human beings in holy innocence and perfect blessedness before the fall, and upon the fall there must have followed an actual curse upon the whole actual earth. We shall now test what kind of actuality this is. Whatever in all respects resembles the

[160]

mythical must be mythical; from this principle we begin the investigation again. That geology has no place for an actual Paradise is surely strong testimony against its actuality; in the present connection, however, the emphasis falls not so much on the facts of natural science as rather on the very concept of actuality. Just as little as natural trees, for example apple and pear trees, can be thought to grow in a supernatural, i.e. supraterrrestrial, soil, just as little can such supernatural trees as the tree of life and the tree of the knowledge of good and evil be thought to grow in a natural soil. If we now ask what the actual soil in Paradise must have been like, the answer becomes very doubtful. It is said expressly that the Lord God Jehovah took the man and put him into the garden of Eden to dress it and to keep it. The part of the actual garden that Adam was to dress and to keep may then well be assumed to have been the natural part of actuality; whereas the section of the garden in which the tree of life and the tree of knowledge grew hardly needed any cultivation and so must presumably have made up the supernatural part.

[161] That Adam is actually to dress and to keep an actual garden indicates, as has been said, that Adam is an actual and natural human being. But how, now, is a natural human being to be thought able to pluck fruits from a supernatural tree, indeed not only to pluck them but even to eat them? And yet, alas, first Eve and then Adam, in their naked naturalness, succeed only too well in plucking and eating the supernatural; in actuality they succeed so well with the tree of knowledge that Jehovah becomes downright afraid that they will succeed with the tree of life as well. "And the Lord God Jehovah said, Behold, the man is become as one of us, to know good and evil: and now, lest he put forth his hand, and take also of the tree of life, and eat, and live for ever." That this may be prevented, Adam with his wife is then actually driven out of the actual Paradise, and the way to the tree of life guarded by the cherubim. Before their expulsion from Paradise, our first parents must thus, in the first actuality, have had a wonderful mixture of the natural and the supernatural, so that only after being driven out did they become properly natural.

If we pass over to the animal world and ask the zoologist what he thinks of

the part of sacred history that deals with the animals in Paradise, he will without doubt answer: Not very much. It is said of the animals that they were created of all kinds, and that they were all brought to Adam, who gave them names. Among the paradisal animals thus brought to Adam the beasts of prey must also have been. In the paradisal state, however, they could not possibly go hunting for prey; that would surely in actuality have disturbed the actual blessedness. But, we ask, what is a beast of prey that does not go after prey? It is a round square. It lies in the zoological character of beasts of prey, in their claws, teeth, digestive organs and so on, that they absolutely must be carnivorous; but how should flesh-eating and blood-drinking animals be able to live when they dared not go after prey? Might it perhaps have been supernatural flesh on which they lived? But then they must surely also have been supernatural beasts of prey. That lions, tigers, leopards and so on did not yet go after prey means that the lion was not yet a lion, the tiger not a tiger, and so on. The species of beasts of prey had thus not come into being; and yet the narrative says that God had already created all “the beasts of the field.” [162]

It becomes still worse when one comes to the serpent. With the talking serpent theology has really taken things far too easily, now without further ado making it the devil himself, “that old serpent,” now, more speculatively, “the cosmic principle.” As regards the cosmic principle, it takes more than human understanding to see how so metaphysical a being as a principle is to be able either to transform itself into a serpent or to speak through a serpent. And as regards the devil, the narrative contains not the slightest hint that the serpent is possessed by the devil.

When the serpent speaks to the woman, it is the serpent itself in a quite different sense than when Xanthus speaks to Achilles, or the she-ass to Balaam. The horse and the she-ass are dumb animals, which only by a miracle could become speaking. But not so with the serpent; for “the serpent was more subtil than any beast of the field which the Lord God Jehovah had made.” The serpent belongs to the beasts of the field, and so to the dumb ones; but—so fruitful is the invention of subordinating the concept of nature to the concept of creation—though by its naturalness belonging to the dumb animals, the serpent has nevertheless from the

beginning known how to unite the supernatural with the actual so cleverly that it
 [163] has become speaking just as well as man. Should anyone still harbor doubt that, in the narrative's meaning, it is actually the serpent that speaks, and speaks of its own, let him but hear Jehovah's curse upon the serpent: "Because thou hast done this, thou art cursed above all cattle, and above every beast of the field; upon thy belly shalt thou go, and dust shalt thou eat all the days of thy life." The serpent has thus by its action drawn upon itself Jehovah's wrath and punishment, is thus accountable, has thus acted with freedom and deliberation. If this is not mythical, what then is mythical? Can anyone well shut his eyes to the likeness between the serpent's trespass and Adam's and Eve's trespass? Eve is punished, for she is accountable and has misused her freedom; Adam is punished, for he is accountable and has misused his freedom. The serpent is punished; so it too is accountable and has misused its freedom. But the consciousness that, as regards freedom and accountability, can set a serpent on an equal footing with a human being is not a consciousness that grasps the actual, but a mythical consciousness.

What the mythical consciousness has in all naivety presented as a supernatural fact can, when the content is of deeper ethical significance, still retain its validity long after the enlightenment of culture has explained away the supernatural; the phenomena are no longer, indeed, taken to be actual, but are honored and used as holy symbols. Instead of a supernatural actuality we get a religious symbolism, and now it is the higher spiritual task of the teachers of the people—a task for whose solution they also, of course, prepare themselves worthily by studying "sacred theology"—to apply this symbolism in so ambiguous, clever and ingenious a way that the common man suspects nothing amiss but takes the symbolic for
 [164] full actuality. Thus the legend of Paradise can be used with success in popular instruction as a symbol and yet look like sacred history; thus the myth of Christ's resurrection can still, many an Easter morning, have its effect as a historical event and yet be interpreted as a symbol of the victory of life over death, of light over darkness, of truth over the lie. But that the story of Christ's resurrection is just as certainly a myth as the story of Paradise, the criticism of knowledge will easily be

able to prove.

We shall not dwell here on what Strausz has sufficiently shown, that the evangelical accounts contradict one another in many essential points; we shall—for the further testing of the actuality that faith gets out of letting the concept of creation supplant the concept of nature—keep to a single account, in order to see how contradictory such an account is in itself.

We choose the account in Luke (XXIV, 36–43). The two disciples who met the Risen One on the road to Emmaus have already returned to Jerusalem, where they find “the eleven gathered together, and them that were with them.” Just as those assembled are absorbed in conversation about the wonderful thing that had happened, Jesus himself suddenly stands in the midst of them. “But they were terrified and affrighted, and supposed that they had seen a spirit”! The first immediate impression is as of a vision of a spirit. To the disciples’ great surprise, however, this vision of a spirit becomes the Crucified himself in bodily actuality, in “flesh and bones.” As yet further proof that in this actuality the supernatural is united with the natural, the one who reveals himself puts to them the question: “Have ye here any meat?” They give him a piece of a broiled fish and of a honeycomb. “And he took it, and did eat before them.” That criticism must regard such an appearance as impossible has simply and solely its ground in [165] this, that it must find what is self-contradictory impossible. That the Risen One presents himself to the disciples as a supernatural being, a spirit, is no doubt in formal agreement with the concept of resurrection, insofar as the resurrection is a miracle, and he whose life rests on a miracle must, in bodily as well as in psychical respects, be a miraculous being. But how, now, is it to be thought that a miraculous being can perform so natural an action as that of eating “a piece of a broiled fish, and of an honeycomb”? It must presumably be thought in faith in the same way as it must be thought in faith that Jehovah, the almighty creator of heaven and earth, actually ate actual curds and actual veal with Abraham under the tree in the grove of Mamre; it must presumably be thought to happen by a miracle. But to eat is a natural action, and no miracle; what is no miracle thus happens by a miracle:

the supernatural devours the natural; but precisely by devouring the natural the supernatural shows itself as the unactual, the mythical.

This is the scientific result of the criticism of knowledge. We have let the knower express himself so many-sidedly, fully and unreservedly that no one who is able to understand his utterances will be able to mistake the fundamental thought; the light with which he gives light is the light of culture, and he does not put the light under a bushel. So long, however, as the people—particularly as regards the great mass—can be kept in a certain peasant-like ignorance, such a criticism from culture will either not be noticed at all, or else the critic will be regarded as an ungodly person with whom it is not worth having anything to do. But as popular enlightenment advances, the matter must change. The enlightened will see that the attacks of the criticism of knowledge on religion do not consist in wanton, [166] arbitrary whims, but proceed with inner necessity from a definite fundamental thought, a distinctive principle. The dispute about the validity of religion must—it is an unrejectable condition for the spiritual life—become a question of principle. In proportion as the principle of culture becomes clear in broad outline to the popular consciousness, the principle of faith must then also become clear: against the criticism of knowledge we set the criticism of faith.

The emphasis falls, as has already been indicated, on the difference between mythology and revelation, between myth and sacred history. This difference cannot be decisively determined by a finite comparison of the phenomena; for the phenomenon of revelation has a deceptive likeness to myth; in the phenomenon as phenomenon a talking horse stands on an equal footing with a talking she-ass. The essential judgment depends on the principle.

That the criticism of knowledge rejects every sign of revelation is quite in order, for the sign of revelation is precisely a phenomenal interruption of the natural connection of things; if it did not appear thus, it could not possibly be a sign. But when the scientific critic imagines that by thinking the sign of revelation through he can dissolve it into a contradiction and present it as a meaningless breach of the order of nature, then he oversteps the absolute boundary of knowledge.

The sign of revelation has nothing whatever to do with the scientific apprehension of the connection of nature; it is and remains a religious matter between the God who reveals himself in the sign and the believer who receives the revelation. From the narrative of the talking she-ass no natural-scientific conclusion whatsoever can be drawn, either in attack upon or in defense of the phenomenon. What is the phenomenon of a talking she-ass? A sign of omnipotence! What is the phenomenon of a burning bush? A sign of omnipotence! What is the phenomenon of the raising of the dead? A sign of omnipotence! Name what wonder, what manifestation in the whole of sacred history one will; as soon as thought tries to penetrate into the essence of the phenomenon, it strikes everywhere against the same barrier, halts before the same riddle, gets to all questions the same monotonous answer: it is the sign of omnipotence! [167]

Were the criticism of knowledge now really able to prove that a sign of omnipotence is impossible, then it would have to be able to prove that the almighty will itself is impossible; but proofs of this nature have validity only for those who, by forgetting personal self-contradiction, prove that in the deepest sense they have forgotten themselves.

“But,” it is objected, “by such signs of omnipotence the most arbitrary of breaches are surely made in the order of nature.” This objection would mean something if the sign, in its capacity as sign of revelation, actually had anything to do with the natural order of things; but such a presupposition rests on a scientific misunderstanding. Each sign is a single, a unique phenomenon, which cannot possibly be introduced as a member in the series of natural phenomena; but if it cannot be introduced into the series of natural phenomena, then neither can it occasion any induction whatsoever that would disturb natural science: the sign is, each time it is given, a personal, an exclusively personal matter between the one who reveals himself by the sign and the one or ones who receive the revelation. The limit for the imparting of such signs cannot be determined by any law of nature; but the limit is not arbitrary on that account: it is determined by divine wisdom, in that it is determined by the divine will.

[168]

It follows from the principle of faith that the concept of nature, namely the religious one, must be subordinated to the concept of creation; but it by no means follows from the principle that the religious consciousness should be blind to actual nature. The poetic contemplation of nature is, after all, still acknowledged as justified over against the scientific, and why? Because one acknowledges the idea of beauty as justified over against the idea of knowledge. Why, then, will one not acknowledge the religious contemplation of nature as justified over against the scientific? Because the consciousness of culture has got so well under way with bringing faith under knowledge that it has overlooked the self-validity of the principle of faith! The Davidic contemplation of nature, for example, is not scientific, but should it on that account have no religious validity? The religious character of the contemplation of nature is determined by this, that everywhere, even where there is no question of particular miracles, it refers the things of nature to the creating and sustaining omnipotence. Instead of dwelling on the natural connection of the phenomena, the believing eye will everywhere, through the phenomena, discover God himself. "He spreadeth out the heavens like a tent; he frameth his lofty halls in the waters; clouds he maketh his chariot; so he rideth upon the wings of the storm" (Psalm. IV). Should such a contemplation of nature well let itself be supplanted either by astronomy or by meteorology? Because the religious view of nature is here uttered in the form of poetry, should it on that account cease to be religious? "The trees of Jehovah stand luxuriant, the cedars which he planted on Lebanon, where the little birds build their nests"; could such an utterance perhaps not subsist alongside a scientific botany? "Thou makest it grow dark," says the holy singer of Jehovah, "then cometh the night, in it all the beasts of the forest creep forth, the young lions roar after their prey and seek their meat from God"; it can surely not be the task of zoology to subject this view of the beasts of the forest to a scientific criticism.

[169]

Should anyone be so cultivated as to think that the Psalmist is not in earnest with the examples of God's activity in nature adduced here, that they are only figurative utterances of a fleeting mood: then such a one shows only that out

of sheer culture he has forgotten what religion is, forgotten what emphasis the believer lays on the words: "O Lord, how manifold are thy works! in wisdom hast thou made them all!" "But," one asks, "can the Psalmist then really himself have believed that Jehovah now and then rides upon the storm clouds, that he actually and with his own hand planted the cedars on Lebanon so that the birds might build nests in them, and that the young lions, when they roar after their prey, actually pray to God? No, the natural sciences surely cannot possibly have stood at so low a level even in that time, which was certainly in other respects by no means enlightened; they must be images, symbols and images, nothing but symbols and images!" Yes, certainly they are images, but yet more than images; certainly they are symbols, but these symbols have nonetheless actuality, full actuality for the spirit; in the believing contemplation of nature actuality is symbol, the symbol actuality. What the symbol is in the contemplation of nature rich in mood, that again, in a special way, is the sign, the sign of omnipotence in the miracle. The actuality of the miracle is a sign, a symbol. "Only a symbol?" Yes, but this symbol is at the same time actuality. The fundamental question is: Can faith count as a principle or not? If one rejects the principle, then the religious contemplation of nature can naturally have only subjective, aesthetic validity, then it gives only images but no actuality; if one acknowledges the principle, then one is also compelled to grant to the contemplation of nature corresponding to the principle actuality, fully valid actuality for the spirit.

[170]

In order now to investigate more closely how the matter really stands with the religious contemplation of nature, and especially with the apprehension of the actuality of the miracle, we must first determine somewhat more precisely the relation between the experience of faith and the experience of sense. When believers in sacred history receive a revelation, the phenomenon often appears with so striking an immediacy, with so definite a stamp of outward actuality, in so unmistakable an interaction with natural surroundings, that it looks as though such a phenomenon could be apprehended by sensuous seeing, sensuous hearing, sensuous feeling alone, and so without faith. This is nonetheless a gross error. Just

as faith always presupposes revelation, so revelation in turn presupposes faith: revelation and faith are in principle one, and cannot possibly be separated. The believer sees, hears, feels; but in all this sensing faith is present; he sees with the eye of faith, hears with the ear of faith: all his experience is and remains an experience of faith. Whether the single individual in the single case receives a true or a false, an actual or an imagined revelation—for that the person concerned must himself be answerable. How a Balaam hears and understands Jehovah's command, for that he stands personally accountable to Jehovah; nothing about such things can be decided in pure generality. How a David hears and understands Jehovah's command is a personal affair between Jehovah and David. In this respect the two accounts of the census are highly instructive. According to 1 Sam. (XXIV) David thinks he hears Jehovah's voice: "Go, number Israel and Judah!" David thus imagines that in this case he has received a true revelation; but it is an imagining.

[171] It is not Jehovah's voice that David hears; no, it is (1 Chr. XXI.) another voice. The revelation is false; why? Because David has aroused Jehovah's wrath, and the reason for this is plain enough. It was, in the religious way of seeing of David and—as one clearly notices from Joab's words: "why doth my lord the king delight in this thing?"—of his contemporaries, a very questionable matter to undertake a census; it was, for good psychological reasons, interpreted as a sign of a certain arrogance; the king wanted by so sensational a step precisely to make it known that the people of Israel was now so numerous that, without needing Jehovah's special aid, it could well rely on its own strength. So it ferments in David's inner being: egoism is in conflict with piety, ambition with humility, vanity with the thanksgiving owed to Jehovah. In such a state the believer is unsure of himself and exposed to false promptings. If, however, the word of revelation could be apprehended by a sensuous ear without faith, then surely the guilt would have to fall on Jehovah; but the falsity lies in the hearing, and the guilt falls on David.

To make sure of the interpretation of an actual phenomenon of revelation, the question is sometimes raised: must not an unbeliever, had such a one been present, also have seen the supernatural? From the answer to such a question one will

learn how far the interpreter regards the manifestation as an actual fact or merely as an inward vision, a product of the believers' own fantasy; but one does not notice that the question contains a self-contradiction. If the supernatural could actually be sensed and seen with the same eyes that see the natural, then it would surely not be supernatural; then a revelation could be imparted to a human being without faith, and faith would cease to be a principle. Instead of joining actual [172] seeing and actual hearing with actual faith, one wants to throw faith away and seize what is revealed in sensuous, raw immediacy; that is to violate the holy. One concludes thus: if an unbeliever who was present could not also have seen the vision, then the vision is not actual; that is a false conclusion. Instead of placing full assurance in faith, one takes faith away and places assurance in mere sensation. Let the subject be Christ's resurrection and the Risen One's various manifestations to the disciples. The evangelists lay the very greatest weight on the actuality of the resurrection: "The Lord is risen indeed, and hath appeared to Simon," say the eleven in Jerusalem to the two who came from Emmaus; but nowhere will one discover in any of the witnesses the remotest hint that the Risen One was seen by unbelievers as well. On the contrary, there are manifold testimonies showing that even the eyes of believers had to be specially opened before they could know the Transformed One. Mary Magdalene meets him in the garden; but she does not know him; she supposed, indeed, that it was the gardener (John XIX., 14–15). Of the two who went to Emmaus, when Jesus "himself drew near, and went with them," it is said (Luke XXIV, 16): "But their eyes were holden that they should not know him." Even those assembled in Jerusalem (Luke XXIV, 36–42), who had already been prepared from several sides by the glad tidings, even these could not at once and directly recognize him who suddenly stood in the midst of them; "but they were terrified and affrighted, and supposed that they had seen a spirit."

Under the presupposition of faith, on the condition of faith, the true revelation first acquires fully valid actuality, actuality for the spirit, spiritual actuality; all phenomena of revelation are in actuality phenomena of the spirit. That actuality [173] here is actuality for the spirit must not be understood as though the spirit itself

were too powerless to annul the immediately natural barriers. It is no imperfection in the phenomenon of the spirit that its highest actuality is exclusively for the spirit; it is on the contrary a perfection: revelation will confirm not the impotence of the spirit but its omnipotence, its absolute power over itself. We see it in the Risen One. As the disciples' eyes are opened, as it becomes clear within them, so that they see him in faith, hear him in faith, the outward form too becomes clear and definite, takes on actuality, indeed tangible actuality. How is it possible that a form which begins by showing itself as spirit can end by presenting itself in full, tangible actuality? Yes, how is it possible? With this question the criticism of knowledge imagines that it can conjure up enormous difficulties and entangle the believing thinker in enormous contradictions. That is an imagining; from the standpoint of faith there is in such a question only one contradiction, one single one, and it lies not in the matter asked about, but in the question.

As a telling example of what a phenomenon of revelation in full actuality has to mean, there serves especially the account of the Risen One's manifestation to Thomas (John XX, 26–29): "And after eight days again his disciples were within, and Thomas with them: then came Jesus, the doors being shut, and stood in the midst, and said, Peace be unto you. Then saith he to Thomas, Reach hither thy finger, and behold my hands; and reach hither thy hand, and thrust it into my side: and be not faithless, but believing. And Thomas answered and said unto him, My [174] Lord and my God. Jesus saith unto him, Because thou hast seen me, Thomas, thou hast believed: blessed are they that have not seen, and yet have believed." The disciple Thomas appears here in a quite peculiar light. He is unbelieving, people say. Certainly he betrays a questionable weakness in faith; we hear him, after all, before the manifestation takes place, expressly declare: "Except I shall see in his hands the print of the nails, and put my finger into the print of the nails, and thrust my hand into his side, I will not believe"; a Sadducee could say the same. And yet Thomas is no Sadducee. He does not deny the possibility of the resurrection; but certainty he wants, full certainty; he wants to have actuality, full, tangible actuality, before him. So then he gets actuality too; he gets it as palpably,

as immediately as can well be thought. But where, and how, does he get it? In the circle of the disciples, and after having heard the Risen One's greeting: "Peace be unto you!" Before this voice doubt gives way, by this greeting faith is awakened, and now Thomas is prepared in the spirit to grasp the full actuality. But with the manifestation there follows a reproach. What is it that Christ reproaches Thomas for? That he wants full assurance of the actuality of the resurrection is not held against him; a credulity that relies on loose rumors Christ never recommended. No, the reproach is that the one of little faith wants to make his assurance dependent on the testimony of the senses. Thomas wants, as the saying goes, "to see it before he will believe it"; he wants, in other words, "to relate himself to the holy facts in a way corresponding to that in which the natural scientist relates himself to the facts of nature."

The mistake of which the disciple Thomas here makes himself guilty at first hand is precisely the one that the orthodox dogmaticians, in Protestantism just as fully as in Catholicism, have in various ways imitated, and of which they have [175] made themselves guilty at second hand. Just as Thomas would rather regard the phenomenon of revelation in a sensuous, outward, empirical way, so the objective dogmaticians even to this day want first of all to make sure of the outward historical actuality of the facts; on the outward, firm actuality they then think, with the aid of the Spirit, to be able to build their faith as on a walled foundation. But when the outward actuality of experience is posited as the first thing, the Spirit is offended and denies the objective believers its testimony. Only to spiritual facts will the Spirit bear witness; its testimony is, according to the principle, conditioned by the phenomena of revelation being apprehended and determined, in their highest actuality, as phenomena of the spirit. Precisely because the orthodox theologians have held fast to the actuality of the phenomena of revelation without spirit, negative criticism has been able to go to the opposite extreme and offer us, in ingenious myths, hollow phenomena of the spirit without actuality.

To get the actuality of the phenomena of revelation thoroughly grasped, and illuminated from every side in the interpretation of sacred history, is an essential

condition for the spiritual life in the present age.

XI.

Sacred history is the history of revelation, the history of the God who reveals ^[176] himself in the Word. But the God who reveals himself in the Word is a speaking God, who differs from the mute gods of the nature religions and from the silent Godhead of science. The mythical gods are mute gods; gods of “silver and gold,” a work of men’s hands. “They have mouths, to be sure, but cannot speak; they have eyes, to be sure, but cannot see; they have ears, but cannot hear” (Psalm CXV). What is said of “the idols” from the standpoint of revelation is literally true, even when we take the idea into account. The poet invokes the Muse; he begs her for mood, for inspirations, for the assistance of spirit, for the wondrous gift of language; but how matters stand with this invocation is easy to see through. For the Muse to be able to give a mood, the poet must already be in the mood; for the flashes of genius to be able to begin within him, they must already have begun; it is the movement of the idea on which everything depends: the Muse as Muse is mute; the mute goddess makes no one speak. That the poet must nevertheless woo the favor of the Muse means that under the pressure of the idea he must redouble his spiritual being, must, in order to be moved, let himself be moved; thus he sees ^[177] the first mover in the goddess’s glance and receives as a divine gift what originally dwells in himself. So understood, the invocation of the Muse is a psychological necessity, a beautiful ambiguity that becomes poetry well. As an image of being that bears the idea, the Muse is not a goddess; as a goddess, that is: as a being on its own in independent existence, the goddess is an idol and no Muse.

If the Muse as goddess cannot speak to the poet, then the Godhead in its pure

concept can still less speak to the thinker. The thinker, to be sure, in thinking the idea of the Godhead, must also redouble his being, insofar as he must necessarily think his finite self in distinction from the absolute idea; but he must in turn be able, with full consciousness, to cancel the redoubling if he wants to keep himself absolutely within pure, universal thinking. To think God, says Hegel, is not like thinking an animal or a stone; for the animal and the stone we represent to ourselves as having a finite existence outside our concept; our concept of the absolute being, on the other hand, our true concept, is the absolute being itself. Although thinking and speaking are so inseparable that all determinate thinking coincides with an inner speaking, it can never occur to the thinker either to speak to the absolute being or ever to expect that the absolute being should speak to him: the Godhead's speaking to man is, from the standpoint of knowledge, man's speaking within himself.

It is otherwise from the standpoint of faith. The God of faith is a God who can speak to man, a God to whom man can speak. The God of revelation is a speaking God: Abraham heard the speaking God and wandered away from the mute gods; Moses heard the speaking God, and Israel became God's peculiar people by virtue of all "these words which God spake."

[178] But for knowledge and science there can scarcely be conceived any concept that contains a greater contradiction than the concept of a speaking God. On this occasion we must once again let negative criticism have its say.

Among all the miracles, great and small, of which the Old and New Testaments tell, the greatest beyond comparison is this, that God in heaven himself takes the floor and sets about speaking. On the assumption that he really has a secret, this is of course quite in order; Paul says: "For what man knoweth the things of a man, save the spirit of man which is in him? even so the things of God knoweth no man, but the Spirit of God." Just as it depends, then, on a man's good will whether he will come out with his secret or keep silent about it, so it depends, in a still stricter sense, on God's good and unsearchable will what and how much of his hidden counsels he will confide to his elect. But when the miracle of the speaking God is

set up as the fundamental miracle of revelation, it is seen at the same time how all the contradictions hidden in the essence of faith involuntarily leap to the eye. If revelation is an arbitrary act, then the revealed word must necessarily become an expression of arbitrariness, hence an arbitrary word. That the word of revelation is an arbitrary word is indeed proved by the Old Testament from beginning to end.

“And God spake all these words, saying”; thus begins (Exodus XX) the lawgiving from Sinai. What is characteristic of this lawgiving is thus not in the first instance its content but its origin; not what is commanded, but that it is commanded, that it is expressly commanded by God. What this signifies can be illuminated by the well-known opposition between two points of view that already [179] found expression in the scholasticism of the Middle Ages: *it is good because God wills it*, and *God wills it because it is good*. The latter proposition makes God’s will dependent on the idea of the good and agrees with the demand of knowledge. If God commands only what is good and forbids what is evil, then I need only use my reason to know the difference between evil and good, and have no need of arbitrary revelations. Such commandments as: Thou shalt not steal; Thou shalt not bear false witness against thy neighbor; thou shalt not kill, and the like, are universally valid commandments of reason, which can be cognized without a speaking God’s needing to dictate them. But to take the moral commandments in this way conflicts with the spirit of the Mosaic lawgiving. Why may an Israelite not steal? Answer: because Jehovah has forbidden him to. If Jehovah had not forbidden him to? Then he might well steal. And if Jehovah one day commanded him to? Why, then it would be his duty to steal. Thus we come to hold fast to the first proposition: *it is good because God wills it*, as an unconditional proposition of arbitrariness, an unadulterated proposition of revelation. From this point of view it cannot surprise us to find moral commandments of reason placed in a row with wholly special, arbitrary commandments. It says: “Thou shalt not make unto thee any graven image, or any likeness of any thing that is in heaven above, or that is in the earth beneath, or that is in the water under the earth”; such a commandment quite rightly presupposes a special revelation, for no reasonable man would of

himself hit upon the idea that God should be so sworn an enemy of sculpture and painting.

When a people is to such a degree made morally a minor that it is not able by its own reflection to find out the difference between good and evil, but is to have
 [180] all its religious, moral and civil precepts expressly dictated, then it goes without saying that “the speaking God” must speak many words and prescribe everything down to the smallest details. The particular laws have therefore gone forth just as immediately from Jehovah’s mouth as the fundamental law. It is incredible how far a legislating God can go into details. “And Jehovah spake unto Moses (Exodus XXV), saying, Speak unto the children of Israel, that they bring me an offering of every man ... And this is the offering which ye shall take of them; gold, and silver, and brass, and blue, and purple, and scarlet, and fine linen, and goats’ hair, and rams’ skins dyed red, and sealskins, and acacia wood, oil for the light, spices for anointing oil,” etc. etc. Further (Exodus XXVI): “Moreover thou shalt make the tabernacle with ten curtains of fine twined linen, and blue, and purple, and scarlet.” If, then, eleven curtains, for example, were used for the tabernacle, the eleventh curtain would perhaps be a greater offense to God than false witness against one’s neighbor. “The length of one curtain shall be eight and twenty cubits, and the breadth eight cubits”; now if it happened that a curtain came out half an inch too short, the guilty party would bring down upon himself the wrath of Jehovah and perhaps be cut off from his people.

Is this not, asks the man of culture, to drag the eternal, the exalted, down into the finite and the petty? And is it strange that the old heathens said mockingly: such a speaking God is no God of spirit; he is a talkative God, who wants to meddle in everything, busy himself with everything, know all about everything (*garrulus, inquietus, impudenter etiam curiosus*)? Where divine arbitrariness reigns, it is impossible to distinguish between essential and inessential, moral and immoral, permissible and impermissible. There is a kind of lie which people are accustomed
 [181] to call a lie of necessity. If we are asked whether such a lie is permitted, especially on a large scale, when it concerns one of the serious relations of life, and where its

use plainly betrays cowardice, we answer unconditionally: such a lie of necessity is not permitted. God cannot possibly approve such a thing; for from the proposition “God wills it because it is good” it of course follows conversely: “God does not will it because it is evil.” Now if one looks in the twelfth and twentieth chapters of the first book of Moses, what is one then to judge of Father Abraham? The twelfth chapter begins with the election of Abraham; Jehovah speaks to him as to his chosen one, and bids him go out of the land; he will show him the way and give him his blessing. Imagine, then, a man who is raised so high that the Majesty, the holy God, deigns to speak to him. Then Abraham comes to Pharaoh in Egypt with Sarah, and what does he do now? He becomes afraid and says to his wife: “Behold now, I know that thou art a fair woman to look upon: therefore it shall come to pass, when the Egyptians shall see thee, that they shall say, This is his wife: and they will kill me, but they will save thee alive. Say, I pray thee, thou art my sister,” etc. What is it that Abraham does here? He does that at which a knight would blush; he conceals that Sarah is his wife, indeed, what is more, he even makes a profit out of it; for in return for Sarah Pharaoh gave him, as we know, “sheep, and oxen, and he asses, and menservants, and maidservants, and she asses, and camels,” as many as he wanted; Pharaoh in his guilelessness has no inkling that he is on the point of committing a great crime. So he must come to know it in another way. To stop the unpleasant consequences of Abraham’s cowardice, Jehovah must step in to help with miracles.

“And the Lord plagued Pharaoh and his house with great plagues because of Sarai Abram’s wife.” How abashed must Abraham not stand before Pharaoh and [182] listen to his reproachful words: “What is this that thou hast done unto me? why didst thou not tell me that she was thy wife? Why saidst thou, She is my sister? so I might have taken her to me to wife: now therefore behold thy wife, take her, and go thy way.” That Jehovah goes along with the intrigue we can understand at a pinch, since Jehovah is, after all, Abraham’s friend; and what will one not do for a friend? “There lies,” say our believers in everything old, “a great comfort in seeing how God can use frail people as pillars of his kingdom. God’s guidance of

Abraham, and his employing him in the service of his kingdom, is defense enough for Abraham.” But had Abraham not deserved a serious reprimand? Since he receives no reprimand, he is naturally so far from regretting what he has done that he rather seems, in all quietness, to congratulate himself on being the first inventor of the lie of necessity. In the twentieth chapter he and Jehovah then play the comedy over again with Abimelech in Gerar. And then people still find it strange that English and German freethinkers have been able to attack the positive moral teaching of the Old Testament; and then they cross themselves that a Voltaire, according to the well-known *taisez-vous, taisez-vous, Habakuk est capable de tout*, thought he could put the greatest absurdities into the mouth of a prophet!

With this the critique of knowledge has had its due. “But,” someone might ask, “why should we sit here and listen to so offensive a critique, since we know, after all, that it springs from sheer unbelief and can easily give offense to the simple believers?” I answer: With the offense of the simple believers there is no danger; their faith does not sit so loosely that a little critique by argumentation should be able at once to shake it. On the other hand there is every possible danger that, under the pretext of not wishing to give offense to the simple, one [183] keeps silent about the objections, veils the contradictions, and keeps the whole in so foggy an indeterminacy that those who think for themselves, who would gladly be enlightened about how the matter hangs together, can never obtain any enlightenment. We hear the Savior’s words (Matt. XVIII, 7): “Woe unto the world because of offenses! for it must needs be that offenses come; but woe to that man by whom the offense cometh!”

Whence comes the offense when the talk is of *the speaking God*? Not from Luther at Worms with the “clear reasons” and the living cognition of faith, no, not from Luther, but from Lutherolatry, i.e. from the Lutheranism stiffened and crystallized in the theory of the schools; from bibliolatry, i.e. from biblical theology’s scientific botching of the doctrine of inspiration. The Reformers had, after all, carried this through: the papal Catholic externality had at last been mastered; but in compensation for the loss of the infallibility of the visible church, Protes-

tant theology then clung again so convulsively to the biblical externality that it declared the whole of Holy Scripture to have been dictated word for word by God himself (*Solus Deus, si accurate loqui velimus, Sacræ Scripturæ autor dicendus est, Prophetæ vero et Apostoli autores dici non possunt, nisi per quandam catachresin, utpote qui potius Dei autoris calami fuerint. Quenstedt*). By making the authors of the sacred books into the “scribes” of God and Christ (*amanuenses, manus, notarii*), the “pens” of God and Christ (*calami*), by letting the Holy Spirit immediately drive these “pens” to write (*impulsus ad scribendum*), inspire in them what they were to write (*suggestio rerum*), and how they were to write it (*suggestio verborum*), the human word was made divine and the divine human to such a degree that not even a glimmer of difference remained. Here is the first ground of the errors, the [184] soil in which the seed of offense has sprouted so abundantly.

Orthodox theology conceives inspiration mechanically; the fundamental contradiction is that it makes spirit, in its richest, purest revelation, spiritless. The old orthodoxy and the modern consciousness meet in the false presupposition that the divine and the human must coincide in spirit. The difference is only this, that orthodoxy lets the human perish in the divine, so that the latter takes possession of the determinate form of the human word, while the modern consciousness lets the divine be so absorbed in the human that the latter, in pure thinking, acquires an abstract divine form. But the unity of the spirit of God and of man is a unity in essential opposition, a unity of opposition. It is the spiritual opposition between the divine and the human that is overlooked from both sides.

We will, with the principle of faith in view, consider the Mosaic lawgiving. The consciousness of culture can understand excellently that Moses is the man of his time and of his people, that he is moved by a great idea, that he has a mission. It can further understand that a man so mightily moved by the idea must, when he is to give his people laws, fit the lawgiving to the people’s spiritual conditions; that the laws, sprung from a single great fundamental thought, must branch out widely and extend to all the relations of life; it can understand that the fundamental thought, when it is, as in the present case, decisively religious, must demand that

the lawgiver speak, not in his own name, but in the name of the Godhead, and speak with divine authority. We need only paraphrase the opening sentence: "And God spake all these words," thus: "And Moses spake all these words in the name [185] of Jehovah," and the consciousness of culture, with its free historical overview, will admire Moses and see in his lawgiving a work of spirit, one of the greatest of antiquity. But further than this the consciousness of culture cannot go. And why not? Because it cannot enter into the relation to God, does not know how to think the thought of faith. Some features of the psychology of faith will be able, at least provisionally, to shed light on the matter.

If we refer the great fundamental idea of the people's liberation and of the lawgiving, not to the human consciousness in Moses alone, but to Jehovah's will, so that the whole originally proceeds from him: then the relation between Jehovah and Moses is not an ordinary relation of idea but a personal relation of spirit, in which the divine self enters into inner reciprocal action with the human. On the conception of this reciprocal action, then, the understanding depends. The strongest, most immediate expression of such a reciprocal action is a mutual speaking. Speech is the immediate form of thought; the two communicate their thoughts to one another by speaking with one another in one way or another. Jehovah speaks to Moses, Moses in turn to Jehovah: now what kind of speaking is this? It is in principle an inward speaking, an original communication of spirit to spirit. There is an essential difference between inward, spiritual and outward, sensuous speaking. When two individuals speak to each other, the speaking is outward; they must understand each other's language in an outward, finite way. Born compatriots therefore speak together most easily and most naturally, a Hebrew with a Hebrew, a Greek with a Greek. Each of those speaking employs the means of language in his own way. One can resolve the speech into so many inferences, so many judgments, so many sentences, so many words; one can in an outward, finite way make sure of what and how much each of the speakers has [186] said. It is otherwise with the inward speaking, the speaking in which the divine spirit communicates itself to the human. Here it does not begin immediately with

words and sentences; but it begins in reflection with thoughts and judgments. The divine thoughts and judgments first give themselves an inner, ideal, mobile form in awakenings, inspirations, penetrating fundamental representations; the communication of spirit may in this respect be said to pass through the idea.

But now it makes a difference in principle that the idea as idea is impersonal, and to that extent selfless, while spirit as spirit is personally a self. Since Jehovah's spirit is one with the almighty self, the divine self-determination is expressly at work in the inner communication. How the awakening inspirations and the strong fundamental thoughts are more precisely to be determined, apprehended and appropriated by the human spirit comes to depend, not, as with the mere inspiration of the idea, on the apprehending consciousness alone, but originally and decisively on the divine will. The next thing we must emphasize is this, that he within whom spirit has begun so supernatural an activity translates the inspirations, the primitive proclamations, into his own human language; in this the communication of spirit again resembles a natural, e.g. poetic, movement of the idea. And yet there is here, according to the principle, a decisive difference. He who is moved by the idea has a content of consciousness that demands and receives its form from his own consciousness; the language in which the idea is uttered the poet must expressly acknowledge as his language: the idea does not speak to him, but only through him, as he speaks out of the idea.

With him who is moved by spirit, God's spirit, the matter stands in another way. Under the influence of the absolute self, the content apprehended in the understanding and translated into human language takes on such a stamp of divine validity that it expressly takes the language with its words and sentences away from man, makes human language its language, words and thoughts its judgments. In inner spiritual opposition to what thus presents itself with the stamp of divine superiority stands the receiving consciousness with its purely human content, its finite representations, thoughts and feelings, as a being on its own, a powerless spirit that is addressed by the Almighty. [187]

If we give up the principle of faith, the immediacy corresponding to such a

redoubling of spirit at once becomes fantastic; in order not to get two independent spirits in one soul, we then transform the divine self into a figment of the imagination, and interpret the redoubling mythically. By virtue of the principle, on the other hand, the redoubling is so far from being mythical that it rather furnishes the absolute presupposition for clear personal self-cognition. If it stands fast that an all-round, complete and sufficiently grounded cognition of the relative self is to be attained only through a penetrating cognition of its spiritual relation to the absolute, i.e. of the relation to God: then the redoubling set forth is of course justified by the same token.

That the relation of inwardness described here must on God's side be a relation of revelation, on man's side a relation of faith, is clear from what has gone before. The relation of inwardness reaches its highest tension in inspiration; only on the condition of inspiration does God speak personally to man, and man to God. But now the inner must in turn have its clear, immediate expression in a corresponding outer; the greater the power of inwardness, the stronger too is the immediacy with [188] which it breaks out in the outer. Jehovah does not speak immediately to the whole people of Israel, for the people in its naturalness is not inspired; but he speaks to Moses, for Moses is his prophet, and the prophet is inspired. From the inner the outer is understood; the inner reciprocal action in spirit acquires, as revelation, full actuality, since its essence comes to light in corresponding phenomena. The inward speaking now becomes an outward speaking; the outwardness is so strong that to a superficial consideration it looks as if it were merely a matter of sensuous seeing and hearing. It says (Exodus XIX) that "Moses went up unto God," and that "Jehovah called unto him out of the mountain . . . And Moses came and called for the elders of the people, and laid before their faces all these words which Jehovah commanded him. And all the people answered together, and said, All that Jehovah hath spoken we will do. And Moses returned the words of the people unto Jehovah. And Jehovah said unto Moses, Lo, I come unto thee in a thick cloud, that the people may hear when I speak with thee, and believe thee for ever." In a more outward and sensuous way a phenomenon of revelation can hardly be described;

and yet, when we look more closely, it will turn out that all this outwardness is the outbreak of something inward, that the phenomenon of revelation, in all its actuality, is a phenomenon of spirit, a phenomenon that presupposes faith and has significance only for believers.

If we begin with the most outward, the grandiose spectacle of nature, the storm with lightning and thunder, then its immediate effect is simply this, that it strikes terror into the sensuous man. In its natural crudeness the multitude is sensuous; the people gathered about the mountain are involuntarily struck with terror and dread. But influenced by the word that Moses speaks, spirit is awakened in the people; they are attuned in faith to a religious apprehension of the natural phenomenon; they perceive that Jehovah is in the darkness of the cloud, and are [189] seized with holy awe. Further than this the people do not come, and cannot come. The outward arrangement by which they are (XIX, 12–13) kept away from the top of the mountain corresponds entirely to their spiritual condition; they are overwhelmed by the sensuous, divine the holy, and are overcome with horror. “And all the people saw the thunderings, and the lightnings, and the noise of the trumpet, and the mountain smoking (XX, 18): and when the people saw it, they stood afar off.” In their dismay the people can now understand that they need a spokesman, a mediator endowed with spirit between themselves and God. “And they said unto Moses (XX, 19), Speak thou with us, and we will hear: but let not God speak with us, lest we die.”

If in thought we follow Moses, who goes up “unto God” on the mountain, and ask: what would a knower, e.g. a bold naturalist, if he had at the same time made an ascent of Sinai, have seen and heard? A storm, a quite natural but terrifying storm; nothing else! That the storm here is a sign of omnipotence, that the Almighty himself is present in the storm, cannot be seen with the eye of natural science. “But Jehovah speaks aloud, does he not; he calls to Moses in the storm?” Yes, he calls to Moses; but this call cannot be heard by the ear of natural science! As Moses ascends the mountain and “draws near unto the thick darkness where God is,” he is not objectively calm like a naturalist, nor overcome with terror like the crude

multitude; but he is moved in spirit and confident in faith: if his faith wavered and his spirit grew weak, he would collapse in dismay. It is in the darkness of the storm, under the immediate impression of the personal presence of the Almighty, hence in the very highest tension of the crisis of the soul, that the inner redoubling breaks out in mighty immediacy, that the inward speaking takes on the stamp [190] of an outward one, that Jehovah calls to him from the cloud. "And God spake all these words, saying" . . .

In the Mosaic lawgiving with its many commandments the divine so coincides with the human that the difference and the opposition are hidden. This one-sidedness characterizes religion at the Old Testament stage and shows it to us as a preparatory, not a consummating, revelation. What we can say about this in all brevity is the following. Had the redoubling of spirit corresponding to the inner revelation been carried through completely, then Moses would have had to be either Christ himself or one of his apostles.

This may perhaps become intelligible if we consider somewhat more closely the opposition, corresponding to the redoubling, between the absolute and the relative self in the relation to God. In Christ the relative self is evangelically determined by this, that "the Son of Man" is "the Son of God" and God his "heavenly Father." The relative self is thus, in this its relation to God, itself divine, is the God revealed on earth himself. The Son's unity with the Father is expressed in the words (John X, 30): *I and the Father are one*; whereas the Son's difference from and dependence on the Father—hence the relativity of the self in the Son of Man—is expressed in the words: *The Father is greater than I*.

From this now follows a decisive change in the relation between the outward and the inward in the redoubling of spirit. Christ's revelation is outward in quite another sense than the revelation through Moses; for Christ appears as the God revealed in flesh and blood, as the Word itself, which was from the beginning, whereas Moses on the other hand appears as a man, as God's spokesman for the people of Israel. But just for this reason the revelation in Christ is inward in quite [191] another sense than the revelation through Moses. What Christ thinks and speaks

as God, that he thinks and speaks at the same time as man; in Christ's inner being the finite separation between the thoughts of God and human thoughts is sublated in personal unity. When Christ speaks, he speaks in his own name. The Old Testament expression: "Thus saith Jehovah, the God of Israel," is replaced in the New Testament by the evangelical: "Verily, verily, I say unto you." To a superficial consideration it now looks as if the Old Testament expression were far more exalted and divine than the New Testament one; but the matter stands the other way round. The Old Testament expression is a divine sanction of the prophetic speech; but the speech itself in its form and its finite content is a human speech. Moses and the prophets speak with divine authority in the name of Jehovah; but they speak in a popular, human way about finite, temporal, human concerns. The Mosaic law with its many commandments is given by Moses, and Moses has taken every possible finite consideration of his people's conditions, its destiny, its upbringing; but this human element in the Mosaic lawgiving is, be it noted, not so separated from the divine fundamental thoughts and counsels that Moses himself arbitrarily devised them and then in an outward way added Jehovah's name. On the contrary! it is in spirit and in truth divine thoughts that are here humanly thought, divine commandments that are here expressed in human words. Over against these thoughts of Jehovah, sealed with divine power and authority, Moses has in his consciousness a circle of other thoughts, such as he must in a finite sense call his own thoughts. We must further emphasize, in consequence of the principle, that the separation a Moses makes between his own thoughts and the thoughts of Jehovah revealed to him is expressly determined by his faith and by [192] the inspirations corresponding to faith.

As for the content of the law, finally, it will easily be understood that the so-called arbitrariness of the commandments is no proof against their moral worth. Every commandment, even that whose necessity is most clearly evident to reason, must as a commandment, i.e. an order, take on the stamp of arbitrariness. The idea of morality is in a decisive sense the idea of the will; the idea has absolute validity only by being posited as one with the absolute will. But from this it follows in

turn that all the original demands of morality must be expressed in the form of divine commandments. The moral proposition: "God wills it because it is good," is so far from excluding the religious proposition: "it is good because God wills it," that the latter is on the contrary necessary to secure the former. Since in all determinations of morality it depends essentially on will, it depends in an absolute sense first and last on the divine will.

What has been said here must suffice to characterize the problem of faith that we can hold fast under the name of the religious problem of arbitrariness, a problem which for its complete solution will require a thoroughly worked-out psychology of faith, philosophy of religion, and ethics.

Of the two propositions set out above, the latter: "it is good because God wills it," points to discipline; the former: "God wills it because it is good," to the self-development corresponding to discipline; the one is the religious proposition of constraint, the other the religious proposition of freedom; the one corresponds to the spirit of the law, the other to the spirit of the Gospel. It is then in order that the proposition: "it is good because God wills it," is one-sidedly put into force at the Old Testament stage. With this fundamental thought one will understand [193] why the Mosaic lawgiving with its many divine commandments must go so fully into details. "Thou shalt" and "thou shalt not" repeat themselves in such manifold ramifications that all the concerns of life are, immediately and mediately, drawn in under them. Everything, not only what belongs to the worship of God with its sacrifices and ceremonies, but also what concerns domestic and civil relations, everything is punctiliously determined by Jehovah's will. At every step the Israelite takes on the road of actuality he meets a divine commandment; by means of the divine commandment the temporal becomes, link by link, an account to be settled between him and the Eternal. In opposition to the priests, who were to watch over the law and the fulfillment of the commandments, the prophets came forward as spokesmen for the right of spirit; but the priests outlived the prophets, and holiness by works, with Pharisaic righteousness, gained the upper hand: with this the limit of disciplining arbitrariness was set; the time of the law was over.

Through the Gospel “the law of commandments” was transformed into the law of love. With the law of love as its foundation, self-development could be united with free obedience, and the proposition: “God wills it because it is good,” could explain arbitrariness by divine wisdom.

It seems that people are bent, from every side, on deducing the will from pure, universal thinking; indeed, it is even demanded that logic should begin with “the good will”; that is how far things have come. This is perhaps the most telling proof yet that the last glimmer of the thought of faith is about to disappear. That the present age cannot grasp the word of revelation about “the speaking God” and reconcile human thought with the divine arbitrariness is an essential hindrance to spiritual life, a hindrance that only the spirit of the will can transform into a condition.

XII.

In the second Epistle to Timothy (III, 16—17) a point of view is given for the [194] conception and interpretation of Holy Scripture and thereby of the whole of sacred history. “All scripture,” it says, “is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: that the man of God may be perfect, thoroughly furnished unto all good works.” By this evangelical-apostolic point of view a decisive separation between the principle of faith and that of knowledge is sufficiently indicated.

Hitherto, however, people have not been willing to heed this separation; that is to say, the opposition has been paraphrased in such a way that its terms yield only two sides instead of displaying two mutually opposed spheres. The doctrine and conviction of which the Epistle speaks is infinitely different from the doctrine and conviction treated of in science. It has indeed been pointed out that the expressions “doctrine and conviction” point to the theoretical, while the expressions “for correction, for instruction in righteousness” refer to the practical. But on the strength of this merely formal difference people have then reasoned thus: Holy Scripture demands doctrine, thorough doctrine, conviction, true and living conviction; but [195] where should we seek the thorough doctrine, the true and living conviction, if not in science alone, the science that presupposes faith, explains and grounds faith, namely theology? Yet we are not to stop at science alone, we are, after all, also to work for life; to the theory must correspond a practice; in practice we have the pastoral, the edifying; it is this that is designated by the words “for correction, for instruction in righteousness.” It has been added that just as the old orthodoxy

one-sidedly kept to doctrine, so pietism has one-sidedly kept to the practical, “the edifying.” “But,” it is said, “we enlightened theologians keep the balance; we have ‘doctrine’ and ‘conviction’ in the objective and ‘correction and instruction’ in the subjective; what more can then be demanded?”

Against this misunderstanding we set up the separation between two absolutely heterogeneous standpoints, the scientific and the religious, of which the first conditions the cognition of impersonal truth, the latter that of personal truth.

When we call scientific truth impersonal, the meaning is of course by no means that scientific thinking could take place otherwise than in a thinking consciousness, that there could be a knowledge without a knower, a conviction without a subjectivity that felt itself convinced; but the meaning is that the knower, in the development of his science, must give up every personal regard for himself, must, absorbed in the cognition of the matter, of things, laws, facts, not let himself be disturbed by any regard whatsoever for any personal interest whatsoever. A physiologist, for example, may as a man, as an existing personality, be infinitely interested in the question of the immortality of the soul; but if he without further

[196] ado lets this interest play a part in purely scientific investigations, he becomes a mediocre physiologist. An astronomer may as a man, as an existing personality, feel the need to make sure whether there is in reality a world of a higher order than this temporal one in which we live; but if, led by this need, he turns his telescope toward the Milky Way and begins to resolve the nebulae in favor of the doctrine of a “kingdom of heaven,” he will hardly keep his standing among astronomers for very long. A geologist may as a man, as an existing personality, feel so strongly attracted, so deeply moved by the biblical narrative of Paradise that he could truly wish, were it possible, to find a point in the earth’s development of which he could say: here is the trace of the paradisaal state; here, on this spot, the Garden of Eden lay! But if he lets such longings and endeavors gain influence on his judgment of the geological facts: then he shows himself a most unreliable investigator. We hope to be understood, not only by the cultivators of science, but by all people of culture, when in the sense given here we repeatedly declare that scientific truth is

and must be impersonal.

That we, in opposition to the scientific, call religious truth personal must not be understood as if the meaning were that the religious cognition of truth should rest only on individual representations, feelings, moods and such indeterminable presuppositions; no, the meaning is that selfhood, absolutely concentrated in the ideal demands of personality, designates the standpoint. What satisfies the absolute demand of personality is valid; what conflicts with it is invalid; what neither furthers it nor conflicts with it is indifferent.

To clear up what this involves, we need not look about us for new and complicated examples; on our way through sacred history in what has gone before we have already come upon so many knots, so many even hard stumbling blocks, that it might well be to the purpose to take up the examples already cited from a new point of view, to see whether a new light might then perhaps fall on what was earlier enigmatic. Thus we saw in the doctrine of creation that the astronomical account of the structure of the universe is in decisive conflict with the account given us in the first book of Moses; we saw how the knot was tied especially by Christ's words in Matthew (XXIV, 29), where he foretells the destruction of the world and expresses himself thus: "Immediately after the tribulation of those days shall the sun be darkened, and the moon shall not give her light, and the stars shall fall from heaven." With an expression such as this, that the stars shall one day fall from heaven, the conflict between science and religion becomes so hard that it seems as though it could never be removed, as though a settlement were impossible. If we say: the stars can fall down from heaven, we contradict astronomy on a decisive point and thereby break the staff over culture and science. If on the other hand we say that that word of Christ cannot be fulfilled, then we violate Christ's majesty, violate religion, and cast contempt on the revealed word. On these terms every way out toward a reconciliation of faith and knowledge seems barred.

However, the barrier is more apparent than real. This heaven and these stars are here seen from wholly different standpoints, with quite different eyes; therefore

they are spoken of in different languages. It is, after all, known to everyone that what is visible in the world must be seen by an eye. As the eye is that sees, so is [198] the visual image, so is the visible world; as the ear is that hears, so is the hearing; as the consciousness is that contemplates, so is the image of what is contemplated. How different the image of heaven and earth must become as the standpoint of the beholder changes we can impress upon ourselves particularly in this connection by distinguishing three standpoints, namely the scientific, the aesthetic, and the absolutely religious.

If we place ourselves at the scientific standpoint, what do we then contemplate as the first thing? The things themselves, their laws and connection! It is the outward heaven, these determinate stars, these phenomena of motion with the corresponding laws, that are the object of contemplation. Does the one contemplating then contemplate himself at the same time? No, for him who looks scientifically at the starry heaven, the starry heaven is all in all. During his observations the astronomer does not think at all of his personality, not of his own wishes and longings. Such longings he would, if someone were so sentimental as to remind him of the heart's need, repel with icy coldness. That is why Minerva's breast is so cold, and her gaze so stern; science is called objective because the beholder, absorbed in his object, is to forget his subjectivity. Astronomy is, like every other science, impersonal, and in its impersonal essence objective, indifferent to the stirrings of our souls, our deepest longings, our pains and joys, our fear and our hope, as indifferent as if it were pure fate.

What personal results, then, can be derived from the contemplation of the structure of the universe? The result of results is that man shrinks to a nothing. In relation to the earth we become far smaller than the ants in their hill; the earth itself disappears in the universe. Refreshment and liberation must therefore be [199] sought in this, that we, instead of holding fast to our own self, lose ourselves in the selfless, that we, instead of being independent within our personal limitation, free ourselves in the limitless. It is remarkable how this absorption in the outward infinity of celestial space, this sublime loss of self, reproduces an oriental view that

belongs already to antiquity; it is Brahmanism we have in mind.

As is well known, the Orientals are inclined, in profound fantasies, to draw a line through the finite and to absorb themselves in the vision of the eternal, the limitless, the infinite. Brahma's priests regard this world in its finitude as a beautiful deception. Its outward multiplicity, its many different colors and tones signify that a veil of time has been spread over the eternal truth; it is the veil of Maya, the glittering veil of illusion, of deception. It is a task for the wise man to lift this veil. First he removes the deception of the senses by denying reality to sensuous things; but this is not yet enough: he must also free himself from the deception of thought. The deception of thought lasts as long as he distinguishes determinate thoughts, the one limited by the other. So he then lets all thoughts flow together into one thought, the thought of infinity; then he enjoys, in his dissolution of self, the bliss of contemplation, loses himself in the limitless, and disappears in Brahm. Here is a liberation that in an inward sense corresponds exactly to the liberation that astronomers and physicists recommend to us in an outward sense, when they recommend us to deny what they call our egoism and to disappear in the infinite universe. This, then, was the first standpoint.

Different from the strictly scientific, objective standpoint is the aesthetic. At the aesthetic stage personality does not, to be sure, give itself up, but in the moments of mood it cancels its actual limitation; it expands fantastically and in its self- [200] expansion embraces heaven and earth. What is characteristic is that the human spirit sees in the sky ideal figures that once lived and acted on earth; thereby the constellations known to us acquire a quite peculiar significance. We know, of course, such constellations in the visible heaven: Cepheus, Cassiopeia, Andromeda, who is chained to the rock, Perseus, the horse Pegasus, the kneeling Heracles, the Lernaean serpent, etc. These names remind us of the mythical heroes and their deeds. What does this signify? It signifies that as man looks up at the starry heaven, he sees a mirror that reflects the images of personality, a reflection of personal life through the ages. "The constellations," says J. L. Heiberg (*Intelligensblade*, vol. 2, p. 41), "are true pictures, which antiquity has hung up in the great gallery

where all generations are to contemplate them. Here it becomes quite evident that the starry heaven, far from being foreign to the earth, is the reflection of earthly destinies, earthly thoughts, earthly dreams. One must regard the starry heaven as an illustrated deluxe edition of Greek mythology in enormous format; one must contemplate it with the poets of antiquity before one's eyes." It is not the single individual who mirrors himself; it is antiquity and its great figures that he sees in the mirror.

Here, then, contemplation is redoubled and the standpoint transformed; for when one is to speak of the figures that are seen in the stars, one must speak not merely from the standpoint of poetry, but in the language of poetry. We surely all know Heiberg's lovely poem, in which among other things he has the starry heaven say to the beholder: "Here the kings and queens of fable stand, with its monsters, dragons and serpents, whose names resounded from the gray of [201] antiquity in songs two thousand years old." Here the cold system of phenomena and laws has vanished; when the poet speaks of the kings of fable, its monsters and serpents, he speaks precisely in his own language, for the language must correspond to the standpoint. In this language of mood memory is invoked. Man knows himself to be limited, not only in relation to outward greatness in space, but also in relation to time. He lives a brief time; his life is "as the grass, as the flower of the field; the sun is risen with a burning heat, the flower withereth and falleth." We live the short life of a day; if personality is to expand and breathe freely in the kingdom of spirit, it must take refuge in memory. In memory it turns toward what has vanished, wanders along the paths of the past, meets with the great ones of antiquity, and understands the heaven that speaks in the poem: "With me thou livest a life that is gone, thou livest with gods and heroes, whose transfigured forms legend bound to my broad and sparkling belt."

No one will say that this standpoint of poetry comes into conflict with astronomy. Here there is no conflict; for the two different standpoints are wholly heterogeneous. The astronomer would only make himself ridiculous if in his prosaic language he began to argue against what the poet here says about the

monsters, dragons and serpents of fable, while conversely the poet would make himself ridiculous if he tried to refute the astronomer with the kings and queens of fable. There are two standpoints, two contemplations, two languages, and two different images of the world contemplated. Each of them has its validity. We will not do without astronomy, but not without poetry either.

This anyone can understand; but should it not then also become intelligible when we in a corresponding way take note of the third standpoint, the religious, not the relatively religious, which is weakened in human knowledge; no, the [202] absolutely religious, Christ's own standpoint?

If Christ did not stand at a standpoint of his own, he could not, after all, be Christ; but if he stands at a standpoint which no mortal can occupy with him, this must surely entail that to the peculiar standpoint of contemplation there corresponds a distinct image of heaven and earth. What kind of standpoint this is has already been said earlier: it is that of personality! The principle of religion is the principle of personality in the very deepest sense.

It is, of course, characteristic of modern times to have respect for laws, "the eternal laws"; when anyone wants to contradict the physicist, he simply points to the eternal laws, and the objections fall silent. Now when we hear Christ and see what lies in his words, he too points to eternal and unchangeable laws; but they are, be it noted, not the laws of necessity but the laws of freedom. Here are two systems of laws, because here, according to the conditions of human cognition, there must be two different standpoints. Here are the laws of necessity, corresponding to the kingdom of nature; but here are also the laws of freedom, of spirit and of personality, which hold in the kingdom of Christ. It is the laws of freedom and of personality of which Christ speaks when he says: "Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away." What is characteristic of this standpoint is that it is personal truth itself that speaks of heaven and earth, and speaks the language of personality, authoritatively decisive. The one speaking is not impressed by the outward greatness of the structure of the universe; for the outward world, its sun and moon and stars, are subject to the laws of necessity,

but truth itself knows with eternal, divine certainty that the laws of necessity
[203] are grounded on the laws of freedom. While the natural man must feel himself shrink to a nothing over against the might and majesty of nature, Christ, as the absolute representative of personality, stands unshakably firm on the ground of freedom. Had he let himself be overwhelmed by strong impressions of nature, by the outward, infinite greatness of the structure of the universe, he would not have been Christ.

One easily sees, however, that the opposition between the religious and the scientific view of the structure of the universe is quite otherwise hard than the opposition between the scientific and the aesthetic. In the aesthetic view reality is not, after all, taken in full earnest; poetry does not maintain that “the kings and queens of fable” really stand on the vault of heaven: the aesthetic and the scientific standpoints are, in other words, only relatively heterogeneous. In the religious contemplation of nature, on the other hand, reality is taken in just as decisive earnest as in the scientific. If we ask whether it can be assumed that heaven and earth will really one day pass away, as Christ has foretold it to us: then science, reflecting on what is its own, answers with an express No, religion, reflecting on what is its own, on the other hand with an express Yes. From the standpoint of knowledge Christ’s prediction cannot be true; and why not? Because its fulfillment is an impossibility! From the standpoint of faith Christ’s prediction must absolutely be true; why? Because Christ is the truth! So science stands against religion as Yes against No, as truth against truth: will anyone be able to deny that here is a dualism?

Those who are bent on undermining positive revealed religion can naturally take the dualism lightly; they can at their pleasure now cancel it by sluggish
[204] abstractions, now again amuse themselves by making it an object of caricaturing ridicule and sniggering distortion. But those who want to hold on to religion without giving up science, the theologians, for example, what can they be thinking of? Can they really make themselves and others believe that their “good will,” if only it is allowed to come along into science, will be able to master the dualism?

The dualism is not an arbitrary invention, not a philosophical chicane; it is a fact, a notorious, incontrovertible fact. For coming to terms with the dualism, or, as it is commonly put, reconciling faith with knowledge, there is only one way out, one single one. We shall shed a little more light on the matter with regard to the example we have set up. Natural science's conception of the structure of the universe is not religious; Christ's view of the structure of the universe is absolutely religious: hence the contradiction. This contradiction can be resolved only by Christ's being granted unconditional right in the name of personal truth, and science, with its impersonal truth, scientific right.

In order to grant Christ unconditional right, we must seek to understand his fundamental thought, the language in which the fundamental thought is uttered, and the reality corresponding to the utterance.

What Christ utters with absolute personal certainty is this, that the kingdom of nature with all outward, sensuous things is subject to the omnipotence of spirit, that the kingdom of spirit, the kingdom whose founder he is on earth, shall, when the hour comes, be actualized, not only in the inward, but also in the outward. This certainty he does not have from any immediate contemplation of nature, any more than from astronomical observations of sun, moon and stars; no, he has the assurance, the full, decisive assurance, in himself, through himself; he [205] has it personally. Faith in Christ's words is on this point too one with faith in Christ himself; in this too he shows himself as the exemplar, as the actualized ideal of personality, that he can speak with so infinite a superiority of the power of freedom over nature bound in necessity.

The frail individualities, the relative personalities entangled in guilt and self-contradiction, are, in spite of all their striving toward the goal of spirit, constantly exposed to being overwhelmed by natural hindrances and cowed by overpowering impressions of sense. It is especially in dark, heavy moments that the pressure is felt. Faintheartedness comes with doubt; and whence comes doubt? From a discord within man! And whence comes the discord? From a conflict between the two absolutely heterogeneous principles, the principle of necessity, with the

thousand proofs from the reality of the sensuous, material world, and the principle of freedom with its demands and ideal promptings from the soul's self. Here an authoritative word is needed, not only for "doctrine," but also for "edification."

In Christ's words there is doctrine, and the doctrine is this: If thou wilt have full assurance of the unconditional power of spirit over corruptible nature, then lay hold of the principle of freedom and beware of staring at necessity! in other words: if thou wilt find the way to the actual kingdom of freedom, of truth and of personality, then do not stray into the regions of impersonal cognitions, do not seek guidance from astronomers and physicists and philosophers of nature, but turn to him who is the way and the truth and the life! In Christ's words there is "edification." What is edifying is that he utters the assurance, not as a general view of life in a mood awakened and stirred by happy omens and bright prospects, but [206] in the heavy, terrible moment, in a moment when he had to say to his enemies: this is your hour, and the power of darkness; it is just such a moment that gives the assurance the inner weight of personality which counterbalances outward reality.

As the fundamental thought is, so must the language be too. What Christ sees in the spirit, the mighty visions, the great images in which what is to come acquires a spiritually immediate presence, he utters in words that even to this day can make the vision living. His discourses to the disciples on the destruction of Jerusalem and the end of the world and his testimony before the high priests in the council are carried on in the same language. "And the high priest said unto him, I adjure thee by the living God, that thou tell us whether thou be the Christ, the Son of the living God. Jesus saith unto him, Thou hast said: nevertheless I say unto you, Hereafter shall ye see the Son of man sitting on the right hand of power, and coming in the clouds of heaven" (Matt. XXVI, 63–64). No faith is needed, but merely sound common sense, to see how absurd it would be to subject Christ's words to a critique based on meteorological investigations. Anyone understands that the language Christ speaks is absolutely heterogeneous with the language natural science speaks.

"But," it is objected—and with this we come to the question of actualization—

“Christ’s discourse does, after all, point to a real impending natural event; that is precisely the knot, that if his prediction is really to be fulfilled, it must come into decisive conflict with the laws of nature whose unchangeableness science presupposes.” We answer that if such a conflict were really to take place, then the reality of which Christ speaks would have to be a simple outward physical reality; but the phenomenon of revelation that he describes is a phenomenon of spirit; its reality is a reality for spirit. “This reality for spirit, then, has nothing to do with the physical?” Yes, it certainly has to do with the material reality of nature; but the manner in which the actualization in the physical sense is to take place is not described physically. The fulfillment of the prophecy presupposes a miracle. How much of this natural world is to be reshaped and transformed by such a miracle, at what point in time the transformation, seen temporally, will set in, and what intermediate stages of reshaping the visible must first run through—of this the discourse contains nothing. [207]

If on the other hand we place ourselves at the standpoint of natural science and hold fast to the principle of necessity, then the actual universe does indeed take on a different appearance, but then the cognition of truth also becomes of a different kind. What we are to seek along this road is not a satisfaction of the ideal demands of personality, but the real connection of things: here truth is impersonal, here no miracles are held out in prospect. Indeed, just as surely as the truth that expresses itself in the Pythagorean theorem is impersonal, just so surely is the whole system of truths that expresses itself in a Laplace’s *Mécanique céleste* a system of impersonal truths. The personal and the impersonal truths are not merely somewhat different, but absolutely heterogeneous. The dualism is here; it stands in force. Those who absolutely want to reject the revealed word and sacrifice their personality to the gray absolute may well cancel it, but veil it they cannot.

To veil the dualism determined by faith and knowledge, and to beguile the half-educated with dogmatic phrases and metaphysical ambiguities, is to hinder and botch spiritual life in the present age.

XIII.

The occurrences in our personal life, what meets us on our way amid changing ^[208] surroundings, we are accustomed to designate by different names according to the different impressions we receive from them. Thus we speak of happenstance, accident, good fortune, misfortune, the blows of fate and the trials of Providence; but are these now also different things in the matter itself? Are there in actuality some occurrences that must simply be ascribed to fate, and alongside these again others that are immediately appointed to us by Providence? Have fate and Providence divided the dominion between them? This question is as personal as possible.

The personal wants to be understood personally; it wants to be interpreted and applied in accordance with the peculiar way of viewing things of the person concerned: only through the understanding and the application does an event acquire its significance for life. Therefore one of two things: either everything is under fate, and there is no Providence, or all things without exception are under Providence, and there is no fate. Which of the two ways of viewing things is in itself the right and true one cannot be decided in objective knowledge; it can be determined only by a personal choice. He who holds to necessity chooses fate; he who with resolved mind grasps freedom chooses Providence. Here again stands ^[209] standpoint against standpoint, interpretation against interpretation; we shall now see how matters stand with this opposition.

To place oneself at the standpoint of natural necessity and choose fate is, in other words, to build one's view of life on objective knowledge and to apply the impersonal truth as though it were personal. What this means we see in many

of the wise men of antiquity, especially in the Stoics. For the noble Stoic, natural necessity is one with the necessity of reason; relying on the necessity of reason, he has with firm will and full consciousness placed himself under fate. His motto, "Lead me, O fate," thus means: Guide me, thou eternal necessity of reason, in thee is wisdom, in thee is truth! and so: Lead me, O eternal truth! How, then, is he led by fate, and how does he understand its leading? First he makes a distinction between the essential and the indifferent. To this distinction among the concerns of existence there corresponds in his own consciousness a sharp and clear personal distinction between "that which depends on us" and "that which does not depend on us." What, then, is it that does not depend on us? Whether we are to be sick or healthy does not depend on us; it stands in the power of chance and belongs to the indifferent. Whether we are to occupy a low or a high rank in society, whether we are to belong to the weak or the strong, the lowly or the mighty, does not depend on us; it hangs on chance and belongs to the indifferent. Thus he continues to go through the finite conditions of life, and levels the differences in the one phrase: "It is indifferent."

That all this indifferent matter nevertheless acquires a kind of validity lies solely and entirely in the significance it has for character. Therefore Epictetus [210] says: "The world is like a great stage; men are the various actors, and the Deity assigns each his particular role." By this he by no means wants life to be conceived either as a blind play of forces or as an arbitrary play of intrigue. When Epictetus speaks of playing one's role well, he takes the word role in another and deeper sense than an Emperor Augustus, who on his deathbed says with an ironic smile to his intimates: "Have I not played my role well?" Epictetus wants to impress the proposition that every human being attains his destiny when with his powers and gifts he fills the place on which he was set according to the order of things. Therefore the wise man bows beneath necessity as beneath a holy power. When you sit in the theater and watch a tragedy, your heart must not beat uneasily, and you must not weep; for you shall not wish that things went otherwise for the hero than they go. It goes as it must go, and with that you shall be content.

However dearly you love your wife and son, impress upon yourself constantly that a precious earthen vessel can be broken; if it is then broken, your misfortune will not surprise and pain you. If you have in good time seriously put it to yourself that your wife and son are mortal, then you will be able to see them die with the calm that is worthy of fate and of reason.

There is in the Stoic resignation something grand and exalted. A Stoic resigns on an altogether different scale than one otherwise resigns in everyday life. Every reasonable person whom a misfortune strikes must, to be sure, try with a certain composure to accommodate himself to the unavoidable; but in finite resignation one renounces only some goods, in quiet expectation of getting them replaced by others. The Stoic's resignation, on the other hand, is infinite; he resigns once and for all all finite goods and gives up all temporal wishes, so that he shall not [211] become a ball for the whims of fortune. One would think that this was the most exalted ethics there was in the world; and assuredly it is also exalted characters that we meet among the Stoics of antiquity. Yet on closer consideration it is easy to see that this moral greatness has something strained, something inhuman about it, that in its innermost nature a contradiction has hidden itself.

The Stoic is cold and strong; for he is the man of fate, and fate is cold and strong. He needs no one, loves no one, hates no one, admires no one, despises no one; he hopes in no one and fears no one. He cannot be bent, he can only be crushed; to him apply the strong words: *Si fractus illabatur orbis, impavidum ferient ruinæ*. The Stoic sets store exclusively by character. But what is character other than pronounced personality? And what is pronounced personality without a personal inwardness? But the principle of the Stoic personality is impersonal: here is the contradiction. The innermost of the Stoic's nature is not a self, but the cold, selfless universal.

Stoicism affords a remarkable example of what comes of wanting to assert the self on a selfless foundation. In the human sense, the Stoic makes the greatest exertions to hold fast to himself, to be in agreement with himself, to be sufficient to himself; but if we look more closely, this self-preservation rests indissolubly

on an essential absorption in the selfless. The Stoic self is without a kernel of selfhood, is only a point of transit for the world-reason, is against the power of fate only semblance and shadow. Its highest is to will, not what a personal self [212] must reasonably will: to assert its original validity—no, but to will what fate wills, to make itself into a nothing. This becomes especially recognizable where conflicts arise that bring the Stoic to seek deliverance in death. Suicide is otherwise usually regarded as an immoral act, indeed as a great crime. But from the Stoic point of view a suicide motivated by the collision of circumstances and carried out with calm deliberation can be regarded as the consummation of virtue. Cato at Utica put himself to death—“after having read Plato’s *Phaedo* and slept calmly until midnight.” Plutarch portrays him as a pattern of virtue. It is the cold consequence of the doctrine of fate that the self, after having exercised all its powers and played its role on the motley stage of life, ends the role by blowing out the lamp and vanishing into the selfless.

Let “modern science” exert itself as much as it will to paint up and embellish the old doctrine of fate by extolling “the Idea” and “the Absolute” and man’s “absolute relation to the Absolute”: it cannot possibly get away from the Stoic self-contradiction. That a personal self should have its ground, its essence, in the selfless is a desperate point that does not bear the light of ethics, a metaphysical ambiguity that makes the innermost of consciousness mythical.

The dialectic of self-contradiction that corresponds to this has been strikingly demonstrated by S. Kierkegaard in his work *Sygdommen til Døden*, in which he among other things treats (pp. 65 ff.) “the despair of willing in despair to be oneself,” and (p. 67) characterizes “the despairing self” in the following manner: “It acknowledges no power over itself; therefore it lacks in the last resort earnestness, and can only conjure up a semblance of earnestness when it itself bestows upon its experiments its very highest attention. This is, however, a counterfeit earnestness; [213] like the fire Prometheus stole from the gods—so this is to steal from God the thought, which is earnestness, that God is looking at one, instead of which the despairing self contents itself with looking at itself, which is now to bestow on his

undertakings infinite interest and significance, while it is precisely this that makes them experiments. . . . There is nothing firm in the whole dialectic within which it acts; what the self is does not stand firm for a single moment, that is, eternally firm. . . . The self is its own master, absolutely, as it is said, its own master, and precisely this is the despair, but also what it regards as its pleasure, its enjoyment. Yet on closer inspection one easily makes sure that this absolute ruler is a king without a country; he actually rules over nothing; his condition, his dominion, is subject to the dialectic that at every moment rebellion is legitimacy. For this rests in the final analysis arbitrarily on the self itself."

From the standpoint of religion, all occurrences, all actual events, all chances that meet us, insofar as they can acquire essential, decisive significance for man's personal life, are without exception to be conceived and determined as dispensations of the governing Providence. This cognition does not rest on insight into the naturally necessary connection of events; on the contrary! it rests on insight into the essence of religion; it proceeds with inner consequence from the principle of faith. Only by thinking this principle through will it be possible to arrive at a penetrating understanding of the signs of revelation in the Old and the New Testament. For what, after all, is a sign of revelation according to its religious concept? It is a fact, an event, which, by having stepped out of the immediate connection of nature, expressly signifies a personal transaction between the God who reveals himself and the one chosen in faith who receives the revelation, and so a dispensation of Providence. Thus the phenomenon of the burning bush is [214] a personal transaction between Jehovah and Moses, a dispensation for Moses. That Moses had in general believed in the God of the fathers and his governing Providence before the revelation occurred must be granted, just as it must also be presupposed that in the solitude of the wilderness he had pondered the deliverance of his people. But there is, in the life of faith too, a great step from the universal to the particular, from wish to fulfillment, from thought to action. At this stage of transition the miracle enters as an express sign. Now the hour has come when the great work of deliverance is to begin; now Moses is to recognize

that he and no other is the man whom Providence has chosen as its instrument. "Come now therefore," so sounds Jehovah's voice (Exod. 3:10), "and I will send thee unto Pharaoh, and bring forth my people, the children of Israel, out of Egypt."

But however definite the calling sounds, however unambiguous the dispensation seems to be, it must nevertheless be conceived in faith and appropriated in faith. One would suppose, according to an external consideration, that Moses must immediately have seen the possibility that, despite his human frailty, he would be able to accomplish what was laid upon him, since Jehovah after all expressly promises to stand by him. But in actuality it does not go so easily with grasping and understanding the divine dispensations. It is indeed quite characteristic that Moses, although he stands before the almighty Providence and hears the promise of divine assistance in repeated confirmations, nevertheless, with the dangers before his eyes, shows himself disheartened and irresolute. Can there be any more telling proof that the miracle, however outwardly it appears, is nevertheless essentially a phenomenon of the spirit, an actuality for the spirit? That the dispensations of
 [215] Providence, even where they enter in the most unexpected manner as a help in the hour of need, even then, when they show themselves as signs of omnipotence, must be conceived and interpreted in faith—of this sacred history affords many quite striking examples.

In the second book of Moses (XVII) the following is told: "And the people thirsted there for water; and the people murmured against Moses, and said, Wherefore is this that thou hast brought us up out of Egypt, to kill me and my children and my cattle with thirst? And Moses cried unto Jehovah, saying, What shall I do unto this people? they be almost ready to stone me. And Jehovah said unto Moses, Go on before the people, and take with thee of the elders of Israel; and thy rod, wherewith thou smotest the river, take in thine hand, and go. Behold, I will stand before thee there upon the rock in Horeb; and thou shalt smite the rock, and there shall come water out of it, that the people may drink. And Moses did so in the sight of the elders of Israel."

If anyone would see in this a proof that the actuality of a miracle can become

knowable also for unbelievers, then he is in a great error. The narrative, after all, proves precisely the opposite. The great crowd, which despaired in its need, accepted the help, drank from the spring (cf. 1 Cor. X), quenched its thirst, was perhaps startled for a moment at so unexpected a piece of good fortune, but here nothing stands about its having received any impression of the miracle as miracle.

Another, still more telling testimony we have in the New Testament (John VI). After Jesus has fed 5000 men in the neighborhood of Tiberias, he goes to Capernaum; "(howbeit there came other boats from Tiberias nigh unto the place where they did eat bread, after that the Lord had given thanks:) when the people therefore saw that Jesus was not there, neither his disciples, they also took shipping, and came to Capernaum, seeking for Jesus. And when they had found him on the [216] other side of the sea, they said unto him, Rabbi, when camest thou hither? Jesus answered them and said, Verily, verily, I say unto you, Ye seek me, not because ye saw the signs, but because ye did eat of the loaves, and were filled." To these people, then, it is quite indifferent where the bread comes from; whether it happens by a stroke of luck, a fabulous occurrence, by sorcery or by a special arrangement of Providence, if only they can get bread.

We learn from these examples not only that the sign as sign can be cognized only by believers, but we learn as well that the believers who see in the sign a dispensation of Providence must will to conceive the dispensation in such a way that it can acquire its significance for life: the appropriation and the understanding bring with them a personal responsibility. This relation between the miracle and the dispensation can in turn cast light on Abraham's conduct before Pharaoh and before Abimelech.

The history of Abraham must, like most of the narratives in the Old and the New Testament, be *interpreted*; that is to say: there must be added intermediate determinations, propositions and judgments, which either immediately or mediately belong to determining the point of view from which the narrative wants to be conceived. The history of Abraham is a popular history; it is communicated in broad strokes; the intermediate determinations recede into the background: the

people's gaze is fixed on the beauty of the ancestress of the tribe, the faith of the patriarch and the grace of Jehovah; in the popular presentation the religious is contained. As Jehovah's chosen one, Abraham is in an altogether special sense a man of Providence, his way through the world a way of Providence. But precisely as the man of Providence, Abraham is responsible for how he interprets and uses the dispensations. So he comes as a defenseless stranger to Egypt, to Pharaoh's court, [217] and sees the danger for himself and his wife. Had he now, amid the threatening surroundings, been without further ado entitled to rely on supernatural assistance; had he dared to be quite certain of understanding the thought of Providence when he said to himself: "I have received the election; it is impossible that the Egyptians can kill me; sooner shall the Almighty by a miracle kill them all," then he would indeed have had an easy time playing the "knight." But to understand the dispensations is a personal task. The matter presented itself to him in another light; the thought on which he comes to agree with Sarah can be expressed thus: "We must gain time, avert the momentary danger and let events develop; who knows what Jehovah will do?" If this is now correct with respect to the doctrine of Providence, then, as regards the criticized "white lie," we need only take note of Abraham's words to Abimelech (Gen. 20:12): "And yet indeed she is my sister; she is the daughter of my father, but not the daughter of my mother; and she became my wife"; for in other words this means: "I have kept something from you, but what I have said is true."

What holds of the wondrous signs and dispensations in sacred history holds in a corresponding manner of the events in every human being's personal life. Faith in Providence requires a doubling of consciousness. Here is presupposed an actual world, an order of things, in which the occurrences are related as links in a chain; this is the one side. But here it is presupposed as well that the whole actual order of things is borne, moved and pervaded by God's almighty will; each single occurrence shows us the opposition between faith and knowledge in the clearest possible way. Let the occurrence be, for example, a sad death; a hero dies at the moment he is on the point of delivering his people; a father of a family

dies and leaves wife and children helpless, and so on. If these cases of death are [218] regarded from the point of view of knowledge, then there is surely no one who doubts that each of them must have had its natural causes. But if we stop at this conception, then there can be no talk here of any Providence; each event is, to recall the Stoics, in its way woven into the great necessity: everything falls under fate. If a Providence is to show itself here, the occurrence must be conceived for itself as an event into which the divine will has expressly laid a personal task for those concerned.

It is now easy to see as well that the conception corresponding to faith by no means excludes the natural one. The natural causes of the hero's death may be known to everyone in the land, and still the people can in earnest be called upon to take note of the will of Providence in the sad event. It must be expressly emphasized that when faith presupposes a unity of the natural causes and God's will, it presupposes as well that the all-governing will can at every moment alter the co-operating causes and let events occur precisely as is most serviceable to man. But science cannot possibly engage in such a way of viewing things. When a physician conceives a death as a physician, and a clergyman the same death as a pastor of souls, then the two conceptions are absolutely heterogeneous. If now the two absolutely heterogeneous ways of viewing things were incompatible in one consciousness, then it would surely be as impossible for the physician to understand the clergyman as it would be impossible for the clergyman to understand the physician. Is this now the case? By no means! The dualistic way of regarding things has grown together with our religious-moral representations to such a degree that it would arouse the greatest offense in a house of mourning if the physician declared that the death in question did not concern Providence, [219] since the patient had demonstrably died a natural death, while the clergyman, in pious zeal to show the finger of Providence, expressly asserted that God himself had literally killed the man.

The religious mourner unites the consciousness of naturally operating causes with the consciousness of God's unsearchable will, thus unites two absolutely

heterogeneous ways of viewing things in one consciousness; and then people still cry Dualism, Dualism! and make a noise and a fuss as though it were something unheard of, terrible and self-contradictory—what, nevertheless, when it is seen in actual life, they will reckon among the most ordinary things of all.

The miracle and the everyday event resemble each other in that both can be conceived as dispensations; but just as impossible as it is without faith to cognize the everyday event as a dispensation, just so impossible is it without faith to cognize the most wondrous thing of all as a miracle. A multitude sunk in coarseness could, according to the account of sacred history, be brought for a moment to be startled and terrified when the wondrous happened; but it soon forgot the surprise and felt no impulse to thank Providence. In a corresponding manner it goes with dispensations even to this day. Something may meet a human being so joyful, so sorrowful, that in the moment of feeling it is as though he saw the eye of Providence; but if there is no power of inwardness, no earnestness of faith in the personality, what happens then? Then what is not unusual happens: the feeling dwindles, the mind loses its elasticity, what began by showing itself as a higher dispensation ends by transforming itself into a quite natural event. The difference between the knowing ones of the present age, who could not see the dispensation in a natural event, and those ignorant ones, who could not see it in [220] the signs of omnipotence, is only this, that the knowing are blinded by thoughts, the ignorant by thoughtlessness.

To what extreme the more recent theology, infatuated and bewitched by “scientific” thinking, has gone in undermining the doctrine of Providence can be seen from Schleiermacher’s dogmatics. Schleiermacher says of preservation (*Der christliche Glaube*. 1ster Band. Berlin 1835. S. 222): “The pious self-consciousness, according to which we place everything that stirs us and acts upon us in the absolute dependence on God, coincides entirely with the insight that precisely all this is conditioned and determined by the connection of nature.” So completely does the divine will, according to this explanation, become identified with the operating natural causes that fate itself becomes Providence, and Providence fate. It is the old

Stoic doctrine of fate, freshened up with a little evangelical paint. Schleiermacher's "pious self-consciousness" and Epictetus' pious resignation are here brought into complete congruence. This congruence has long been in preparation: Holberg already saw it.

"Nothing," says Holberg, "can move more than the resignation to God's will that is made by Epictetus. His words are these: I wish with my whole heart that death at my last may find me prepared, so that without confusion, without hindrance and constraint, I may end my life, and that I may say to God: Lord! have I transgressed thy commandments? have I misused the gifts with which thou hast endowed me? have I not subjected my will to thy will? have I ever complained of my evil fate? have I ever accused thy divine Providence? I have been sick, because it has been thy will, just as it has also been my will; I have been poor, because it has so pleased thee, and I have been content in my poverty; I have lived in contempt, [221] because thou hast willed to have it so, and I have not striven to raise myself up. Thou hast never seen me distressed in my poor condition. Thou hast never found me impatient and grumbling. I am still ready to submit to all that thou findest good to lay upon me. The least sign that thou givest is for me a holy and inviolable order. Thou willest that I shall leave this glittering stage of the world: behold! I leave it, and render thee a thousand thanks that thou hast deigned to set me upon it, to show me thy works, and to place before my eyes the excellent order with which thou governest all created things." (Hundrede og tyve af Holbergs Epistler ved Fabricius. Kjøbenhavn 1858. S. 114).

At a first fleeting glance it must surely seem as though there were contained in Epictetus' utterance a deeply satisfying doctrine of Providence; but precisely the opposite is the case. It is the selfless being, the universal necessity of reason, that here in the pious contemplation is personified; there is ascribed to fate a wisdom, a self, a will, which by the nature of the case it neither has nor can have. Precisely by the impersonal element in the government of the world taking on in this manner the semblance of personality, it comes about that the pious resignation, far from nourishing and strengthening the personal self in man, consumes the kernel of

personality. The pious one wills what the personified fate wills; by making his will one with the will of fate, he sacrifices the noblest powers of personality to the impersonal.

[222] The pious doctrine of fate and the evangelical doctrine of Providence proceed from absolutely heterogeneous principles. Just as revelation as a whole is characterized by subordinating the concept of nature to the concept of creation, so the revealed doctrine of Providence is characterized in particular by subordinating all operating natural causes to God's governing will. Instead of identifying God's will with the natural causes, faith on the contrary presupposes the difference. (Observandum quod Deus non solum vim agendi dat causis secundis . . . , sed quod immediate influit in actionem et effectum creaturæ. Qvst.): the cause that is freedom itself determines the events which, to judge by the phenomenon, proceed immediately from natural causes.

He who cannot conceive the miracle as a sign of omnipotence cannot conceive any event whatsoever as a dispensation of Providence either. The unity of the will of Providence and natural causes that is characteristic of the everyday event receives in faith its light from the opposition between the will of Providence and the natural causes that is made visible in the miracle; the unity must be illuminated by the opposition, and the opposition by the unity: the miracle and the dispensation presuppose and explain each other mutually.

The true doctrine of Providence is an unconditional doctrine of personality; the pattern, the true personality, is himself the revealed Providence. What, then, has the revealed Providence taught us about dispensations and trials, about courage and patience, about fear and danger? We hear His word, which says (Matt. 10:28–30): *Are not two sparrows sold for a farthing? and one of them shall not fall on the ground without your Father. But the very hairs of your head are all numbered. Fear ye not therefore, ye are of more value than many sparrows.*—“If these words were only human words, then we should surely have to regard them as an exaggeration in an outburst of enthusiasm; for in the world of dangers that lies between man [223] and God, a human being has, after all, much to fear. But when he who speaks the

word is the Word itself, then we must learn from him where the danger is, and what we have to fear. There is in the world of dangers only one unconditional danger, only one thing that is fearful, only One who is to be feared. Therefore the Word says: 'I will forewarn you whom ye shall fear.' And Providence is human. He who speaks of the danger and shows us whom we shall fear; he who surveys all the dangers of finitude and says: 'Fear not!'—he knows what danger is; his life was familiar with danger. Danger sought him in his cradle; it followed him to his grave. Everywhere, in the desert as in the cities, on the plains of Galilee, among the mountains of Judea, everywhere he went, danger went after him and lay in wait for him. Watchful as Providence, confident as he who is under Providence, the Son of Man goes along the way of dangers and fears nothing in the world. He works, and no one stops him; he goes to his goal, and no one lays a hand on him before his hour comes. But when his hour had come, he went willingly to meet the danger; it did not surprise him as an accident, it did not come over him as a fate; it came because he let it come. Nor did it come, then, in outward tumult, not in a storm of human passions, not in a clamor of hostile weapons; it came in all stillness, alone to the lonely one; only thus did he let it come. Alone that night in the still garden he let the danger come to him and strove with it, not as the strong strive, but as the frail, so that in flesh and blood there should be no difference of fate between the strong and the frail, but a victory of devotion in frailty. Alone that night in the still garden he let the danger pass as a mortal anguish through his soul; he did not defy it, he did not despise it; he did not proudly lift his head like one who sacrifices himself to fate; he fell on his face and bowed himself humbly [224] beneath the Father's will. Alone that night in the still garden he let all the dangers of finitude transform themselves in inwardness into one danger. So he strove in inwardness and conquered in inwardness; and when he then rose from the strife, behold, then it was over with the danger, then there was no danger at all." (Om Tilværelsens ideale Magter: Skjæbne og Forsyn. Andet Oplag. Kbhvn. 1867. S. 30 flg.).

The doctrine of Providence is dualistic. If the dualism is abolished, then

Providence vanishes. But when Providence vanishes for the leaders of the people and for the people itself: how will it then go with the spiritual life in the present and the future?

XIV.

It was about hindrances and conditions for the spiritual life of the present age [225] that these lectures were essentially to treat. But for an assessment of the spiritual life, its phenomena and powers, it was first and foremost necessary to choose a standpoint from which the whole could be tolerably surveyed, and to secure a standard under which the mutually different, intersecting tendencies could be brought. It is the separation between faith and knowledge, between religion and science, that marks our chosen standpoint. From various sides this standpoint has gradually been illuminated in the foregoing; but we must admit it, it is only a partial illumination! Here an all-round settlement is required, a last concluding account.

Such an account must surely at first glance seem bound to become very intricate, since it is to be rendered before two tribunals, each with its own procedure, that of religion and that of science; the values must in this settlement be reckoned in two kinds of coin: it becomes, as has been said mockingly, a double bookkeeping. Nonetheless the matter can from the beginning be laid out very simply. For since there are here two circles of cognition, each with its principle, it suggests itself that each of the parties must punctually have its own; but when each gets its own, then [226] surely all strife and complaint cease. If religion, with its ideals of revelation, its sacred facts and personal thoughts of will, is permitted to constitute a kingdom of the spirit for itself, a region of representations and concepts that are developed with inner consequence in their own connection from their own presuppositions: what more can faith then demand? And now to the other side! what greater concession

can one well make to science than when one ascribes to it a standpoint of its own, a method of its own, laws and consequences of its own, and besides freedom to develop in all directions, to draw everything before its tribunal, to investigate and test everything that can in any way fall within a human horizon? One would think that science for its part would have to find itself satisfied, just as well as religion. And yet, we dare not conceal it, the account has its difficulties. The point is that the two circles of cognition, although they are mutually absolutely heterogeneous, are to be united in one consciousness, and this in such a way that the personality developed to self-understanding becomes able to move with certainty in knowledge and yet find rest in faith. This can only happen by its learning to see through the fundamental error, the first false presupposition from which all the objections of knowledge against faith proceed, so clearly that it is able everywhere to remove the misunderstanding without violating science. But in this endeavor the personality is exposed to temptation. "The temptation is that faith and knowledge are so easily made somewhat homogeneous, although they are absolutely heterogeneous. If the absolute in the heterogeneity is stressed sharply enough, then a screaming contradiction is heard: *what is truth in faith is untruth in science; what is truth* [227] *in science is untruth in faith*. But in the contradiction lies the possibility of its solution. It is the absolute limit of our knowledge, it is the riddle of existence, on which the attention of the knower as well as of the believer must here fix itself. If all human knowledge has an absolute limit, if there is here really a mystery of the spirit, a riddle of existence, then there is here also something that must be *believed*, because it cannot be *known*. Now when that which is hidden in the riddle, that which is solely and entirely destined to be an object of faith, is nonetheless drawn under knowledge and science, what then? Then knowledge oversteps its absolute limit. And when knowledge has overstepped its absolute limit, what then? Then science sets about, blithely, to fathom, to ground and to comprehend that which by its nature neither can nor shall be scientifically comprehended. But when science takes it upon itself to comprehend the incomprehensible, what then? Then it necessarily arrives at contradictory concepts. What can only be

expressed in contradictory concepts must be untrue; the mysteries of faith can only be expressed in contradictory concepts: therefore they are untrue. That something can be true in faith and untrue in science now follows directly from this, that *science, by wanting to comprehend what lies outside its limit, itself becomes untrue.*"

"But how can something that is really true in science be untrue in faith? Answer: Because it is not only knowledge, but faith too, that has an absolute limit: that knowledge has faith as its limit necessarily presupposes that faith has knowledge as its limit. But that faith has knowledge as its limit means that a concept of faith cannot possibly be developed into a concept of knowledge. In relying on the miracle, faith presupposes an actual nature with actual laws. But how is nature related to the miracle? Why, that is precisely what is the riddle of [228] existence. If now faith, forgetting its absolute presupposition, namely the riddle, oversteps its limit and begins to want to overhaul the scientific concept of nature for the benefit of the miracle, then the concept of nature of natural science becomes not only an untruth in faith, *but faith, which has engaged in something it is not equal to, itself becomes untrue.*" (Om den gode Villie S. 31–33.)

The next thing that presents difficulties is the form of the account. This difficulty does not concern in the first instance the religious, but the scientific. The fundamental thoughts of the spiritual life can really be presented in a humane form of communication. It would here be out of place to make excuse for what is deficient in such a way as to shift the blame onto the difficulty of cognition. That would be a self-contradiction according to the chosen standpoint; for it lies, as already shown, in the nature of personality that its decisive conditions of life must be capable of being developed clearly, comprehensibly, popularly, and intelligibly for all.

Otherwise with the scientific side of the account; here the humane form of communication is insufficient. A scientific account can only be rendered in strict scientific form, and every attempt to make it fully recognizable and comprehensible for outsiders, for the humane consciousness in cultured circles, is an attempt to convert the strictly scientific into something popular; but how much the popular

form departs from the scientific requirements has already been sufficiently emphasized in the foregoing. Among the stupefying elements in the spiritual life of the present age one may without doubt reckon the disproportionate trust in scientific communications at second hand, in conception in popular forms.

[229] I must therefore forgo presenting the scientific account; but so that it shall not look as though under this pretext I were evading a subsequent account, I will go as far as is tolerably possible, in that I will briefly point out the points of view and orienting points of departure on which, in the rendering of the scientific account, it must essentially depend. I indicate these points of view by referring to written statements, insofar as these are available. The matter is, after all, in its first coming-to-be; I have not yet had occasion—what is nevertheless necessary for the complete elucidation of the whole—to give a detailed lecture course on the philosophy of religion.

When the talk is of separation between faith and knowledge, it suggests itself to separate religion from science by making religious cognition into a paradox. This is what Kierkegaard with wonderful power and genius has carried through. In resolutely breaking the staff over every attempt to want to justify the truths of religion by the scientific way, he made the break so decisive that every cognition from the side of religion turned against science with a pricking sting, faith being posited as paradox. I shall remark on this that my chosen standpoint does not stand in conflict with, but neither does it coincide with, the Kierkegaardian view. This marks a stage, a standpoint by itself; this stage had to be reached, and the knot of the paradox drawn properly tight, before we could get further in religious cognition. How different the chosen standpoint is from the Kierkegaardian can be made plain in a few strokes. The opposition between faith and knowledge is in Kierkegaard transformed into an opposition between passion and science. Science and passion are the terms of the fundamental opposition; he complains precisely

[230] that the theologians in our theocentric nineteenth century are about to forget passion over science. He wants, then, to make passion count again, especially the holy passion, faith. When faith is posited as holy passion, one sees at once how

impossible it is to present it in a doctrine, in an objective dogmatic form of teaching. Therefore Kierkegaard impresses again and again that the truths of religion cannot be taught; Christianity, he says, is no doctrine, it is a communication of existence.

For the sake of an overview I have published a work: "Paa Kierkegaardske Stadier, et Livsbillede." I have not published this work to spare the reader from going to the sources; but the Kierkegaardian literature is so extensive, many-sided and ramified that one easily goes astray in the various forms of productivity as in a primeval forest. Therefore there are many who read large portions of Kierkegaard without having a sure overview of the whole productivity. Some lose themselves in "Enten Eller" and appropriate him as a witty, brilliant aesthete; others skip over the aesthetic, keep to "Frygt og Bæven," to "Kjærlighedens Gjerninger," to "Indøvelse i Christendom," and so on, and take him without further ado for the stern preacher of repentance. The little work therefore presents the stages, the aesthetic, the ethical and the religious, in their mutual relation—for an overview.

"Love," says Kierkegaard, "has after all its priests in the poets, and at times one hears a voice that knows how to keep it in honor; but of faith not a word is heard; who speaks to the honor of this passion? Philosophy goes further. Theology sits painted at the window and courts its favor, offers its loveliness for sale to philosophy." The presentation of the ideals of faith ought by no means to be doctrinaire; Kierkegaard does everything here to break the scientific form. Thus in [231] his "Smule Philosophie" he keeps the positive content of Christianity in the form of an experiment, and in the scientific Efterskrift presents the whole so humorously and with such light play that one would think it was only a jest, although with this jest it is in dead earnest. To present the ideals of faith is for the defender of the paradox rather a poet's task than a scientific concern. "If it is so that you can present faith, that only proves that you are a poet, and if you do it well, that you are a good poet, but nothing less than that you are a believer. Perhaps you can also weep when you present faith; that would then prove that you were a good actor." To develop the paradox theologically would in Kierkegaard's eyes be one of the most wrong-headed things one could undertake, for the paradox does not

allow itself to be determined from a traditional or objective doctrinal standpoint. The whole manner of presentation must, according to his way of viewing things, essentially be a presentation of moods. The Kierkegaardian dialectic is a dialectic of moods, his concepts are concepts of mood. As far as I know, no one in the present age has been able to measure himself with Kierkegaard in developing the religious concepts to the highest pathos. I choose an example from "Frygt og Bæven." The pseudonymous author speaks of Abraham's faith, and speaks in mood. To characterize Abraham's spiritual greatness he compares him with other heroes and thereby comes to depict for us characters of different spirit, different kinds of greatness. "No one," he says, "shall be forgotten who was great in the world; but each was great in his own way, and each in proportion to the greatness of that which *he loved*. For he who loved himself became great by himself, and he who loved other men became great by his devotion, but he who loved God [232] became greater than all. Each shall be remembered, but each became great in proportion to his *expectation*. One became great by expecting the possible, another by expecting the eternal; but he who expected the impossible became greater than all. Each shall be remembered, but each was great wholly in proportion to the magnitude of that with which he strove. For he who strove with the world became great by overcoming the world, and he who *strove* with himself became great by overcoming himself; but he who strove with God became greater than all. Thus there was striving in the world, man against man, one against a thousand, but he who strove with God was greater than all. Thus there was striving on the earth: there was he who overcame all by his power, and there was he who overcame God by his powerlessness. There was he who relied on himself and gained all, there was he who, secure in his strength, sacrificed all, but he who believed God was greater than all. There was he who was great by his power, and he who was great by his wisdom, and he who was great by his hope, and he who was great by his love; but Abraham was greater than all, great by the power whose strength is powerlessness, great by the wisdom whose secret is foolishness, great by the hope whose form is madness, great by the love that is hatred of oneself."

Here, then, we have the paradox, in the highest pathos, the richest mood. One easily sees that this speech rich in mood does not at all permit any scientific reasoning. How would not every formal, metaphysical objection fall dead and powerless to the ground in the face of an utterance such as this, that *he who expected the impossible became greater than all!* To expect the impossible, what does that mean? When one is to reflect, one can well grant that in faith man expects the improbable; but who can expect what is in itself impossible? And yet [233] the impossible is posited so sharply in the place of the improbable. Much may seem impossible for men, but precisely the fact that it is impossible for men lays a tacit stress on its being possible for God. Every accord between what is impossible for man and what is possible for God is, however, cut off by the paradox. The direct understanding is rejected, all finite reasoning must fall silent; the force and the momentum lie in the ideal pathos: the communication of existence does not take time for theoretical negotiations.

Kierkegaard has strikingly seen that the question of the truth of Christianity cannot possibly be decided in science, since subjectivity in science must always be contemplative, and the contemplative subjectivity objective. "The modest, objective subjectivity keeps itself outside with applauded heroism; it is at your service in being willing to accept the truth as soon as it has been procured. Yet it is a distant goal that is striven for (undeniably, for an approximation can go on as long as it pleases)—and while the grass grows, the observer dies, calmly, for he was objective. O thou objectivity, not praised for nothing, thou art capable of everything; not the most believing one has been so certain of his eternal happiness, and above all so sure of not losing it, as the objective one! Unless it should be that this objectivity and modesty were out of place, that it was unchristian. Then it would indeed be precarious to enter in that manner into the truth of Christianity. Christianity is spirit, spirit is inwardness, inwardness is subjectivity, subjectivity is in its essence passion, at its maximum an infinitely, personally interested passion for its eternal happiness." (Afsluttende uvidenskabelig Efterskrift til de filosofiske Smuler af Joh. Climacus. Kbhvn. 1846. S. 19–20).

[234]

When Kierkegaard develops his concepts, we must not take them in the merely general form; for when one separates these concepts from the corresponding mood and strong pathos and draws them under contemplation, one has distorted the whole, and it is precisely this that Kierkegaard inveighs against so strongly. Metaphysical objections, critical nit-picking remarks have nothing to signify here.

[235]

That this standpoint does not coincide with the one chosen by us can easily be seen; for we have, after all, precisely in direct opposition to the Kierkegaardian rejection, striven again and again to draw the whole system of religious cognitions under the level of contemplation. We grant that Kierkegaard is unconditionally right in the assertion that faith must be a paradox for the non-believer. We grant that he who, although he accepts the presuppositions of faith, nevertheless desires to clarify these in knowledge and science, and thinks he has need of a science of faith, is repelled by the paradox. We grant that the existing individual, the one hard pressed in the crises of existence, must be stimulated by the sting of contradiction, must again and again be wounded by the paradoxical. But now a question remains, and it is the one that has moved through our investigations, namely this: Is faith, then, also a paradox for itself? Is the believer so blind to his own moments of thought that they cannot possibly develop for him into clear concepts coherent in themselves? This must be denied. Faith is in itself a principle of cognition; the word of faith is the word of light and of life, and from this proceeds all clarity about the content of religion. Faith is indeed "a holy passion," but when the holy passion is reflected through, it shows itself as a pathetic expression of the will striving after holiness: the principle of faith is in the deepest sense a principle of will, faith itself an act of will, an innermost action (*nemo credit, nisi volens*): the thoughts of faith are thoughts of will, all of them together decisive thoughts of personality. When the whole, internally coherent sum of religious thoughts of will is developed and clearly presented in a system of concepts of faith, we get, not a paradoxical communication of existence, but a doctrine of religion valid from the standpoint of faith, a systematically coherent doctrine of religion. So much with regard to the Kierkegaardian stage. We come now to the next question.

For if it is granted that there is a system of religious cognitions, that we must once again get a doctrine of religion, then the chosen standpoint seems, although we have declared ourselves decisively against all theology, nevertheless to fall back under the theological. I will begin with a stupid remark, a remark which otherwise from so many sides presents itself as the offspring of rare cleverness; the remark is this: “to give a systematic presentation of the religious cognitions is to make the doctrine of religion objective; to make the doctrine of religion objective is to place oneself at the standpoint of the observer and to make the doctrine scientific, and so, when one is nevertheless to hold to the unconditional validity of subjectivity and reject science, an obvious contradiction.” Why I call this a stupid remark I can easily explain. If it were not possible to develop and ground the doctrine of religion because this can only happen on the condition that one places oneself at the standpoint of the observer, then it would, after all, not be possible either—what has nevertheless notoriously happened in “Uvidenskabelig Efterskrift”—to give a humorous, experimenting presentation of the Christian problems. Johannes Climacus himself stands, after all, from first to last at the standpoint of the observer; and yet there is no contradiction whatever in his, standing at this standpoint, smiling at the “applauded heroism” of the “modest objective” subjectivity, and sharpening the subjective. For here there is an enormous difference between the contemplative consciousness that argues and the consciousness of which, from which and to which the argument is made. In the doctrine of religion as well as in the humorous experimenting, the argument must throughout the whole contemplation be made from the selfhood concentrated in itself, the unconditionally valid subjectivity. Now follows another, more reasonable objection. The systematic development of a doctrinal concept corresponding to the principle of faith is, and must by its nature necessarily be, scientific; but what is a scientific development of the content of positive religion other than theology? “You can,” people say, “choose your standpoint where you will: if you really solve the task of presenting the content of the revealed religion in a coherent development flowing from one principle, then you are and remain a theologian, and it is no use your protesting.” [236]

To see how matters stand with this assertion, we need only cast a glance at the theological standpoints.

The first that presents itself is then the more recent speculative-dogmatic one. This standpoint has, after all, wanted to take up all the presuppositions of faith, has wanted to build the cognition of faith on the life of faith, has wanted to develop the concepts not from pure knowledge but from "the good will," and in this way has wanted to make the principle of will into a principle of science. But to make the principle of will into a principle of science is impossible. Should theology by virtue of its good will really be science, then it would have to be the highest of all sciences; it would have to be able in the name of the will to regulate the other [237] sciences, which stand lower in relation to the holy and are therefore subordinate; it would, in short, have to be able to re-establish its medieval universal monarchy.

"But a new theological universal monarchy, what an enormous thought! Can a thought of this height, without stooping so low that it becomes quite crooked, enter by the door of actuality? I too have met the lofty thought; it has many times come to meet me when I regarded dogmatics, not from the shadow side, but from the light side; for although, according to my task, I have most often had to wander through its shadowy parts, I have not therefore forgotten where I can still find the sunlit places. But when, after having beheld the ideal in all its glory, I then seriously asked myself: can such an ideal be realized? I have always received a negative answer. It is surely so that the idea of the good, conceived as the idea of love, of the holy will, is in divine knowledge one with the eternal idea of truth; but from this it by no means follows that the idea of truth in a human knowledge is one with the idea of the good in human existential willing. It is surely so that in wisdom itself no gulf can be thought between faith and science: but why is God no man of science? Because God is no believer. To think of the divine knowledge as a scientific knowledge, be it philosophical or theological knowledge, is as blasphemous as to speak of a believing God. Why must a human being apprehend the absolute in faith? Because the purest and highest development of human knowledge is, not divine, but scientific. Why must a human being

apprehend the absolute in knowledge? Because faith is a human, not a divine, cognition. Why does the absolute that is apprehended in human knowledge show itself so heterogeneous with the absolute that is apprehended in faith? Because [238] the relative forms of apprehension grasp the absolute, not in its central depth, as it must be thought by us *in abstracto* to be, with infinite concretion, in the divine self, but in two polar extremes, of which the one is marked by universal thinking grounded in rational necessity, the other by the punctual life of will germinating in conscience. Here there is in the absolute something I must absolutely believe, because there is in the absolute something I must absolutely know." (Den gode Villie som Magt i Videnskaben S. 6–7).

That there is a relation between will and science cannot be denied; he who is to think must will to think; he who is to cultivate a science must will to cultivate it. Indeed, the relation is even personal, ethical, insofar as everyone who spends his time cultivating a science must be responsible for how he employs his powers, whether cases do not arise when for higher considerations he must break off; and so on. But these and similar considerations have nothing whatever to do with our present question. The personality, which is answerable for everything it thinks and does, is answerable also for the manner in which it conceives the relation between the will and science. The good will is not a power in science, but it is a power in religion. The religious problems of thought are at bottom all problems of will. In every problem of will the argument runs from the self, by the self, to the self; whereas in every problem of knowledge the argument runs from the thing, by the thing, to the thing: to argue from nature is to argue from the thing, to argue from creation is to argue from the self; to argue from the physical-organic individuality is to argue from the thing, to argue from the pure heart and sinless will of the ideal man is to argue from the self; to argue from an inner necessity of [239] the idea is to argue from the thing, to argue from the freedom of the spirit is to argue from the self, and so forth.

The confusion in the Christian-speculative dogmatics betrays itself in each of the chief dogmas, creation, the incarnation, inspiration, in that two half thoughts,

one half from the self and one half from the thing, one half from the will and one half from science, one half from the subjective and one half from the objective, rise up against each other, clash with each other and end by neutralizing each other. This *concordia discors* of the heterogeneous thoughts has already been described in several ways and can be described in still more.

“One knows how it has gone with ‘the Christian dogmatics,’ what mishaps it has had with the antirational in the great simple chief dogmas. Take now the dogma of creation; why, that would be a very profound and exceedingly scientific dogma, if only there were not the snag, the antirational, about it, that as surely as dogmatics is quite honestly to make it come out that the world is created from nothing, then there is no nature in the world, and if it is to acknowledge that here is an actual nature, then it cannot possibly make it come out that the world is created from nothing. (Cf. ‘Den gode Villie’ S. 96–104.) To lump the whole together in speculative common stock, to let nature be creation and creation nature, so that faith may be knowledge and knowledge faith, is so humble an inconsistency that it will surely not fail to humble theology. But the incarnation, the dogma of the God-man? Yes, the dogma of the God-man, the great dogma which through the centuries, with the rational, the antirational and the irrational, has set so manifold thoughts as well as passions in motion, would undoubtedly be the favorite dogma of the faculty, the palladium of theology, the central dogma [240] of the heart, if ‘the Christian dogmatics’ had not had that sorrow at the last, the great sorrow with the Son. What sorrow? Alas, his consciousness, his dogmatic Logos-consciousness, is, *horribile dictu*, cracked, dualistically cracked; the one Son has—through the crack—become two sons: one whose consciousness is from eternity but who has not become incarnate, and another, a younger, who has become incarnate but whose consciousness is not from eternity. (Cf. ‘Den gode Villie’ S. 91–92.) To be sure, theology holds as much as it can to ‘the unity of consciousness,’ in the incarnation too; but the crack, the crack! The dogma of the incarnation is a very difficult dogma. But the dogma of inspiration, that is surely not so difficult? If there is any dogma that has the testimony of the Spirit,

then it must surely be the dogma of the outpouring of the Spirit. Since it is now, moreover, to be quite certain that dogmatics too, by virtue of the dogma of the outpouring of the Spirit, has 'the testimony of the Spirit,' we may well expect that the dogma of the outpouring of the Spirit must be as though made for dogmatics. Yes, it really would have been as though made for dogmatic speculation, if 'the Christian dogmatics,' in stumbling over the antirational, had not in the fall had the mishap that its Pentecost miracle came to stand on its head. But to turn the Pentecost miracle, the great 'church-founding miracle,' upside down to such a degree that the hearers hear many *different* tongues although the apostles together speak only one *single* tongue; that the uppermost thus becomes lowermost, the lowermost uppermost—that is more than reformatory, it is revolutionary. That dogmatics with its miracle revolution has meant well, heartily well, both with the apostles and with the Church and the feast of Pentecost, we shall gladly grant; but revolutionary it is, that is certain (Cf. 'Den gode Villie' S. 84). The dogma of inspiration is therefore a very difficult dogma. Yes, and the dogma of baptism, [241] with its conscious 'mystical-magical' element, is a very difficult dogma; and the dogma of the speculative presence of Christ's body in the Supper is a very difficult dogma; and the dogma of eternal damnation is a difficult, a very difficult, dogma. There is in eternal damnation something so antirational that 'Christian dogmatics' has expressly had to demand a non-damnation (apokatastasis), so that damnation and non-damnation, in a terrible collision, might end the whole with a solemn antinomy, and the antinomy (the conflict of reason) might stand as a testimony, a testimony concluding the system, that there is unity in the dogmatic consciousness, that theology truly masters the antirational. — So long as we frivolously slip away from every particular discussion of any particular dogma whatsoever by saying, when things get tight: yes, here of course there are difficult points, but for the rest, etc., it is an easy matter to play at reconciliation with faith and knowledge. But if a stand is to be made on definite points, if the particular, definite dogmas are to be accounted for in earnest, then one will soon come to acknowledge that all dogmas without exception are equally difficult, equally antirational, equally at odds with

scientific comprehension. The thoughts of faith all bear the mark of faith, are all furnished with the antirational sting, so that whoever would crumple them scientifically will surely feel the prick in the end.” (Om Holbergs Kirkehistorie og Theologie. Kjøbenhavn 1866. S. 35–37).

The same thing is said in another way in my work *Den gode Villie som Magt i Videnskaben*, S. 92–93: “What is peculiar to dogmatic thinking is that one thinks scientifically within faith: *credo, ut intelligam*. That one thinks scientifically within faith means that one does not think, but represents, intuitively, fantasizes in [242] a metaphysical manner for the elucidation of the mysteries, for the benefit of revelation, for the joy of faith. Dogmatics, which objectively builds on the word of Scripture, sees in the passages of Scripture something quite other and deeper than either Christ himself or his apostles ever saw: it sees the metaphysical. ‘He would not,’ it says (Dogm. § 133) of Christ’s self-abasement, ‘merely live in the pure glory of the Godhead, in metaphysical majesty; but he emptied out his fullness in the lowly form of a servant in order to become the head in the kingdom of love, the reconciler and the redeemer. But this self-abasement must at the same time’ — here comes the proper positive explanation of the miracle — ‘be seen as his self-perfection,’ the self-perfection, namely, of the Logos that is in itself eternally perfect. Inasmuch as he, the one and same Logos, ‘lives in human fashion, and as the Son of Man possesses his Godhead only within the limitation of human individuality, in the bounded forms of human consciousness, he must indeed be said to live in abasement and poverty, since he has renounced the majestic glory in which, as the omnipresent Logos, he shines through the whole creation.’ (Dogm. § 133). If we now take note of the two expressions ‘he has renounced’ and ‘he shines through,’ and remember that it is the same, the very same Logos, the one and very same Logos-I, that has here renounced the majestic glory, which he nevertheless has not for a single moment renounced, how then could we doubt that it is precisely the higher Phlyaric, the deeper Phlyaretic, that by this explanation is posited in its positive moment.”

The result of the investigations can be held fast in the following little-edifying

reflection: "The mediation of faith and knowledge can of course only be carried through on the condition that both parties approach each other with all possible [243] diplomatic courtesy, that is, in all sincerity, disinterestedness, animated only by the warmest wishes for peace and good understanding. In the course of the mutual approach a happy change takes place in both of them: faith becomes genial, knowledge good-natured. That faith becomes genial means that it gives up its old-fashioned orthodox fastidiousness, is ashamed of what is to the Jews an offense and to the Greeks foolishness, smiles at philosophy and falls in love with speculation. It can of course be no ordinary faith, not the popular, simple faith of refuge, that behaves so charmingly; no, it is a cultured, well-bred faith, a faith that knows its mystics and has attended lectures at the Institute; only such a faith, a subjective faith with an objective heart, a faith that would not love practically if it did not love theoretically, can open its arms, its deep, dogmatic arms, to the higher knowledge. That the knowledge which is to be able, without nausea, to give itself up to so cultured, so Institute-cultured a love must absolutely be *good-natured* is surely self-evident. For here there is a difference, a very considerable difference, between the good-natured and the not good-natured knowledge. The not good-natured knowledge we may with reason call the teasing knowledge, namely the dogmatically teasing, because it always takes its pleasure in teasing dogmatics. The teasing consists quite simply in this, that it pursues with merciless consistency every contradiction into which dogmatics in its innocence has entered. Out of a couple of innocent "Must-not-be-thought"s it conjures up, with the help of the logical-physical, a demonic swarm of "Must-not-be-thought"s; by critical-dialectical witchcraft it gets the dogmatic contradictions, if we may say so, to breed. Yes, what is most outrageous: the very deepest positive, that of which [244] dogmatics expressly says that *it must be thought*, it transforms into a restless negative, a thoroughly unthinkable, a "Cannot-be-thought": that is malicious. The malicious knowledge, the knowledge that will not let go of the logical-physical, is a sinful knowledge, a knowledge that cannot say *credo, ut intelligam*, an *unbelieving* knowledge. It is otherwise with the good-natured knowledge: blessed are they who

will not criticize the good-natured knowledge. The good-natured knowledge does sometimes look somewhat thoughtless; but, by dogmatics, it is not thoughtless, for it goes about lost in thought. Why does it go about lost in thought? It is in love, subjectively in love with the objective heart of faith: it is, after all, a believing knowledge. The believing knowledge is a knowledge that longs — out beyond the logical into the supralogical: the metaphysics of miracle is the goal of its longing. If it does not reach the goal of its longing, it dies; but if it reaches the goal of its longing, it lives, lives on the positive of faith, snaps its fingers at the negative of criticism and lulls all contradictions to sleep in absolute joy over the relative mysteries. Should one or another contradiction be so unruly as to cry out from the nest of the mysteries, what does that matter? ‘The French don’t take it so precisely.’ The believing knowledge is good-natured: good-naturedly it sinks to the breast of dogmatics, good-naturedly it rests at the heart of faith. Practically, good nature is love; theoretically, love is good nature. If it must be said in the practical sphere that love covers the multitude of sins, then it must be said here, where the deepest practical is at the same time the highest theoretical, that good nature, the incredible good nature of the believing knowledge, covers the multitude of [245] contradictions. On these terms the union of faith and knowledge is accomplished; the Phlyaric is posited in speculative perfection.”

Here, then, there can be no doubt that there is a conflict in principle between my standpoint and the speculative-dogmatic one.

Then a third question arises: How does the chosen standpoint relate to the old orthodox doctrine? For when one departs from the paradox by forming a doctrinal concept, when one departs from the modern foundation by protesting against mediation, then it seems we must surely come back to the old orthodox presentation. Is this now the case? I answer: the chosen standpoint can by no means merge with the old orthodox one; for the orthodox standpoint is characterized by pointing up the concepts of faith quite rightly but motivating them very badly. What is characteristic of the concepts of faith the old dogmatics knows how to find out with rare acuteness, but it is beguiled by science and takes purely human

knowledge up into its development. Its fundamental contradiction is that it too makes the doctrine of faith into science, and the consequence is that this doctrine then in turn falls prey to scientific criticism and is dissolved by science.

In order to become science, theology must necessarily use reason; but in order to be a doctrine of faith, an orthodox doctrine of faith, it must at the same time take reason captive under the obedience of faith. To use reason is to acknowledge the consequences that follow with logical necessity from the premises set up in the name of faith; but to take reason captive, in other words, not to use reason, is to deny a consequence even though it manifestly, and with logically irrefutable necessity, follows from its premise. As a science of faith, theology is thus both [246] to acknowledge and not to acknowledge that the consequence follows from the premise, is both to use and not to use reason; this is the self-contradiction, a self-contradiction as old as theology. There is not a single dogmatic dispute in the whole history of the Church that does not bear witness to this. A more telling proof of the scientific self-contradiction of Lutheran orthodoxy than its protest against Calvin's doctrine of election can hardly be conceived. It is openly admitted that Calvin is scientifically consistent, and just as openly his consistency is condemned; and yet theology is a science!

"The beneficently inconsistent way of representing things in the Formula of Concord, in relation to the blasphemously consistent Calvinist one, is," says a Lutheran orthodox church historian, "in brief this: sanctification and salvation are according to both only a work of divine grace, damnation a consequence of one's own guilt. But whereas the Formula of Concord humbly stops at this last proposition, and therefore expressly ascribes the guilt to man alone, and not to the lack of grace ..., Calvin argues further: But that guilt occurs only because God does not here too powerfully impart his grace; but God does not here too impart his grace because from eternity he has decreed damnation, and even the fall of man has had to serve to realize this decree, just as in general everything is decreed from eternity — God has thus himself willed the sin of men. This last necessary consequence, however much it may be embellished, the Formula of

Concord especially abhors as contrary to the holiness of God and to the divine word in Scripture, although it also does not fail to recognize the difficulties in [247] the whole connection of this doctrine, which no human understanding is able to resolve.”

If, after what has been made clear here, there should be any sense in applying the laws of reason in some cases and abolishing them in others, then there would surely have to be in theological knowledge an infallible divine rule according to which the application and the abolition could be carried out. But where should we turn to find such a rule? It is no use applying to reason; for if reason itself could teach us in which cases we ought, for faith’s sake, to prefer “the humble inconsistency” and suspend the law of reason, then the application of reason would precisely be confirmed just as it was to be abolished: reason would in this way be judge in its own cause and would get an absolute dominion over faith. If, on the other hand, it is faith separated from reason, and so a faith that by its separation from reason is unreasonable, that is both to annul and to confirm the law of reason, well then faith certainly keeps an unconditional dominion over reason; but what then becomes of the scientific character of theology with this faith that is in itself unreasonable? To speak of a certain reasonable suprarational, a mystical something, which by standing both above reason and above faith should regulate the relation between them, is to talk off into the fog; for the “humble inconsistency” of the Formula of Concord proves precisely that here there is at bottom neither regulative nor consistency. In the dispute over election the Lutheran theologian solemnly declares Calvin’s “inference” to be “contrary to the holiness of God and to the divine word in Scripture.” On which side, now, is consistency? Naturally on both sides. Calvin proceeds with the Lutheran from the premise that sanctification and salvation are only a work of divine grace, and then concludes in his fashion [248] consistently that the failure of salvation must absolutely be a consequence of the failure of grace, and this failure in turn a consequence of the divine decree. The defender of the Formula of Concord proceeds with Calvin from the premise that damnation is a consequence of man’s own guilt, and then concludes from this quite

consistently that it cannot possibly be a consequence of God's eternal decree. On which side is inconsistency? Naturally on both sides. Calvin is inconsistent when he posits damnation as a consequence of sin and would make God the eternal author of damnation without, however, making him the author of sin. The defender of the Formula of Concord is inconsistent in that, in order to make God alone the author of salvation, he declares that man does indeed have the ability to resist grace when it is a matter of perdition, but on the other hand no ability to cooperate with [grace], and so no ability to resist grace when it is a matter of deliverance and salvation. The Lutheran's inconsistency consists in this, that he now adjusts the principle to the outcome, now again the outcome to the principle: if the outcome is damnation, then man has been able to resist grace, for man must himself be to blame for his damnation; if, on the other hand, the outcome is deliverance and salvation, then man has not been able to resist grace. Had man's will been able to resist saving grace, then this man's will would, precisely by not counteracting grace, have cooperated with grace. But the thought that man's will should in any way be able to cooperate with divine grace, is a synergism which the Formula of Concord can only pronounce upon with condemnation.

If now both, the strict Calvinist and the strict Lutheran, are equally consistent and equally inconsistent, then it is surely impossible for science to award the one the advantage over the other. On what, then, does Lutheran theology ground its [249] advantage over the Reformed? Not on its consistent character (for it itself admits its inconsistency); nor directly on its inconsistency, but on what is humbling in the inconsistency, and so on humility. When the Calvinist is inconsistent, the Lutheran is permitted to use his reason, appeal to logic and hold to consistency, for what is the Calvinist inconsistency but an unscientific self-contradiction, a dogmatic prostitution? But when the Lutheran is not merely caught, but manifestly catches himself, in notorious inconsistency: what is it then? Why, then it is not self-contradiction, not scientific prostitution, but humility, pure, sheer, theological humility. And what, then, is the Calvinist's consistency? Naturally pride, sheer pride, the ungodly conceit of uncircumcised reason, of the unregenerate

understanding.

If at least we could in the end descry a sign, a mark, an unfailing distinguishing mark by which one were able in a scientific manner to distinguish between the unscientific, and so prostituting, and the humble, and so not prostituting, inconsistencies: then shipwrecked theology might perhaps still hope for a plank of rescue; but where do we find such a distinguishing mark? "In Holy Scripture," the Lutheran answers; "for Holy Scripture is God's word, and it stands expressly in Holy Scripture: God will have all men to be saved and to come unto the knowledge of the truth." The Calvinist's pride is thus seen from this, that his consistency is in conflict with God's word. But it also stands expressly in Holy Scripture that "God hath mercy on whom he will have mercy, and whom he will he hardeneth." If we now proceed from the latter passage, then the Calvinist's consistency becomes [250] humble, while the Lutheran's inconsistency, by coming into open conflict with the word of Scripture: "Nay but, O man, who art thou that repliest against God? Shall the thing formed say to him that formed it, Why hast thou made me thus? Hath not the potter power over the clay, of the same lump to make one vessel unto honor, and another unto dishonor?" — is transformed and becomes a sign, not of humility, but of pride, *the* most outrageous pride, the pride of wishing to reply against God and deny him the right from eternity to elect — "one vessel unto honor, another unto dishonor." This must suffice to illuminate the original fundamental contradiction of orthodox theology.

This fundamental contradiction must be kept sharply in view if one would understand the relation between orthodox theology and the rationalism that followed.

Rationalism, however much it conflicts with orthodox doctrine, has developed as a scientific consequence of orthodoxy's own method. Had orthodoxy not called to its aid what it called reason, captive reason, so that it fell into the contradiction of making use of reason and yet holding it captive, rationalism would never have penetrated into the Church. This, as already indicated, I have sought to clarify in a little work, "Om Holbergs Kirkehistorie og Theologie, et Bidrag fra Fortiden til

at belyse Nutiden,” from which work I will further bring forward the following: All knowledge and science is in its essence rational; here no confessional charters are tolerated, no high-priestly guardianship ... without reason the Church could not possibly erect its edifice of doctrine; reason was thus the real master builder, and the master builder the only one who knew the technique and could assess the durability of the building. Certainly reason had not from the beginning erected the great building either on its own initiative or on its own account; it was, on the contrary, forced labor and at faith’s expense; the faith of the Church was, if we [251] may use this image, the real owner of the building. Had the owner now wished to secure himself forever against the demolition of the building, then faith, like that barbarous despot who, by having the master murdered, secured himself against another still more glorious masterpiece being erected, would have had to secure itself against reason’s tearing down the old half-timbering, clearing the site and erecting a new, solidly walled building in a new style, by getting reason strangled. But for such a misdeed the faith of the Church, however despotically it otherwise behaved, had neither courage nor strength. So it came about that reason, as soon as it had finished the edifice of doctrine on faith’s account, immediately began to tear it down again on its own account.

Since now, as is well known, work goes on inside a building just as much when it is being torn down as when it is being built up, it easily looked to those standing outside as if the work of demolition which reason carried out on the old theological building at the end of the 18th and the beginning of the 19th century was the work not merely of the theologians but of theology, as if the process of dissolution that destroyed theology were a reformation that theology, with inner consistency and from its own scientific impulse, accomplished upon itself: a great literary illusion of the senses! The time of theology lies behind Holberg; the busy thoughts we meet in him are a demolition corps that he has just assembled and set to work. When, then, the reason that had begun its work on its own outside the theological faculty gradually, though not without considerable resistance and all manner of trouble, obtained an appointment in the faculty, what happened

then? Did it perhaps end with the theologians, after having let reason continue
[252] the work of dissolution for somewhat more than a generation in the faculty itself, arriving at more positive results than Holberg? No, it ended with a purging of the old leaven of orthodoxy down to the last remnant; it ended with a pure, clear, altogether water-clear rationalism.

In the spiritless sensibleness of rationalism the life of faith perished. Therefore on the side of faith what was needed was a break, not merely with a worldliness in which a doctrine of utility smeared out into trivialities had effaced every trace of the ideal, but first and last with a churchliness whose edifying discourses might well distinguish themselves even by recommending the use of church towers as windmills and, quite *con amore*, varying Master Mannegrim's favorite themes: superstition and crop rotation and stall-feeding with potatoes. On these terms the protests had to become sharp, and even the judgment on Holberg fall stern and severe; for, it cannot be denied: with Holberg rationalism makes its appearance in Denmark.

At the beginning of our century what was needed was something more than becoming a little witty in a spiritless age; what was needed was to seize the banner of faith, break with the nature of unbelief and make the break so deep and incurable that it could never again be healed. So a break was made with all the powers of the age, made for faith's sake in the name of the congregation; it came to battle, inspired battle for the right of life, for the light of spirit, "for the riddle in the word divine that creates what it names, that fills the valleys round about on earth, and levels the rocks." What was needed was not to come to terms with the formal enlightenment, adorn oneself with the charms of reason and get oneself a halo by recommending a new middle way; no, the time of middle ways was past; what was needed was a breakthrough. Had it been the task, in an ingenious, supple
[253] manner agreeable to the cultured, to smuggle in a quantum satis of the old faith without offending the new reason: then a tasteful oratorical fusion of much that is subjective with something objective, a little mysticism and a little philosophy, a little John and a little Jacobi, would have been fully sufficient. But here something

more was at stake; what was needed was precisely not to glide over knotty places, but to press on the plow and plow so deep that the sprouting seed-corn could take root, and the congregation see its fruitful ground with the holy springs. The enlightened age, to be sure, held that a reawakening of the simple faith of the fathers was as much a popular impossibility as a scientific absurdity; but the enlightened age was mistaken. The old faith rose up “like ears of corn in the field, like May in the beech woods”; it really rose up again, to everyone’s astonishment. An Easter morning, yes, how incomprehensible, an Easter morning gave the dead life: “an Easter morning came and took — the black cross from the grave.”

In the last words connoisseurs will hear an echo of the Grundtvigian tones and see the mighty figure in the background. Thus the break has taken place, essentially and from the ground up. With the break, dualism is posited; but the personal unity of consciousness is by no means broken on that account. Far from it! It is precisely the highest intellectual task of personality to recognize the worth that must be ascribed to science and yet hold fast the ideal demands that proceed from faith. The investigations belonging here are to be carried out not in any theology — for theology must go — but rather in a philosophy of religion.

“But what, then, is philosophy of religion? To what sphere must it be reckoned? Insofar as philosophy of religion is a science, it must naturally belong to the domain of knowledge; but insofar as it has religion for its content, it must orient us in [254] the sphere of faith. By this two-sided task its two-sided character as a *boundary science* is determined. The philosophizing consciousness is, as goes without saying, the subjective medium in which the heterogeneous concepts meet; from this it follows that the unity of consciousness must presuppose a formal unity of concept corresponding to the determination of the boundary, that, in other words, the absolutely heterogeneous concepts must in the boundary itself become formally homogeneous. What such a formal homogeneity has to signify can easily be shown. We speak of absolutely heterogeneous principles, but a principle is, after all, *in abstracto* always a principle. We speak of heterogeneous cognitions, heterogeneous concepts, etc.; but when we abstract from what is peculiar, cognition = cognition,

concept = concept.

As a boundary science, philosophy of religion gets its concepts of faith from the life of faith and its concepts of knowledge from science. In the latter respect it becomes apparent what a logical theism has to signify; in the former respect it depends on religious psychology. It is of no use for the philosopher of religion to try to help science along with assurances about his own faith, his own individual experiences. The question here is not where the philosopher has his experiences from; the question here is the psychological value of the experiences in their relation to the principle of faith. The apparent contradiction, that philosophy of religion on the conditions set out must become a science that treats both of what falls *outside* and of what falls *inside* science, is easily removed. Should anyone maintain that there cannot possibly be a knowledge of a cognition of faith when the cognition of faith by its nature is to fall outside knowledge, let him then begin [255] at the beginning and maintain the impossibility of there being a consciousness of the earth when the real earth by its nature is to fall outside consciousness. An objection such as that the concepts of faith, by being reflected in knowledge, must absolutely become concepts of knowledge, signifies nothing; the task of science is precisely to know the heterogeneous as heterogeneous.” (Den gode Villie. pp. 136–37).

XV.

As often as there is talk of the spiritual life, its conditions, requirements and obstacles, in particular of the conflict between faith and knowledge, so often must we think of Luther's words: Faith is a restless thing. And which of the Church's great teachers could say this with stronger emphasis than Luther himself? It was faith that gave him peace! Yes, but faith also prepared a struggle for him, a struggle that lasted his whole life through, a struggle first in the inward and then in the outward as well. In the darkness of night, in dread of the world and of himself, the young man flees to the Augustinian monastery in Erfurt, knocks and is let in. One would now think that he who, with a thunderstorm behind him, went in at the monastery door escaped the storms of life, the unrest of the world, and entered into peace; but it was not so. He entered not into peace but into strife, the most terrible strife, strife with himself and with God, strife in conscience, strife with doubt in order to win faith. And when he had won faith, when he recognized that it was not by papal good works but by faith alone that a man is justified, how does he then characterize faith? Does he perhaps say that in faith there is nothing but peace, and that it costs strife and unrest only before one reaches faith? No, of the faith that gives peace, of just that faith, he says that it is a restless thing. And it went on being so for him. For it was not enough for him to have won peace in his own inner being. What had given him inward peace wanted to come forth on his lips, wanted to be proclaimed with his mighty voice; then the strife began in the outward. When the tempest then came in the outward, when for faith's sake he found himself in the midst of the stream of events, in the midst of the wild struggle,

roared about by storms, then he surely had to say with strengthened emphasis: Faith is a restless thing.

Luther's words about faith as a restless thing are confirmed in the history of the Church from first to last. It is known to those versed in the matter how the ancient Church under bloody persecutions fought its way forward to victory. In the time of dangers, when the persecutions truly raged against the Christians, then the strength of faith grew, then more and more came forward with ever-rising enthusiasm, not only vigorous men but youths, women and old men, all with frank confession, all prepared to sacrifice their lives in the name of the Crucified. If, on the other hand, the Church had had peace for a time, then slackness was felt. The longer the interval had been in which faith was, as it were, on the point of becoming a restful thing, so that one could arrange oneself with it too for comfort and well-being, the less prepared one was when the storm suddenly broke loose. Under the Decian and later under the Diocletian persecutions so many fell away precisely because the Church had had peace too long.

That faith is and must always be a restless thing follows directly from its being the highest personal concern and, as the highest personal concern, grounded in a dualistic consciousness. Or could perhaps the opposition between the worldly and the holy, between the flesh and the spirit, between the old and the new man, ever [258] in the world cease to be dualistic? It is another matter that the dualism can show itself differently at different times, and the personal strife in consequence take on a different appearance.

It makes, as regards the restlessness, a very considerable difference whether the strife is outward-going or merely inward-going, whether it is waged on barbarous, half-barbarous or humane terms.

The time of the persecutions was for the first confessors a barbarous time; under the first immediate opposition between Christianity and paganism the decisive trial of faith had necessarily to be: to be able to sacrifice one's life for the confession of Christ's name; the ideal was to become a blood-witness. So glowing was the spirit, so flaming the holy passion, that the craving for the martyr's crown

even became a kind of vain point of honor. The Redeemer's words: "Fear not them which kill the body, but are not able to kill the soul," found ample fulfillment: the young "soldiers" of faith went bravely into the fire. But however magnificent the testimonies to the power of spirit and the victory of freedom that came forth in this way, the fulfillment of the first elementary fundamental demand was nevertheless not sufficient for an all-round development of the spiritual life as a whole. An unceasing continuation of persecutions and blood-witnesses would surely have led, not to higher personal self-understanding, but to wild enthusiasm and dark fanaticism. The excesses of the Montanists and the Donatists bear witness to this.

It was, then, for the sake of the development of spirit, to the benefit of religion as much as of culture, of the new man as well as of the old, that the Church at last got outward peace.

But merely outward peace could not bring rest, for faith is a restless thing. The outward resistance in inflamed paganism now transformed itself into an inward resistance in heresies and sectarianism. If during the persecutions it had been the most essential condition for eternal salvation to be able to sacrifice one's life for the faith, then now, after the persecutions had ceased, it became an inescapable condition to secure the separation between the true and the false faith. Hereby not only the passions but also the thoughts were set in motion. The violent dogmatic disputes in the Greek Church from the fourth to the eighth century were all waged on half-barbarous terms. The jealousy of the bishops, the fanaticism of the monks, the passions of the people and the emperor's words of power give the course of development so worldly a direction that the Church's doctrinal concept seems bound to become a simple product of human arbitrariness; and yet a development of ideas takes place. As the many voices are heard, and all means are employed, arbitrariness falls away: through the din of strife the spirit of the Church moves forward with inner assurance toward a consistent shaping of the content of faith.

It is a first step on the way of thinking for oneself that the Church gets its propositions of faith set up and brought into a system. But precisely with this first step it made a false step that brought it to apostasy from the apostolic way of

thinking: in the further formation of the doctrinal concept it came onto the way of objective knowledge, it got theology founded.

Through theology the doctrine became outwardly objective in the same sense as a positive legislation can be said to be outwardly objective; through the favor that Christianity on the whole enjoyed from the emperors from the time of Constantine the Great, the Church's position in the State likewise became outwardly objective: the emphasis falls in all directions on the objective, the outwardly objective.

The main thing in the outwardly objective is that the Church gets a doctrinal concept of dogmas fixed once and for all; for by such a doctrinal concept its ideal [260] subsistence "through changing ages" is far better secured than by the congregations' "uncertain and fluctuating, poorly guaranteed" appropriation of the spirit of the Gospel according to the merely apostolic confession of faith. The main thing is — in the outwardly objective — "that the Church's revenues are in grain value according to the capitular price assessment, and that the Church possesses landed estates"; for by the Church's possessing landed estates "its material subsistence through changing ages is far better secured than by uncertain and fluctuating, poorly guaranteed money matters." The main thing is that the whole ecclesiastical system, spiritual as well as temporal, comes to rest in the objective. But faith is a restless thing.

Why, now, was it precisely necessary that to the apostolic confession of faith there should be added the Nicene, concerning the Son's unity of essence with, and eternal generation from, the Father; to this in turn the Constantinopolitan, concerning the three hypostases in one essence; to this in turn the Chalcedonian, concerning Christ's two natures, which must neither merge together nor keep apart; to this in turn the confession of Christ's two wills, etc.? Why, we say, was such a heaping up of subtle dogmatic determinations, whose interpretation and grounding had to require superhuman acuteness, necessary at all, unless to give faith a truly intricate, entangled and learned foundation? Why should faith have so intricate, entangled and learned a foundation? Naturally for the sake of objectivity, so that the teachers, standing on this objectively firm foundation,

could through changing ages with force and vigor interpret to the simple believers Christ's words: I thank thee, O Father, because thou hast hid these things from the wise and prudent, and hast revealed them unto babes! And why must the Church now absolutely have its revenues in grain value according to the capitular price assessment? Why must it for its material subsistence necessarily possess landed [261] estates (Patrimonium Petri)? Naturally for the sake of objectivity, so that Christ's vicars through changing ages might know themselves secured! How should the preachers of the Word be able to give the believers comfort against cares for temporal things if they did not themselves feel secured against temporal cares; but how should they feel secured, how should they with full confidence interpret the words of the Gospel: "Take no thought for the morrow, for the morrow shall take thought for the things of itself," if they did not know within themselves that through changing ages they received their ecclesiastical revenues in grain value according to the capitular price assessment? "Consider the lilies of the field!" Yes, but when the Church has no landed estates, then it has no fields, and when it has no fields, then it has no lilies either. Were a preacher of the Gospel through changing ages, without fields and without lilies, to be secured only by uncertain and fluctuating, poorly guaranteed money matters, how then could he with a calm mind go out and consider the lilies of the field!

There are different ways of considering the lilies of the field. It is one thing to consider them from the standpoint of the Gospel, another to consider them — according to the capitular price assessment; one is the consideration of the new man, another that of the old; the two considerations are absolutely heterogeneous; the absolutely heterogeneous considerations make consciousness dualistic! the dualistic consciousness makes faith a restless thing.

But is it not, then, a law of civilization that human society is to work its way forward to order and rest? We answer: it is not only a law of civilization but also a law of religion; only one must fundamentally distinguish between order [262] and rest in civil society and order and rest in religious society. Just because in religious society a different spirit must reign from the one that reigns on human

terms in civil society, order and rest must also be brought about by other means and on other conditions in religious than in civil affairs. In civil society laws of compulsion hold, in religious society laws of freedom. It is a crude confusion of laws of freedom with laws of compulsion that makes the medieval spirit of the Church half-barbarous.

On the hierarchy and the papal power the great order of things, civil as well as religious, was to be grounded in the West. All, great and small, laymen and learned, were religiously and civilly interested in there being able to rise above the confusion an ordering, governing power, an established order capable of holding unrest down and, in human fashion, in the name of the holy, of stifling the revolt of thoughts; but faith is a restless thing. In the name of faith and for faith's sake the papal Church got the great tracts of land, the many temporal goods with their many glories, so that Christ's kingdom might truly be glorified in the visible; but the enjoyment of these glories had such questionable consequences for the faith of the clergy that an Arnold of Brescia took it deeply to heart and the Fraticelli despaired over it. Unrest came, moreover, from another side. In the name of faith and for faith's sake the Church at last got such supremacy over the State that Innocent III could compare the papacy with the sun and the empire with the moon, which gets its light from the sun. But the same tendency of spirit that gave the Church political power also tempted the hierarchy to misuse the power. When [263] the Pope, in passionate struggle against Germany's medieval Emperor, had struck the Hohenstaufens to the ground, he came, as is well known, into dependence on France, which was striving politically forward toward a new order of things, and as a consequence had to bring himself to leave his eternal Rome and move to Avignon. Thus began what church history calls the Babylonian captivity of the Pope, or the Exile. The consequence of the Exile was the great papal Schism; the consequence of the Schism was an enormous offense. Pope stood up against Pope, Pope condemned Pope; to whom was Christendom to hold? Yes, faith is a restless thing. The unrest went not only outward in disputes about the worldly, it went also inward in disputes about the spiritual, in the mutual strife of thoughts about the

eternal truths. The thoughts of knowledge from a classical, pagan culture were to be reconciled with the thoughts of faith in the Church's dogmas; Greek philosophy was, in the name of theology, to spread the light of reason over the mysteries of revelation; Aristotle, a Christian before Christ (*Christianus ante Christum*), was supposed already to have comprehended everything in the Church's doctrine that could be comprehended. So there was reasoning and disputing; in the universities of scholasticism and dialectic men contended and fenced in knightly fashion as at a tournament. During this continued feud many were restless, some on behalf of knowledge, others on behalf of faith.

The unrest increased when at last, after the conquest of Constantinople, amid the steadily growing interest in science that characterizes the period of Italy's history called the age of the humanists, men more and more immersed themselves in the classics, and so also in Plato and Aristotle. Then it became clear that here there must be two systems of cognition: one in philosophy, the Greek-classical, grounded on reason; another in theology, the orthodox-ecclesiastical, resting on the authority of the Pope. These two could not be reconciled; therefore certain thinkers, who did not dare break with the Church while on the other hand they [264] would not give up philosophy either, sought to escape the impending danger by proclaiming a doctrine of two truths, a philosophical and a theological. If only they might have their philosophical truths in peace, they were willing in every way, as regards authority and faith, to bow beneath the doctrine of the Church. So Pomponatius in the 16th century and Vanini in the 17th. But it did not work. Pomponatius discovered that the classical Aristotle had quite another doctrine of the nature and immortality of the soul than the scholastic one. The scholastic Aristotle was supposed to agree with the doctrine of the Church and furnish proof of the immortality of the soul; the classical one, on the contrary, furnished precisely proof of the mortality of the natural soul. The Inquisition was set in motion; Pomponatius was saved through the intervention of powerful friends (cardinals), but Vanini was burned. They burned the confessor of the two truths, and at that point in time it was quite natural.

It is understandable that the Catholic Church could not be content with that division of truth; for our part, we cannot either. If the division were to mean anything, it would have to be understood thus, that only philosophy was science and theology a self-contradictory monstrosity; but for such a break with the dogmatic science of miracle the time had not yet come. That conflict, then, was also soon succeeded by one far more deep-going. It came so far that the truth of faith became divided against itself at the Reformation. What happens? Out of the old Church's bosom a new Church proceeds, and yet the old Church does not die. So Church stands against Church, each with its doctrine of faith. What is true in [265] Protestantism is untrue in Catholicism, and conversely. If the Catholic's faith was true, then the Protestant's was untrue. So one could then see that faith is a restless thing.

The unrest went further still. As the evangelical Protestant Church broke with the papal Catholic one, it was split again dualistically into two great oppositions: the Lutheran and the Reformed type, with the traditions belonging to them. Indeed, the splitting went so far that the Catholic Church even became divided against itself, as the Jesuit Pelagianizing tendency set about stifling the Augustinian. The forces were set in motion: assertion stood against assertion, passion against passion, word of power against word of power; but the principle of faith itself was not clarified, the thought of faith not developed.

The evangelical Protestant fundamental thought, as it was apprehended and held fast by Luther himself, would surely have been carried through far more consistently, and the conflict with the papists as well as with the Reformed would have led to a different result, had not the theological *idée fixe* intervened that the dogmas ought after all, at least to a certain degree, to be explained and grounded scientifically. We see it from the disputes over the Supper. Against the Catholic doctrine of transubstantiation Luther set the words of institution. But then Carlstadt comes forward and twists the words of institution, because he cannot comprehend how it is possible that Christ's body and blood can be in bread and wine, whereas he can quite well comprehend that Christ, pointing to his body, may have said:

this is my body, and thereupon, pointing to the bread, added: take this — the bread, which is not my body — etc. What Luther would answer to this had already been stated in his work on the Babylonian captivity of the Church, in which he says: “Truly, if I cannot comprehend how the bread is Christ’s body, yet I will take my understanding captive and hold simply and solely to his word.” What he adds by way of elucidation: “If iron and fire, two substances, are so united in the one [266] glowing iron that every part is iron and fire, why then should not the body of the almighty God-man, the glorified Lord, much more be able to be in the substance of the consecrated bread?” is certainly not put forward as any dogmatic grounding. “No reason,” says Luther in his “Manifesto against the heavenly prophets,” “is so feeble that it would not rather believe that plain bread and wine are present here than that Christ’s flesh and blood are hidden here. For that one needs no spirit; it is easy for anyone to believe, and nothing more is needed here than that someone who has a little standing is bold enough to preach it, and he already has disciples enough. But if one will deal with our faith in such a way that we first put our own preconceived opinion into Scripture and then twist it according to our mind and look only to what is straightforward for the common darkened understanding, then no article of faith will remain standing; for there is not one in Scripture that God has not set above reason.” — So here, then, according to Luther’s express testimony, there is dualism of faith and reason: faith is a restless thing.

Luther was right, he felt it deeply; it was this feeling that made him so strong in confession, so bitter in strife. Yes, certainly Luther was right; modern Christendom is hardly conscious of what the Church owes to the man who on this point stood so hard upon the words of the text and defied a world with the Gospel of faith. Yes, Luther was right, yet not as theologian but as priest. His conception of the Supper is explained precisely by his having originally seen the sacrament not with the theologian’s but with the priest’s eye. What Luther as theologian put forward about the doctrine of the Supper is significant only for his time; his theologumena are vanishing, but his priestly testimonies will remain as long as faith is — faith. [267]

Luther himself was not clear about the relation in principle between religion

and theology. The new doctrine needed the assistance of science; Melancthon was a theologian, and the theologian then thought that Calvin was right, for Calvin was, after all, a theologian too. But the Lutheran Church, which was unconditionally right in faith, now wanted at the same time to be unconditionally right in theology as well, and so it went from bad to worse. Lutheran theology worked itself weary in unspeculative speculations, and has long since had to see its favorite theories of *communication idiomatum* and *ubiquitas corporis Christi* given over to dissolving criticism. (Evangelietr. og Theolog. pp. 117–118.)

Already at the end of the 17th century there had formed *two altogether opposed views; according to the one of these one should give up outright the connection of faith and reason, religion and science; according to the other one should defend and assert it by all possible scientific means*. The first-named view in turn took two directions, in that on the one side one confined oneself to operating scientifically by pointing out contradictions and awakening doubt, on the other side conceived religion practically as life and relied on feeling; the representative of the first direction is Bayle, of the latter Spener.

In Bayle's historical and critical dictionary (*Dictionnaire historique et critique*) the conflict between faith and knowledge, religion and science, is pointed out with great acuteness. The dogma wants to be believed but not comprehended; *it is and must be a mystery to human reason*. "The secrets of revelation belong [268] to a supernatural realm; they rest on the highest authority, the authority of God, and he has not set them before us so that we should comprehend them, but so that we should believe them with all the humble submission that we owe to the infallible highest Being. The incompatibility of revelation and philosophy makes it necessary to choose between the two and to decide for one of them. He who will believe nothing but what is clear and in agreement with common notions, let him seize philosophy and let Christianity go; for it is impossible to possess clarity and incomprehensibility at once; the union of these two things is no less impracticable than finding the quadrature of the circle. He for whom a round table is not convenient, let him have a square one made; but he must not demand

that one and the same table shall afford him the conveniences of both a round and a square table.” Bayle pleads with equal facility now the cause of faith, now that of reason. In favor of faith he adduces: “In order not to grasp blindly in the choice, one must make oneself closely acquainted with the nature of both sides, of faith and of science. At first glance, when one hears that faith is a certainty whose object remains obscure, but that science, on the other hand, besides giving certainty, also makes what is known clear and distinct, it would seem as if the decided advantage were on the side of science. But science comes about through reason, and what if reason should not be equal to such a task? But this is in reality the case; reason is only a principle of destruction, not of edification; it knows better what things are not than what they are; it is fit only for awakening doubt and for twisting to right and left so as to draw out the dispute into infinity. It is a vagabond who cannot come to rest, a Penelope who continually unravels her own web. It is [269] good only for bringing to men’s consciousness the darkness in which they grope, their incapacity to work their way out of it, and the need for a revelation.” For reason he adduces: “There are principles against which doctrines of Holy Scripture, however expressly and definitely stated, would be unable to accomplish anything, as for example the principles that the whole is greater than a part of it, that two mutually opposed propositions cannot possibly both be true, and the like. This the orthodox theologians of all confessions also concede, in that they do not admit that the Trinity and the Incarnation are dogmas that contain a self-contradiction; whereby they in fact acknowledge reason as the highest court, since they do not believe that a dogma is sufficiently secure unless it is, so to speak, registered and formally ratified by the supreme court of reason. God willed to bestow on the soul an infallible means of distinguishing the true from the false, and this means is the natural light, the metaphysical principles, in which we possess an original rule by which we can distinguish whether the various doctrines we find in books or hear expounded by our teachers are correct or incorrect. The only criterion of truth we therefore have in the agreement of objects with this universal and original light which God has poured out into the souls of all men.”

One would now suppose that such deeply penetrating discussions must especially have attracted the attention of the theologians, since it is manifestly the scientific standing of theology that is at stake here. This was indeed also partly the case in other countries, notably in Holland, where a Clericus came forward against Bayle; but it was by no means the case in Denmark. In Denmark the theologians, after all, had enough on their hands day to day; what should they want with [270] investigations of principle in general science? Bayle's scribblings were, after all, an ungodly business, some philosophical trumpery that did not concern God-fearing men. Certainly they had an uneasy feeling that the time was not favorable to them, that something here was amiss; but where the trouble lay, they did not comprehend. It must be the wickedness of the world, the unbelief of the generation and the age, the pride of reason; so they easily agreed to regard the many uneasy phenomena, however diverse these otherwise were, as manifestations of one and the same ungodly nature. Whatever did not agree with their theological views was, under the most diverse designations, lumped together in one single great heap of heretics. Naturalists, indifferentists, syncretists, atheists, pietists — Pontoppidan, out of sheer godliness, does not even dare write the blasphemous names out in full, but abbreviates them to A . . . ists and P . . . ists — fanatics, enthusiasts, deists and rationalists fly about one's ears when one starts stirring in the heap. So the theologians went round in the old treadmill, and the old treadmill went as best it could. (Om Holbergs Kirkehistorie og Theol. pp. 41–43.)

If the difficulties could be blown away by the theologians' shutting their eyes so as not to see them, then they would long since have been blown away; so the partridge no doubt thinks that by sticking its head in a hole in the stubble it becomes invisible to the hunter; but fact is always fact. If theology does not have its opposition outside itself, then it has it within itself. The old orthodoxy held on to faith by fighting against reason; that was dualism. Theological rationalism held on to reason by fighting against faith; that too was dualism. Dualism recurs under the most diverse shapes; even the separation between faith and faith, between [271] faith in revelation and faith of reason, is, after all, dualistic. We see it in Strausz.

“Although Strausz, by assuming a faith of reason, is not yet quite clear about the relation between rationalism and philosophy, between the religion of reason and science, it is nevertheless clear that his faith of reason suits only those he calls the knowing, not the believing. ‘Here,’ he says, ‘is a gulf fixed between two classes of human society, the knowing and the people, i.e. those who do not philosophize, in the higher as well as in the lower estates, and it will perhaps never be filled ... So let the believer let the knower, as the latter the former, go his way in peace; we let them keep their faith, so they must also let us keep our philosophy; and if the overweeningly pious should succeed in excluding us from their church, we shall count it a gain; of false attempts at union enough has now been done; only a sharpening of the oppositions can lead further.’ With this the dualism, the dualism between religion and science pointed out by Bayle, and with it the invalidity of theology, is pronounced as the result of our century’s scientific testing.

And with that, our learned theologians will perhaps say, it is supposed to be proved that the death sentence on theology has been irrevocably passed. Who does not now see that the juxtaposition of Bayle and Strausz proves precisely the opposite. Bayle, and with him numerous freethinkers, were in their time just as sure of the so-called dualism, i.e. of the insurmountable gulf between faith and knowledge, as Strausz, with numerous other freethinkers both hidden and open, may be in our time. Nevertheless it came about that faith and knowledge, under a constantly advancing theological science, went on working together a good century after Bayle: what now, we ask, should prevent faith and knowledge, once [272] the passing day’s paradoxical squalls with “stray thoughts, aphorisms, notions and flashes” have gone by and it clears up again in the heaven of the sciences, from continuing to work together on new terms in a new century and giving theology a new shape? Experience surely teaches that one should not be in a hurry to declare a scientific standpoint, still less a science that has the prescription of centuries, something absolutely overcome: *multa renascuntur, quæ jam cecidere, caduntque, quæ nunc sunt* etc. — Reflections of this nature strongly recall the well-known: *qui nimium probat, nihil probat*. By adducing limited truths in limitless generality

one ends either in the meaningless or in the trivial. Insofar as all things in the world go up and down, theology must naturally go up and down. — Theological consolations of this sort strongly recall the people's wise fool, who always laughed when the road went uphill, because after an adversity going up there must follow a prosperity going down; or, perhaps better still, the drunken poet who, when everything was going round, stood still with the key and waited for the door to come to him in due course, without his needing, in his infallibility, to change standpoint. Theology has long gone up and down, down and up, as in a swing; but precisely because theology has sat so long in the swing, it has now at last, despite the many alternations in movements and oscillations, become possible to trace its path and determine the equation of the curve.

If we compare the dualism of religion and science as it appears in Bayle with the dualism as it has come to a breakthrough in more recent times, then it is clear that the latter is more than a simple repetition of the former. When Bayle set religion and philosophy against each other, he took, without further ado, [273] religion as it then existed in the Church's confessional writings, in theologically positive, determinate form. In his time it had not yet become clear to the thinker what would happen when one broke the crystallized forms, melted down the religious and recast the content in another form; it had, in other words, not yet dawned on scientific consciousness how the matter would look when the content of faith took on the form of the concept. To carry out the labors of this great experiment in melting down and recasting required no less than a whole century, the period between Bayle and Hegel. Hegel's philosophy of religion is the deepest consequence of rationalism, its transformation into science proper. But scarcely was the transformation carried through before it stood clear to the knower as to the believer that faith is not knowledge, religion not science. The last glimmer of faith of reason, an afterglow of the old rationalism, which Strausz still let remain in his doctrine of faith, has vanished in the name of knowledge in L. Feuerbach, in the name of faith in S. Kierkegaard. Kierkegaard and Feuerbach, however diametrically opposed they are, are both agreed in declaring the characters of

religion and science incompatible.” — Even if knowledge can come to rest in the idea, faith nevertheless cannot come to rest in knowledge: faith is a restless thing.

But — it is asked — will not the whole ecclesiastical edifice of doctrine collapse; will not the religious representations fall into ferment and much confusion; will not the foundation necessary for the clergy’s more thorough culture, higher development of spirit and freer overview of the people’s religious and civic conditions be undermined, when the scientific preparatory school is closed, when, in other words, theology is thrown on the scrap heap? No, let us think of a reform of theological study, if such a thing is really needed at present; there is sense in that; [274] but to want to abolish theology as theology is a crazy notion, a project that may perhaps find acceptance with those who want disturbance and unrest, but not with those who want peace and order.

To meet such objections, we must first and last be agreed with ourselves about what theology is, or rather, gives itself out to be: that theology expressly gives itself out to be a science, an outright science of faith, a science of the supernatural, the suprascientific, the miracle, that it is thus a self-contradictory science of miracle; that what is self-contradictory in theological science is only veiled and concealed by its having an apparatus of historical, philological, dogmatic, metaphysical, semi-metaphysical components for use and critical treatment, insofar as there can be talk of objective use by subjective judgment and critical treatment without principle. This is the contradiction, an age-old, ingrown fundamental contradiction, which must be completely laid bare and brought forth if we are to understand properly what theology is.

“Although philology, criticism and history, which in and for themselves belong to science, constitute components of theology, they by no means constitute what is theological in theology. Insofar as the disciplines named are treated scientifically, they are treated untheologically; insofar, on the other hand, as they are treated theologically, they are treated unscientifically. What is theological in theology is known, namely, by this: that the cause from which all effects in the realm of nature as in that of spirit are derived and explained, partly immediately, partly mediately,

is sought not in the nature of things or the essence of reason, but in the absolute will, in the Almighty, who creates out of nothing. But even the purest, most acute
 [275] and most consistent application of such a principle (occasionalism; Malebranche) makes science unscientific. — When a principle is at issue in the theory of science, the matter cannot be settled by a more or less, as if someone, by following “the middle way,” would think that one could still get through scientifically by assuming a little of the supernatural, provided only one did not make too much of it. The question of a principle is a question of an unconditioned presupposition that conditions everything; such a question must therefore always be answered with yes or no. Either, then, theology must once and for all avow supernatural causality, and has thereby at once repudiated the objectively rational foundation, or else once and for all avow this foundation, and has thereby at once renounced every footing in the supernatural. In the first case theology will thus cease to be science, in the latter case to be theology.” (Cf. *Philosoph. Propædeutik*. Copenhagen 1857. pp. 70—80).

A glance at the spiritual conditions of the present age teaches that the theologians’ many-colored dogmatics are no longer able to master the contradictions breaking in in ever-growing numbers and with renewed strength, or to give the religious instruction of the people any firm, universally valid foundation. A revision of the doctrine of faith in its entirety, a development and presentation of the essence of Christianity that could show how the personal truths in their mutual connection proceed from one single principle, valid in itself, must surely be said to be needed as far as religious thinking is concerned. But if such a revision is to be carried through, then theology must go; for theology botches the principle. If a younger generation of popular teachers of religion is to find the right tone, hit the right mark and, with the spiritual superiority that only assurance in thinking can
 [276] give the preachers of the Word, stand up against a reflecting cultural consciousness: then a stricter preparatory school, expressly designed for the solution of life’s tasks, is altogether necessary. On theological terms such a preparatory school is impossible: if the priests are to come forward, the theologians must go; for

theology botches the principle.

With the dualism of faith and knowledge there is no danger when those whose calling it is to proclaim the word of faith have first learned to think the thoughts of faith. But to think the thoughts of faith is not possible without essential insight into the corresponding thoughts of knowledge. Even if the knowing have hitherto neglected to think through the principle of faith, the spokesmen of faith must above all see to it that they do not in return neglect to think through the principle of knowledge. Only when it comes so far that the believing thinker can truthfully say to the knower: I understand you well enough, but you do not yet understand me — only then will the superiority be reached that can be reached by the way of reflection for the benefit of faith. Will faith then at once be secured? No, for faith is more than a thinking; its unrest is more than an unrest of thoughts, it is also an unrest of hearts: faith is a restless thing.

The unrest of faith, however, does not stem from its principle but from the natural frailty of believing individualities. When even a Paul (Phil. III, 13–14) must say to the Philippians: “Brethren, I count not myself to have apprehended. But this one thing I do: forgetting those things which are behind, and reaching forth unto those things which are before, I press toward the mark,” he speaks in “fear and trembling” of the unrest of faith and of the struggle of personality for the holy ideal; but when he then, as in the Epistle to the Romans (VIII, 37–39), adds: “Nay, in all these things we are more than conquerors through him that loved us. For I am persuaded, that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor powers, nor things present, nor things to come, nor height, nor depth, nor any [277] other creature, shall be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord” — then he speaks of the assurance in which the unrest is annulled, the ground of inwardness in which the believing mind finds rest. At no time in the temporal can the doubleness of rest and unrest disappear without faith itself disappearing; but the incessantly continuing strife can be waged on ever more humane terms.

From many sides and in many ways the powers of faith have been tried; from

the first persecution of the Christians right up to the latest Jesuit-reactionary attempts to root out the last shoots of evangelical freedom the trial has been withstood, often heroically and under the most barbarous ill-treatment; but only in the present age, the age with the humane conditions, has the development of spirit come so far that not only the powers of faith but, what is decisive in relation to our cultural life, the thoughts of faith as well can be subjected from the ground up to a trial.

Should anyone perhaps, on the pretext that Christianity is *a life*, not *a theory*, dismiss the intellectual trial as an impractical, hair-splitting scholastic dispute, lay about him with phrases and assure us that nothing comes of disputing about faith, that one should at once declare oneself a believer and fight for faith, etc.: then I know no more fitting way to conclude than by recalling a statement with which seventeen years ago I introduced my work *Evangelietroen og Theologien*: "If those days when the question of the blessed life was the highest question of the race were to return immediately; if the Church's great jubilee year were now so near that it rang in our ears, as though we already heard the sound of the bells that are to ring it in: why, then our awakened ones might well dismiss 'a merely theoretical [278] scholastic dispute,' and direct to life's 'trial by fire' those who — 'instead of acting accordingly!' — only write about it, insofar as they write about faith. 'But' — adds a Christian psychologist — 'shall faith be found on the earth?' ... Should it at last come so far that one did not even find it worth the trouble to *dispute about* faith, would that too be a good sign? Would it not much rather be a sign that one despised the human strife because at bottom one did not respect the divine either; a sign that one found it still less worth the trouble to *fight for* faith: a sign that faith was no longer found on the earth?"

So, then, when the talk is of the spiritual conditions of the present age, we must abide by Luther's words: Faith is a restless thing!

XVI.

It is “a closer scientific cooperation between the Nordic universities” that I have ^[279] had the honor of inaugurating with the lectures now delivered. If, however, one lays particular weight on its being a cooperation between the universities that is in question, and on this cooperation’s being scientific, a natural objection arises. Why, it will be asked, precisely where a contribution to a scientific cooperation is at stake, choose a form of presentation that is not scientific? It is, as it seems, a contradiction to want to inaugurate something scientific in an unscientific manner. In conclusion I owe the highly esteemed assembly an account of my choice.

If a cooperation between the different universities is to mean anything, if the teachers from these universities are to be able to entertain the hope of contributing to such a cooperation, then, so far as I can see, two things must be kept in view. It is, in the first place, natural and necessary that every university teacher choose his subject from his own field and in accordance with his scientific position. It is natural that the jurist choose a juridical subject, the physicist a physical one, the historian and the philologist a historical and philological one, and so on. That is my first point. The next is that no visiting teacher will choose his subject in such a way that ^[280] he communicates something that must be presupposed to be known to everyone at the other university. For it surely cannot in truth be called inaugurating any higher cooperation, that a lecturer from another university comes and communicates to the students what they already know. I would thus have to regard it as less fitting to lecture to the Norwegian students on a survey of some general part of philosophy or a fragment of propaedeutics, in short, something which, given the

thoroughness, purity, and rigor with which philosophical science is cultivated here, the students could hear just as well from their appointed teachers. No, to offer something of that sort to the awakened young men whose lively interest in a freer development of spirit has in particular set the matter here under discussion in motion, I would regard not merely as a sign of illusion on my own part, but as an insult.

Had I chosen a philosophical subject, I would have had to choose it from another standpoint and in such a way that what is peculiar to me in it found expression; and such a subject I could easily have chosen; for so far as I know, my endeavors diverge, in a fairly decisive way I believe, from those of the philosophers in the various literatures, when the talk is of method and in particular of the interaction between philosophy and the investigative sciences.

For a long series of years I have made it my particular task to study the encyclopedia of the sciences, since I have considered it altogether necessary that philosophical science, if it is to be carried a step further, must first give itself an account of its relation to the other sciences, the so-called special sciences. Had I, then, chosen a philosophical subject peculiar to me, I would have had to limit it to [281] such a degree that the subject itself would undoubtedly have interested only a very small circle of the students. Just imagine what it means to have to carry through, in a comparatively small number of hours, a strictly scientific analysis from which it could be seen how philosophy, for example, relates to mathematics. How many listeners would have followed these analyses with undivided interest; in how many could I have presumed an equal knowledge of philosophy on the one side and of mathematics on the other? Had I chosen another, related subject, for example to set forth the relation of philosophy to chemistry, particularly with regard to the so important doctrine of atoms, and then also with regard to the problem of change and the relation between the two concepts of change and transformation, then again I would have been confined to a very limited circle of listeners.

If, now, for the reasons stated, I had to give up choosing a strictly scientific subject, I was on the other hand directed to the great circle of humane ideas of

which the science of spirit has so rich a store at its disposal; and as I looked about in the circle of these ideas, I truly did not lack subjects that might come into consideration. But among all the subjects there was one that came to the fore again and again, the question of faith and knowledge, a question that is on the agenda, indeed, I might say, at present a burning question in my native land. This question has precisely a peculiar main aspect by which its treatment falls under the humane point of view, and I was in this respect particularly tempted to let the choice fall on just this subject.

But here again a natural objection arises. Why, it will be asked, not simply announce lectures on the relation between faith and knowledge and deliver them, since they were after all meant to promote a scientific cooperation between the universities, in the academic, strictly scientific form? I answer: that was impossible [282] for me! As far as faith is concerned, I could indeed, as I have tried to show, develop the great fundamental concepts even for those who were not quite clear with themselves about the principles of knowledge; but when, on the other hand, it was a matter of assigning to knowledge and science their strict limit, it was altogether impossible for me here to give any survey that could lay claim to scientific stringency; I would then have had — it lies in the nature of the case — to give a detailed account of my philosophical concept of knowledge. The peculiar limitation that, according to my way of seeing, I must give to science is motivated precisely by the encyclopedic studies mentioned before and by the investigation of the relation of philosophy to the exact and positive sciences. Since I could not, as I said, expect to present anything on this last point that would be penetratingly intelligible, I could not get the concept of knowledge treated with sufficient thoroughness, and so, as far as this subject is concerned, had to give up the scientific mode of presentation in the narrower sense.

To this was added yet another consideration: what is most important to me at the moment — for with knowledge and science I believe I shall certainly manage — is not the concern of knowledge but that of faith. It is not the purely scientific but the popular development of the opposed concepts on which I have to lay particular

emphasis. Now, in order not to incur the inconsistency, when I expressly put the two concepts, knowledge and faith, side by side and thereby obliged myself to elucidate knowledge just as clearly as faith, of leaving science in the shade, I recast the title of my lectures and announced them, not under the heading Faith and Knowledge, but under the more general and more humane point of view:

[283] Hindrances and Conditions for the Spiritual Life in the Present Age. Under this point of view I could in a freer way bring forward much that belongs partly to civilization, partly to the life of the people, and particularly to religion. Here I could move freely in the domain of free cognitions. So much for the choice.

If, now, the choice was — as I believe I have shown — in a way prescribed for me, there was added to this the by no means inessential consideration that on these terms I could entertain the hope of gathering a circle of cultured listeners; indeed, not merely of listeners, but, and I must lay particular weight on this circumstance, also of women listeners. These are not flattering words; for flattering words there is no place here, no mood; it is my full conviction that fundamental thoughts that move in the life of faith, fundamental thoughts with a personal and popular stamp, must on the highest as on the lowest rung of culture be heard equally by man and woman. In treating such tasks it is important to have the feminine individuality present, especially for the sake of the presentation, where it is precisely a matter of distinguishing sharply between the scientific, the popular, and the folk-like. Only before a feminine tribunal are we quite sure not to mix the heterogeneous forms with one another. As to the scientific treatment, in the first place, surely no one who has resolved to speak about the general concerns of culture to the cultured will be in danger of straying into the learned preserves; but should it happen to him, he would become aware of the mistake with a certain embarrassment on seeing himself surrounded by attentive women listeners. It is probably only rarely that a gifted woman feels herself drawn to learned investigations. Of course: no rule without exception, and where talent is, be it in woman or in man, we

[284] must hold it in honor. We know, in individual cases, the peculiar gift in noble and beautiful women. Madame Chatelet, for example, had so eminent a talent for

mathematics that, besides playing the role of the amiable great lady in the salons, she passed for a scientific authority among the great mathematicians of her time. But how rare, indeed, to the good fortune of society, how exceedingly rare is such a phenomenon! If we keep to the rule, then a lecture that is to be able to count on feminine attention had best be freed from learned baggage and artificial formulas; but lectures of this nature are, after all, best suited of all for the communication of humane, aesthetic, ethical, and religious content.

The next thing on which I must lay weight is the distinction between the popular and the folk-like. For the popular, woman in a certain sense has just as much sense as man; she has, and must have, her share in culture and civilization: without her participation the so-called higher culture would look meager. But the merely popular will not easily beguile her; if she has not been twisted into a seminarist-governess by all too encyclopedic cramming at the institute, she will always with fine tact note the limit where the ensouled leaves off and the unintelligible begins; the fleeting, light, seemingly superficial way in which she intimates a view is often a telling proof that with the certainty of instinct she has at bottom hit upon the right thing. Even if she cannot go quite so far into popular astronomy as the cultured man, she can in return as a rule go all the more deeply into poetry and psychology. The folk-like, the religious, in short: all that is personal a woman apprehends deeply and essentially, just as deeply and essentially as a man. But when we say that woman is capable of understanding the highest truths of personality just as originally as man, we do not therefore say that she [285] understands them in the same way as he. No! The difference between man and woman is essentially a difference of soul. It has often been asked, naturally not without learned self-importance, whether woman, this weaker sex, could now really also in actuality think thoroughly, reflect thoroughly, argue thoroughly, and so on. We answer Yes! but she does not reflect, she does not think, she does not argue like a man; she is, after all, a woman.

This takes us a step further; for precisely by touching on the difference between man's and woman's appropriation of the highest truths we come at the same time to

reflect on the double conception of popular instruction, of what was characterized in an earlier connection as the enlightenment of the people. Should it really be the case, as “the modern consciousness” assures us, that knowledge must in the end dissolve faith, then woman will sink back down to a very subordinate rung in society; for this is certain: on the terms of knowledge woman can never become man’s equal. Should it on closer reflection prove impossible for a many-sidedly cultured man to unite knowledge and faith in one consciousness, then a chasm of soul will open between man and woman; for this is certain: a woman who for the sake of knowledge will give up having her life in the mystery of faith must forfeit her womanliness and wither like a plant cut off from its root. A man, even if he is not properly a man of science, can at a pinch scrape along with the help of the popular; but a woman whose whole culture is built on reasonings and principles taken from popular writings is a prosaic magnitude, an individuality bedraggled in soul. A man can at a pinch become a cosmopolitan and perhaps [286] come out of it tolerably well; but when a woman becomes cosmopolitan, what does she then become? A barren abstraction, a schema painted in many rubrics, an outline of the universally feminine without light and life. Even on the highest rung of culture the feminine individuality stands guard for the religious as well as for the folk-like. This Grundtvig has strikingly seen, and what Grundtvig asserts in robust immediacy S. Kierkegaard’s subtle reflection has fully confirmed through aesthetically, ethically, and religiously nuanced transitions.

As the characteristic mark common to the feminine and the folk-like we name the deeper simplicity. From the simple all true personal culture, all development of spirit, must begin; to the simple the whole development, however rich and manifold it may otherwise be, must return again. Popular instruction begins simply; for it begins with the children, and it begins with the common people. Herein lies that it must begin precisely in such a way that in its rudiments it has possibilities enough, has the whole wealth of the endowment in its first shoots. For just as little as a child is destined to live out its time in a perpetual childhood, just so little are the common people destined to remain common people forever. The

common people are the people in a state of spiritual childhood; in the common people the life of the people has its root, its endowments, its instincts; in the common people the spiritual powers stir in an obscure but original and naturally peculiar way. The common people are the people itself, not in complete being but in becoming and growth. If we forget the growth and put a static being in place of a continual becoming, then we must necessarily run aground on one of two extremes: either simply make the people into the common people or regard the common people merely as a mass. Those who in a crude way identify the people with the common people distinguish themselves especially by a peculiar [287] hatred of everything that suggests higher culture, richer development of spirit, intellectual superiority: science, art, poetry are regarded askance by the leaders of the masses. Those who, in the blindness of an aristocracy of spirit, look down on the common people as on that part of the population which fate has once and for all destined to toil in tutelage, and relish the well-known words: "Zuschlagen kann die Masse, da ist sie respectabel, urtheilen aber gelingt ihr miserabel" — forget the dearly bought experiences of history, how terribly such contempt has nevertheless avenged itself, and will go on avenging itself. The instruction of the people must not stop at what belongs to the common people; it must just as little restrict itself to the religious alone as to the civic. There is in the people, we repeat it, a double need: need of religion and need of enlightenment, need of the soul's salvation and need of culture. Step by step the common people must be raised to human insight into what is human, to ever higher self-cognition, to a clearer understanding of actuality, to deeper personal conviction.

Without personal conviction there is no inner independence, without inner independence no real freedom. There is, and can be, a free people, but there is not, and cannot be, a free common people; for the rung of the common people is, spiritually seen, the rung of tutelage, hence of unfreedom. In popular instruction it is a matter of bringing the ordinary man so far that he will be able: to think his own thoughts clearly, to give himself a sufficient account of his own actions; to see and understand that no one in society can have rights without at the same

time having duties; to see and understand that the interest of the individual man is furthered in a reasonable way only by the interests of society being taken care of [288] on the large scale; to see and understand that the interests of society on the large scale cannot possibly be furthered unless the different working classes, not merely those who work in the bodily sphere, but also those who work in the spiritual, enjoy full recognition, each according to the terms grounded in the nature of the circumstances. Only he who is able to give himself reasons for what he wills and what he does will be able to understand the reasons that are given him by others. The difficulty with the emancipation of the ordinary man is not that he lacks either noble self-respect or sound understanding or honest will; but the difficulty is that his thinking is unclear, his horizon restricted, his mind suspicious. The difficulty is that he does not rightly know how either to give reasons or to accept reasons, because he is essentially unfree. The ordinary man is unfree as long as his inner being is obscure; but that his inner being is obscure shows itself especially in his being dark, shut up, in the most personal concerns. Inner obscurity and reserve give the character, under the pressure of life, a perceptible tinge of melancholy. On the surface the life of the people may indeed in certain sunshine moments be festivity itself, an image of natural carefreeness, immediate joy, and inexhaustible zest for life; but innermost there is something dark, and in the dark dwells melancholy. A thorough connoisseur of the folk melodies from the various regions of the world has said that on the whole they bear the stamp of its not being joy but sorrow that taught the peoples to sing. This heavy, oppressed, shut-up nature will disappear only as the warmth and light of the sun of freedom penetrate further into the masses.

And who, then, is to instruct the common people, provide for their growth, educate and form them into a people? However many changes the forms of society [289] may undergo, there can be no doubt that pastors and schoolteachers must continue to be the real teachers of the people. How these teachers conceive and tend their calling is then of the very greatest significance, not merely for the state, that it may maintain peace and order, but for the people itself, that it may secure spiritual

freedom for itself. One sometimes hears remarks such as these: to learn a science requires a good head, to become an artist requires talent; even to become a riding master requires natural aptitude. But to become a village pastor? Well, one can surely become a pastor in the country with a small head, without talent. And a schoolteacher? For that, natural aptitude is hardly needed! Such judgments are in a high degree skewed and confusing. When there is disputing about how much endowment is required for preaching to the common people, it is from the outset a thoroughly false beginning to seek the standard in the good head. The standard is theological, and precisely for that reason false. One proceeds theologically from the presupposition that a pastor at bottom ought to be a learned man; or at any rate, so to speak, a kind of popular man of science, if he is to be a pastor of standing. Now this is the ideal. But since ideals are very seldom realized in the world, one must in many cases turn a blind eye to the scientific deficiencies and console oneself that a pastor, although he is neither properly learned nor a man of science, can nevertheless, if he is otherwise a believing man who knows his Christianity, very well be a good pastor of souls. Of course, as a rule he cannot get the great living, the one with many and rich revenues, when he does not have the great theological grade; but for all that he can surely get a considerable, burdensome living, namely a living with many poor souls, if, as was said, he is good enough to be a pastor of souls. In the manifold cases of practical life there can hardly be [290] shown any greater contradiction between the standard and what is to be measured than the one that strikes the eye when the question is of judging the qualifications of the pastors of souls paid by the state. No one, of this I am convinced, can feel this more deeply than the pastors themselves.

For, let us speak quite plainly, how many pastors actually become men of science? Not very many — to the good fortune of the clergy, indeed to the good fortune of the congregation! It is surely in truth not the pastor's calling to immerse himself in learned scientific studies; he has another work to do, a work of the spirit, for which there is required, not only in the divine but also in the human sense, a special endowment, a particular preparation, upbringing, and culture. Let

us ask the pastors round about the country whether most of them will not admit that the extracts of learned theology that were impressed upon them in a so-called scientific manner belong precisely to what they would most like to manage to forget, the sooner the better, in order to be able to begin afresh? Would not most of them have noticed a difference, an essential difference, between the theological and the religious way of thinking, between the learned and the edifying discourse? Instead of making do with learned fragments and scientific surveys, they are directed precisely to observations of actual life, to personal apprehension and appropriation of the apostolic word, to drawing from the well of inner experiences.

Certainly there may be need of an objective rule by which the qualifications of the people's teachers can be judged, as surely as the state is not merely to pay its officials but also, as far as possible, to fit the pay to the service; for a subjective, pietistic opinion about the individual's "sealing" is quite certainly [291] unreliable. But precisely in this respect the absurdity shows itself when theory goes in one direction and practice in another. Were the present school for pastors really fitted to give its students the scientific culture, the religious cognition, the spiritual consecration that in a special degree make them fit to educate the people and to proclaim the Gospel in the congregation: then a testimony as to how the individual had passed his final examination could quite certainly be orienting; but is this now the case? There can be no doubt that the pastors themselves, when it becomes clear to them that the way that is to lead them to the goal is quite another than the objectively dogmatic one, will be the most zealous in working against the theological nuisance. For it weighs on them, this nuisance; it dulls the sense and confuses the eye; it paralyzes the powers of the spirit by cramming the memory with bits and pieces of learned traditions, literary relics, into which not even a demon shall be able to breathe either life or spirit, unless it happen by a speculative miracle. To form pastors in a school that effaces the characters of revelation, overlooks the principle of faith, and denies the original validity of religious thinking — what does that lead to? It leads to a quiet, systematic, steadily advancing undermining of the position of the clergy in civilized society. What was

it, then, that really grounded the power and authority of the clergy in the Middle Ages? It was its clearer eye for spirit, its deeper insight, its ideal advantage. In the present age, whose spiritual direction is on the whole predominantly intellectual, reflecting, criticizing, the clergyman must not merely manage to keep up, but, as far as the religious is concerned, expressly assert his intellectual superiority. His contemporaries must get the impression that he is precisely the man, the right man, who knows what is what when the question is of the decisive fundamental [292] thoughts of personal life, the man who in religious reflections can master the freethinker, settle accounts with those who know, and orient the believers. If this impression can become the predominant one in society, then the clergy can assuredly be untroubled about all the rest. Among warring powers, the one that has the greatest forces, the strictest discipline, and the best weapons will always be surest of victory. It will surely be confirmed in the strife of spirits that on the path of history there is no spirit so mighty as the spirit of the Gospel, no thought so penetrating as the thought of the will, no word so powerful as the word of faith, and that then, too, no combatant who knows his weapons is so well equipped as he who fights for the right of personality, its true life in the eternal kingdom. But the priestly coat of arms is not theology; to clothe the clergyman in a theological harness is in our day just as preposterous as it is preposterous to puff him up into a “witness to the truth” and expose him to satire.

One more point shall be touched on here. In the spiritual life of the present age it is a matter of interaction between science and the enlightenment of the people, a higher interaction which will undoubtedly bring with it that what has already in my native land been the object of very comprehensive and serious deliberations will soon attract attention in Norway and Sweden too, namely, whether the spiritual conditions of the present time should not require that, over against the university, the learned high school, there should arise another high school on a popular foundation on a large scale. It is not enough with the small peasants’ high schools; what is needed here is an institution of learning resting on so broad a foundation that it can comprise the various elements of culture and of science, mark well,

in such a way that the fundamental thought of the enlightenment of the people
 [293] penetrates each single element and governs the whole. It is my hope that it will come to that, as I at the same time presuppose that such an opposition of folk high school and university, far from oppressing the university and putting it in the shade as an antiquated institution, will on the contrary mightily contribute to raising its scientific standing, giving it new impulses, freeing it from extraneous burdens, setting ideas in freer circulation, and rejuvenating the blood in the old limbs. There are those who think that the universities are antiquated institutions that have essentially played out their role. This opinion I cannot join; whereas I can well understand that the highest point of union of the sciences cannot suffice as the sole focal point of the enlightenment of the people, once it stands firm that this enlightenment must have a double point of departure, one in faith and one in knowledge.

There can surely be no doubt that the particular special sciences do best to group themselves into one great whole, just as it cannot be doubted either that the enlightenment of the people, with its peculiar tasks, had best have its own center. As for philosophy, as the science of spirit it will deal equally with both; on the one side it will immerse itself in the strict sciences and take scientific elements up into the doctrine of ideas, on the other side enter into the fundamental thought of popular instruction and take religious problems up into the theory of cognition, thus forming a connecting link between the two schools. If, now — so far as we can judge — the two schools are so far from one-sidedly restricting, stunting, and harming each other that on the contrary they will strengthen and help each other forward by their opposition, then it appears from this point of view too what the redoubling that we have here sought to assert essentially has to mean. So much
 [294] with regard to the main matter. As for the more detailed carrying-through of the fundamental thought, we must, in the practical as in the theoretical, refer to the future itself. For it goes with ideal tasks in such a way that he who solves one always gets two back. This, that the more one works at a task of the spirit the more manifold it becomes, is precisely what frightens so many, both those who

choose theory and those who tread the practical way of experience. And yet this is precisely the law of the development of spirit. The one comprehensive task, to further and promote the spiritual life, contains innumerable tasks; the fewest will probably be solved in the present age; most belong to the future. Of the tasks of the future one had best speak briefly, since otherwise speech easily becomes tiring, in becoming hovering, groping, indefinite: to use the present in the best way is to prepare what is to come.

It was a great and, as we hope, fruitful thought of the future that gathered this honorable circle of listeners, men and women. How far an utterance has now been heard in the lectures delivered, a thought of life developed, that the future itself will approve, is a question that must no doubt wait some time yet for its answer. Only this I can say, and I say it openly, that I trust in the weight of the reasons. I have spoken without reserve, from inner prompting, decidedly; but I have never thought or meant that any of my propositions should count as articles of faith. I have spoken in order to submit the matter to the consideration of those competent to judge; I have spoken against the encroachments of civilization, but not against civilization, against the missteps of reason, but not against reason, against scientific delusion, but not against science. I have spoken of the people's [295] need and the people's right to a peculiar enlightenment independent of science and learned research; I have spoken freely and openly, for I was conscious that I was speaking to an assembly in whose midst men of high culture, thorough learning, practical and theoretical expertise, some among the first men of the realm, to whom the people must look up with esteem and confidence, had for the sake of the cause decided to choose a seat. I was convinced that one could speak to men of science, not merely in praise of science, but also of scientific encroachments, without being misunderstood; I was convinced that one could speak to men of the people about the people's need and want and right without occasioning ill feeling. I have spoken freely; but I take with me the conviction that however much may

have been defective in the particulars, my free speech can hardly have obscured or botched any good cause.

Now we stand at the goal; I confess with deep gratitude that these lectures will be characteristic of my activity as a teacher in more than one respect, that they mark an essential turning point for it. It is a leaf of the book of my life, a leaf of remembrance, that I have here got written; among many leaves it is in truth one of the richest, I confess it, one of the most beautiful. So I will then imprint this deeply in my mind, dedicate it to a grateful remembrance; so then let the cause be inaugurated, so then let the inaugural lectures herewith be concluded: may the honored assembly of listeners, men and women, receive my warmest, my most respectful thanks!

Postscript.

However much I have striven in these lectures to state my view of the relation [297] between faith and knowledge quite clearly and definitely, it has nevertheless not been possible to avoid several, even very essential, points being exposed to misunderstanding. I perceive this partly from individual inquiries from listeners, partly from articles in Norwegian papers. In particular there is one point for whose further clarification I find myself called upon first of all on this occasion; it concerns the *actuality* that must be ascribed to the sacred facts, particularly the resurrection of Christ.

As regards this matter, I can refer to an article to be found in *Aftenbladet* for the 24th of December 1867 under the heading: Professor C. P. Caspari on “Faith and Knowledge.” It is in “the form of confession and testimony” that the Professor states what he “with a little-fitting word” must call his “standpoint.” “I do so,” he says, “because on account of views and thoughts which in recent times have gradually begun to stir and assert themselves among us, . . . I must consider it to be not so entirely out of place.” Since the “views and thoughts” that Professor Caspari here means to meet by making his confession of faith are not directly connected with my lectures, it naturally cannot occur to me to want to burden him with [298] any scientific exchange with me; I merely make use of his statement because it gives me a convenient occasion to set down some further determinations of what I understand by *phenomenon of spirit, actuality of spirit, actuality for the spirit*.

Professor Caspari confesses the faith “that the revelation of salvation of which the Holy Scriptures tell belongs to external historical actuality, that it is not merely

true but also actual, that it possesses not merely an inner actuality for faith — which would be the same as that it exists only in the idea, or that it is at bottom only an imagination — but also an external actuality in itself, and that not merely in its main features and fundamental facts but also in all its particulars. And on the external actuality of this revelation of salvation our salvation rests; without it we would be and remain to all eternity in our sins, be and remain eternally lost. Mere ideas of salvation cannot give the human heart, restless in sin, peace and blessedness. ... But” — the Professor continues — “the objections of science to the fundamental facts and particulars of the revelation of salvation? — I am myself, by the grace of God, a man of science, but I must openly confess that they have never caused me a single sleepless night. As regards in particular the objections to the miracles of the revelation of salvation, I must on the contrary set against them the historical actuality of these miracles and above all of the resurrection of Christ. If there is any fact that is sufficiently, indeed superabundantly, historically attested, it is the resurrection of Christ; if it is not to be called historical, then we may as well strike a line through everything that is called history. ... And then there is, after all, a miracle that happens to this very day, that is a fruit of those old miracles of the revelation of salvation and therefore also bears witness to them, and that everyone can experience in himself, I mean the miracle of rebirth, the [299] great inner miracle, a miracle which — if it is permitted in the domain of miracles to speak of greater or lesser — is just as great as the resurrection of Christ. Every true Christian knows himself as a living miracle; the actuality of the miracles is therefore also just as certain to him as his own existence as a new man, as a Christian.”

In this statement there is something about which I must at once declare myself unconditionally in agreement with Professor Caspari, and it is: that the facts in sacred history are not “imagination,” that “mere ideas of salvation cannot give the human heart, restless in sin, peace and blessedness”; with how much reason I emphasize this here, anyone who with an unbiased eye has read through not merely the present lectures but any one whatever of my other writings will be able to tell

himself. It is precisely the actuality of the sacred facts, their religiously marked character, their full, undistorted reality, their unweakened validity in themselves, whose acknowledgment I seek from every side and in every possible way to enjoin. But when it is in earnest a matter of asserting actuality, full, self-valid actuality, then surely the question presses itself upon us: what is actuality, the true actuality, fully valid in itself? It is in the answer to this important question that I do not know whether I dare declare myself in agreement with Mr. Caspari.

In the first place it seems to me as if the Professor, where the talk is of the phenomena of revelation, lays rather much weight on the sensuous exterior, when he makes our salvation and blessedness dependent on it and enjoins that this exterior of actuality is to hold, not merely of certain facts, but of all, not merely of “the fundamental facts,” but of “their particulars.” Let me choose some examples. Isaiah describes his calling as a prophet (Isa. VI): “In the year that King Uzziah died I saw the Lord sitting upon a throne, high and lifted up, and his train filled the temple. Above it stood the seraphim, each one had six wings” and so on. The [300] prophet Amos describes his visions (Amos VII): “This vision Jehovah let me see: he was about to form grasshoppers. ... This vision Jehovah let me see: Behold, the Lord Jehovah called upon the flame as his advocate; it licked up the mighty deep and devoured the portion. ... This vision Jehovah let me see: the Lord standing upon a wall made by a plumb line, with a plumb line in his hand. And Jehovah said to me: What seest thou, Amos? I said, A plumb line. Then said the Lord: now I will cast the plumb line into the midst of my people Israel” and so on. To Ezekiel the divine voice sounds (Ezek. III): “Son of man! eat what thou here receivest, eat this roll of a book; then go and speak to the house of Israel. And I opened my mouth, and he gave me this roll to eat. And he said to me: Son of man; let thy life be consumed, and fill thy inward parts with this roll that I give thee; and I ate, and it was in my mouth as honey for sweetness.” ...

That these prophetic visions are not empty imaginations but true revelations, that these revelations have actuality, full actuality for the spirit, must be held fast; but, we ask, is it now permissible, with such phenomena, to set up a separation

between the prophet's vision and what the prophet sees? May we really assume that the throne on which Jehovah lets himself be seen by Isaiah in the temple has the same outward actuality as the temple of Jerusalem? that the grasshoppers that Jehovah forms in the vision for Amos have the same outward actuality as natural-historical grasshoppers? that the plumb line Jehovah casts into the midst of Israel has an outward actuality like the plumb weight that hangs on a Bornholm wall clock? that the roll of a book that Ezekiel eats — in the vision — has the same outward actuality as the Bible that lies on the table?

The prophetic visions are seen in the spirit. He who says that the visions the prophets see have the same outward actuality as the things that are seen with [301] bodily eyes, what does he do? He makes revelation spiritless. Can a spiritless revelation be called a "revelation of salvation"? Can anyone, without mocking what is holy, really maintain that all salvation and blessedness rests on the external actuality of the revelation of salvation, that he who, as regards the visions named, does not lay the truth into the exterior of the external actuality of "the throne," of "the grasshoppers," of "the plumb line," of "the roll of a book," in short: of "all the particulars," must "remain to all eternity in his sins, be and remain eternally lost"?

It is by no means my intention to want to force upon Professor Caspari the consequence of his own statement; I only want to draw the attention of thinking readers to the dangerous misdirection that lies in so one-sided a "testimony." It is one thing to acknowledge the exterior insofar as in the phenomenon of revelation it belongs to determining the interior, another to be so dazzled by the exterior, the sensuous exterior, that one makes all salvation and blessedness dependent on the external actuality of the particulars. That the Professor by no means wants to deny the interior he makes clear enough by the emphasis he lays on the miracle of rebirth, "the great inner miracle, which — if it is permitted in the domain of miracles to speak of greater or lesser — is just as great as the resurrection of Christ." By this "testimony" decisive weight is now quite certainly laid on the interior; but how does the latter now relate to the former? Of the miracle of rebirth it holds, after all, that it has inner actuality, actuality for faith. Take faith away, and what

then becomes of the “great miracle” of rebirth? The assurance of this miracle’s validity is in faith alone; or should the believer perhaps be able to behold his own rebirth in an external actuality, an actuality with which it stands, to use the Professor’s expression, “as with the sun, which indeed first comes to be for me by my seeing and feeling it, but does not thereby first come to be at all, but exists before all my seeing and feeling, has an existence independent of it, and would [302] exist though no human eye had ever seen it or any human body felt it”?

If every thinking human being — consequently Professor Caspari too — must concede that the miracle of rebirth has its true validity in itself by means of the spirit through faith, indeed for faith and the spirit *alone*: then it is surely herewith conceded that there is an inner, and yet in itself valid, actuality, an actuality of spirit, an actuality for the spirit. But how are we now to understand the Professor’s “confession and testimony,” for he confesses and testifies that the revelation of salvation that possesses merely an inner actuality in faith “exists only in the idea, or that it is at bottom only an imagination.” In truth, a terrible testimony — against “the great miracle of rebirth”! Since, now, Professor Caspari has here borne not one but two testimonies to the actuality of the miracle of rebirth, namely one *for* and one *against*, both equally forceful, the question is: how are we, who would gladly accept his “testimony,” to make sense of a “confession” so at odds with itself?

We shall surely be compelled to concede: 1) that the actuality of revelation is first and last actuality of spirit, actuality for the spirit; 2) that the actuality of spirit always goes from the interior through the exterior back to the interior, so that its decisive mark must always be sought in the interior; 3) that the exterior which the spirit, the self-revealing Spirit of God, masters, pervades, and takes up into the peculiarly determined actuality of the sacred facts, is of very different kinds, now bodily, now incorporeal, now natural, now supernatural, now immediately sensuous, so that the phenomena of revelation, precisely for that reason, if we are really to be able to “give ourselves up to them and immerse ourselves in them,” must become clear to us through a criticism that answers, not to “our own arbitrary representations,” but to the self-valid principle of revelation and of faith. [303]

I shall briefly illuminate each of the propositions set out. Thus:

The actuality of revelation is actuality of spirit, actuality for the spirit. Herein lies that nothing can have validity for faith except that which the believer, by virtue of the testimony of the Spirit, must ascribe validity in itself. According to Professor Caspari's "testimony" one would surely have to assume that something could have inner actuality for faith and yet perhaps be a pure and simple imagination; this must be denied. That something has inner actuality for faith means that for the believer it has validity in itself; as soon as the believer becomes conscious that that in which he believes has no validity in itself, he also ceases to believe in it. He who believes in God ascribes to God validity in himself. Were anyone to say: God, to be sure, does not exist in and for himself; but precisely for that reason I believe in him, that I may give him an inner actuality in my faith: what would one then have to judge of such a person's mental state? Were anyone to say: I believe in God, that is: I give him a provisional inner actuality in my faith; but whether the God in whom I believe also has actuality in himself, that I must leave undecided until I can in one way or another get to see him in an external actuality, for example sitting on a throne in the temple or standing on a wall with a grasshopper or with a plumb line in his hand: what would one then have to judge of such a faith? No, to believe in God is to ascribe to God validity, absolute validity in himself; he for whom God's personal being does not have validity in itself does not believe in God. When Professor Caspari, instead of "mere ideas of salvation," wants to have "persons, divine persons, the personal triune God" to hold to, we can be wholly [304] and entirely in agreement with him in this; but the actuality of the triune God is, after all, actuality of spirit, actuality for faith, inner actuality for the spirit. It is not with the assurance of God's existence as with the assurance of the sun's existence. A human being can, even if he becomes bodily blind and is thereby put out of the condition to see the sun, still continue to feel assured of the sun's existence; but a human being cannot in spiritual blindness cease to believe in God and yet continue to feel assured of God's existence: the original assurance of the existence of "the divine persons" is not given by external actuality for the senses, but by

inner actuality for faith.

2) *The actuality of spirit goes from the interior through the exterior back to the interior, so that its decisive mark must always be sought in the interior.* When the question is of the external actuality in which God has personally revealed himself, we must think particularly of Christ's manifestation in the flesh. With regard to this fact, Professor Caspari has then also quite rightly referred to 1 John 1:1 ff. With this external actuality it is so much in earnest that the evangelist declares every spirit that testifies against it to be a false spirit. "Beloved! believe not every spirit, but try the spirits whether they are of God; for many false prophets are gone out into the world. Hereby know ye the Spirit of God: every spirit that confesseth Jesus Christ to be come in the flesh is of God. And every spirit that confesseth not Jesus Christ to be come in the flesh is not of God, and this is the spirit of Antichrist, whereof ye heard that he cometh, and even now already is he in the world" (1 John 4:1–3). But let us now see how the exterior in this manifestation stands to the interior. Is the relation this: that the certainty of the manifestation of the Son of God begins with the exterior and from the exterior passes over into the interior? Is the relation not rather this, that the certainty begins from the interior, dwells for some time with the exterior, and then at last, after this exterior has vanished, returns with reinforced emphasis to the interior? If the cognition that Jesus of Nazareth is the Christ originally rested on the exterior, then all who saw the man Jesus with bodily eyes must surely also have been able to see from his exterior that he really was the Son of God. But that this was not the case the Gospel history teaches. The sensuously present Jesus of Nazareth was in actuality the Son of God only for those who saw him with the eye of faith, heard his word with the ear of faith. What it means that the actuality of Christ revealed in flesh and blood is an actuality for the spirit is seen, among other places, from Matt. 16:13–17. "When Jesus came into the coasts of Caesarea Philippi, he asked his disciples, saying: Whom do men say that I, the Son of man, am? And they said: Some say that thou art John the Baptist; some, Elias; and others, Jeremias, or one of the prophets. He saith unto them: But ye, whom say ye that I am? Then Simon

Peter answered and said: Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God. And Jesus answered and said unto him: Blessed art thou, Simon son of Jonas, for flesh and blood hath not revealed it unto thee, but my Father which is in heaven.” Had Christ been directly recognizable by his exterior, there would surely not have been such divergent opinions about him, and there would have been no reason to call the disciple blessed when he saw only what anyone, even a Herod and a Pilate, must have been able to see. How the exterior in the actuality of Christ’s manifestation relates to the interior we learn from Jesus’ own words at the parting from the disciples (John 16:7 and 13–15). “Nevertheless I tell you the truth: it is expedient for you that I go away; for if I go not away, the Comforter will not come unto you” ... This we must surely understand thus: it is expedient for you that my external [306] actuality vanish from your sight, for only on this condition can the Spirit enrich you in inner actuality with the full truth. The conversion of the exterior into the interior is expressly designated in such a way that in Jesus’ own words we have a sure guide for apprehending and understanding sacred history. Here it is said that the Spirit “shall not speak of himself; but whatsoever he shall hear” (from the mutual speaking of the Father and the Son, the interior) “that shall he speak.” The Spirit’s presentation of Christ’s life on earth is not to be restricted to a finite copying and registering of external occurrences; the Spirit of truth is to explain, illuminate, and present the history of the Savior in such a way that the exterior receives its significance from the interior; in this interior is his glory, a glory that only the eye of faith can see in the light of the Spirit. “He shall glorify me: for he shall receive of mine, and shall show it unto you.”

3) *The exterior which the Spirit of revelation takes up, pervades, and transfigures is of very different kinds, so that the facts in sacred history on this account assume a very different stamp of actuality.* “If there is,” says Professor Caspari, “any fact that is sufficiently, indeed superabundantly, historically attested, it is the resurrection of Christ; if it is not to be historical, then we may as well strike a line through everything that is called history.” We say the same, but on the condition that this fact is not drawn down into the circle of the events that belong to profane history

and are subject to the criticism of knowledge, but is acknowledged for what it in truth is, a supernatural fact, a fact whose actuality, with all its exterior, is actuality of spirit, actuality for the spirit.

That sacred history takes up and unites absolutely heterogeneous elements of actuality becomes evident at once when we reflect that, in connection with natural events, it contains miracles. The crucifixion, for example, is a natural event, [307] the resurrection on the other hand a supernatural one; this makes an essential difference when the talk is of an evaluation of the historical testimonies. That Jesus of Nazareth really was crucified under Pontius Pilate is a fact that no historian, whether Jewish or heathen, has called into doubt; on the contrary, it was with scorn and mockery cast up against the first Christians, by Jews and heathens alike, that they believed in a crucified malefactor. It is otherwise with the resurrection; this fact has been assumed to be historically actual by neither Jews nor heathens; it is, says the critic of profane history, by no means sufficiently attested. How does this stand?

The resurrection is a miracle, one of the most strongly attested miracles; but by whom is a miracle attested? Only by believers, never by non-believers! This is no accident; it lies in the nature of the case; it follows with irrefutable consequence from the character and significance of the miracle.

From the side of the act of power, nothing can, on the presupposition of faith, be objected against a miracle being performed in such a way that even the most obdurate would have to concede that they had really seen a sign of omnipotence. Had Christ, for example, when he meant to raise Lazarus, had it solemnly announced some days in advance, so that those who wished to make observations, Pharisees, Sadducees, an Annas, a Caiaphas, a Herod, a Pilate, could be sufficiently prepared; had he further seen to it that each of the observers could go into the tomb and assure himself that the corpse had really gone into putrefaction; had he next placed these observers in a circle around the tomb and in their hearing uttered the words: Lazarus, come forth! with such an effect that the dead man was really seen to rise and come out, bound hand and foot with graveclothes, and so

on; had he then finally, after this had happened, prevailed on the observers, among whom there would have to be not merely adherents but also opponents, cultured
[308] men whose testimony had weight and significance in all circles, solemnly to attest, one for all and all for one, what they had seen and heard: then the criticism of profane history would absolutely have had to declare itself satisfied, then every inquiring historian, be he otherwise believing or unbelieving, would have had to concede that if any fact “is sufficiently, indeed superabundantly, historically attested,” it is the raising of Lazarus. But the story of the raising of Lazarus is not attested in that way, and the story of the resurrection of Christ is not attested in that way either.

Why, now, does there rest, for profane eyes, a mystical veil over the miraculous in every one of the miracles of sacred history? Because it conflicts with the purpose of the miracle to come forth so outwardly visibly that an observer without faith should be able, by the mere exterior, to assure himself that it is a will with supernatural power that makes itself known in such a work. If true submission to God’s will could be effected by an indisputable sign of omnipotence in the exterior, then Christ would easily, with a couple of miracles, have brought both an Annas and a Caiaphas, both a Herod and a Pilate, to throw themselves in the dust before the divine majesty. Pilate, who is so cowardly, so afraid of falling into disfavor with the emperor, because, by keeping to the exterior, proceeding from the exterior, and staking the truth on the exterior, he is assured that the emperor has the power, the power that makes poor and makes rich, the power that exalts and that casts down — that same Pilate would certainly have crawled like a dog at the feet of the man whose almighty word could strike a legion of Roman soldiers to the ground. By coming forth in such an external sphere of action, a miracle of Christ would quite certainly have become an indisputable fact of world history; but if a single such miracle had happened, the revelation of omnipotence would at one stroke have
[309] crushed all inner independence, all human personality, and let a Messiah after the Jews’ mind, infinitely mightier than the emperor but like the emperor, set up an earthly kingdom and rule as divine despot over slaves. Quite certainly the actual

miracle has its exterior, indeed, according to its different purpose, a very different exterior; but the exterior does not here have its significance in and through itself; it has, and must have, its true significance through the interior, solely and alone through the interior: it presupposes faith, is apprehended in faith, strengthens faith; it presupposes the spirit, is attested by the spirit, strengthens the spirit.

To demand a miracle in order to ground one's faith on the exterior solely as exterior is a crime against the spirit; it is *to tempt God*. To venture the uttermost for faith's sake and then, in the midst of dangers, trust in God's wondrous help and assistance is not — as soft-hearted preachers sometimes, in commending "Christian wisdom," let the congregation understand on the quiet — to tempt God; but to demand miracles with so prominent a historical exterior that all salvation and blessedness could be built on immediate assurance of all the historical particulars in this historical exterior, because one imagines that without all this external actuality we would be and remain to all eternity in our sins, be and remain eternally lost: that is in truth to tempt God. There is one miracle, but only one single one, of which the believer must say that its exterior, when it really comes to pass, will be raised above all doubt even for non-believers; it is Christ's manifestation to judgment; but this manifestation cannot then become an object of historical criticism either, for with it history will end.

Only on one condition can it be said, but then with full right, that the resurrection of Christ is sufficiently, if not "superabundantly," historically attested, namely this, that its actuality is not one-sidedly placed in the exterior, but, with all the determinations of an exterior, is referred to and united with its interior; that it is, in other words, not degraded to stand on an equal footing with other historical [310] actuality, but raised to its proper height by being apprehended and determined as actuality of spirit, actuality for the spirit. The true, complete actuality of spirit is neither an exterior by itself nor an interior by itself, but an exterior answering to its interior, an interior determined by its exterior; of such an actuality of spirit, expressed in fact, testimony can be borne only in faith: all the witnesses of the resurrection are witnesses of faith.

After these explanations it can surely be seen that, if it is not Professor Caspari himself, neither is it I who rates the actuality of Christ's resurrection too low; I am conscious that the view set forth here agrees in each and every respect with the one stated in the lectures, and can therefore conclude with the assurance that the representations of "mere ideas of salvation" which the Professor wants to combat can be ascribed to my ideas only by misunderstanding. Of course, ideas can well make a person sleepless. It would, however, be regrettable if ideas, even in the form of "ideas of salvation," should now all at once come up and cause unrest and disquiet a man who has hitherto had it so quiet that as a "man of science by the grace of God" he must openly confess that "the objections of science to the fundamental facts and particulars of the revelation of salvation" have never yet "caused him a single sleepless night."

Even before that statement of Professor Caspari's was inserted in *Aftenbladet*, *Morgenbladet* had furnished a series of readable articles under the heading: *Epilog til R. N.s Forelæsninger* [Epilogue to R. N.'s Lectures]. These articles, which all bear the traces of a practiced pen, are composed with a free scientific overview, in a benevolent mood, a well-sounding, humane key, and an easy language; but, we ask, for what purpose? Is it to *guide* the public or to *misguide* it? Obviously the latter! In assuming this without further ado, a knowledgeable person will at [311] once understand that it is not censure but on the contrary praise that I herewith express; for as *guiding* the articles would be rather mediocre, as *misguiding* they are excellent. "But misguiding? That is surely an insult to the author!" By no means; it is on the contrary a compliment. The honored author has by his appearance paid me so many compliments that I would have to lack all culture and good manners if I omitted most dutifully to pay him my counter-compliment: before a display bout one salutes, after all, with the rapier.

For *misguiding* and *misguiding* are in philosophical discussions two highly different things. There is a misguiding that harms the truth, the clumsy, disagreeable kind that arises when an immature person wants to orient the public without being oriented himself; under this category the honored author may by no means

be reckoned. But there is also a misguiding that by dialectical side-lights lures the public along into the investigation, leads the reader out onto slippery ice, and gives him the notion that he who now really wants to get into the matter must see with his own eyes and think for himself. The author's misguiding is, as I hope to be able to prove, a higher intellectual guiding; it is the old, well-known art of midwifery that he employs: the method — anyone who knows a little of Greek philosophy sees it with half an eye — the method is *Socratic*.

Right at the beginning, where the author (Epil. II) expresses himself on the introductory lecture, one suspects that something must lie behind this. On the occasion of a figurative expression I am supposed to have used in the course of the lecture, namely "*the breath of the spirit*," he expresses himself in the following manner: "When the spirit thus by its mere blowing transforms hindrances into conditions, it may on the one hand seem impertinent to ask again about the condition for the spirit's doing this, or about the reason why it does not always blow. For it might be said that the spirit bloweth where it listeth, and we hear its voice, but no one knows whither it goeth. And that question can besides, as [312] one easily sees, go on endlessly. But when, on the other hand, the spirit is such a sorcerer that, unconditionally, when and where it will, it transforms hindrances into conditions or the reverse, what then is the point of the whole question of hindrances and conditions for the spiritual life? Both seem to have anything to do only where there is a reasonably grounded connection and a law-bound activity; over against the absolutely magical, both hindrances and conditions are empty words. So on the one side there looms an endless heaping up of condition upon condition, on the other a dismissal of the whole question! This certainly seems to be a hindrance to the investigation begun. Will the speaker's spirit perhaps blow on it and transform it into a condition, or will he blow it off and jump over it?" — See, that was now the yield of the first lecture, hence the first guidance.

Those readers who, without having acquainted themselves with my introductory lecture, entrusted themselves to such guidance must, by taking it straightforwardly and in dead earnest, indeed get a strange notion of my appearance at

the foreign university. Just imagine a visiting lecturer coming blowing along with some phrases about “the blowing of the spirit,” and that without even having so much going on in his head that in the midst of the stream of words it might occur to him to ask “why the spirit does not always blow”! Just imagine a philosophical professor, who by his position must after all be obliged to know a little about the relation between the conditions and the unconditioned, lacking reflection to such a degree that one must remind him afterward that “over against the absolutely magical, both hindrances and conditions are empty words”! Just imagine a circle of cultured listeners, among them even highly esteemed men of science, who for all of sixteen hours have been able to hold out listening to something so ungrounded, [313] so little coherent in itself, as such a lecture on “the blowing of the spirit” leads one to expect! Just imagine the ill will that must now be awakened afterward in the public when, guided by the Epilogue, it has to admit to itself that it let itself be taken by surprise, that the phrases by which in an unguarded moment it let itself be beguiled contained only windy witticisms, castles in the clouds driven by the blowing of the spirit. “Lamentable blowing, disagreeable — but nevertheless salutary — guidance!”

That the guidance is salutary I shall willingly concede, once we, without puff and blowing, first get the guiding transformed into a misguiding. This happens quite simply by paying heed to what our guide in the Epilogue calls “a reasonably grounded connection.” There must, after all, be a reasonably grounded connection between what has really been said in a lecture and what is said about it afterward. That my introductory lecture, as it now stands, is in all essentials the same as the one that was delivered, my listeners can attest; but once this stands firm, anyone, even on a cursory reading-through, will be able to convince himself that what stands in the Epilogue as guiding is precisely misguiding. But this misguiding has again, as by a smile from blessed gods, become for us a true guidance. The spirit spoken of in the introduction is “the absolutely divine Spirit,” hence the almighty Spirit. Now the author of the Epilogue knows very well that when the omnipotence of the spirit is to be spoken of, a listener, man or woman, can easily

mishear, and afterward think that the talk was of a spirit that worked magically and therefore needed to heed neither hindrances nor conditions, and that this is precisely a disturbing misunderstanding when the lecture is expressly to treat of hindrances and conditions. To forestall such intellectual after-pains, the honored author has wanted, in a reversed style, to enjoin what is needful. Remember what is said here: *The spirit in its working is by no means indifferent to conditions, not [314] unconditioned, nor does it create the conditions directly out of nothing; no, it forms them out of natural presuppositions, it forms them by a transformation* (p. 8). This transformation is not magical, for remember what is said here! The old, worn-out question: *if the spirit must itself inspire its servants and itself bring the conditions along, is it not then incomprehensible that it will not always and everywhere work with equally forceful presence?* is not cursorily dismissed, but answered in detail by an illumination of freedom and of the irrefutable conditions of freedom (pp. 9–16); and that this illumination, necessary for the fundamental thought, constitutes precisely the main content of the introductory lecture — see, this the clever author of the Epilogue has obviously wanted to enjoin. But how, then, has he gone about it? In order to impress on the listener how dangerous it is to begin with a complete misunderstanding, he has himself begun with a complete misunderstanding; in order to show the comical in a listener's forgetting the objections that in a lecture are not merely raised but also met, he has himself — comically enough — begun by forgetting them; in order to forestall anyone with a short memory making himself important by having forgotten the most important thing, the author begins by pretending that it was he who became important by having forgotten the most important thing. In truth, a guidance that demands resignation and self-denial: one warns against misunderstandings by making oneself guilty of misunderstanding; it is as if a father wanted to warn his sons against drunkenness by getting himself tipsy.

In Epilogue IV the following rather misguiding hints for guidance occur. “No one shall, because he says A in science, have the right to say B in faith. ... If only, the moment this is conceded, logic at any rate does not poke its nose into

[315] this system of concepts of faith, and so the magic circle by which all science was to be kept away is broken through.” Hereby the author gives a Socratic flick to all those who, although it is shown again and again that thinking, consequently logic too, has validity just as well in the doctrine of faith as in science, are caught in the old ingrained prejudice that faith as faith is thoughtless and must borrow all its thoughts from science. To drive this misunderstanding to the point of caricature, he now depicts quite ingeniously what comes of giving oneself up to a kind of scientific fantasizing about the heterogeneous circles of thought of faith and knowledge. “I do not know,” he says, “to what degree I may demand mutual agreement in the domain of faith. How does faith relate to Holy Scripture? Are these perhaps also heterogeneous, so that what holds in the one must not be carried over to the other? — And Holy Scripture itself? Mutual contradictions have, after all, been shown, for example between 2 Samuel and 1 Chronicles. Can these then be removed by the magic formula imparted, that A and B must not belong to heterogeneous domains? Is the Bible, then, itself so heterogeneous within itself that the one thing may well be true in the books of Samuel while the opposite is true in the books of Chronicles?”

From the conspicuous superiority with which the author here gives free play to the misguiding, one notices how easy it would have been for him to keep to what is stated in the lectures and give us a straightforward guidance. That it must have cost him self-conquest not to do so I may well assume; for the temptation has truly been great. How far a conclusion can be drawn from given premises does not, after all, depend on your pleasure and mine; it depends on the laws of thought. Were the guidance not, in accordance with the method, absolutely bound to be misguiding, then the author of the Epilogue would naturally have strongly emphasized that in the lectures no magic formula at all has been set up, but that it has been shown in definite examples what it leads to when one draws

[316] consequences for knowledge from the presuppositions of faith and consequences for faith from those of knowledge. The question is: can it be done or not? If it really can be done, then let the lecturer be shown how it can be done and what

his mistake consists in; if it cannot be done, then the lecturer is surely right, and what, then, is the use of the many hovering, over-hovering, extravagantly hovering deliberations concerning magic formulas where there is no magic formula?

The tactic that the author has employed with so much success to misguide the readers concerning the inner agreement of the concepts of faith within their circle, the same tactic he employs with equally brilliant effect to confuse the representations concerning the inner coherence of the concepts of knowledge. "There has," he says, "as far as I remember, been nothing said about mutual contradictions in the domain of science. Perhaps it is presupposed that they will not occur. But what if they occurred nevertheless? I at any rate cannot feel quite secure. For I have after all heard talk of disputes between different sciences which, when they are set forth sharply, might easily seem just as radical and inaccessible to mediation as the dispute between Samuel and Chronicles, indeed as several of the contradictions that seem to obtain between faith and science in general... I am in general not at all without fear that the absolute separation between faith and science set up by the new doctrine will consistently — if consistency is not in the end a quite empty word — lead to dissolving the inner unity of both faith and science and splitting both into atoms, so that there will be neither any faith nor any science any more, but only an indeterminable multitude of detached representations of faith and scientific concepts or propositions. Indeed, there already seems to appear a prevailing inclination at least to conceive the sciences exclusively one by one, while the thought of a general organism of science, of which the individual fields are integrating members, comparatively recedes into the background." Here we [317] have the Socratic roguery again.

The ironizing author wants to make guileless readers believe that because religion is heterogeneous, absolutely heterogeneous, with science, it should follow that all the sciences together, when they noticed that faith was no longer able to keep them in check, might take it into their heads to become refractory and declare themselves mutually absolutely heterogeneous. He paints a dark picture. It might then happen that even each single science, once it had tasted the absolutely

heterogeneous, got an ache in its limbs and began to dismember itself; that arithmetic and geometry, for example, when they got wind that something could be true in 2 Samuel (XXIV) which was untrue in 1 Chronicles (XXI), and conversely, took the resolution that something should in future be able to be true in arithmetic which was untrue in geometry, and conversely. These are threatening prospects! Some “lover of knowledge” or other, not yet properly oriented in the republic of letters, might at such ill-boding omens be seized with anxiety, get a fright in his blood, imagine that we already had anarchy, that the sciences were in full revolt, that there was fire in the philosophical quarter, and start crying Fire!

For the calming of tempers I must point out that the matter is not so dangerous. The sciences are, after all, all of a sober, calm, and at bottom peaceable character; certainly they have various mutual disputes; these disputes may well also now and then become somewhat vehement and passionate; but the vehement and passionate proceeds from the human “lovers of knowledge,” not from the sciences. It is precisely through the quiet impersonal power of scientific truths over the passionate personalities that the lost equilibrium is restored and harmony preserved. Should anything bring the sciences into revolt, it would have to be that [318] they were brought back under the guardianship of faith, under the “good will” of dogmatics, into the theological universal monarchy. I have really investigated the matter, I have been round and made inquiries of the individual sciences, and can from each and every one (cf. “Den gode Villie som Magt i Videnskaben,” pp. 9–108) procure a certificate that they are all unconditionally agreed in not wanting to take up miraculous elements. On the other hand, I was to give their regards and say that if they might only be free of revelations, miracles, and prophecies, they would never say an ill word either against faith or against the believers, but in all personal concerns conduct themselves morally and reasonably, and well know how to observe the dignity they owe themselves over against religion. Our Socratic’s fear that “science without Christianity, in its extreme consequence, would have to abolish itself and perish in skepticism” is thus a misguiding guidance.

So that it shall not look, however, as if on the occasion of the fright I had only

now hit upon the thought that the sciences constitute an organism, I shall here permit myself to refer to “Philosophisk Propædeutik” i Grundtræk, Copenhagen 1857, pp. 68–117, and particularly to emphasize the following (p. 71): “From the relation between the theory of cognition and the theory of science it follows that the true comprehensive theory of science can come about only by the fundamental interests of the heterogeneous sciences being represented in the discussions from which it issues. In ‘the comprehensive discussion and debate of all against all’ (Sibbern), each science thus has its vote and makes its contribution. That philosophy works together, clarifies, and organizes these contributions into an intellectual whole proves that in this respect it does not decide the matter on its own authority, but works as the common organ of the sciences, as their own universal consciousness, the being that is their kinship, the light in which they know and recognize one another mutually.”

The fixed idea at which our Socratic ironizes most finely of all, and rightly, since it still haunts so many brains, is precisely the representation of the necessity [319] of Christianity for grounding, maintaining, and furthering the sciences, from which in turn follows the necessity of the sciences for grounding, maintaining, and furthering Christianity. “Supposing,” he says (Epil. V), “that there were some truth in the thought from which I have not yet been able to free myself, namely that there is after all an inner and essential connection between science and faith, then there would thus lie in it a reasonable answer to the ... question why — by and large — science and faith have not been able to leave each other alone, but have either sought to be united or fought each other. There may certainly have been much sophistry both in the strife and in the attempts at union, and in particular many an intended encroachment on the part of science; but the sophistry and the encroachment would be without motive if faith could be indifferent to science as a whole. If, on the other hand, it is so, as history too seems to show, that certain forms of faith will exclude science, and that its flourishing is in general conditioned by a certain prevailing religious standpoint — so that, for example, science and the whole culture bound up with it have never been able to attain the depth and extent

on Mohammedan as on Christian soil — then science surely has good reason not to let the content and form of faith be a matter of indifference to it. Only the faith that is essentially pure and true and free can therefore also let science develop freely; but precisely the true faith has no need either — for example by a doubtful exceptio fori or other means — to withdraw from the criticism of mature science. For the full truth bears the full light from every side.”

The historical and the unhistorical, the true and the half-true, the loose and the firm, the author has here driven in among one another in a most ingenious way, as under all manner of remarks he spins the reader round once, twice, three times and helps him most adroitly to mistake what essentially matters — naturally in [320] order to put his independent thinking to the test. What history teaches about the many disputes between faith and knowledge and the corresponding attempts at reconciliation I have, after all, sought to show in such definite features that no one who will take the trouble to go through my writings will easily mistake the results. He who can still think that, after so many shipwrecked attempts at mediation, there is the least prospect here either of making science believing or faith scientific must surely be without all knowledge of the theological and philosophical literature of the last century.

It is surely this too that the author wants to remind us of in his Socratic-backward way. “There is,” he says, “an inner essential connection between science and faith; faith cannot be indifferent to science.” He who takes these propositions literally is fooled; for — that we should repeat it once more — there is in our day no true science, be it empirical or a priori, that in any way either directs itself or will direct itself by faith, namely the positive faith of revelation, and it is of that we speak; on the other hand, meaning is pressed into the phrases when one understands them thus, that *it can by no means be indifferent to personality how the religious and the scientific truths relate to each other.*

“The true faith has no need to withdraw from the criticism of mature science” — this proposition is misleading when it is taken as straightforwardly guiding. What becomes of the Gospel of Christ’s birth, of Christ’s resurrection, of Christ’s

ascension, of the outpouring of the Spirit, and so on, when sacred history is really to be subjected to “the criticism of mature science”? Give me a sample of such a piece of criticism, a criticism that equally satisfies both faith and science, and I shall say with Socrates: ἀγαμην ἂν θαυμάστως, ὦ Ζηνῶν. If, on the other hand, we understand the proposition as misguiding, then there is meaning in it; the [321] meaning is then this: the true faith has no need to fear the criticism of mature science, for if the believer is at the same time a knower, then he must surely know that the criticism of knowledge precisely dissolves the sacred facts, because these facts have their truth not in knowledge but in faith.

In confirmation of my view that the author of the Epilogue guides backward by misguiding, I could cite a great many more, even brilliant, examples; but time does not permit it. In order to repel the stupid tittle-tattle with which the theologians so often regale us, that certainty about the sensuous rests on faith, that astronomy rests on faith, that induction and with it all empirical knowledge and science rests on faith, and that such a faith is then again akin to religious faith, I have (particularly in Lecture IV) strongly emphasized the *certainty* of empirical knowledge. To make this certainty evident to outsiders, I appealed to a natural *instinct for truth*; this our Socratic wittily twists into the backward assertion that I was about to want to ground science on “unmediated instinct”; he reminds us of Descartes’s proposition that all human certainty rests on confidence in God’s truthfulness. Hereby he has in an indirect and very fine way referred those readers who misunderstand my presentation, as if I built science on raw instinct, to my theory of science, particularly to Grundideernes Logik II (pp. 176–275).

What ironic roguery runs through the author’s maieutic distortions I illustrate with yet one more example, in which humor and wit rise almost to exuberance. I have (Lecture V, p. 81) expressed myself thus: If it is asked, for example, what granite and flint are, then these concepts, with corresponding facts, can be fixed so definitely that anyone who has sound understanding, preparatory education, and [322] a sense for scientific investigations, be he otherwise Jew, Greek, Mohammedan, regardless of national differences and faith, is compelled to concede the validity

of the concepts: "This must be granite, this must be flint." ... What has our Socratic not managed to get out of this! "There is held up to me," he says, "yet another mark by which I am to tell the concept of faith from the scientific one, namely that the latter can be made comprehensible to every human being, while the former presupposes a certain religious standpoint. The concept of oxygen and the propositions of geology must be able to be grasped and appropriated by Christians, Mohammedans, and Brahmins without distinction, while one will seek in vain to convince others than Christians of the resurrection of Christ." The adroit distortion now consists in this, that whereas I make "sound understanding, preparatory education, and a sense for scientific investigations" in every human being express conditions for understanding a scientific doctrine, our Socratic briskly skips over the conditions and has me speak quite generally of "every human being." The exaggeration that *every human being* should without further ado be able to be convinced of a scientific truth is then (Epil. VI) illustrated by examples such as these: "that it might perhaps be just as difficult to get a Chinese to grasp European law and European history as to grasp Christianity; that it is difficult to get the Germans to comprehend that the greater part of Schleswig is Danish, and that a Negro who believes he can raise or still a storm with the help of a fetish will have difficulty enough in grasping the thought of unchangeable laws of nature."

Herewith I close these discussions, and thank the honored author of the Epilogue for the essential service he has rendered me on this occasion. The Epilogue [323] has a broad stream; the stream runs through a whole nine articles, until in a tenth it at last flows out into an "Epilogue to the Epilogue." Precisely this is what is Socratically excellent. Were I to clarify in detail and point by point every one of the subtly feigned misunderstandings, I would have to write a thick book. And what would the result then be? That the public, having had enough of the articles, would decline with thanks to read the book. This the author of the Epilogue has very cleverly calculated, and precisely for that reason wanted to give me occasion to get it established.

There can, as is well known, always be said various things for and against anything, and especially for and against a new philosophical doctrine. That contradictions arise against my philosophy is so far from surprising me that the opposite would on the contrary have prepared me a by no means pleasant surprise. “*What is philosophy?* A science full of contradictions! This definition, however much, regarded from one side, it seems designed to break the staff over all philosophy, is nonetheless grounded both in the history of science and in the nature of the case. For any other science such an admission would surely be annihilating; for philosophy it indicates an essential point of departure, a reliable point of support, a firm, unshakable foundation. That philosophy must contain contradictions is, after all, a matter of course, since it is precisely the science that everywhere, both in existence and in sound common sense’s apprehension of existence (Propæd. pp. 40–44), discovers and points out contradictions; with regard to this, philosophy is precisely to be conceived as a *general doctrine of contradiction*. As doctrine of contradiction, however, philosophy must not merely discover and point out the contradictions, it must also test the contradictions; for there is a difference among contradictions. Some contradictions, namely, are superficial, unnecessary, easy to avoid, others on the contrary pressing and irrefutable; some contradictions creep in through thoughtlessness, others are artificially produced by hair-splitting, others are exposed by acuteness; some contradictions play as in a game of thought, [324] others mark essential knots, difficult problems, hard to resolve.” (Forelæsninger over “Philosophisk Propædeutik” from the academic year 1860–61, Copenhagen 1862, pp. 1–2.)

The circumstance that philosophy moves through contradictions of different kinds and very different depth makes it so exceedingly easy to conduct a polemic of opinion against any philosophical doctrine whatever; for the public is easily dazzled when, without deeper insight into the connection of the matter, it sees contradictions set out in a few propositions and supported by detached quotations. If sound common sense gets a contradiction under one illumination, it can see through its nullity at once and is not beguiled; if on the other hand it gets the

same contradiction under another illumination and in another connection, it is impressed and believes that it is something. If I say: "God and the world cannot stand in opposition to each other without limiting each other; they cannot limit each other without restricting each other. God must thus be restricted by the world just as well as the world by God; but a restricted God is a contradiction, therefore God does not exist": then sound common sense smells a rat. One need only recall the difference between limitation and restriction, such as that every head must be limited, but that it by no means follows that every head is a restricted head; that one art can have its limit in another without the one therefore restricting the other, or *doing the other damage*, and so on — and anyone who has natural understanding grasps at once the difference between *limiting*, i.e. *determining*, and *restricting*, i.e. *doing damage*. If, on the other hand, the talk is of faith and knowledge, hence of an opposition that is still rather unclear to the general consciousness, then it is [325] easy to impress by the contradiction: "Faith and knowledge limit each other, for faith is not knowledge, knowledge not faith, and yet they are not to restrict each other; but to limit is surely to restrict; therefore: faith and knowledge are to restrict each other by not restricting each other. What a contradiction, indeed what a monstrous contradiction!" The reader's understanding stands still, the polemic of opinion flourishes, and the public believes that it is something.

To expose all the hollownesses, distortions, and crude misunderstandings that can be contained in a pamphlet of a few sheets, I would, as I said, each time have to write a voluminous book; it is a fruitless and unmanageable labor. Here comes one in the juggling, gallant manner of wit with "dualism" and "genius" and "collier's faith" and presents the public with one and a half nimbly fabricated contradictions, and then I am to answer that! Another, in the dogmatically trumping high-pressure manner, with a theological universal monarchy on the tip of "the good will," steps up and shows the public a blind man who is not riding on a lame one, a figurative, emblematic contradiction, and then I am to answer that! A third, in the speculative-turkey gobbling manner, announces himself with twelve blasts on a mystic trumpet; each blast is a contradiction, a turkey-cock contradiction,

and then I am to answer that! A fourth, in the well-known nice-man manner of self-important narrowness, comes stalking along with something on a critical lime-rod that he calls a conviction; the conviction is a contradiction, and the lime-rod is a contradiction too; he strikes at my edifice of doctrine with the conviction and the contradictions and the lime-rod and says Ruin! then I am to answer that! Here comes a fifth, a sixth . . . — it exceeds my powers. Perhaps the gentlemen pamphleteers would very well live on answers; but it is certain that were I to answer them all and on everything, I should have to die of answers.

From these prolixities, troubles, and difficulties my Socratic benefactor has [326] now, by his feigned misconstructions, misconstructions that in a light and pleasant way caricature what the public otherwise so readily takes for serious objections, freed me for the time being. The author of the Epilogue has held out a helping hand to me; I thank him, moved, and press his hand with gratitude.

Errata.

- | | | | |
|----|-----|---------------------|---|
| P. | 50 | line 1 from top | vente at finde den <i>read</i> : vente det |
| - | 70 | — 1 - - | stridt mod <i>read</i> : stridt med |
| - | 109 | — 3 from bottom | det absolute Selv <i>read</i> : det Absolute selv |
| - | 174 | — 9 and 10 from top | Saducæer <i>read</i> : Sadducæer |
-